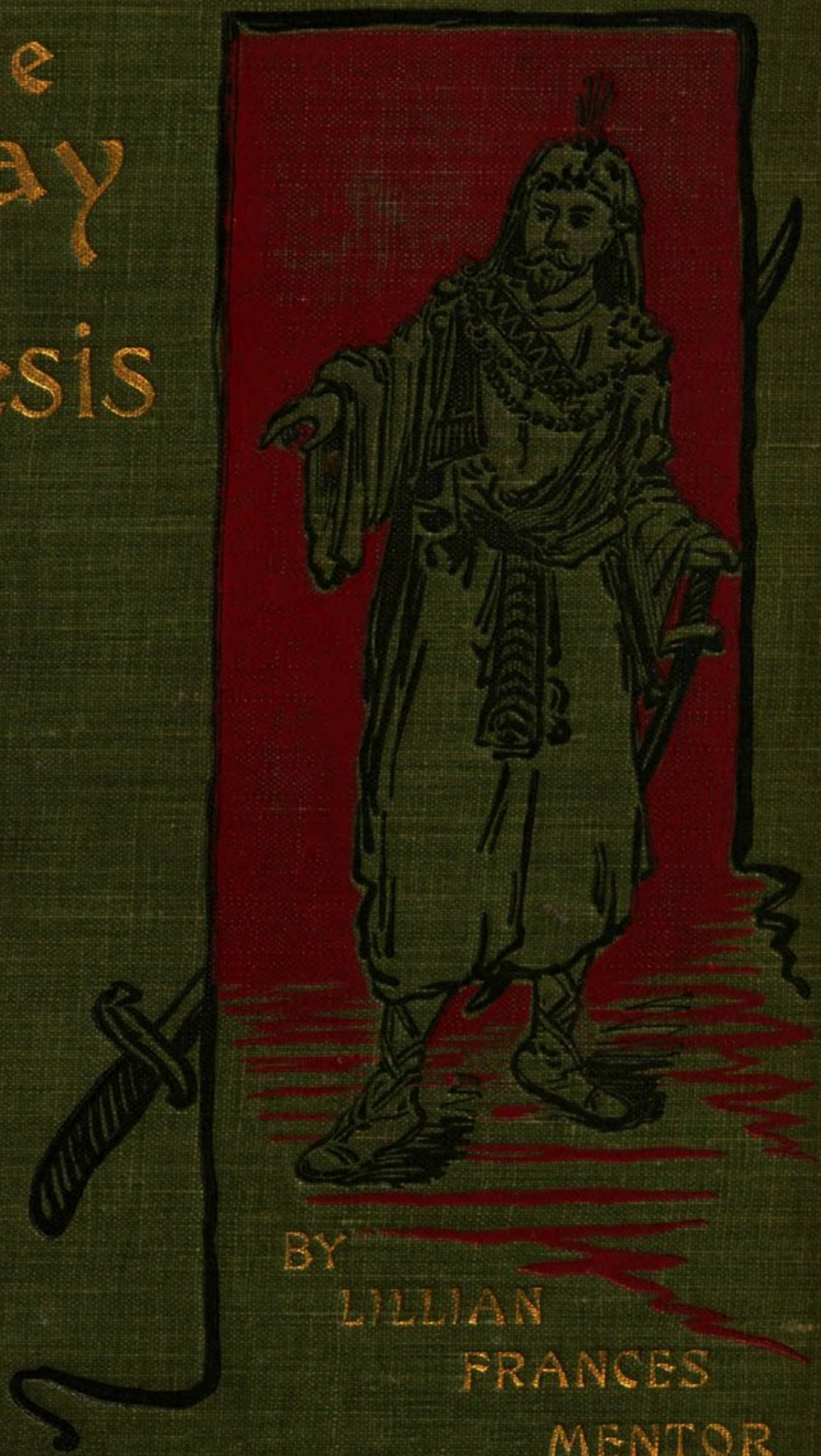


The Day of Resis



BY
LILLIAN
FRANCES
MENTOR

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THE DAY OF RESIS.

BY
LILLIAN FRANCES MENTOR.

ILLUSTRATED BY
HARRY L. V. PARKHURST.



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THE DAY OF RESIS.

CHAPTER I.

THE STRANGE DOCUMENT.

The following letter and document were the first causes of the long journey, and strange adventure.

“DEAR MISS CAMERON:—You will probably be much surprised to hear from me in this out-of-the-way place, but knowing the pleasure you take in everything pertaining to Africa, I thought you might be interested in a matter which came before my notice recently.

Some months ago I joined a hunting party bound for the interior of Africa, and on our return march at Rehenoko we fell in with another caravan bound for the coast. Having a common destination, Zanzibar, we travelled together. An Abyssinian, Sedai by name, was in charge of this caravan. He is a large, powerful man, and very intelligent. I often talked with him during the long marches, and one day he told me that he had on this trip, come across a strange manuscript, a part of which he had been able to decipher, but some words of which he could not make out. He asked me to help him decipher the difficult phrases; so that evening, after everything had been made snug for the night, Sedai produced a piece of goat-skin, on which was inscribed the following strange tale.

‘Name Philip Harding—English—left England July 6, 1801—Zanzibar, February 16, 1802—expedition just left Bagamayo—myself and nine other sailors started to overtake it—on 26th, lost our way—wandered long and far—hostile tribes—fight—four men killed—others escaped—three die with fever, reach mountains—one man killed by lion—discover opening into mountain—make torches and enter—companion starved—discovered line

of broken stones—followed these—found bridge—crossed this—followed stones again—found secret door—Land of On—people thought me from another planet—lived in temple—strange people—no knowledge or connection with outside world—highly civilized in their way—have strange Day of Resis—mysterious ceremonies on this day—people never mention it—day sacred—here nineteen years one month and sixteen days—made escape—looked five days for opening key—removed stone set in cliff behind palm tree under eagle’s rock mountain—lifted lever seen in spring—rock door turned giving time to pass through—passed into cave—crossed bridge—dropped torches in lake, am lost—exhausted—starving—if document ever found write friends—growing weaker—can write no more,’

Here the writing ended. The first part, or that part which had been written before entering the cave was in regular lines, but the last was evidently written after entering the dark cave, or passage, as the characters were scattered and very irregular. Sedai intends placing the matter before the next party who are about to enter the interior, and have them look up the mysterious cave and land. He says that the old man, of whom he got the manuscript, is still living, and knows the entrance to the cave, in which he found the body of Harding still warm, and on it this strange document.

Sedai is a trustworthy fellow, or otherwise I would take no stock in his story, or manuscript.

Hoping you may find some interest in this strange tale, I am,

Very Sincerely Yours,

FRANK BOYD.”

Such was the letter and weird tale which came in Enola Cameron’s mail one morning in the early nineties. Only the fact of hearing from Frank Boyd in Zanzibar surprised her. The story in itself did not surprise her, for she had so long made a study of Africa and its dark secrets, that nothing pertaining to it seemed strange to her. She was as enthusiastic in this research as most women were in studying the art of dress and beauty. She had met the great explorer Stanley during his late visit to New York, and had read the story of his travels again and again. She had met Herbert Warde socially, had

overhauled his trophies to her heart's content, and his books had also been added to the long shelf of African works in her library. Here poor Jameson's story had filled her eyes with tears, and here, too, she had escorted Glave that she might, in confidence, reveal to him the one great desire of her heart, and to learn from him the possibility of its fulfillment. She had studied the history of the dark continent from every obtainable source.

Works, which for the average woman held no attraction, aroused in her the liveliest interest. Her enthusiasm had reached such a pitch that but one course seemed open to her, namely, to experience the adventures which had made the names of Baker, Grant, Speke, Livingstone and Stanley famous. She had passed her twentieth birthday; she was of medium height and well-rounded figure, brimming over with health and strength, as was shown by her clear, rosy complexion and bright eyes, which lighted up with enthusiasm as new thoughts opened to life in her active brain.

There was nothing of the so-called New Woman about her; far from it; she was a womanly woman with a great sympathetic heart and kindly nature. She was an orphan, her parents having died when she was yet a child, leaving her with a life-long friend of the mother. This was Mrs. Graham, a most estimable woman, wealthy and moving in the best circle in the city in which they lived. Enola had long since learned to look upon Mrs. Graham and her kind husband as her second parents, and she was as dearly loved by them as were their own children. She had a snug fortune of her own and was thoroughly independent.

But now that she had made up her mind to go to Africa and ascertain the truth, or fallacy, of the tale which had just reached her, she felt a little hesitancy in broaching the subject to her friends. But she was not the one to be intimidated so easily, so went direct to the library, where she knew that Mr. Graham and Harry, the son, would be, and opened the subject at once.

"Uncle," she said (she always called her second parents uncle and aunt), "I am going to Africa, and will want your help."

Mr. Graham's glasses fell from his nose, so suddenly did he look up.

"To Africa," said he; "Well, has it come to this."

"Exactly," said Enola. "Now don't look as if I had declared my intention of committing suicide, although in your eyes I suppose the two are synonymous."

“When do you start?” asked Mr. Graham. Having long since learned that to cross Enola was to make her the more determined to carry out her own plans.

“To-day or to-morrow, or as soon as you can make preparations. Now remember, I am only suggesting this adventure; you are the real instigator of the project, and have asked me to accompany you, you know.”

“Well, if that isn’t a woman for you,” said Mr. Graham, laughing in spite of himself. “You come here declaring your intention of going to Africa, asking my help and then tell me that it is I who must assume all responsibility. Well, I will do it for your sake, but I hope it is not to be out of the regular beaten paths of travel in Africa, for it might not be pleasant, you know, fighting hostile natives with a woman about.” And Mr. Graham again laughed.

“The woman will take care of herself, never fear,” said Enola. “But seriously, uncle, I never would have asked you to accompany me on this journey, but for your having spoken some time ago of your intention of going to France to spend your vacation, and the thought occurred to me that you might care to go with me for two reasons. First, of course, to be my escort, and secondly, because the adventure would please you. And as for the danger, from what I can glean from Mr. Boyd’s letter, I should say that we will not meet with any great amount of this, for, from the coast to the mountains, the road leads through a comparatively open country, and if we start now we will get to Zanzibar about the right time to enter the interior. I anticipate but very little trouble in reaching the mountains. What will happen after that I cannot say.”

“The adventure will just suit my ideas of such things,” said Mr. Graham, “and I will go with you gladly. And you want to start immediately?”

“Why, yes,” said Enola. “This man Sedai was to present the matter before the first party entering the interior, and if we should wish to be the ones to discover this strange land, we must lose no time in getting to Zanzibar. It will not take long to make preparations, will it?”

“Well, no,” said Mr. Graham. “We will take but very little with us from this country, for everything can be obtained in Zanzibar. Let us see,” and he consults a New York paper. “To-day is Friday and the Paris sails from New York next Wednesday. We can leave here on Sunday evening if you wish to, and mother and Nellie can get packed in that time, and arrive in New York

Tuesday morning. We can make what few purchases we need, and go on the steamer that same night. Now what do you think of that for quick work?"

"I see you are quite as enthusiastic as myself in this matter," said Enola. "But where will we leave Auntie and Nellie while we are making our longer journey?"

"Oh, they can stop somewhere in Europe," said Mr. Graham, "or go on to Zanzibar if they wish, and wait there for our return. I am afraid, Enola, that you will have harder work to convince them of the advisability of this trip, than you have had with me."

"I am afraid so," said Enola, "but you must help me."

"I will do the best I can," said Mr. Graham.

"But look here," said Harry, who had kept perfectly quiet up to this time. "Where do I come in?"

"Why, Harry, I supposed you understood that you were to accompany us," said Enola. "Your father is perfectly willing, I know, and your mother will not object when she learns that I am determined on going. It will be pleasanter to have you with us, for there will be so few of us at the most, and among strangers home faces will be very comforting."

"It will have to be pleasant or otherwise," said Harry, "for I intend accompanying you, most certainly. I wouldn't see you take such a journey without me. There ought to be two of us with you anyway Enola, so that in case anything should happen one of us, you would still have another to protect you. It is a serious thing I should judge, to have to trust wholly to the half savage negroes who will make up your escort. So we must guard against any contingency."

"Very well," said Enola, "then it is settled that we start on Sunday night."

"Sunday night if you can get ready and I can get accommodations on the steamer," said Mr. Graham.

"Don't worry about me, uncle," said Enola. "Look out for yourself and Auntie. I will be ready," and saying this Enola turned and left the room.

Harry had long since learned to love Enola, but she had told him positively when he approached her on the subject of marriage, that she only thought of him as a brother, but that sometime she might learn to think of him in a different way; until that time, however, he must not mention the subject again. Harry had promised, and so the matter had rested; but he had

not forgotten her words, and he now saw a chance, while on this long journey, to win the love he craved.

He was twenty-eight, and by hard work, and strict attention to his duties, had been promoted to the position of cashier in the bank of which his father was president. He and his father had both left the bank for an indefinite period just a few days before our story opens, fully decided on taking a long vacation, spending the time in Europe. So Enola's plans had not upset theirs to any great extent; they would now take a trip into Africa, instead of through Europe.

When they had thought the matter over for some time, they came to the conclusion that the African trip would be more to their liking, for they were both good hunters and lovers of adventure. So Harry and his father lost no time but went out that same afternoon and made purchases of shotguns, rifles and pistols, fishing tackle, and some of the more necessary medicines. They trusted to getting everything else which they might need in New York and in Zanzibar.

That evening at the dinner table, the subject was brought up before Mrs. Graham and Nellie. Both objected, but when Mr. Graham and Harry both avowed their intention of accompanying Enola, then the ladies gave their consent.

Sunday came around and the party had gotten all ready and started for New York. Arriving there some few purchases were made, and then in the evening the party boarded the great steamer which was to carry them to Southampton. The following day opened up bright and beautiful, Enola remarking that this foretold success. The steamer left the dock early and moved slowly down the bay, past Governor's Island, Bedloe's Island, the Statue of Liberty, and then along the Staten Island shore, past Quarantine, the forts, Fire Island, Sandy Hook, and then, after a glimpse of Coney Island, Brighton, Manhattan Beach and Far Rockaway, the steamer turned her nose toward the Old World, and land was soon out of sight. The trip was an enjoyable one, the steamer not breaking her record, but still reaching Southampton in less than seven days. They did not tarry in England, but took one of the Channel steamers for Boulogne Sur Mer, and arriving here boarded a train for Paris, which city was reached the same night. The following day Mr. Graham looked up a steamer for Alexandria, and learned that one sailed for that port on Saturday from Marseilles. This was

Thursday, so no time must be lost in reaching Marseilles. Sleeping accommodations were secured on the night train, and the following morning found them in the quaint old city. The day was spent in taking a drive along the Mediterranean. It was at a time when the Riviera is generally crowded, and the beautiful driveway was filled with elegant equipages.

The following morning they took the steamer for Alexandria.

This was the most delightful part of the trip. The sky never looked so blue, the water never so calm, the sun never so bright, and the air never seemed so pure as on this two weeks' trip, from Marseilles to Alexandria. Stops were made at Algiers, Tunis and at several other points before reaching Alexandria, and at these different places, the boat stopping for a few hours, our friends disembarked, and made short excursions over the towns.

At Alexandria a freight steamer was found bound for Madagascar, and arrangements were made with the Captain to give the ladies his cabin, Mr. Graham and Harry being satisfied with humbler quarters. Down through the Suez Canal, into the Red Sea, out through the Gulf of Aden and then into the Indian Ocean, and the little steamer headed due south. This trip was rather slow but without much hardship, the Island of Zanzibar was at last sighted, and, later in the day, they were taken off in lighters.

"The civilized part," as Enola called it, of the journey was finished, and it remained now to make preparations for that other journey, which might prove less agreeable and a great deal more dangerous.

CHAPTER II.

INTO THE HEART OF AFRICA.

After landing at Zanzibar, the labor of equipment began. Bales of cloth and boxes of wire, innumerable colored beads and trinkets were shipped to Bagamayo in charge of reliable Zanzibari, the most trustworthy of African carriers.

Harry first looked up the reputation of Sedai, the Abyssinian, and finding this to be good, he then went in search of the man himself. He was found on the quay with a lot of natives, and upon Harry telling him what he wanted, he followed him to the hotel. Sedai was a monstrous fellow, standing fully six and a half feet high, and built like a Hercules. His skin was of a bronze color, smooth and shiny; his eyes were piercing black, his forehead high, and his face above the average in intellect for one of his race.

“You remember Mr. Boyd, do you not?” asked Mr. Graham, when the hotel had been reached.

“Perfectly well,” answered the Abyssinian.

“And you believe that the mysterious Land of On exists?”

“I do.”

“I wish to make that belief a certainty. Will you join us and get together a proper number of carriers and natives to insure comparative safety in making the journey?”

“Gladly,” said Sedai.

“You shall have something more than the usual amount paid for such services, for the journey may entail more than the usual amount of work and danger.”

“I shall expect nothing more than I have been accustomed to getting,” answered the Abyssinian.

“We will decide on that later,” said Mr. Graham, “but tell us now of the finding of the goat-skin.”

“I will do so,” said Sedai. “When on my last expedition, far up in the country, I heard this story from the mouth of an old man. It may be false, but I believe it to be true. Umsaga, that is the name of the old man, said: “One day when I was quite a boy I was out hunting on the mountain side, and among the undergrowth disclosed a flat stone, which had at some remote period covered an opening about four feet square, in the side of the mountain. Being curious to know whither the hole led, I entered, but had gone only a short distance when I heard a groan. This scared me but I determined to learn what it was that had made the noise. I returned to the outside and procuring a torch, again entered the cave, and followed in the direction from which the sound came, and had not gone far when I almost stumbled over the prostrate body of a man. I felt it and found it still warm, but upon close examination found that life was extinct. He was of the white race, but exposure and starvation had tanned and drawn the skin tight over the bones. By his side was a knife, and clutched in his hand was a piece of goat-skin, on which he had cut strange characters, which I could not decipher. I took the goat-skin and never again entered the cave.”

“This was the old man’s story,” continued Sedai, “and offering him a piece of cloth for the goat-skin, he eagerly accepted it and I left him.”

“And you could read it?” asked Mr. Graham.

“I was for a time in the service of an Englishman in my own country and knew some English. I have learned more since, but I could not make out all of the letters. With Mr. Boyd’s help, however, all was made plain. It is here,” and Sedai saying this, handed the parchment to Mr. Graham.

The party gathered around Mr. Graham and examined the goat-skin closely.

“And the old man never sought to solve the mystery?” said Harry.

“So he said,” answered Sedai.

“This parchment tells us how to leave this strange country, when once it is entered,” said Mr. Graham, “but it does not tell how to find the secret door which is to admit us.”

“The sailor found it,” said Enola, “and it seems to me that we ought to.”

“Well, we will never know until we get to the point where we may expect to find it,” said Mr. Graham. “How far is it, Sedai, to this mountain, through which we will have to go to find the strange country?”

“About three hundred miles,” said Sedai, “through a country not difficult to travel, and among natives not usually hostile.”

“Can you be ready to start to-morrow?” asked Mr. Graham of Sedai.

“I can,” said Sedai.

“Then be at Bagamayo to-morrow at daybreak, ready to start.”

“I will be there,” answered Sedai, and with this he left.

That day a Mr. Bruce called on Mr. Graham, making a request to accompany the expedition, and Mr. Graham, having looked up his reference and found that he was a Scotchman of first-class standing both socially and financially, he consented to his accompanying them. Later in the day the party crossed over to Bagamayo, so as to be there for an early start in the morning.

Early on the following morning the caravan was drawn up and carefully inspected by Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham, Harry and Enola. Twenty donkeys and one hundred carriers, with one cart, were to transport the goods of barter. A double relay of six carriers was detailed to carry each of the sedan chairs of Mrs. Graham and Nellie, after having learned that the country through which they would pass would be open, and the tribes not hostile had decided to accompany the caravan. They were desirous of seeing the strange land and people. Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce and Harry had procured horses from an Arab in Bagamayo, and when the caravan was drawn up it made an imposing sight, and one well calculated to inspire hostile tribes with a wholesome fear.

At six o'clock, with the sun shining brightly, and amid the shouts of many Arabs and natives who had assembled to see them depart, the caravan moved slowly out of Bagamayo. The American flag was unfurled, and floated merrily in the breeze at the head of the column. Out through a narrow lane they passed, the sun speeding to the west, beckoning them on. Loveliness glowed around them, the fertile fields, rich vegetation, strange trees bordering their path, the jubilant sounds of many insects, the cry of cricket and pewit, all seemed to tell them that they had started.

The first camp was only five miles distant, and the next few days were spent in completing the preparations for their long land journey. After all was in readiness the caravan again started. From here on the roads were mere footpaths, leading through fields in which naked women were at work, who looked up and giggled as they passed. Passing on they entered an open forest. Reaching the Kingimi, they passed over a bridge of felled trees, made by some previous party.

Harry came to the side of Enola's chair and laughingly said:

"One would think from the half-sad expression in your eyes, that you were already regretting having taken this trip."

"You are mistaken, Harry; I was simply lost in admiration of the beautiful scene about us."

"Yes, it is beautiful," said Harry, "but it is so different from what I have been used to, that I often find myself thinking, or wondering if it is not all a dream, and if I will not wake up some morning in my room at home, and find that I have only visited these lands in my dreams."

"Yes, it is decidedly out of the ordinary," laughed Enola, as she saw the serious look in Harry's face; "but if you were as well read in African history and lore of the people as I am, you would accept all this as genuine at once. Listen. For centuries Africa has been known as the Dark Continent. The edges of this immense tract have been known as far back as history goes. Egypt, on the North, is the oldest government on earth; while the nations bordering on the Mediterranean and Red seas, were actors in the earliest recorded histories. Still, Africa to-day is an unknown land. That Africa was a rich country, was proven by the treasures brought from the interior by the rivers Nile, Niger and Congo. That it was populous, was demonstrated by the millions of slaves furnished by the native tribes to the outside world. For curiosity alone, explorations were made in the early part of the century; but it remained with Livingstone to first open up the Dark Continent, and with Stanley, to pierce its very heart. Africa is to-day, however, a mystery which, it seems, will never be penetrated. Strange stories come to us of people never seen by white men, of customs foreign to all history, of abandoned cities, of desolated countries. Africa is synonymous with mystery and darkness, and nothing seems strange to me which is connected with it."

“Such words should be convincing,” said Harry, “but my education in life has been too practical to realize that there is so much mystery left in the world in this, the nineteenth century.”

“It will all be real enough before we get back to civilization, I have an idea,” said Enola.

“Well, it looks real enough now,” said Harry. “This moving caravan, those hippopotami in the river, and the antelope in the forest, all scout the idea of there being anything uncanny about our present surroundings.”

And so days passed, some amid pleasant surroundings, and others in a part of the country not so agreeable.

One day they passed through a continuous jungle. The path was only a foot wide, each side being bordered with thorny plants and creepers, the spiky twigs of which were as sharp as needles. The entire party was badly scratched with these irritating twigs, and the caravan was in a sad plight when it reached Msuwa that night. The chief of this tribe was very kind to the tired and wounded party, however, and they remained in this camp two days. After leaving here, the country was open and beautiful, presenting a natural park, and the roads were good.

They reached the Ungerangeri River on the evening of the twenty-fourth day, where they encamped, and on the following morning crossed the river and entered the Wakami territory. Five days later they reached the Wassagahha district. Here several of the party were stricken with fever, and several days were lost, but all getting better at last, the caravan again moved on. Away off to the North and West, could be seen a long range of mountains, in which, Sedai informed them, was situated the hidden country of “On.”

Shortly after leaving here they entered a very wild tract. Numberless antelope, spring-bok, zebra and giraffes were seen, but upon their approach they would scamper away. Here was a hunter’s paradise. What nobleman’s reserve in civilization could compare with this vast expanse of field and forest? How small and insignificant would they seem in comparison! The first herd of elephant was also seen here, but they passed them by without disturbing them. That evening they entered the Usugara district, and although the mountains were a considerable number of miles nearer, they still looked just as far away. The atmosphere in this country is so clear it makes distances very deceiving. It was a mountain world which they looked

upon, for peak beyond peak, cone beyond cone, fold above fold, they rolled away like so many waves.

“We shall soon descend into the valley and across this to those distant mountains directly west of us, at the base of which we shall find the village in which lives the old man of whom I obtained the parchment. We will reach there in four marches,” said Sedai.

“And you say there are lions and tigers in the valley?” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes,” answered Sedai, “and this part of the journey will be very dangerous.”

And this proved to be true, for two evenings later, when the supper had been eaten and all had been made snug for the night, Harry and Enola came very near falling victims to one of these ferocious beasts. They had wandered a little distance from the camp, and had sat down on a mossy bank for a few moments’ talk before going to bed. They had been here only a short time when they heard a rustle in the bushes, and turning they saw, standing not ten yards away, with his yellow eyes glowing through the semi-darkness, and his long tail swaying from side to side, an immense lion. Harry had not brought his rifle, and they were at the mercy of the beast. The lion seemed to realize this, for he quietly settled down on his haunches and watched them intently.

“Listen,” said Harry, and his lips hardly moved, “he will make a leap for us, and when he does, stoop low and run toward him. We will try to pass under him while he is in the air, and before he alights and turns we may be able to reach camp.”

“I understand,” said Enola.

The lion again rose to his feet, and then settling on his haunches prepared to spring.

“Be ready,” said Harry. “Now,” and he darted forward, but stopped again as soon as he could, for Enola’s hand had left his and she had fallen. There she lay with the lion’s paw resting across her breast. Harry could see that she had neither lost consciousness nor presence of mind, for she was gazing steadfastly into the eyes of the huge beast.

It was a terrible moment. Harry was afraid to move or cry for help, for fear of the lion seizing Enola and making for the bush.

All this time the lion was watching Harry intently, seeming to know that interference would come from that quarter. But he was as powerless to help Enola as if he had been bound hand and foot. He could see that she was becoming weak from terror and loss of blood, and that she could scarcely breathe owing to the weight of that fearful paw on her breast. Her eyes closed several times, and Harry could see that she would soon be unconscious. Something must be done. Would the lion, if he made a rush for him, turn his attention from Enola long enough for her to get out of reach? It mattered little what became of himself if he could but save Enola.

Harry seized a short piece of wood lying near him and made a rush for the lion. The lion raised on his haunches as Harry struck him a powerful blow between the eyes.

“Roll out of the way,” said Harry.

Enola rolled over once and then staggered to her feet, but sank down again too weak to move farther. The lion was dazed for an instant by the blow, but only for an instant, and with a lightning stroke of the paw, struck Harry on the shoulder, knocking him senseless and bleeding on the ground.

“Help,” cried Enola, but the sound was so faint that she despaired of its reaching the camp. Nevertheless it was heard, and the commotion caused the lion to turn to see what was happening. That look was his death warrant, for a bullet struck him squarely in the eye, and he rolled over with scarcely a groan, dead. One paw was lying across Harry’s neck, as though defying them even in death to take his prey from him.

Mr. Bruce rushed up gun in hand, and with several of the carriers bore Enola and Harry to the camp. Restoratives were administered and Enola soon regained consciousness, but Harry lay in a stupor for hours. Both were badly torn by the claws of the lion, and it was several days before the caravan could move on.

The journey from here on, was through an open forest, watered by numerous streams which sprung from the mountains. Their progress was somewhat impeded by these streams, but two evenings later they camped near the village in which dwelt the old man, who was going to show them the entrance to the cave. Was he still alive and would they find him?

CHAPTER III.

IN THE CAVERN.

Early the following morning, Sedai went into the village to find the old man Umsaga. After much inquiry he learned that the old man still lived but was very feeble. He went to his hut and telling him what he wanted, and that he would be well paid for the information which he would give to the party, the old man agreed to go. Sedai had to support him, for he was too feeble to walk alone. They reached the camp and Sedai acting as interpreter, Mr. Graham asked Umsaga:

“Do you know where the opening to the cave is?”

The old man made quite a long speech, which when interpreted ran as follows:

“I will show you the opening on condition that you take none of the carriers or soldiers with you, and for this service I demand one hundred yards of cloth, and one pack of beads. The opening is about four hours’ march from here, and one of your men will have to carry me to the place, as I will not allow either my countrymen, or your carriers to accompany us. If you will agree to this I will go with you to-day, to-morrow, or any time that you wish.”

“We will remain here to-day to settle up with our carriers, and to-morrow morning we will have him show us the opening.”

Sedai interpreted this to Umsaga, and then helped him back to the village.

The caravan had only been engaged to go this far, but it was decided to have it wait three months for them. If they had not returned at the end of that time, the carriers need wait no longer. They had paid the natives well for their work, and had promised them still more for the return trip if they

would but wait for them. They hoped that these inducements would hold them until the expiration of the three months. Arrangements were made with the chief of the village to give sustenance and shelter to the members of the caravan during this time.

Late in the afternoon, the goods promised Umsaga, besides a liberal present to the chief were sent to the village, after which the remaining bales and boxes were carried up the mountain side to a place designated by Umsaga. This place was near the opening of the mountain, and here the party camped for the night.

Early the following morning, Sedai went into the village and helped the old man up the mountain. Umsaga directed them in the way to go, and it was not long before they reached a level spot well up on the mountain. The trees in this vicinity appeared to have been planted in the far distant past, with a peculiar regard for regularity. A broad avenue of stately trees of an unknown species to the travelers, led directly to the face of the cliff. It suggested that the hand of man had long ago intended that they should serve as a hint of the possibilities within the mountain.

The party moved through the avenue and halted at the extreme end. Here the high cliff seemed to stop all further progress, but Umsaga hobbled up to the rock barrier and with the help of Sedai, removed some of the bushes growing at the base, and disclosed a large flat stone leaning against it. This, Sedai with difficulty moved aside, opening to view an entrance about four feet in diameter. All started forward and gazed intently into the darkness. It required considerable courage to even think of entering this dark passage which the sunlight penetrated but a few feet.

For hours the men labored in transferring the bales and boxes to the cavern, where they were to remain until their return. Torches had been procured from the natives, and lighting one of these the party started on their long underground journey. The passage was very narrow for about twenty yards, and was very smooth and clear cut, but at the end of this distance a vaulted cave, lofty and wide, opened before them. The dim light of the torch lit up this vast subterranean cavern but indifferently, the roof being so high that it could just be seen in the darkness.

The goods were stored safely and the journey commenced in earnest. The men carried what provisions and torches they thought would be needed in the march across the cave. They had gone but a short distance when Enola

and Harry, who were a little in advance of the others, stumbled over something, which the light of the torch revealed as the body of a man. The skin, dry as parchment was drawn tightly over the bones; the eyes were sunken; the head was covered with a growth of long hair; the hands, which with their long finger-nails looked like talons, clutched the garment at the throat, as if the man, when dying, had tried to tear it away, in order to gain greater freedom to breathe. This garment was all that the body was clothed in, but around the neck of the dead was a chain of gold engraved in a peculiar manner and in which diamonds and opals were set. The ends of the chain were attached in front to a strange red stone, that resembled liquid fire.

Mr. Graham unfastened the garment, and slipped it off. A solid substance was discovered inserted in the middle of the back, and slitting the garment with a knife, a piece of thin, highly polished hard wood was revealed. Tracings were found on it which seemed to be the diagram or map of a country; but these were so dim it was difficult to discover what they represented. After studying further, however, a circle was seen in the corner with the word "ON" written in its centre. This then told the tale; this was a map showing the location of the mysterious country. On the other side were more tracings. A straight line was drawn from one corner to the centre, where a hole about an inch deep was cut. On the opposite side of this hole the tracing continued in a straight line, but just before reaching the corner it turned to the left and ended at the edge of the block. Nothing more could be made out until Mr. Bruce, who had looked at it more closely, and whose eyes seemed keener than those of the others, discovered the letter "u" and a little ways further the letters "g" and "e." All looked at the tracing intently for a few moments trying to guess the riddle. It was finally decided that the "u" was the first letter of underground, and "ge" the last two letters of passage. This then was the path to be followed through the cave. Along the edge of the block could be faintly discerned the name "Philip Harding;" this was the body of the man who long ago had visited the mysterious land, and had suffered and died in this cave. This was he who had given them the knowledge of the hidden country, and who, years after, was staring at them with those sightless eyes that seemed to warn them back.

"How terrible," said Mrs. Graham.

“Yes,” said Enola, “my heart turns sick at the sight. And to think that he died so near help and liberty.”

“And do you still feel like going on?” asked Mr. Graham.

“Yes,” said Enola, “for now my doubts are at rest; all the fears that I had of this strange country being a myth are gone. Success seems sure now and all our long journey has not been in vain. But how strange that this body should have lain here all these years and not decayed.”

“There must be some preserving quality in the atmosphere of this cave,” said Mr. Bruce, “or else the body would have turned to dust long since.”

“But come,” said Mr. Graham, “we must yet find the line of broken stone which is mentioned in the document.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “the block would be of little use to us in this vast cavern without some better guide than its tracings.”

So the party began looking for the string of broken stone, and found it but a short distance from the body. From here on the cave widened, and the roof became too lofty to longer be in the rays of the torch. Monstrous stalactite formations hung from the ceiling, and tremendous stalagmite pillars reached from the floor into the darkness far overhead. These pillars were of fantastic shapes. Some were perfectly symmetrical, others irregular, but all were of wondrous beauty, their surfaces being covered with delicate tracery as fine as lace. On every hand could be heard the dropping of lime-water forming new pillars. Ages must have passed since this cave was cut out of the solid rock by the action of some subterranean sea, or by a weakening and wasting away of the lighter strata, or by some tremendous convulsion of nature, which, raising but the upper part of the mountain, had left this vast open space.

A little further on a halt was made for the midday meal, and after this had been partaken of, Harry and Enola walked a little apart from the others, and sat down on some of the broken stone to talk over their future plans.

“Harry,” said Enola, “I am a little slow in doing so, but I want to thank you for having saved me from the jaws of that fearful lion. While I was lying beneath the paw of that awful beast, I for one short moment wished that I had not come.”

“And what did you think I would do?” asked Harry.

“Just what you did do,” said Enola, “A brave man could not have done otherwise. But there are few brave men when it comes to a question of their own lives, or those of others. There must be no selfishness where bravery is to play a part, and it is this unselfishness that must be rewarded, and I can only do this by thanking you, and by telling you that I appreciate the brave act.”

“Let us forget that fearful moment,” said Harry. “It was little enough to do for a life-long friend, and I would do the same thing over again a thousand times if the opportunities should offer.”

“Let us hope that they will not,” said Enola.

“It is hard to tell in this strange country,” said Harry.

At this moment, they heard a loud shout to the right. They could see their friends rushing in the direction of the sounds, and Enola and Harry hurried to join them. Nellie was standing wringing her hands and trying to explain how she and Mr. Bruce were walking along leisurely, when he suddenly dropped out of sight, the torch being extinguished leaving her in utter darkness. She had called to him, but receiving no answer, had shouted for the others, whom she could just see in the torchlight some distance from her. Taking torches they went to where Mr. Bruce had so mysteriously disappeared, calling to him constantly. They proceeded carefully for fear of falling into the same pit; and it was well that they did so, for before them, gaping as if anxious to swallow up the whole party, was an abyss opening into the very bowels of the earth. They leaned far over the edge and peered into the darkness, calling, but no answer came to them, and they felt assured that Mr. Bruce was lost.

Harry brought a coil of fine silk rope, and fastening one end to a stalagmite, prepared to descend into the darkness. Sedai pushed him gently aside, however, and taking one of the torches between his teeth, he let himself down. Down, down he went, until he could see a black torrent rushing madly through the crevice. He saw a rock near him, and swung so as to land upon it. He could see but a few feet about him and Mr. Bruce was nowhere visible. He called again and again, and once he thought he heard a faint answer. He grasped the rope and jumped into the stream and let it bear him down until, clinging to a jagged rock he saw Mr. Bruce. He swung toward him, and catching him under the arms, began working his way back. This was tedious work, and would have been an impossibility to a man not

endowed with Sedai's herculean strength, but happily Sedai was equal to the task and soon had Mr. Bruce on the rock. He gave the signal to those above, and tying the rope under Mr. Bruce's arms, he was pulled to the surface. The rope came falling back, and Sedai, hand over hand, rejoined his companions. It took some time to restore Mr. Bruce to consciousness, but he was finally brought around.

After he became stronger he said that he had fallen head first, but hearing a rush of waters, he clasped his hands above his head in the manner of divers, and thus broke the blow which his head otherwise would have sustained. He had gone down a hundred feet he thought, but had then began to rise again, and reaching the surface he had grasped the first object which his hand came in contact with, which proved to be the rock upon which Sedai had found him. Then he saw Sedai coming and lost consciousness. The party moved no farther that day but on the following morning they took up the journey with renewed vigor.

They had but one fear, and that was as to the possibility of their finding a door when they had reached the other side of the cavern. This did not worry them a great deal, for the path laid out for them to follow both by the broken stones and the tracings on the block of wood, led to one point and this would undoubtedly be near the stone door, but the secret of the spring had not been learned, and they might have trouble in finding it.

CHAPTER IV.

DEATH FACES THEM.

The next morning they had gone but a short distance when they came to a vast inland lake. The bridge mentioned in the manuscript stood before them, and mounting this they startled to cross the lake. They had followed this about four miles when they came to a break in the solid masonry. The hole was fully eight feet wide, and it was a serious question as to how they were to get to the opposite side; but Sedai offered to tie the rope to his arm and leap across. The end of the rope could be fastened and the ladies and Mr. Graham could cross over, while Mr. Bruce and Harry could make the leap as did Sedai.

This Sedai did, and fastening one end of the rope to one of the huge stones, which had evidently come from the break, Mr. Bruce and Harry held the other end, and Mrs. Graham and Enola worked their way slowly across. Nellie then grasped the rope and was half way over, when a terrible commotion was heard near the bridge, and a spout of water was sent thirty feet into the air. The whole party was deluged; the torches were put out, and when their first surprise was over, they saw with horror that Nellie had loosened her hold on the rope and had dropped into the water. Hastily relighting the torches, they saw Nellie disappearing in the swift current. It took but a second for Mr. Bruce to throw off his jacket and plunge in after her. He hoped by the help the current and his long easy strokes to overtake her. He could just see her above the surface of the water about one hundred yards ahead of him, evidently fast giving out. He strained every nerve, put forth every effort, resorted to every means to force himself through the water, and he could see that he was gaining slowly. He called to her to keep her hands and feet moving and to keep up courage. He could see her beating the water making frantic efforts to keep afloat, but her struggles were

becoming weaker and weaker, and at last they ceased altogether and she began to sink when he was only a few feet away. Making one grand final effort he caught her by the hair just as she was sinking beneath the surface.

Grasping her about the waist, and holding her head above the water with one arm, he tried to swim out of the current. This was a hard task, but he was an excellent swimmer, and nearly succeeded. But the struggle was an unequal one and having but one hand to use, he soon found that the current was getting the better of him. He now threw Nellie over his shoulder and grasping her dress between his teeth, he in this way gained the use of both hands, and soon made his way into more quiet water. Turning he saw the flickering torches far in the distance, but close at hand were two round balls that shone like fire. The water was terribly agitated and he soon found himself struggling against waves like those thrown up by the paddles of a steamboat.

Nearer and nearer came those fearful eyes, and Mr. Bruce thought all was lost. Happily for Nellie she had fainted, so she was spared the terror of this new danger. Mr. Bruce was not one to give up, however, as long as there was a shadow of a hope, and he was thinking hard to devise a means to escape this monster. Those eyes were nearing him, and in an instant he would feel the hot breath in his face. Down he sank holding Nellie about the waist. Rising to the surface again he started for the lights. He was afraid to look back for fear of seeing those fearful eyes following him. Larger and larger grew the lights, nearer and nearer he came to his friends. His strength was fast failing but he must not give up when so near to those who could rescue them. A few strokes more and he was in the radius of the torchlight, and a shout of encouragement from his friends greeted him. This seemed to rouse Nellie for she gave a long sigh.

“Throw your arms about my neck and hold on for your life,” said Mr. Bruce, and Nellie having done this it left his mouth free, and he breathed with greater ease.

“Look behind you,” called Mr. Graham, and looking over his shoulder, he saw those awful eyes again, with the huge black body, following them. He turned and faced the monster again, just as it was opening its cavernous jaws. Once more he sank bidding Nellie to hold her breath. The huge mass passed over him, and coming to the surface he saw the great black body going straight ahead at a fearful speed. The serpent made a big circle and

then turned and came toward them again. Mr. Bruce was nearly exhausted and felt that he could not risk again that terrible plunge under the passing monster, and still have strength to reach the pier. He could see Harry and Sedai preparing to swim to them, and knew that Nellie and he were safe if the terrible serpent did not make another charge on them. Sedai now came towards them holding a flaming torch. Back of them but a few yards could be seen the sea monster again making for them. They were fast nearing the bridge. The rope was thrown to them and Mr. Bruce fastening this around Nellie's body, she was pulled out of the water. It was then thrown to Mr. Bruce and Sedai, just as the terrible monster opened his jaws. Sedai thrust his blazing torch into the creature's mouth, and then with Mr. Bruce, hurried hand over hand up the rope.

The water was lashed into foam by the struggles of the serpent, and bullets from Harry's revolver seemed to have no effect. They got a good look now at the monster. The largest part of the body was just back of the head and tapered from this to the end of the tail. The head was at least six feet long, and flat, or nearly so. The wide jaws, when open, showed a double set of irregular teeth. The tongue was forked. A large horn about three feet long sprang from the head just back of the nostrils, and from this to the point of the tail was a succession of smaller horns. Just back of the large horn or tusk, was a hole through which the monster forced a stream of water high into the air. Three great fins on either side of the body were tipped with long claws looking as if they might be used for crawling. Its rage was terrible when maddened by the flaming torch and by the escaping of its prey.

The party now hurried on over the bridge after they had transferred the packs by a succession of leaps across the break. The monster followed them for awhile but finally turned and swam away. They reached the end of the bridge about two hours later, and calculated that it must be about ten miles long. Leaving the shores of the lake they again followed the line of broken stone, and two days later reached the opposite wall.

For awhile they sought a possible opening in the wall, but could nowhere detect any evidence of human handiwork. To and fro they went, pressing hard upon every piece of rock which projected from the wall. This they kept up all of the first day, and they laid down to rest that night pretty well disheartened. Their provisions were getting low for they had calculated in

getting through in much less time. They had been living on short rations for the past twenty-four hours, but now they had but a few crackers left. They still had hopes, however, of finding this secret door on the morrow, when they would find food in plenty on the other side of the wall. The following morning after a frugal repast of dry crackers, they again began the search. They first examined the wall directly in front of them, but could see no crack or crevice which might indicate the presence of a door. They had carefully followed the line of broken stone, and they might reasonably expect to find the door at the end of this.

Striking on the rock with a hammer at different places, they could not distinguish any difference in tone, which would indicate a thinner part of the rock wall. They examined the rock for about four hundred feet, and all seemed perfectly solid. They discovered in their search many holes about four feet square, two feet wide, and three feet deep. These were arranged along the side of the cavern, having been cut in the wall, and upon close inspection they found them to contain what proved to be mummies. These were wrapped in heavy sacking, many of the envelopes being of fantastic colors. Harry took one of these bundles from its place and cut it open. A number of cloth coverings were found under the outside wrapping, and then came a covering of large leaves which crumbled into dust when exposed. Next to the leaves was a wrapping of fine silk. This having been removed the body was discovered. It was that of a man who must have been more than six feet in height when alive. The head was brought forward between the knees, which were drawn up; the skin was dry and hard and drawn closely over the bones; the hair was long and still retained a beautiful lustre. The head was small but beautifully formed; the hands and feet were also small and symmetrical. Inside the covering were a number of gold balls about one half inch in diameter; two characters were engraved on one side of each of these balls. Examining them closely, Mr. Bruce declared that the hieroglyphics were undoubtedly Egyptian. Around the neck of the mummy was a chain of gold set with diamonds and opals. This chain was similar to the one found around Harding's neck, but the bright red stone was missing.

Eight o'clock had arrived and they were still searching for the opening. A supper of crackers had been eaten. They were already suffering from the pangs of thirst. The water gourds which had been refilled before leaving the lake were again empty. The food, with the exception of a few crackers, was gone.

Mrs. Graham and Nellie laid down to get a few hours' rest, but Enola, with the men of the party, kept bravely on in search of the opening. Midnight came and found them still searching. Hungry and thirsty, they, too, at last lay down, feeling that they must reserve their strength as much as possible. Their few hours of sleep, however, did not seem to refresh them, for the thirst had made them restless. The whole party arose about the same time and the search was soon taken up again. They examined the wall more closely, going farther on either side, but with no success.

Late in the afternoon Mrs. Graham became so feverish for want of water that Sedai started with two large gourds for the lake. If they should find the opening in the meantime, they were to leave directions as to how to open the rock door, and then pass on. About midnight Mr. Graham also became delirious, and Mrs. Graham's and Nellie's lips were so swollen that they could scarcely articulate. Mr. Bruce and Harry, although suffering terribly, still kept up the search. All night they tramped up and down the cave, trying to find the secret opening. Toward morning they became so famished and their tongues and lips were so parched and swollen they could not make each other understand what they were saying. Enola alone seemed to retain her clear and unfailing senses.

Mr. Bruce and Harry had thrown themselves on the ground at last, thoroughly worn out, their lips and tongues swollen terribly. Mrs. Graham and Nellie were mumbling something in their delirium which was unintelligible. This drove Mr. Bruce and Harry nearly frantic, and again they arose and took up the search. Their breath came hard through their parched throats, and their eyes were wild and glaring. Mr. Bruce walked over to where Mrs. Graham and Nellie were lying, and suddenly drawing his knife, he slit the sleeve of his jacket and shirt, and made a deep incision in his arm; then carefully raising Nellie's head with his other arm he let the warm blood from the wound drop between her half-open lips; then going to Mrs. Graham he partially alleviated her sufferings in the same way. Finally overcome with weakness Mr. Bruce fell back, and Harry, who had stood by looking at the strange sight, but hardly realizing what Mr. Bruce was doing, now came up, and tearing off the sleeve of the shirt, bound the arm tightly above the wound. Enola stood watching this self-sacrificing act on the part of Mr. Bruce, and when Harry had bandaged his arm, she turned and walked toward the wall, mumbling something to herself. Harry saw that

she, too, was fast becoming delirious, but he was powerless to help her, he being almost too weak now to again take up the search.

He arose to his feet, however, and again joining Enola, they together staggered from point to point of the wall, feverishly looking for some indication of a revolving stone. Hours had passed since Sedai had left them, but they seemed like years to his suffering companions. Praying for his return, praying for deliverance from this cavern, Enola felt her senses leaving her. She fought against this but to no purpose. Harry finally sank to the ground in a delirium. Enola gazed at him for a moment, and making one final effort, stumbled along leaning against the wall for support. She had gone but five or six paces when her strength gave way entirely, and she sank back upon the rock floor. Death seemed inevitable.

CHAPTER V.

THE CITY OF ON.

But Enola had not lost consciousness entirely when she sank to the floor. She had rested there only a moment, when she thought she felt something pushing her. She half rose, and looking over her shoulder thought she saw a ray of light. Could she be dreaming? Was this some awful torturing vision come to torment her in her fearful suffering? No. She could see the sun, the sky, and far away she caught a glimpse of a beautiful city. She now realized it all; her weight upon this particular part of the floor had set the door to moving. She must move through the opening quickly. Her senses were roused to action by this revelation. She knew the door would revolve and close again perhaps forever.

She had by some strange fatality accidentally found the means of opening it, for which they had searched so vainly, but while in such a semi-conscious state she might not be able to repeat the operation. She knew where to find the spring on the other side, and as the opening began to grow smaller, the door slowly swinging into its place again, she gave one frantic leap and turned to find herself cut off from the rest by the solid wall of rock.

From the ground she began to tear bits of grass and succulent weeds, and partially allaying her thirst with these, she hurried to the point which might be, she thought, the hiding place of the spring. Almost tearing the flesh from her hands in pulling the underbrush away, she was rewarded by seeing a loose piece of rock set into the solid cliff. Removing this the lever was before her. It took nearly all the strength she had left to move the lever, but she was rewarded at last by seeing the door swing on its pivots again. Peering through the opening she saw the light of a torch moving quickly toward the door, and she knew that it was Sedai returning. Sedai had caught the glimpse of daylight, and hastening his steps, he had moistened the lips

of the sufferers, and when the door again swung open he hurried through with Mrs. Graham, and as often as Enola would lift the heavy lever he would carry out another of the prostrated companions.

One by one, all were carried out, and Sedai returned for the arms and accoutrements. Ladened with these he lacked the rapidity of motion necessary, and the massive stone as it revolved, caught him squarely between the shoulders. Slowly the grinding mass pressed closer, while Enola, petrified with horror for the moment, pressed her hands to her throbbing temples. Finally, realizing the fearful position that Sedai was in, she seized one of the rifles, and using it as a lever, placed it in the crack of the door and threw her whole weight against it. At the same time Sedai, with a herculean effort of his mighty muscles, strained every nerve, pushed himself through, and fell on the ground bruised and bleeding. Enola, taking one of the water gourds which Sedai had tramped so far to fill, placed it to the lips of the noble fellow, and then gave the others a very little. Her strength now gave out again and she sank down thoroughly worn out.

The few drops of water had partially roused the others, and Mr. Bruce especially seemed to have regained complete consciousness. He looked about him, but it had grown dark and he could see nothing; but he could hear, and the cries of many beasts reached his ears. He tried hard to remember how he had come here, and wondered where his companions were. The cries of the wild beasts, however, brought him back to himself, and he knew that a fire must be built or the beasts would be on him. He rose and began looking for some dry twigs with which to build the fire; he stumbled over something, and stooping, he found it to be one of his companions. He felt about him and found a torch, and lighting this, he saw the rest of the party lying about him. He started a fire, and not a moment too soon, for the cries of the animals were growing dangerously near; and a little while after he saw two bright eyes looking at him from out the darkness; then all about him he could see those glaring eyes. The number was growing, and Mr. Bruce becoming thoroughly alarmed, roused the others, and all gathering near the fire, waited for further developments. They were jackals, as nearly as the party could make out; and occasionally one a little bolder than the rest, would come within the circle of light; but a ball from one of the rifles would stop him, when his bloodthirsty comrades would jump on the body and devour it in an instant. They increased in numbers until those in the rear, crowding forward, pushed the foremost

nearer and nearer the fire, it became necessary to use the rifles as clubs and beat them back.

The situation had become most alarming when the roar of a lion almost in their midst struck terror to the hearts of the travelers, and made the jackals scamper off into the jungle. A crashing of the underbrush was followed by another mighty roar, and looking, our friends could just see, in the outer edge of light, two tawny monsters about to engage in a combat, evidently over the possession of a beautiful lioness which was moving about urging the lions on. The two lions sprang at each other simultaneously, and meeting in midair, down to the earth they fell, fastened together by teeth and claws. Over and over they rolled, biting and snarling, and striking murderous blows with their powerful paws. It was a magnificent battle, and in spite of bleeding wounds, raged furiously for a quarter of an hour, when, through loss of blood, the blows became weaker, and the biting less fierce. The royal combat was drawing to a close. Suddenly, as though determined to win or lose all in one final struggle they separated and once more came together in savage fury. A terrific blow from the paw of the one laid open the neck of the other, but not soon enough to check the fearful crunch of the powerful jaws upon the throat of his opponent, and in a moment the writhing mass lay quiet on the ground, dead.

Our friends had stood gazing at the awful fight with a horrible fascination, and it was some minutes before they could take their eyes off the fallen foes. When they did, and looked at the east they saw that dawn was breaking.

As the shadows faded before the rising sun the sounds from the forest grew less and less, until nothing was heard but the songs of the wakening birds. Slowly the dawn crept into the heavens. The gray turned to pink, the pink to a rich red and then to a yellow, and the sun rose in all its equatorial splendor. A mist hung over the landscape, but gradually this was dissipated before the hot rays of the sun, and the country and city of On lay before them.

They were standing on a small plateau on the eastern slope, a lofty range of mountains or cliffs. As far as the eye could reach westward, these mountains rose in perpendicular cliffs, thousands of feet into the air. A few miles east of them the range turned in a northerly direction, and extended on and on until the eye could follow it no farther. The mountain descended

about six hundred feet from where they were standing, and ended in a beautiful valley.

In their immediate vicinity was a dense jungle, and to the north of a magnificent forest. At the base of the mountain was a wide river, and on the opposite bank of this was a stone wall fifty feet in height. Beyond this wall stretched a beautiful valley, dotted with numerous groves and small lakes. To the northwest of them a few miles rose the tall towers of a vast and beautiful city, all glistening in the sunlight. The city rose from the valley to the top of a high hill on the summit of which was a grand structure, probably a temple.

The scene was ineffably grand, and our friends looked on it in wonder.

“Are you now convinced, Harry, that there are a few real things in Africa?” asked Enola.

“The scene before me would hardly convince me of this,” said Harry, “for everything seems too beautiful to be real.”

“Disabuse your mind of its being a dream?” said Enola. “It is a most sublime reality, and a happy ending to the horrors and sufferings of the cavern. But look, do you not see a body of horsemen yonder? Probably they saw our fire last night and are coming to investigate.”

The horsemen were lost to view for a moment but again appeared to the party as they came out on a clear stretch of road. In a short while the men had arrived at the wall, and opening a gate in this which was at the end of the bridge, they waited for our friends to approach. The travelers moved slowly toward them, and as they came nearer the men dismounted and made a respectful obeisance. These men were the handsomest and most beautifully formed ever looked upon. They were fully seven feet high, and their figures showed great strength and suppleness; their heads were rather small but beautifully shaped; the skin was a light bronze color, soft and healthful-looking; the face was covered with a short beard of dark brown color; the eyes were large, dark, and full of expression; the nose straight and well-proportioned.

Each wore a loose garment with large flowing sleeves; this tunic was belted in at the waist by a girdle of gold; sandals were fastened to the feet by golden lacings extending to the knee; a round helmet was worn on the head, but as our party approached these helmets were removed disclosing short curly heads of hair.

Their steeds were of the same species but much larger than the ordinary zebra, standing at least eighteen hands high; they were beautiful creatures, with small heads, arched necks and finely shaped bodies and limbs; stripes encircled them from the tip of the nose to the tail; the manes and tails nearly touched the ground.

The trappings of the animals were gorgeous; the bridle was of polished gold wire with large ostrich plumes reaching up from the head-piece; the reins and martingales were made of white leather heavily studded with precious stones which glistened in the sunlight; the saddle was flat, being nothing more than a pad made of cloth-of-gold and without stirrups.

As our friends approached them, the men stood leaning against their steeds, holding their helmets in their hands. The rest of the party having halted, Mr. Graham went up quite close to the natives and by signs made them understand that they were tired, and hungry, and wanted food and shelter. One of the men showed by signs that he knew that which Mr. Graham wished to convey, and that they would send to the city and get other beasts to carry them there. Four men now left the band and rode off toward the city, and about two hours later the adventurers were surprised to see approaching them a body of at least one thousand zebramen and in front six monstrous white elephants.

With the greatest care all were helped upon the backs of the royal beasts, but Enola was given the largest, whitest and most richly caparisoned. These elephants were partially covered with cloth-of-gold, and on each of their backs was a comfortable howdah shaded by a canopy of palm branches.

When all was in readiness they started with Enola's elephant in the lead. The cavalcade moved slowly over the beautiful highway on through green fields, along the shores of miniature lakes, over low eminences, past well-cultivated farms, under stately palms and eucalyptus trees until the white city was seen but a short distance away. Here some of the party left the cavalcade and rode on ahead.

Shortly after this the road widened into a wide well-paved boulevard, lined on each side by lofty trees, and bordered by beautiful villas built of an exquisite pinkish white stone which resembled Mexican onyx. These villas were broad and deep, and moderately high; a wide flight of steps led up to each entrance which was easily twenty-five feet high, and which was sheltered by a portico, with immense pillars supporting its roof. The

surrounding grounds were large, delightfully shaded and bright with flowers.

On the cavalcade moved, through the broad avenue, the houses becoming larger and more magnificent as they approached the centre of the city.

CHAPTER VI.

THE BANQUET.

They came at last to a large opening, at least one thousand feet square and paved with exquisite onyx. In the centre of this square was a huge column, surmounted by a statue of magnificent workmanship. Surrounding this statue were five immense fountains. In each was a heroic statue of a woman with her head thrown back, from whose mouth spouted a stream of water high into the air. The arms were outstretched with the palms of the hands turned upward, and from these also sprang streams of water. Beyond the fountain, facing the avenue through which they had entered the square, was a stone sphere ten feet in diameter, on the top of which was a beautifully carved chair of onyx inlaid with gold. A man was seated in this chair who was probably thirty-five years old and of immense build. As the cavalcade approached he arose, showing to the full his magnificent figure. This personage afterwards proved to be the King.

The square was thronged with the inhabitants of the city, the porticos and roofs of the surrounding houses being filled with the populace.

The men were magnificent specimens of the human race. The women were six feet six inches in height, of stately figure and dignified bearing; their heads were small but well-shaped; the hair was of a dark brown color fastened in a coil at the back of the neck. A band of gold passed around the forehead just below the hair and was studded with precious stones. They wore loose, flowing robes of white silken cloth drawn in at the waist with a girdle of gold; around each neck was a golden chain set with diamonds and opals; these chains were similar to those worn by the men but of finer workmanship.

As the King raised his hand the mighty throng broke forth in beautiful song, the King moving his hand right and left as if directing. The voices of

the men were deep and melodious, and those of the women soft and musical. When the song was finished, the King turned his back to our friends, and facing the magnificent building on the summit of the hill, made a movement with his right hand. The doors of the temple were thrown open, and a band of beautiful young girls came forth singing the same song that the populace had sung. Merrily these maidens came tripping toward the square, the great throng of people making an opening through which they could pass.

Upon reaching the space before the great sphere of stone, they waited for the occupant of the throne to descend, then fastening gold cords to the tusks of the elephants they led them toward the temple, the populace falling in behind. Slowly the maidens led the animals over the beautiful square, through the mass of eager and interesting people, all of whom made deep salaams as they passed on through the wide avenue which led to the temple and past the magnificent buildings to the summit of the hill. When nearing the temple ten men came forth, each wearing a long robe of embroidered white silk.

The elephants were stopped at the main entrance of the temple, and immediately fell to their knees, when the party dismounted. Carefully the priests assisted them to the pavement and then walked before them burning sweet smelling incense from silver vessels, which they swayed to and fro. Through a wide court with a lofty colonnade on either side, up a broad staircase with battlemented towers they proceeded, and then entered a hexagonal hall, one hundred and fifty feet square. From here they passed into a second court of quadrangular form. All around the court ran arcades, forming chambers or recesses open in front, with long silken curtains hanging from the top of the arcade, and caught up at the sides to be used when needed. The roofs of the chambers were supported by columns, the beauty of conception, and the exquisite finish of which, astonished our friends. The decorations were most elaborate. Nobly sculptured statues occupied spacious niches, and showed that those who executed them were masters of their art. The quadrangle itself was about three hundred and fifty feet square.

Enola was led by a priest to one of the semi-circular chambers and the curtains were drawn. Each of the others was shown to one of these recesses.

Enola, upon entering the chamber, looked about her and was surprised to see the preparations made for her. In the centre of the chamber was a beautiful designed square onyx table, supported by four spheres. Upon this table, in great profusion lay girdles and circles of gold, all heavily studded with diamonds and opals, similar to those worn by the native women but of more exquisite design; also gold pins, bottles of gold, filled with delightful perfumes, golden combs and highly polished mirrors of silver. Upon a smaller table at the far end of the chamber was a ewer filled with perfumed water. Near this table, resting on an onyx sphere, was placed an extinguished lamp of fine workmanship. Couches were in various places in this luxurious apartment; upon one of them lay a gown of silk and gold with short flowing sleeves, and near it another gown of pinkish white silk which was evidently meant to be worn as an undergarment.

Across the end of the chamber were hung heavy silk curtains, which, when parted, disclosed a bath sunken in the floor. About the bath stood six of the maidens who had conducted the party to the temple. The maidens stood motionless watching Enola as if waiting for her to come to the bath. Enola hesitated for a moment, then determined to accept the situation and walked towards the bath. The maidens disrobed her, and leading her into the bath, forced her gently backward in a reclining position with her head resting on an onyx head-piece, and then poured the perfume from the golden vessels over her body, rubbing her gently with a silken towel while doing so.

She being tired and worn out, the luxury of the perfumed bath, with the pleasing treatment of the maidens, rested and refreshed her.

After remaining in the bath for some time the maidens raised her in their arms, and carrying her to a couch laid her down and rubbed the moist skin until it was perfectly dry. They then sprinkled scented powder over her body, rubbing it gently; then motioning her to arise, the undergarment was thrown over her shoulders, after which one of the maidens dressed her hair in a low knot on the back of her head. A band of gold was placed over her forehead and then the outer robe was donned. This was fastened in at the waist by a girdle of gold; the necklace from Harding's neck was brought to her, but Enola noticed that none of the maidens touched it with their naked hands, and she soon divined that in some way her royal reception was connected with the necklace and its flame-colored stone. Enola was then led

to an alcove before which a curtain was hung, and then the curtain being drawn aside she found the alcove faced on either side with polished silver mirrors. She was surprised at the lovely picture she presented, in rich gown and golden bands around her head and waist, making her appear like an ancient Egyptian goddess.

The long tramp through the cavern with its scarcity of water and clean garments had left Enola in a pitiable plight, and this sudden change was most gratifying to the natural pride of the woman. Enola was next conducted to a couch and a pair of sandals were fitted to her shapely feet; these were laced as far as the knee with silken cords. One of the maidens left them for a few moments, and upon her return, motioned to Enola and the others to follow her. They passed into the quadrangular court and from here into one of the other semi-circular chambers. Here on a long onyx table was spread a sumptuous repast.

Enola was led to a seat or couch at the head of the table, and half reclining upon the soft cushions, while waiting for her friends, looked in wonderment at the elaborate prodigality in the equipment of the room.

The sides of the chamber were hung with heavy silk curtains alternating white and red, on which scenes of the chase, of banqueting and of worship were gorgeously embroidered with gold thread. Exquisite sculptures rested upon spherical pedestals. Lion, tiger and leopard skins covered the floor, and upon the ceiling, beautifully carved, was an immense eagle with outstretched wings, the tips reaching almost to the ends of the chamber. In the talons of the eagle was a scroll upon which were engraved strange hieroglyphics. At one end of the chamber a human skeleton was standing, the only discordant object in the entire furnishings. The table was of semi-circular form, and was covered with flowers, fruits and chalices of wine. The flowers were held in high, beautifully carved vases of gold and were profuse and fragrant. In the center of the table a tiny fountain threw forth a spray of perfumed water.

Enola was lost in admiration and did not hear a slight noise behind her, and was suddenly startled by the immense figure of the King as he entered and stood before her. She motioned him to the couch and he sank down beside her. He kept his eyes intently upon her, but noticing his look of respectful admiration Enola was half amused, and soon began a conversation by signs all of which were readily understood by the King.

The rest of the party now came in, each of the ladies accompanied by three maids, and the men by two male servitors each.

Nellie and Mrs. Graham were attired much the same as Enola; Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce and Harry were dressed as the native men, but their garments were of a finer quality of silk.

Upon entering the chamber the male servitors retired and six maidens took their places. Nellie was given a seat next to Enola, and next to her came Mr. Bruce and then Harry; Mrs. Graham sat next to the King with her husband at her left.

When all were seated, a strain of exquisite music from some hidden orchestra of stringed instruments burst forth. The King gave a command and fifteen maidens came tripping in singing a pretty song, their harmonious voices blending deliciously with the music. Seven of the maidens carried gold dishes containing chipped ice, while the others carried cups in one hand and a vase of honey in the other. They rested the cups on the tables and after filling them partly with honey added wine from the chalices and then dropped into the cups some of the chipped ice, stirring this gently with small golden ladles. This done they stepped back and the King raising his cup, waited for the others to do so; when they had done this the King arose and looking toward the skeleton at the end of the room, raising his cup and saying a few words, drank the contents. All had followed the King in his movements, and as the cool beverage touched their lips it seemed that they had never tasted anything half so sweet or refreshing. Months had passed since they had known such luxuries as ice and wine and they emptied their cups almost greedily, hoping that the etiquette of the feast would allow them to drink long and unsparingly of the delicious beverage.

The maidens bore the cups away, and others brought in trays containing small silken napkins and golden finger bowls filled with perfumed water. Other maidens brought in trays, covered with figs, fresh herbs, chipped ice and eggs of a peculiar kind in tiny cups of gold.

Thus far not a word had been spoken; the King, however, seemed surprised at the silence, and probably surmising the reason pointed to his lips and then to the guests, making them understand that he would like to hear them talk. Enola took upon herself to instruct the King as far as possible in English, pointing to different articles on the table and then

naming them. Onrai, for this was the King's name, named the articles slowly after her and then gave the names in his native tongue.

Mr. Bruce, who had listened intently to the names given the articles by the King, and who had carefully studied a piece of papyrus upon which the King had inscribed some characters when passed to him, declared the characters to be Egyptian hieroglyphics or closely resembling them. He had been a close student of the Egyptian hieroglyphics while at college, and had spent many spare moments in the great British museum going over the ancient inscriptions in the vast collection of that home of relics. He had noticed also the inscription upon the pennant held in the eagle's talons on the ceiling, and the characters above the skeleton at the end of the room. All these convinced him that the strange people around him had originally come from Egypt, but it must have been thousands of years before, for the language and written characters of the ancient Egyptians had been obsolete for centuries. The skeleton in the banqueting hall was an old Egyptian custom, and this but added to the belief that these people had originally sprung from that race.

"One would think," said Harry, "that we had been taken from the world of hurry and bustle which we so recently knew, and set back two or three thousand years into this ancient city."

"Yes, it all seems very strange," said Mr. Bruce, "but I must admit there is novelty in the change at least, and for my part I am enjoying it immensely."

"Well, I never expected to find iced wine in the heart of Africa," said Mr. Graham.

"Nor I," said Mrs. Graham, "nor cups of gold from which to drink it."

"Truly, we must have discovered a city of the gods," exclaimed Mr. Graham.

"Yes," said Mr. Bruce, "one could easily imagine from the beauty of the city, the stateliness and courtesy of the people, and the delights of the feast, that we have dropped into something supernatural."

The music changed to a livelier measure, and the maidens tripped more lightly to and fro as the feast progressed. Roast kid with wine sauce, composed the third course, and when this was removed, the finger bowls were again passed among the guests. Then, after more iced wine and honey,

a delicate kind of fish was served, after which came fowl, followed by sliced fruits covered with shaved ice, and accompanied by a new and delicious wine. The feast ended, the King arose, and leading the way with Enola at his side, passed into the large court, where they witnessed a magnificent entertainment.

CHAPTER VII.

THE LAW OF THE LAND OF ON.

Four weeks of constant enjoyment passed. The greatest kindness had been shown the explorers by both king and subjects. The most sumptuous repasts were set before them; the most beautiful robes were presented to them, and the most glorious entertainments gotten up for their delight. Their attendants anticipated their least desires and the King himself personally supervised the festivities. Great hunts had been projected and carried out; excursions through the beautiful country had been made on the backs of white elephants; points of interest in the city had been visited; moonlight rambles through the beautiful groves had been taken, and there seemed no prospect of diminution of enjoyment.

They were living under the laws of three thousand years ago. Little had been learned of their history or religion, for they had not become sufficiently acquainted with the language to have these things imparted to them. With Mr. Bruce's help, however, they had learned that these people were closely affiliated with the ancient Egyptians. Onrai had promised to give the party some of the laws that night.

During the four weeks which had passed so pleasantly, the adventurers had studied closely the people and their country. The rays of the sun were intensely hot during the day, but owing to the thickness of the onyx walls of the temple and the system by which air was forced over blocks of ice, the apartments were delightfully pleasant and cool. The streets during the day were deserted, but as evening came on the people would leave their homes and promenade the principal thoroughfares and squares, enjoying the cool and refreshing breezes which sprung up from the south as the day declined. The people themselves were the most remarkable feature of this strange

country. The women stood fully six feet and six inches high and the men seven feet.

Another very noticeable thing was the total absence of aged people. In all their excursions they had not met a man or woman who looked to be past middle life. Had they discovered a fountain of youth, which, when bathed in, gave them a long lease on life with health and beauty? No cripples or infirm people were seen, all being robust and healthy. All resembled each other. It could be seen that their dispositions varied to some extent but not radically, since all seemed inspired by the same motives. They were easy in their movements and very graceful.

After four weeks of studying these people and their lives, our friends considered them the happiest mortals they had ever known, for they did not seem to have a care or trouble in the world.

That evening Onrai took the evening meal with them as usual and after this was over, and they had repaired to the large court, Enola said:

“Onrai, you promised to tell us of your laws to-night and we are waiting patiently to learn the government of such a happy people.”

“Our laws are simply nature’s law,” said Onrai. “In the first place, the laws governing our physical welfare are very strict, for we believe that happiness springs from a strong constitution and a healthy body. Our tables are spread with an abundance of viands, but just so much must be eaten and no more. We have certain hours for work and certain hours for entertainment and recreation; the hours for work are few, because we believe that overwork is injurious to the constitution and this we always try to prevent. Our people are educated in religious laws and language between the ages of seven and twelve.”

“Who are the teachers?” asked Enola.

“We are all teachers,” answered Onrai. “In our temples of learning all above the age of twenty have their days for teaching. This is considered one of the lightest duties, and we arrange the days so that they may come directly after those of the hardest toil.”

“But is it with all other occupations as it is with teaching?” asked Mr. Graham. “Do you not assign certain work to those who are most proficient in that work?”

“We have none who are more proficient in one thing than another,” answered Onrai. “Between the ages of twelve and twenty, our young people devote certain hours each day to the study of trades and professions. They may work for two weeks on a farm, and for the next two weeks study architecture, and so on until they arrive at the age of twenty, when they are as well versed in one thing as in another.”

“But are there no differences in the intellects of the people?” asked Mr. Graham. “Are not some brighter and more clever than others?”

“No,” said Onrai. “Our duties are simple and easily learned, and when we have once mastered them thoroughly, what difference would it make, if, as you say, some should be brighter than others.”

“But,” said Enola, “Do you not have those who go beyond the things taught them and develop new principles and invent new contrivances, which might make their duties less irksome, their labors less arduous?”

“No, we have none such,” said Onrai, “or, if we have, their ideas never take shape or form, for the one great law is to be content with what is taught us. Look about you, see this beautiful country, the grand palaces, the statuary and paintings; could we conceive of more beautiful architecture, or grander statuary, with which to adorn these beautiful palaces? No, I think not. We have certain lines to follow in architecture, certain forms to copy in our statuary, and certain rules to observe in our painting, and these lead to but the one thing, and that is, perfection, which, when once reached cannot be surpassed.”

“Tell us more of the laws,” said Mr. Graham.

“After the physical welfare of our people is looked after, we make it imperative that they study, and learn and adhere to the laws governing the spiritual being. Our religion teaches us that if we abuse the body and die before our time we shall not enter the great hereafter; we shall be condemned to everlasting punishment. This religious law, and the dire future for those who break it, makes all observe it, and consequently you see no sick or infirm about you. We are taught to believe in one God, and live so that we may enter a home of everlasting bliss when we have lived out our lives on this earth.”

“Tell us how you punish murder and stealing,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Stealing, murder?” asked Onrai.

“Yes, taking from another that which belongs to him, either property or life.”

“These are unknown to us,” said Onrai. “We are all equal; we have the same duties to perform, the same garments to wear, the same things to eat and drink. Why should we take from another that which we have ourselves?”

“Is there no buying and selling?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“No,” said Onrai, “We all share alike. When a citizen wants a certain article he has but to ask for it and it is his. We have an abundance of all things, at all times and it is as free to one as to another.”

“What are your laws concerning marriage?” inquired Enola.

“Our religious laws govern this,” replied Onrai. “At the age of eighteen the young people are taken before a council of ten and a careful examination is made of both physical and mental health. These examinations are reported on tablets and at the age of twenty they are again summoned and a husband or wife is allotted.”

“But love,” said Mrs. Graham, “does not love enter into the compact at all?”

“No”, said Onrai, “We are taught by our religion, not to allow ourselves to love until married. Those, who from association learn to seek one young person more than another, are brought before the council of ten and steps are taken to prevent a recurrence. It is by this law that we have attained a point in physical culture which shows a race of healthy, strong and vigorous beings. In the course of events there are occasional errors which render it necessary to forbid the further production of children. When the young people are examined, if any organ seems at all weak a companion is selected in whom that organ is at its best. If three decided weaknesses are found, the person is not allowed to marry. Dispositions and tempers are also considered by the council before selection is made. We, of course, in our short lives, cannot notice the great effects such a method brings about, but reason tells us that it must be a safeguard to the strength of the people.”

“But what of the history of your people, Onrai?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“Our history is unknown to us,” said Onrai. “The history of the people is not divulged. They know the events which occur during their own lives, and that is all. At the expiration of each king’s reign, the history of his reign in

inscribed on a tablet of hard wood, and this is placed in a secret chamber. Those who are living at the time of his death are forbidden to ever mention the events of his reign when his successor has ascended to the throne.”

“We are greatly disappointed,” said Mr. Bruce. “We have become very much interested in your country and people, and we had hoped that we might learn their history.”

Onrai at this moment called an attendant to him, and speaking a few words to him the attendant withdrew. Presently the High Priest came forward, and Onrai held quite a conversation with him, after which he turned to our friends, and said:

“The High Priest informs me that he knows of no law which would forbid your entering this secret chamber, and there read from the tablets the history of our country and people.”

Our friends were much surprised at being granted this privilege, and thanking Onrai, they repaired to the Secret Chamber with the High Priest. While going to the chamber with the priest, he informed the party that he was entrusted with certain religious secrets which the rest of the people were not allowed to know, but as far as the history of the country was concerned he was forbidden, as were all others, to consult the tablets. Upon arriving at the Secret Chamber, a secret spring was touched, and an immense stone door turned on a pivot, much the same as the door to the cave. After entering the Priest showed them the location of the secret spring on the inside, and also the location of the most ancient tablets, and then retired. The great gate swung shut and they were left alone in the immense chamber which contained the unknown records of the history of On. They removed a great number of tablets, until those bearing the earliest dates were uncovered, and found them in a state of excellent preservation. With Mr. Bruce’s knowledge of ancient hieroglyphics he was able to decipher most of the inscriptions; by deciphering certain portions it was not difficult to fill in between without the labor of actual translation. The research stretched over several days, but condensed, the account ran as follows:

“During the reign of Amenophis of Egypt, the country was scourged by numerous and grievous plagues, and the people were sorely tried. These plagues were inflicted upon the Egyptians by the God of the Israelites, as a punishment for the severe treatment of the latter race. One Moses, who had been reared in the royal house of the Pharaohs as a son, adopted the

religion of the Israelites and was chosen by them for their leader to deliver them out of the land of Egypt. But they had no remedy at hand and still bowed in submission to the fearful task imposed upon them until Moyses at last saw a favorable opportunity for their deliverance. Reminding them of their former freedom, and of the God of their fathers, and that their cause was His, he prevailed upon them to regard their deliverance as an article of religion, and they again became a united people in their determination to seek refuge from the oppression of the Egyptians in the wilderness, which was the dwelling place of their kindred and the seat of their God. Then the fearful plagues were visited upon the people of Egypt and they became desperate.

“Many Egyptians in the vicinity of Goshen, the dwelling place of the Israelites, had accepted the religion of that people, and seeing no end to the plagues which were scourging this country, they gathered together and determined to emigrate to some distant land where they could live in peace and happiness, and without fear of molestation from their idolatrous countrymen. At the final meeting of these people, On, of the city of Goshen, and the land of Egypt, was chosen as their leader, and it was determined to follow the Nile as far as expedient, until they had reached such a land as would suit them for a dwelling place. It is I, On, who am now inscribing this record. There were six thousand and six hundred of us, men, women and children. To leave Egypt together would create suspicion, so choosing forty sub-commanders, an equal number of companies set out at stated intervals and marched until the southern boundary of the country had been crossed, when all were consolidated and marched into the vast interior. When all were united, preparations were made for the great journey. Boats were built, and many provisions were procured, for we knew not the country into which we were going, or how long it would take to reach a desirable land in which to take up our abode. When all was in readiness we embarked in the boats and followed the Nile until coming to the many streams which comprise its source. Here we disembarked, leaving the boats in the river. Towards the south we marched, the journey being very slow, tedious, and fraught with much sickness and danger. Strange tribes of people we met, much darker in color than we, and very hostile. We struggled on for many weary leagues, fighting the strange people and being a prey to fever and wild beasts. Our band was altogether discouraged; still I

pleaded with them, telling them that we would, sooner or later, come to an uninhabited country with fertile fields and cooling streams.

“We came at last to a lofty range of mountains, running north and south, extending, peak beyond peak, far to the westward. Following the mountains south, for many leagues farther, the range suddenly turned west. Still following along their base, we came to a beautiful open country. Here we decided to take up our dwelling.

“We had been here but a short time when one of the men discovered a hole in the side of the mountain. Ten men were sent to explore the vast cave which this opening led into. At the end of three days they returned and told us that an immense lake of water had stopped their further progress, and that they had returned for boats. These were made, and with them the men again started. Many times did the sun rise and set before they again returned, but at last they came with a story which made us all joyful. They had crossed the lake but had been lost on the opposite shore, and had wandered for many days until they saw a ray of light and making for it found an opening which led into a beautiful country, stretching far to the west and north. They explored a part of the country, finding numerous lakes and rivers, and then returned to tell of the wonderful hidden land.

“After a consultation it was determined to pass through the mountains and take up a permanent abode beyond. Preparations were made and together we started. The lake was crossed, the opening found and we reached the country which was to be the scene of our remaining life and death. Our numbers were taken, and it was found that during the two years’ march to this land we had lost more than half of our band. But three thousand and two hundred remained of the six thousand and six hundred which had started from Egypt. Fifteen hundred of those remaining were men, the women and children having succumbed more readily to the hardships of the journey.

“A site for a city was picked out and a part of the country cultivated. Our land abounded in wild animals and fruits so we were well-provided with food. A quarry of beautiful hard stone was found and we determined to build our city of this. The architects drew up the plans for the city and work was commenced. The Temple, which when finished will be the grandest which the world has ever known, will stand in the northern end of the city on a slight eminence. The streets are to be broad and paved. At frequent

distances will be squares for public amusement, and parks for recreation will be placed conveniently near the city. We made two discoveries which have helped us in the manufacture of necessary implements and added to our comfort. A mine of gold was found, and in a cavern through which the wind rushes like a blast from a mountain of snow we found a lake of pure ice. This ice was of great thickness and it took us a great while to cut through it. We have also a mountain of iron, a field of diamonds and a forest of wood so hard that we find great difficulty in cutting it. On blocks of this wood I am now inscribing the infant history of our country.

“I am growing very old. My people have increased rapidly and great work has been done. The City and Temple are fast nearing completion; most of the streets are paved with hard stone and cultivated fields are about us; we have measured the length and breadth of our country and find that it is nearly three hundred miles square. We have driven the wild animals from our cultivated land into a section near the mountains, and at the border of this vast land of jungle and forest we are building a wall fifty feet high to keep the animals within bounds. We also built a stone viaduct to cross the lake in the cavern and several across the river which flows at the base of the southern mountains. During the building of these viaducts hundreds were engaged in keeping the laborers furnished with meat, the animals being skinned and dressed for food in the cavern. The inhabitants who died during the first twenty years of our settlement here were embalmed, and their bodies placed in the niches of the rock in the cavern. After this date the dead were cremated and this is now a law. I am now ninety years old and we have been in this country fifty years. The city and country has been named “ON,” in honor of me, because I led the people to it, and I have been the people’s chosen King since we left Egypt. I have laid down the laws which are to govern the people for all time. These laws I have made simple and just, guarding against any contingency or cause for dissension, profiting by the experiences of other countries. I have tried to formulate laws which will not allow of jealousies or covetousness.

“Again, the laws are aimed to make a race of people grand in physical strength and beautiful in moral character. All are equal in the eyes of the law. All are made to work at the different vocations. All are furnished with the same provisions and raiment. The best artisans have laid down rules to be followed by the people in architecture, sculpture, painting, and in the making of ornaments. The best agriculturists, the foremost of our

quarrymen and miners have made new inventions and laid down rules which will lighten and facilitate their labors.

“To the religion taught by the Israelites I have added nothing. From their teachings I learned that they expected to have the Son of their God visit them at some future time. They also taught us that there was a great and eternal hereafter which was to be entered into after death, and I have made this hereafter so bright and beautiful that my countrymen will hail with delight their day of death. I have also made it possible to stop the over-increase of our people by a certain law. To guard against intemperate habits of any kind, by which so many diseases and so much unhappiness are brought into the world, I have established a law that all dying because of intemperance or over-indulgence in any of the necessary things of life will enter into everlasting punishment. I have made the delights of our future life so bright that my people will guard against everything which might bring on disease and premature death. Already the effects of these laws have been seen, for disease is passing away and my people are striving in every way to live until their day of death.

“I alone of the many Kings who are to follow me am allowed to reign for so many years. I have given myself the right to reign thus long because I wish to have my laws well-established before abdicating in favor of another. I have found that some of the laws first laid down were defective and by still retaining my sceptre I have been able to correct them. To the High Priest I have given certain knowledge which is denied the remainder of the people, and this knowledge is to be guarded by him as a sacred commandment to be imparted only to his successor.

“The language of my forefathers I have changed but little. I have added some few words from the language of the Israelites and a few from the Syriac. I have made the language as simple as possible as well as the hieroglyphics. The history of the reign of each King shall be inscribed on tablets of wood and placed in the secret chamber of the Temple but the people are to know nothing of their former history. This is done to keep them from knowing anything of the outside world. I wish them to believe that the world is bounded by the mountains which enclose their country; for thus believing they will remain together and will never undertake needless excursions into other countries, which would result in war and bloodshed. I

wish them to be a peaceable, law-abiding people believing that they are the people and that theirs is the only country.

“I have fitted to the opening in the mountain a stone turning on pivots and opening by a secret spring, of which I alone know the secret. Those who fitted the stone were forbidden to speak of it and they have long since died, and the laws forbidding access to the inscribed history have been so well kept that none of my countrymen to-day are aware of the existence of an outside world.

“This is not a history, but a simple outline of the events which led to our emigration, the long journey, and the discovery of the country and the laws which I have made. I have inscribed this during my few leisure hours more for recreation than aught else. The history of our people and country will be found inscribed on the King’s tablets.

“I have made the one holiday of the Land of On, ‘The Day of Resis,’ and this day, if all of my laws are adhered to, will be the happiest day in the lives of those who participate in its ceremonies.”

CHAPTER VIII.

THE ROYAL HUNT.

Mrs. Graham had, during the past few weeks, given herself up to the comforts of her delightful boudoir, seldom accompanying her friends on the many excursions which were projected for their pleasure. The splendid attendance, the magnificent apartment, the sumptuous table, all tended to make her new life a happy one. It was just suited to the fastidious tastes of such a woman as Mrs. Graham, and she had determined to startle her native city with a reproduction of many of its delightful features.

Nellie had enjoyed the new life quite as much as her mother but in a different way. With Mr. Bruce she had visited every nook and corner of the Temple, and had taken sketches of the principal courts, colonnades and terraces, intending to copy them in oil at home. Then they had taken long walks through the city and visited the schools in which Nellie was especially interested; had remained one whole day in the provision market, where the inhabitants went each morning for the day's supplies, and another in the mills where the cloth for wearing apparel was woven. They had spent many happy hours in the fine art studio, where beautiful statues were being carved out of blocks of onyx, and where pictures were being painted on flat pieces of hard wood.

There was also the school of architecture, where students between the ages of twelve and twenty were busy working out the difficult problems and drawings. In this building also were made the gold ornaments which were used in every household in rich profusion, in the shape of girdles for the waist, bands and ornaments for the hair. It was noticed that certain models were used for all these different works of fine art, and that nothing new was ever executed. As Onrai had told them, though, the models were perfect and nothing more beautiful could be conceived. They had also visited the parks,

squares and principal thoroughfares, and had taken an interest in studying the architecture and furnishings of the different residences. All places were open to them and the greatest attention was paid them wherever they went.

This constant association and similarity of tastes had brought these two closer together, and although Mr. Bruce had never yet mentioned his love to Nellie, still he felt that she reciprocated that love.

Mr. Graham, sometimes accompanied by Harry, but oftener alone, had gone everywhere. He was in his element, for, astride of a beautiful zebra, he would take long rides into the country and spend whole days fishing on the small lakes, or at other times, would venture a short distance into the great hunting reserve. In this grand expanse of wild jungle and forest could be found every known species of African animal, and Mr. Graham was especially delighted in the hunting of large game. The laws governing these hunts were rather strange; the smallest of each species of animal was killed, the largest always being left. The same laws which governed the inhabitants were applied to the wild animals and also to those domesticated, allowing the larger to mate and bring forth healthy offspring. If a colt or baby elephant should be dwarfed at birth, or show any ailment afterward, it was instantly killed. By observing this law with the domestic animals, and in killing only the smaller of the wild animals, the whole race had become large and powerful.

Harry seemed to be the only unhappy one in the party. This was easily accounted for. During the long excursions the King would be at Enola's side constantly, and Harry had hardly found time to speak with her alone since they had arrived in this, as he called it, barbarous land. Onrai always dined with the party and sat at Enola's right. Harry had been given a seat the farthest from her; whether this was done intentionally or not, Harry could not say, but he fumed in silence. After the evening meal, Enola would invariably accompany Onrai to the terrace where they would sit until near midnight. Occasionally Harry would have a short talk with Enola in the morning, but even then their conversation was of Onrai.

Sedai had been given a home with one of the inhabitants and was enjoying the new life greatly. He had been given a zebra and spent most of the time on its back. Once each day he would go to the Temple to see his friends, and while there would tell of his exploits among the fair woman of the city. Because he was one of the party he was looked upon with great

admiration. As he was but little below the height of the native men and was only a shade darker in color, the inhabitants had been led to believe that he was one of their own race, but had in some mysterious way left his own land and visited that planet from which the strangers were supposed to have come. The women smiled on him, the men treated him with the greatest respect and he could hardly help liking this new life. He had come up to the Temple on this morning to join the party in the royal hunt.

The rifles which our friends had brought with them they had never used for fear of the natives coveting them when they learned their value in the hunt, but now they felt, because of the great respect which had been shown them, that they and everything pertaining to them was held as sacred by the natives, and they had decided to use the guns on to-day's hunt.

The morning was bright and the hour early when the party started. Enola and her friends were seated on huge black elephants with long formidable tusks and trained to the hunt. Around the neck and also around the body, just back of the howdah of each elephant was a band of gold, in which were embedded the handles of large pointed daggers, the blades pointing outward. These were placed for the protection of the elephants and of those who rode them. The rest of the party rode zebras which were to-day only plainly caparisoned. The weapons of the natives consisted of large cross-bows with quivers of flint-pointed arrows, daggers with long, narrow blades and axes with short handles.

About one hundred comprised the party, all well armed and impatient for the hunt. They traversed the same road over which our friends had been conducted when they first came to the city, and very soon passed through a huge gate on the border of the hunting reserve and then across the long stone bridge. Before going through the gate, the zebramen had all dismounted, leaving the zebras to graze in a near-by field until they returned. These men were to beat and cut the bush, to stir up the game and also to make a pathway for the hunters. The footmen went forward, and with huge clubs in one hand and axes in the other, opened up a passageway. A little while later an open forest was reached and passed; the trees of this forest were literally alive with monkeys which chattered and made grimaces as the party passed. Deer were seen scampering away, and occasionally a huge boa constrictor could be seen crawling through the high grass or suspended from the limb of a tree waiting for its prey. On the

opposite side of the forest a thick and almost impenetrable jungle confronted them, but the bush-beaters went to work again and a way was opened up.

Suddenly a roar was heard which was almost deafening. The elephants stopped and began to move their huge ears forward and back and give short cries similar to those of a baby. The men immediately scattered, dividing equally and moving to the right and left. Soon they had formed a circle about two hundred feet in diameter, and then commenced to close in toward the centre. This was slow work but they knew that it would not last long, as the lion or lioness would make a dash for liberty or jump at one of the party. Mr. Graham had directed his elephant near the circle and from his elevated point of view he could occasionally catch a glimpse of a tail above the bush. The men were slowly closing in on the lion and Mr. Graham held his rifle in readiness to get the first shot. Suddenly the lion raised on his haunches so that his head appeared above the bush. This was enough for Mr. Graham, and taking a quick aim at the head, he fired. The lion dropped, and the natives stood aghast at the sound of the shot and the sudden flash of fire and smoke which followed. Mr. Graham slipped from the back of the elephant and made for the bush and, with the help of an axe, which he was wielding, was fast nearing the lion, when the huge beast leaped into the air and struck him fairly on the side of the head. Mr. Bruce, who had half-expected something of the kind, had been waiting for the lion to leap, and as he appeared above the bushes, had aimed at a point just behind the brute's shoulder and fired. Mr. Graham had been stunned by the powerful blow of the lion and Mrs. Graham screamed and fainted. Leaving the backs of their elephants, Onrai, Harry and Mr. Bruce hurried to their companion's assistance, and soon reached the spot where he and the lion lay together. He was insensible and bleeding badly from his wound and with the lion lying dead over his lower limbs. Harry and Mr. Bruce called some of the natives, and together they moved the body of the lion, after which they carried Mr. Graham to an open place where his wound was washed and wine being poured between his lips he was soon restored to consciousness. Mrs. Graham was revived by Enola and Nellie, and Mr. Graham refusing to return, he again took his place in the howdah and the hunting party proceeded after leaving a number of the natives behind to skin the lion.

Mr. Bruce's shot had struck the lion just behind the right shoulder and the bullet had penetrated the heart. It was lucky for Mr. Graham that it did so,

for the lion, being maddened with pain, would soon have torn him to pieces. The King and his men looked at the lion carefully, turning it over and over, trying to find the marks of wounds such as their arrows would have made. Harry took his rifle, and handing it to the King, showed him how to hold it properly, and then how to aim it, telling him to aim at one of the lion's paws. He did so, and pulled the trigger. The King dropped the gun as soon as it was discharged, alarmed at the loud report it had made so near his ears. Harry and the King went up to the lion and pointing to its huge paw, Harry showed Onrai the hole made by the bullet. He was greatly surprised, but could not understand it. Harry then showed him one of the cartridges and explained to him how the concussion caused the powder to ignite, forcing the bullet from the tube and through the gun-barrel with such swiftness as to penetrate anything that it came in contact with. Onrai slowly shook his head as if it were still a puzzle to him.

They again took up the march through the jungle, and presently came to a large stream which must have found its outlet in the river at the base of the mountains. They followed the bank of the river for some distance, until they came to a stone bridge over which they passed. Another open forest was entered, and here was seen the first herd of elephants. Upon catching sight of the elephants which our friends were riding, the curiosity of the herd was aroused, and they came crowding about the hunting party by scores. So quick had been their movements that the men on foot had time to do nothing but climb trees. These elephants were huge monsters, but did not seem ill-disposed towards our friends. They were very curious, and could not understand the queer things on the necks and backs of the domesticated elephants. They came crowding around our friends, shoving their trunks up into their faces and under the saddle-cloths, as if trying to find out all they could about these strange visitors. Occasionally one would come too close to the elephants of our party, and would be pricked by the long daggers about their bodies, when it would give a cry and retreat. The tame elephants paid no attention to the others, seeming to consider them as beneath their notice. They probably looked upon these denizens of the forest as our friends would on a band of savages. Their curiosity satisfied, they slowly retreated through the forest, throwing their enormous trunks into the trees and breaking off limbs half the size of a man's body. The men came down from the trees and the party again took up the march.

They had proceeded but a short distance when a shriek of terror from Mrs. Graham caused all to look in her direction. A huge gorilla had sprung from a neighboring tree and seized her with his powerful arm, showing his white teeth and chattering wildly. For an instant all was confusion. Harry sprang to the rescue and before the animal could drag Mrs. Graham from the elephant, his rifle was emptied of its deadly load and the gorilla laid writhing on the ground.

With two such experiences in such a short time it was deemed expedient to abandon the hunt for the day, and though Mrs. Graham was sorry to cause this break in the programme she could not but admit her desire to leave a place so fraught with danger. So back through the jungle and forest, over the bridge and through the gate, and along the white road, the cool evening breeze now refreshing them after the fearful heat of the day, the party made its way toward the city.

CHAPTER IX.

THE GOLD MINE AND CAVE OF ICE.

The shock of the day before had left Mrs. Graham in a very nervous condition. Having arrived at the Temple, she was given into the hands of her attendants, who soon had her in the perfumed bath, and with a treatment much resembling our massage, she was soon brought out of her nervousness. Still to-day she was far from feeling like herself, and when Onrai had proposed a trip to the gold mine and quarries, she declined to go.

Mr. Graham, having already visited these places, decided to remain with his wife.

Onrai had each day since their arrival, projected some novel excursion or entertainment for our friends, the preparation for these always being both elaborate and complete. So much of interest was to be seen in this strange city and country, our friends never tired of these excursions. Many things were seen which contrasted favorably with similar contrivances in their own country. The streets were paved with the beautiful onyx, and were always scrupulously clean. There were no sidewalks, the pavements stretching from lawn to lawn. These pavements were cleaned once a day with a combination of sweeper, watering cart and dirt gatherer in one, which did its work most effectually. The contrivance, but for the material used in its construction, the striped animals pulling it, and the queer costumes of the drivers, would have caused no comments on the streets of an American city; for it looked like the invention of some modern genius.

This had been used, however, as had every other contrivance or machine, since the foundation of the city. In fact, the city or country must have been founded by a race who had reached a high point in civilization, for their architecture, their fine arts, their implements of manufacture and farming, all showed deep thought, careful study, and great knowledge of the

principles involved. And the laws which were made to govern the people were perfect, and, being carried out, left perfect results.

But our friends had not seen all the wonders of this strange country, or the works of its people; nor had Onrai given to Enola or the rest of the strangers, any idea of the immense resources of this land. They had many things to learn still, and one thing in particular, which would startle and surprise them. Our friends were happy though, and not one of them had as yet given a thought to the returning to their homes. This life was so pleasant, every feature of it so enjoyable, they had little time or desire to think of aught else. The time would come, however, when a longing to see their friends left behind, to once more taste the delights and pleasures of modern civilization, to be where people talked and acted as themselves, would take such hold on them that they would wonder how they ever could have found any pleasure in this strange city and among a people which knew nothing, or cared to know nothing, but what had passed down to them from the founder of this country, who had lived thousands of years before.

But as yet this longing had not come to disturb their peaceful thoughts, and to-day, as they were about to start on another excursion to see more of the wonders of this strange country, they were never happier. As was customary on such occasions, our friends were mounted on the white elephants, accompanied by the king and ten zebramen, who acted as an escort.

Their first stop was to be at the onyx quarries, five miles distant. They started early, so as to reach the farthest point before the middle of the day, when the heat was so intense, it was hard to withstand it.

Their way led through a broad avenue lined on either side by tall palms, back of which were beautiful palaces, the large entrances being open, showing their dark, cool interiors. Many of the inhabitants were also on the street, enjoying the fresh morning breeze. Some were lounging about the broad terraces, while others were seated on onyx chairs, in the great gardens surrounding each house.

The sun, just rising above the eastern mountain, the songs of the birds, the perfume of the flowers wafted to them by the cool morning breeze, the beautiful palaces with the white-robed inhabitants lounging about them, the broad, paved avenue with the white elephants and beautiful zebras, moving stately along it, left but one thought in the minds of our friends, namely, that

they would willingly brave the hardships, trials and dangers of their past journey, for this one short hour in the beautiful city of On. The paved avenue reached on as far as the Cave of Ice, which the party was to visit before their return.

At last the immense quarry of onyx was reached, and our friends stood in wonder, gazing at its great extent. At least forty acres of onyx had already been taken from the quarry, and huge blocks of the beautiful stone lay finished on the broad pavement, while others were being placed by means of levers, on rollers in readiness to be moved to the new building in course of construction in the city. Some of these blocks measured twenty feet in length, being five feet square.

These were moved to the city, and placed in position by means of rollers and derricks, the huge elephants doing most of the work. About the quarry were a great many beautiful columns, capitols, pedestals, stones for arches, balustrades, stairs, and roughly hewn statues, ready to be moved to the school of fine arts. A great many men were at work, all taking the greatest interest in their labors. The king explained that these men discontinued work at eleven o'clock, and were through for the day. At three o'clock another body of men went to work, and continued until seven in the evening. The following morning another body of men would take up the work, and so on, until each company of workingmen had taken their turn at the work in the quarries. From the time one company of men leave the quarry for any one of the other duties, which had to be performed, two weeks elapsed before they again returned. Four hours comprised a day's work, and each day found the men at different employment from the one preceding it, until all of the different vocations had been temporarily filled.

The party now continued their journey, passing the gold mine on their way to the cave of winds, or ice. Arriving at the latter place, before going into the cave they were taken into a small house and given very warm garments of untanned lion skins, their attendants telling them that the air was very cold in the cave and the heavy garments would not feel uncomfortable. The King taking the lead, they were led to a large arched opening into the side of the mountain. Torches were carried by the attendants who preceded them.

A loud rumbling, which resembled the noise made by the great cataract of Niagara, soon fell on their ears, and this increased in volume as they

penetrated farther into the mountain. The passage for some distance after entering, was about ten feet wide and that many high and large cakes of ice were piled up on each side as if waiting transportation. The passage soon widened until they found themselves in a large cave, the sides of which could not be seen in the darkness.

The air was growing colder each moment and the awful rumbling had become almost deafening. Far on ahead could be seen numerous lights flickering in the darkness, and upon our friends asking the King what this meant, he told them they were used to light the lake on which men were cutting ice. Here the torches were exchanged for a kind of lantern with a globe of mica, and before our friends had proceeded much further they realized why this was done, for a howling wind struck them broadside nearly knocking them from off their feet. The wind and the deafening noise it made in its wild rush through this subterranean passage was terrible. It was fearfully cold, too, and the attendants went among the party and adjusted the warm fur hoods over the heads and faces, leaving space only for the eyes and nose. Even these precautions did not save our friends from the piercing cold, for the blood had been accustomed to the equatorial heat on the outside and this quick change could not but make them shiver. Mr. Bruce calculated that the extreme cold would lower the mercury to 40 degrees, Fah., below zero, but he might have been mistaken, so long had it been since he experienced such freezing atmosphere.

On they went, fighting against the wind and cold until they reached the shore of the lake. Here about one hundred men were at work cutting ice, using a sort of long saw and an axe with a very large but narrow blade. The men were bundled up very carefully and worked very fast. The lake extended as far as could be seen in the darkness and was one solid sheet of ice with the exception of the place cut by the men, and even a film was already beginning to form over this. Near where our friends were standing was a flume or chute declining towards the entrance of the cave. The blocks of ice were brought to a point directly under this and being caught in a fork were raised by means of a windlass to the flume, where they were sent sliding to the entrance. An acre of ice was cut one day, and the following day another acre was cut, and by the next day, or at the end of forty-eight hours the ice had gained a thickness of ten inches over the acre that was cut on the first day. Thus had it gone on for centuries, each day an acre of ice being cut and supplied to the inhabitants. Each palace was furnished a

quantity of ice sufficient for its needs. It was used for cooling the atmosphere as well as for drinks and preserving provisions.

Our friends now being thoroughly chilled, and having seen all they wished to, they left the cavern and as soon as the villa was entered, attendants took charge of them, and disrobing them, plunged them into a hot bath, after which they were given a good rubbing and dressed in the clothes which they had worn upon arriving. After this a meal was served them.

At three o'clock a start was made for the gold mine, and upon reaching this they were put into large cages and lowered down, down, down, until the very bowels of the earth must have been reached. They could see by the light of the torches, as they were lowered, the abandoned shafts which centuries before had probably been mined.

Down they went until the bottom was at last reached and they left the cage to explore the mines. The air was fearfully hot and would have been unbearable but for the cool air forced into the mines from above. Miners were at work, wearing nothing but a breechcloth. The quartz found at this depth was the richest our friends had ever seen or heard of. Mr. Graham calculated that it would assay about eighty per cent. pure gold, and the quartz was easily mined. Not many men were working in this mine, as the quartz was so heavy with gold, that but very little was needed to satisfy the demand.

Our friends wondered no longer at the profusion of gold ornaments and implements. Here was enough gold apparently to furnish the world for hundreds of years. The shaft which they were now working was easily one hundred feet wide and ten feet high. Just think of quartz assaying sixteen hundred pounds to the ton and thousands of tons in sight! Still these people did not consider it as valuable as iron, of which latter they had plenty, but which they found so hard to work. Onrai explained to our friends that the miners only worked one hour at a time and there were months at times when the mines were not worked at all, owing to an over-supply of gold. Truly these people were rich if they only knew it, but wealth was an unknown word to them.

The party, after being shown through some of the unused shafts, where there was also plenty of quartz, but of an inferior quality, was hoisted to the surface. The mill for crushing the quartz was shown them and the process proved very interesting.

They returned to the city in the cool of the evening, well satisfied with their day's excursion. The longer our friends remained in this strange country, and the more they saw of its beauties and wealth, the more they were astonished at its vast resources. But they had seen only a small part of its wonders.

CHAPTER X.

THE JOURNEY TO THE LAKE.

In the centre of this vast country was an immense lake, covering at least fifteen thousand square feet, and this was filled with almost every conceivable species of fresh-water fish. This lake was undoubtedly fed by springs, for no inlet had ever been found. The river was its outlet, and this, as has been said before, emptied its waters into a large gulf, or hole in the ground which had a subterranean outlet.

For a long time our friends had wished to visit this inland sea, but their days had been so taken up with their other pleasures, a visit to the lake had been quite impossible, heretofore. However, the day was fixed for the long-looked-for pleasure, and they were about to start. It was intended that three days should be spent on this journey, one in going, one in fishing and the next in returning.

Mr. Graham was here in his element, for he found more real pleasure in fishing than in any other sport; and then, from what he could learn, this fishing excursion was liable to have its adventures, for it was said, that not only were there small fish in this lake, but also marine monsters too fearful for description and still more fearful to come in contact with. He would rather that the ladies remain in the city, but all were determined to go, so he gave his consent.

The morning, like all others in this fair land, was beautiful, and early, even before the sun had risen, the party started from the Temple. The ladies on the backs of the huge elephants, and the men riding ahead on sleek, well-groomed zebras, made a picture as they rode through the beautiful streets.

The populace was already astir, and the royal party was greeted on all sides with that respectful salute which was so graceful, but which had so

little humility in it. A road new to the visitors was now taken, one which led in a straight line due northwest, and which was smoothly paved with onyx. This road, or avenue, was lined with tremendous trees, the thick foliage of which met and mingled a hundred feet above their heads, making a vast shady arch through which the sun's rays could not penetrate. As far as their eyes could reach this tree-arched avenue extended.

"How far is it to the lake?" asked Nellie.

"Twenty miles, according to your method of measuring distances," answered Onrai.

"And does this magnificent avenue extend so far?" asked Enola.

"Not only to the lake," answered Onrai, "but it borders its shores, its entire circumference."

"And is it all paved as it is here?" asked Harry.

"Yes, throughout its entire length," added Onrai.

"And has this been done recently?" asked Enola.

"Recently," answered Onrai, "I do not understand you."

"Has it been done during your reign or the reign of your predecessor?" exclaimed Enola.

"No, it has not been done during my reign or during my life, so I, as a consequence, know nothing of the time of its laying," answered Onrai.

"But it must have been laid but a short time," said Enola, "for not one of these beautifully polished stones shows the least defacement."

"Oh, that counts for naught," said Mr. Bruce, "for they are placed together so carefully, and the onyx itself is so hard, there is no possibility of its chipping."

"This is called the Avenue of On," said Onrai, "and not only circumvents the lake, but stretches on from the opposite side to the farthest corner of On, or to the great field of brilliants."

"To the field of brilliants? Tell us of this, Onrai," said Enola.

"Far away in the direction in which we are now going is a large field devoid of all verdure. Rocks from the size of a zebra's hoof to those half as large as the Temple cover the ground. The cliffs which surround our country at this point are seamed and very irregular, which shows that at some remote age the rocks which now cover the field were torn from them, and

having been ground and crushed in their rush to the level field, have finally there found a resting place. But these stones and rocks do not entirely cover the field, for there seems to be an ashy substance and in places a bluish sandstone, and covering these are small, white brilliants as pure, white and clear as the water from a spring. During the day these stones catch the sun's rays and gleam forth like polished silver but with a brilliancy much more intense. But at night when the great white sentinel rises in the heavens and throws its soft light on these stones, they look like the reflection of stars in the lake. I have never looked upon this field but once at night and it impressed me then as being the grandest sight in our whole land."

"Diamonds," said Mr. Graham.

"May be so, or they may be nothing but brilliants, as he calls them," said Mr. Bruce.

"But do you use these?" asked Harry.

"Yes, we use them," said Onrai, "the larger ones in our sling-shots for killing small game; the smaller ones we polish and use for ornamentation. They are very hard, harder than onyx, and we find it very difficult to polish them."

"You are undoubtedly right, Mr. Graham," said Mr. Bruce. "They must be diamonds."

"How strange it is that these people think so little of everything on which civilization places the greatest value," said Enola.

"Yes," answered Mr. Graham, "but it is because these articles, gold and diamonds are so plentiful. I doubt not but that if these were as plentiful in our world we would care but little for them."

"May be," said Mr. Bruce.

It was now high noon, and although the sun's rays did not reach them, still the day was very hot and it was decided best to wait over for three or four hours in one of the farm villas which they were now opposite. They accordingly dismounted, and although the house was unoccupied at the time, still the same comforts and conveniences which were found in all of these charming villas were also found here. After partaking of a light lunch of iced wine and honey and cake, the party retired for a short siesta.

The sun was well toward the western horizon when they again took up their journey and now a cool breeze had sprung up which made the ride

along the shady flower-scented avenue, delightful in the extreme. They now began to meet the fishermen with their day's catch on their way to the city. There were a great many of these for the lake furnished most of the fish for the entire populace. These fish were carried in a sort of kettle which was partly filled with ice; this kettle was swung between two zebras, the back saddles of which were connected by the rod from which the kettle hung. So well-trained were the zebras to this work that they went along perfectly and one man was able to manage eight or ten of these teams.

Now through the trees in the distance could be seen the blue waters of the beautiful lake. As far as the eye could reach stretched the calm waters, the surface as smooth as glass. As they drew near the shore numerous small boats could be seen.

"These are the boats of the fishermen," said Onrai, "and that black speck well down toward the horizon is the island Myrrh, on which is a villa in which we will spend the night."

"But can we reach it before dark?" asked Mr. Bruce.

"We will have to," said Onrai, "for it is not safe to be on the lake after nightfall."

"And why?" asked Enola.

"Because of certain sea monsters which inhabit its waters," said Onrai.

Mr. Bruce looked at Nellie and the thought occurred to both.

"Can these fearful monsters be like the one which so nearly proved our death in the cave?"

"These marine animals are not seen during the day for they lie at the bottom of the lake as long as the sun is shining, but when the glorious orb of day has set and can no longer cast its hot rays on their hideous bodies, they then come to the surface and very often fearful fights occur among them. They prey on each other and after one of these nights of terrible battle I have seen the surface of the water red as far as the eye could reach, and may be several of their ugly dead bodies would be floating about the water near the island."

"It is fearful," said Mrs. Graham.

"Yes, it is the one fearful thing in this fair land of ours," said Onrai.

They now reached the shore and Onrai signaled one of the boats to approach. These boats, long and narrow, were propelled by six oarsman. They almost flew through the water and in a very short space of time the boat which Onrai had signaled drove its bow far up on the shore of the island. Those who had accompanied the company thus far, were to wait on shore until the following morning when Onrai and his friends should return. The boatmen pulled a quick stroke and in a half hour the island was reached.

Attendants had anticipated them and had prepared the evening meal and all were soon enjoying the delights of fair On's cuisine.

CHAPTER XI.

THE FIGHT OF THE SEA MONSTERS.

The island on which they now were was very small, not being more than one half mile in circumference. In fact it was a mere dot on the surface of this vast inland lake, but it was of considerable importance, nevertheless, for here the King made periodical excursions, and often took up his residence for weeks at a time in its charming villa. From the shore on which the party landed, the island rose gently to the centre, and on this slight eminence stood the villa. On the opposite side the shores were precipitous, rising in a cliff about fifty feet high. Bordering this cliff had been built a low, onyx wall and the intervening space between this and the villa had been laid out in a magnificent garden, filled with the redolent flowers so numerous in this country.

It was this delightful spot, shaded by immense palms and eucalyptus trees, which so pleased the King and which brought him here so frequently. From this garden could be seen the cliffs far away to the south and east and the fertile country lying between, and on the opposite side of the lake spreading on and on until merged into the blue horizon. Even from the broad dining hall, in which the party were now sitting, could be caught glimpses of the city as it lay bathed in the bright moonlight far away, and occasionally dim lights could be seen which shone from the open villa of the pink-white city.

“Look,” said Enola. “Is the scene not grand?”

“Yes,” said Harry, “the most exquisite picture I ever looked upon.”

“It is because of this natural picturesqueness that I visit this island so frequently,” said Onrai. “To me it has no equal, and I can conceive of nothing more beautiful.”

“No,” said Enola, “nothing could be more beautiful, for here we have every element which goes to make up a grand landscape; the distant city standing on the gentle slope of the foothills, the towering cliffs beyond, their jagged rocks softened by the moonlight; the broad fields, the noble forests, and about us the blue waters of the lake.”

“Truly a good country to live in,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, a fair country, with which God has dealt most kindly,” said Mr. Graham.

The party arose and through the broad halls and lofty entrance they went into the garden; across this and near to the stone wall reclining seats had been placed for them. The scene which now met their gaze was ineffably grand. The lake lay before them like a sea of liquid silver the surface scarcely ruffled by the soft evening breeze; beyond, the shore of the mainland with its flickering lights, dimmed by the bright rays of the moon, and beyond these the magnificent panorama already described. The party sat for a long time lost in contemplation of the magnificent scenery.

“Look,” said Enola, “a boat.”

“No, Enola, not a boat,” said Onrai, “for it means death to any who may venture on the lake at night.”

“It may mean death, Onrai, but nevertheless some one of your countrymen has undertaken the hazardous journey to-night, for see, the lights in the bow shine brightly,” replied Enola.

Onrai had arisen as Enola had spoken, and stepping to the wall looked long at the black object coming toward them, then resuming his seat, he said:

“No, it is one of the monsters; those lights are its fiery eyes.”

A shudder ran through the frames of all present excepting Onrai, who had long since become accustomed to look upon these fearful sea serpents. On the black mass came, growing larger and larger as it neared them. Remembrances of the fearful race with and escape from the monster in the cavern came to the minds of those who had participated in this dreadful scene, and Mrs. Graham arising, said:

“Onrai, you will pardon, I hope, a woman’s faintheartedness, but I cannot look upon the scenes which we have been told by you will shortly take place near us; so with your kind permission I will retire to my apartment.”

“You have my permission most assuredly, Mrs. Graham, and it grieves me to think that I have been the cause of this disturbance of mind. When these monsters come together the battle will be fearful, and if the other ladies feel that they cannot witness it, it would be better for them to retire also, for see! other monsters are now coming, and the fight will soon commence.”

At this Nellie arose and together with her mother they entered the villa.

As Onrai had said, other black masses were now seen and the glow of red eyes shone through the semi-darkness from all directions. On came their bodies growing larger as they came nearer. Now the foremost had reached the base of the cliff and raising its huge body half out of the water, threw its ugly head back and fastened its glittering eyes on those who were watching its movements from above. The moon shone full on its long, dragon-like body and the party shuddered with horror as they recognized in it the exact counterpart of the sea-monster of the cave. After gazing on those above it for a full minute, and then realizing probably that they were out of its reach, the monster became enraged and, throwing itself back into the water beat the surface with its wing-like fins and long tail until almost lost to view in the foam thus created. But others had now come close to the rock, and as the number increased the water was blackened by their dark bodies. It was a mass of writhing, horror-depicting sea reptiles, and as they wound in and out under and over each other, their eyes glowing the while, it was enough to make the stoutest heart grow faint.

Suddenly one of them, which had been crowded close to the rocks by the great number from behind, and finding it impossible to extricate itself in any other way, dove, and piercing the body of the one next to it, held it half out of water, pinioned on its formidable horn.

“Ah, the battle has commenced,” said Onrai.

“It is fearful,” again said Enola.

“Horrible but fascinating,” said Mr. Bruce.

“This is but the beginning,” said Onrai. “In a few moments the whole seething mass will be engaged in one grand battle royal. If, Enola, you think you cannot look on this hideous spectacle, it would be better for you to retire now.”

“No,” said Enola, “I wish to see it all.”

They again turned their attention to the monsters. When the beast had been pierced by the horn of its companion, it had given out a fearful groan like that of a dying man. This seemed to be a signal, for immediately the beast began to beat the water with fins and tail, until the spray was forced upward almost splashing our friends. In fact the lake looked as if it had been struck by a hurricane so turbulent had the waters become. All this commotion was but preliminary, however, for it soon ceased, and all was perfectly quiet for a moment, when, as if moved by a common impulse the battle commenced in earnest.

Each had, seemingly, during the short interval of rest, selected its prey or opponent, for as far as could be seen the fight was a succession of duels, not more than two being engaged at once in tearing each other to pieces. Fastening their fiery eyes on each other they would retreat for a short distance, and then, with heads thrown back and their enormous jaws opened, would make a rush for each other, coming together with sickening force, their huge jaws crunching into each other's bodies, or, perhaps fastening jaw into jaw. Then they would writhe and squirm, beating each other with their fins and tails. Upon becoming exhausted, if one or the other had not been overcome with the struggle they would disengage themselves, and retreating, rest for a moment and then make another rush for each other. Now they would dive, ripping each other with their murderous tusks, frequently both being beneath the surface, but the agitation of the water telling that the fearful battle was being continued far beneath.

Again they would rise to the surface, their bodies torn and lacerated, and blood from the gaping wounds dyeing the water a crimson red. One would finally succumb and the survivors, after giving their fallen antagonists a parting thrust, would swim away until outside the seething, battling mass. Here it would nurse its wounds, waiting seemingly for the horrible struggle to end. Here also it would be joined by other victors, but these undoubtedly having the proper respect for the fighting powers of those about them, would not again take the risk of being annihilated.

The duelling was becoming less fierce each moment for the weaker were fast being overcome and the survivors joining their victorious comrades. All this time the dreadful groans continued. Now the last victor had vanquished his foe and joined the others.

"Ah, the battle is finished," said Mr. Bruce.

“No, not yet,” said Onrai. “Watch the line of victors.”

These had formed a straight compact line, and as if by a signal, they charged on the bodies of the dead and wounded floating on the surface. Their movements were as swift as lightning, and like a body of well-drilled cavalymen they charged, killing the helpless wounded, and lacerating the bodies of the dead. Then they again retreated and, as the first faint rays of morn streaked the eastern heavens, they sank beneath the surface, leaving the bodies of their victims to rot in the heat of the equatorial sun.

When the party again reached the mainland, they were taken to the villa in which they were to spend the night. The men returned to the lake in the evening and watched the process of cutting up the monsters, and taking from them the fat which produced the oil. The remains of the animals were then piled in heaps and burned. One hundred and four had been killed the night before, but how many still remained to be slaughtered by their mates?

As the men stood watching the scene, Onrai said:

“This sight is even becoming loathsome to me; let us return to the villa.”

As they were crossing the broad avenue, a suspicion of music was wafted from the direction of the city. It was so faint that our friends could not say whether it was the music of distant harps, or the song of some night bird, far away. They stopped for a moment and listened, but the sound not again being heard, they resumed their walk toward the villa.

Onrai had also stopped and seemed to be listening, but had offered no explanation until they again started for the villa. Our friends seemed to think he could explain this distant music if he wished to, and they looked at him inquiringly. Noticing this look, Onrai said:

“In two months comes the Day of Resis. It is our custom during the two months previous to this day to sing songs of praise at this hour each evening.”

“Are they songs of joy and happiness?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“They are,” said Onrai. But he would say nothing further on the subject.

CHAPTER XII.

THE NIGHT OF PRAYER.

As the night came on and the glorious moon rose high into the heavens, bathing all in its silvery rays, the very beauty of the scene made our friends forget the horrors of the night before. They had assembled in the garden, and the swinging chairs, as they were moved slowly backward and forward by the attendants, were conducive to rest and comfort. They were far enough removed from the lake to be entirely free from any suggestions which its busy scenes might make.

Near Enola stood the great white elephant, which she rode on all journeys, its huge body towering into the air and nearly touching the lower boughs of the trees. This elephant had become so attached to Enola that it seemed happy only when with her, and she had requested of Onrai that he allow "Gip," as she had named it, to come into the garden while they were there. He had now taken hold of the rope with his trunk and was swinging the chair as carefully as could be done by the attendants. Occasionally he would let out that peculiar cry so much like an infant's, when Enola would hand him one of the sweets which she always had about her when he was near.

Several of the zebras were also grazing in the garden and the deer, which were numerous, would come up now and then, and with their great liquid eyes, gaze into the faces of our friends. There was no timidity in these animals, for they were all treated so kindly, and had so long been made pets of, that all fear of the human form had left them.

The lofty trees, the flower-bedecked garden with the animals wandering through it, the perfumed air, the pink onyx villa in the background, the silk-robed party swinging lazily to and fro, the attendants standing near, and above all, the glorious moon, made an enchanting scene. Suddenly, as if in a

dream, too faint almost to be heard, was wafted on the evening breeze a strain as sweet and indistinct as the low melody of an Æolian harp. Onrai half rose and as the music grew stronger he became erect, and bowing his head, almost whispered, "'Tis the night of prayer."

The attendants discontinued the swinging of the chairs and also bowed their heads. Our friends, half aroused from the sweet languor into which they had fallen, looked with wondering eyes at Onrai. The exquisite music was coming nearer and nearer, and now could be discerned harmonious voices mingling with the strains of the harp. On and on they came, the music growing louder and stronger, but losing none of its sweetness. Onrai and the attendants still stood with bowed heads, and in a subdued voice, Onrai was evidently repeating a prayer. So impressive was the beautiful music and the devout attitude of those about them, our friends were deeply moved, and had now also arisen and were standing with bent heads and clasped hands, breathing a prayer.

Now those who were making such sweet music had reached the villa, and our friends raising their eyes, looked upon a picture. Standing in the foreground, with his arm thrown over the neck of the zebra, from which he had dismounted, and holding in one hand a shepherd's hook, was a white-robed priest. Grouped in a semicircle about him, were a number of maidens all carrying tiny torches. Back of them was a body of men, and still further in the background were the elephants and zebras which had brought the party from the city.

As they stood there, Onrai approached and spoke to the priest in the native tongue. Then, with the King leading, they went direct to the villa and entered.

"How strange," said Enola, when Onrai with his visitors had left them alone.

"Strange indeed," said Mr. Graham. "Can it be that they bring unexpected news from the city?"

"It is hard to tell," said Mr. Bruce. "But I think not. It is evidently a celebration of one of their religious rites. From the solemn proceedings I should say that this was so."

Just then Onrai was seen approaching them and when he was directly opposite, he said:

“’Tis the night of prayer, come;” and turning, he retraced his steps with our friends following.

They were led through the wide hall to a spacious apartment in the rear. This apartment was the exact counterpart of the large devotional chamber in the Temple, but somewhat smaller. Subdued lights were placed at frequent intervals about the sides of the apartment, and others hung from the lofty ceiling. In the centre was a wide, crescent-shaped platform, and standing about its base were those who had so recently come from the city.

As the King entered with our party the natives commenced playing on their native harps, and the low, sweet music penetrated to the very souls of our friends. Onrai led them to the platform on which seats had been placed; then the priest also mounted the platform, and facing the King, commenced reading in the native tongue from one of the polished tablets of wood. He then passed this to the King and he, arising, read from it the same inscription. Then the priest raised his hand, and all joined in a chant, the maidens accompanying the voices on the harps. It was solemn but grand and very impressive. The chant ended, the priest again turned toward the King and began speaking, the maidens in the meanwhile playing a sweet refrain on the harps. The priest having finished speaking, the King arose, turned his face heavenward and prayed:

“God our Father, God of the Heavens and earth, God of On, God of all, as the flowers turn their faces to the great orb of day, so we on this night of prayer, turn our faces to Thee. O God, we know that all blessings come from Thee and we thank Thee. We thank Thee for the fertile fields, the green pastures, the silvery waters, the shady forest, the life-giving sun of day, the soft-lighted moon and cool breezes of the night. We feel Thy presence O God, we know that Thou art near us. Still be with us and when our time has come take us home to Thee, our God, our Father.”

Onrai ceased praying and the sweet voices and the music of the harps again broke forth. Now the voices grew fainter, the music more subdued, the lights growing dimmer and dimmer. Now the voices were almost whispering, the strains of music are dying, dying, the lights are flickering. At last all is hushed and dark. Suddenly the Temple was flooded with brilliant light, a glorious grand flood of song and music burst forth. More brilliant becomes the light, louder and grander grows the music, as if from a thousand voices, as if from a thousand harps. Now comes a troop of

maidens robed in shimmering white, singing and playing. Lightly they trip over the polished floor, their forms swaying and their limbs bending gracefully as they dance.

Our friends hold their breath for fear of losing one strain of the sweet music; they lean forward eagerly to catch every movement of the willowy figures. All is grand beyond conception. The music becomes more soul-stirring, the dance grows quicker, the lights blinding in their brilliancy. Our friends arise in their eagerness to see and hear. 'Tis glorious!

Suddenly the maidens leave the room, the song and music cease, the lights are darkened. 'Tis over.

The night of prayer with its grand and imposing ceremonies had passed, and now the party had again assembled and were partaking of the morning meal preparatory to starting on the day's journey. It was yet very early, for in this equatorial climate the journeys had to be taken in the cool of the mornings and evenings. The sun's rays in the middle of the day were too hot to withstand. Through the open door could be seen the elephants and zebras trapped and waiting for the start. Nearby stood, not only the attendants, but also the party which had arrived the night before. Turning to Onrai, Enola asked:

“Are those who came from the city also to accompany us, Onrai?”

“Yes,” answered Onrai, “it is essential that they should go with us, for we shall not have returned to the city before the night of prayer shall have again come, and on this night we must have a priest and attendants.”

CHAPTER XIII.

THE ACCUSATION.

The heat of the day had been excessive, but our friends had not suffered to any great extent because of the shade which the avenue trees had afforded; and then they had rested during the midday hour, and had not taken up the journey until late in the afternoon. Then, too, the brisk trot of the animals, as they moved over the smooth stone pavement, had created a breeze which was very cooling to the riders; but as they emerged from the forest, dark clouds were seen rising out of the west; dark, forboding clouds, which portended rain and probably a hard blow. The forerunner of this equatorial storm reached them before they arrived at the villa, in the shape of quick, rapidly moving gusts of wind, which would overtake them and moving on would leave the air perfectly calm, hot and humid, until the next gust would spring out of the ground seemingly, and fly after its leaders.

The riders hurried on, one minute fanned by a refreshing breeze and the next almost sweltering in the dead calm. But they suffered only a short time, as the villa was reached and once inside its cool, onyx walls, all thought of the humidity of the outside was forgotten, and the on-coming storm was only thought of as making the air cool for the morrow's journey. After dinner the travelers went into the garden and hardly any signs were seen now of the approaching storm; in fact, the evening was much the same as had been many others since their arrival. They retired late but had not slept long when the wind rose almost to a gale. The storm was a novelty, and our friends never having seen an equatorial storm, all arose and went on the terrace.

The elephants had already sniffed the approaching storm and began to throw their trunks in the air, moving their huge ears back and forth, all the time making those funny sounds, which seemed so strange in such large

animals. The storm meant to them a refreshing bath, coupled with a feed of grass and herbs washed by the cooling rain; they gloried in it. The zebras were already grazing, or half buried in the long grass, were rolling and kicking, happy to be free from bridle and saddle.

Onrai alone, of all the party, after going onto the terrace, seemed to be worried over the storm. He had gone to one end of the terrace, and now stood looking intently at the black mass of clouds which were rolling on, coming nearer and nearer, and reaching out huge, dark arms toward the earth. He was muttering in the strange tongue of his people:

“An omen. Is our great God angry? Have my people failed in their duties? Have we neglected our work? Have we treated lightly our teachings? No; but our God is great. He sees all things, and goes deep into the hearts of his people, and he knows even if they contemplate doing wrong. Oh!——” Onrai raises his hand to his forehead, and pressing it tightly against his throbbing temples, he staggers and almost falls.

“Can this thing be?” he gasped. “Is this a warning to me, the King of the Land of On? Is this to show me that God knows my sinful thoughts and would check them before it is forever too late? Oh, my God, spare me!” he cries, and sinks into one of the onyx chairs near him. His powerful frame shook like an aspen leaf; his breath came in gasps; his hands twitched nervously; his eyes almost started from their sockets as he gazed on the black clouds, which seemed to engulf him. Unable to look upon the fearful sight any longer, he sprung to his feet, and shading his eyes with his hand as if to hide from view those fearful clouds, he staggered towards the entrance. He struck something as he hurried forward, and started back frightened. Looking up he saw that it was Enola, and raising his hand as if to warn her back, he said:

“You, too? Have you come to accuse me at this moment? Could you not have spared me?”

Onrai again started for the entrance, but Enola noticing the pained look in his face, and being totally at a loss to know why he should address her in this manner, caught him by the light tunic as he was passing her. He stopped and looked at her with frightened eyes.

“Onrai,” said Enola, “don’t look at me in that way. How have I offended you? Tell me, is it I or one of my people?”

Onrai looked at her, his heroic figure standing erect, his shoulders thrown back as if to defy the influence which Enola was exerting over him. But his face was deathly pale and his hands clutched nervously as they hung by his side; his eye never flinched, however, as he looked at her.

“Onrai, do not look at me so,” said Enola, stepping back, growing afraid of that unbending figure and steely gaze.

“What have I done?” she continued. “I come to seek you to-night to thank you for the happy, happy day which you have given me; for having suggested this pleasant journey. The beautiful music of the evening made me forget for a time this duty, but I thought of it as I retired to my apartment and was glad of the opportunity which the storm afforded me to thank you yet to-night. My heart was light as I came from the villa, expecting to find that great, noble Onrai glad to see me and ready to hear my thanks, but I find him excited and nervous, and when he sees me he speaks as I never heard him speak before. Tell me, oh, tell me, Onrai, what have I done?”

Enola stopped near the entrance and waited for Onrai’s answer.

“What have you done?” he said. “Everything. You have come from that planet home of yours and have stolen into our land in the night; but we have received you as guests and have treated you as we would those who come from afar and sought our hospitality.

“Myself and my people have done all in our power to make your sojourn in our world a happy one. From that world of yours, far above, in one of those shining stars which twinkles and throws its soft light on us on the clear beautiful nights, we believe that your people have for ages looked down on us, and have learned our life, our customs and our secrets. This we have learned to believe since you have come among us, for before that time we knew nothing of another people. And you come to us with the chain of the high priest about your neck, and this is proof that you know the great secrets of the high priests and those of the Day of Resis. For this reason we have looked for you to respect our laws and customs. To all but me you seem to have done this. I have just begun to believe that you, and may be your people, have no respect for the sacred laws that govern me, the King of On. To-night has been a revelation to me. Never before, during my life, has there come such a storm at this season. I looked at the dark heavens and saw the black clouds hurried on by the mad winds, almost sweeping the earth, and I could see in it only a warning. Then it flashed over my

bewildered brain that the warning was meant for me. I had sinned. But why had I sinned? Because tempted by you who knew our laws, and knew the fearful punishment which would be the King's who would dare disobey these laws. You who cared naught for all these, but still threw out your alluring temptations, your subtle fascinations, in order to entrap me. But God has spoken in this storm and I am saved. Listen to His voice," and as he ceased speaking a fearful peal of thunder broke through the air as if in answer to him.

Enola stood aghast during this accusation, unable to account for this fearful change in Onrai's conduct toward her, until he had mentioned the storm, and then she realized that it was this unusual phenomenon which had wakened in his mind the sin he was committing in loving her; she must let him know that these fascinations were only those which God had given her, and that the seeming allurements were but the graceful acknowledgments of his many courtesies. But how to tell him, how to convince him! He still stood like a statue, like an accusing Apollo who had but little mercy for one who had caused him even a moment's pain. To suffer for even an instant was such a new sensation to the man, and it was so acute withal, that for the time he could find no forgiveness for the one who had caused it, and he stood contemplating Enola, for the moment a savage, glaring at the one who had caused him a moment's pain, and whom he had in his power to torture as he saw fit.

He forgot his love for her for the moment; he only remembered that she had hurt him, and when the first great fear of the discovery was over, he grew hard and cold and wanted revenge. Enola saw that she had blind superstition to deal with, superstition whose birth was in sin, and she knew that it would be hard to convince Onrai of her innocence. But this she must do; so taking a step timidly toward him, she raised her hand as if she would touch his arm, but when he saw this movement he involuntarily drew his arm away as if afraid that her touch would contaminate him. The movement hurt her more than all his harsh words had done, and she partially turned as if to walk away, but remembering the fearful consequences that might ensue unless Onrai's mind should be disabused of this fearful mistake which he had made, she turned again, and placing her hands behind her, walked up to him and looking him straight in the eye, said:

“Onrai, look at me. Do you see any guilt or flinching in my eye? Do you think that I, who have the same faith in the same God that you have, could look at you now if I were guilty, and too, when this fearful storm is raging, which you call the voice and anger of God? No, Onrai; you and your people have a mistaken idea when you think we knew your life, customs and laws before we came to your world. We did not even know that your people existed; but we knew that there was a world here and we determined to visit it, and learn whether it was inhabited or not. So we came and found this glorious land and this beautiful, justice-loving people. And never until tonight have I learned to think that they had any but the grandest minds, with the most charitable thoughts for those who had been thrown in with them for awhile. I understand your laws but imperfectly, and I do not understand why you should treat me thus, or accuse me of wishing to make you sin or suffer because of an unusual phenomenon. Search your mind, Onrai, and see if it was not yourself who sinned willingly and not because I have tempted you; ask yourself if in any way I have been less modest than your native women; whether I have sought you, or you me; whether I have not avoided you rather than sought you. Ask yourself these questions, and then accuse me if you can.” And as Enola finished speaking, she drew herself up nobly and started to walk toward the entrance. She had nearly reached this when Onrai stepped forward and almost in a whisper, said:

“Enola, wait; wait; let me think; let me think; my brain is whirling; I cannot see all clearly yet; but it is growing brighter. Oh, Enola, forgive, forgive me. I cannot now tell you the great sin which I thought was your making, but which I can now see was all my own. The laws of the Land of On are stringent on this point, and if I should give up to the temptation I would be killed. To be killed for sinning means not only the death of the body, but the everlasting torture of the soul. It is a fearful thing for any of us to sin, but how much more so is it for the King, the chosen one, who is the people’s choice not because he is the greatest physically, but the purest of mind, if there can be one purer than the others. But I have sinned unwittingly, and it is because of this that I was so ready to accuse you. But I look at you now and see in that clear, unflinching eye, that smooth brow and erect body, no guilt. You are innocent, Enola; innocent and I ask forgiveness. It seems strange that I should use the word to one on earth, for it belongs to God, and is never used among us. But I have wronged you

fearfully and I know not how else to make amends. Forgive me, Enola,” and as he finished, he took her hand and raised it to his lips.

Enola was crying, for the pleading words of this strong man, this King, touched her strangely.

“But tell me, Onrai, of this strange sin, that I may know,” she said.

“No,” Onrai answered, “it would be a greater sin to tell it to you. But listen; what is that fearful rumbling sound?”

CHAPTER XIV.

THE STORM.

So absorbed had Enola and Onrai been in their talk that the storm had been forgotten for the moment. But it had not abated but had rather grown fiercer and blacker, until now it was so dark that objects only a short distance away could not be seen. The elephants could be heard stalking through the garden, and occasionally their huge bodies and also the zebras would be lit up by the lurid lightning. But the wind had died down to almost a calm a few moments before, and nothing had broken the stillness of the night but the sharp peals of thunder which would follow the brilliant lightning.

But as Onrai spoke, a rumbling was heard, not like distant thunder, but less distinct, like the rattling of a distant railway train, the sound being regular but growing louder each moment. The others of the party now joined Enola and Onrai, and the attendants grouped themselves about the terrace. There was no fear depicted on their faces, or shown in their actions, but there was the greatest wonderment. This was something unheard of, a storm like this promised to be, in the heart of the dry season; still fear was unknown to them, or that fear which is caused by a possibility of bodily suffering. They simply wondered and did not even try to make out the mystery.

Now the elephants seemed to scent danger, for they would sniff the air and then give out that peculiar cry. The zebras had gathered together in one part of the garden and would neigh in a pitiful manner as if expecting danger. The rumbling grew louder and more distinct and now sounded like the falling of many trees. The heavens were lurid with flash after flash of lightning, this lending a fearfulness to the scene which was awful. Now the elephants came up quite near to the terrace as if trying to find a place of

refuge, and standing together with their backs turned toward the storm waited for the worst. Then the trees gave out a gentle wail as they were touched with the first breath of the wind; then they began to sway and groan as if in mortal agony. Each moment the wind grew more fierce, the lightning more vivid, the rumbling more deafening.

“Is this not unusual, Onrai?” asked Mr. Graham.

“It has never before happened at this time of the year,” said Onrai. “At this season we never expect rain and depend wholly on the heavy dews to moisten our vegetation.”

“It seems to be very fierce. Are your storms all like this?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“We have very hard storms accompanied by very strong winds, but I have never seen, or heard anything like this. Listen; is it not growing worse?” and Onrai’s face for the first time looked troubled.

“Yes, very much worse,” said Harry, “and I would advise that we all go inside the villa.”

“No, Harry,” said Enola, “let us remain outside until driven in. The sight is too grand to lose.”

“I am willing to remain but it is much safer inside during a storm like this,” said Harry.

Now the noise drowned their voices and conversation was given up. The air seemed full of electricity; the flesh tingled with it; the nostrils inhaled it and a copperish taste was left in the mouth.

“Look,” shouted Enola, “what is that fearful mass approaching, and hear that terrible sound. It is like the dashing of thousands of waves against the rocks, or the tearing asunder of mighty mountains.”

This was true; and now in the lurid lightning could be seen the dark clouds flying over Mother Earth, crushing all in its way. On the left of the villa was an open space, probably five miles broad, and on the far edge of this, as Enola spoke, could be seen the black cloud approaching. It seemed to take everything in its course and now the air was filled with all kinds of debris; huge logs of wood and even large boulders were seen flying through the air. It was a seething, hurling mass, made more awful by the ear-piercing noise and the continuous lightning.

“A cyclone,” shouted Mr. Graham, but his voice could hardly be heard above the fearful din. “Hasten,” he continued, “into the house,” and leading his wife by one hand and Nellie by the other he hurried toward the entrance.

Onrai took Enola by the arm and was hurrying with all speed toward the large arch, when Enola, looking at the elephants, saw Gip looking pitifully at her and extending his trunk toward her as if begging her to help him. “Poor Gip,” she said, and freeing herself from Onrai’s retaining arm, she walked to the edge of the terrace and patted the elephant on the trunk stretched toward her.

“Come Enola or it will be too late,” said Onrai. But it was even then too late, for Enola had leaned too far over the edge and losing her balance, fell to the lawn beneath. The distance was not great and Enola was not hurt, so she picked herself up and started for the steps leading to the terrace. But the wind had now grown so fierce she could hardly keep an upright position, and before she realized it she was being hurried forward with a speed which almost took her feet from under her. On by the steps she sped, unable to battle against the wind and force her way up these.

Gip had followed her, wonderingly at first, but at last, seeming to realize her peril, quickened his pace and just as the wind was about to hurl her to the ground, he grasped her about the waist with his powerful trunk and turned toward the terrace again; but the awful wind was even stronger than this mighty animal, and he was losing ground each step. Bravely he battled, holding Enola far above his head, his trunk encircling her body just tightly enough to keep her from slipping through its folds. His great body now began to sway in the gale and it looked for a moment as if both elephant and Enola would be picked up and swept into the fearful, swirling holocaust overhead.

Gip knew his danger, so turning his back to the storm he hurried on with it. At first he traveled only in a trot as if reluctant to give up to the power of the storm, but his pace grew faster and faster as this fearful power asserted itself, until he was flying over the ground, he seemed to no longer touch the ground so rapid was his pace. He had thrown Enola over on his back so that she could rest her limbs, but he still kept a firm hold on her with his trunk, and they kept up the mad rush together. The air was filled with debris of all kinds and Enola was afraid to open her eyes for fear of being blinded. On they rushed, the elephant keeping up the mad pace before the wind. One

moment it would be as black as Erebus; the next the lightning's glare would break through the dirt filled atmosphere. It was a seething mass, a hurricane sweeping all before it; twisting trees from their roots or snapping their huge trunks like straws; sucking up great quantities of water as it crossed inlets of the lake; picking up in its mighty grasp cows, sheep, deer, zebra and all other animals excepting the huge elephants, whose great weight kept them from being carried from earth.

Enola was lying flat on Gip's back, he holding her there as if he understood that she would be drawn from his grasp if he allowed her to sit up for even a moment. Grandly the noble beast fought against the fearful storm; the awful pace had now kept up so long he was fast giving out, and Enola could feel his grasp growing weaker, and feel the weary limbs give way when they would strike the earth; his breath came quick and he was gasping like a dying human being; but he kept on fighting, still fighting that enemy which was each moment getting the best of his efforts.

He stumbled and fell to his knees, but he was up again in an instant and hurrying before the wind; again he fell, and this time his huge body lay flat on its side, but he had held Enola aloof and she had been only slightly jarred. A groan escaped the noble beast as he tried to regain his feet. "Brave Gip!" said Enola, as she patted him on the trunk. "Once more, Gip, just once more, my noble friend, and we may yet escape." Gip made a supreme effort, and regained his feet. The thought now occurred to Enola that if she could guide the elephant out of this current of wind which was hurrying them on to destruction, they might yet be saved. She had seen the attendants touch the elephants on the right or left side of the head when wanting them to move in either direction, and she determined to try it. Reaching her hand out as far as she could, she was just able to touch the right ear of the elephant.

She struck this with her open hand, saying, "Try it, Gip, good Gip," and Gip, with strength nearly gone, turned as much to the right as possible, and beating against the strong wind, hurried on as fast as his weakened condition would allow him. In thus beating against the storm in an oblique direction, it brought them in a direct line with the flying debris, and Enola began to be bruised by the sticks and small stones which filled the air. She could hardly breathe either, for the dust and dirt which were swept up by the swirling current. She tried to protect her face with her hands, but these were

soon raw and bleeding with the sand blast. Her eyes were filled with dirt, and her throat was dry and parched with the inhalation of the dirt-filled atmosphere.

She was suffering fearful agonies, and her suffering was growing worse every moment; she tried to hold her face closer to the elephant's back, but she was too weak now to make any exertion at all. On the great, brave beast moved, his body swaying with the wind, and each minute looking as if he must give up the struggle. Now the fury of the storm seemed to have grown worse, and the next instant it seemed to be abating. This would give hope to the suffering girl and to the animal, and a moment's breathing space in which they could recuperate slightly and prepare for a renewed effort.

It was just after one of these momentary spells of comparative quiet, that Gip, reeling and almost falling, had tried to pull himself together for another trial. His massive body seemed almost rigid as he stopped for a moment and braced himself; he half released his hold on Enola, and she, almost exhausted, felt that the grand fortitude of the animal and his sublime strength had given way, and that hope was indeed gone. But no; Gip shook all over; and, his nerves again relieved, made a last effort to go on. Painfully he strode on, never for a moment leaving the course which Enola had started him on.

The air seemed to grow thicker with sand and dust, while above them and all about them were flying logs, trees and stones. Enola was bruised and bleeding and she was on the point of fainting, when she opened her eyes for a moment, and just in time to see a huge tree fly through the air, and strike Gip fairly on the side of the head. Down he went like a shot, carrying Enola with him, but still holding her in his trunk. He had made a brave fight and lost.

CHAPTER XV.

IN THE TRACK OF THE STORM.

Sedai, who had been such a prominent figure in the first part of the journey, and who had played such a part in the real cause of the expedition, had not been forgotten since reaching the Land of On, but so many new and strange things had come up to occupy the time and minds of our friends, and so many attendants had been placed at their disposal, Sedai had not been called upon to perform the many little duties to which he had become accustomed, and he was left to enjoy himself much as he saw fit. He had accompanied the party on the first part of the journey, but the King wished to send word back to the city, of the change in the programme and of their intention to proceed to the far end of the country before their return, and Sedai had offered to carry the message. Not that native messengers were wanting, but Sedai seemed to find more enjoyment in the delightfully cool and comfortable city than he did riding through the somewhat heated country.

But he had been too long accustomed to the march, and the white companions of the past few weeks had become too dear to him, to long remain away from them; so after spending one day in the city, he determined to start out and overtake the party. But now a strange thing occurred. Far off in the west, just creeping up from the horizon, rose a dark cloud, at first no larger than a zebra, but growing in size each moment and fast approaching the city. It soon overcast half the heavens and the entire populace was standing in the streets gazing at this wonder. The cloud had cut off the twilight completely and now, while it was yet early, darkness was over all, a darkness which was appalling. The populace exchanged looks of wonderment, but offered no explanation of this strange freak of the elements.

Sedai, who had long been accustomed to seeing these fearful electric and wind storms, was surprised to see the wonderment in the faces of these people. Turning to one who was near him, he said:

“Why do you gaze at the heavens in that way; have you never before seen a storm?”

“Many of them,” answered the man, “but never at this time of the year, and never at any time as fierce a one as this promises to be.”

“It does indeed look very threatening,” said Sedai.

The night grew even darker, and then the lightning broke through the black clouds for a moment illuminating the beautiful city which the inhabitants had for the first time in their lives, failed to lighten. The thunder rolled up from the west, making a deafening roar, and still the people stood gazing, so overpowered were they by this strange event. And now the fitful gusts of wind reached them, and then a few drops of rain fell; and listen: what is that fearful sound. It is not thunder, for the thunder is roaring peal on peal and cannot be mistaken. This is something else. It can be heard only when the thunder rests for a moment. And it is growing nearer, and a little longer and it seems to be almost on them.

Like a flash it comes to Sedai.

“It is the simoon,” he cries, in such an alarmed voice that all look at him in surprise. Again he called out, “the simoon.” And now the natives all crowded around asking him what he meant. He had not learned the language sufficiently to make them understand by words, but by making signs he explained to them how the great winds sweep over the earth, leveling houses, trees and all else to the ground. Even then they showed no signs of fear. But one of them happened to remember the King, and that he, with the strange guests, was somewhere in the country, over which the storm was now approaching.

“The King,” the man cried, and then, the others catching his meaning, and realizing the King’s danger, the cry of “the King” rose high above the roar of the storm.

Sedai grasped the situation at once and knew that the King and his friends must be in imminent peril. The storm had come up just at that hour of the evening when the party, having rested during the heat of the day, might be expected to be on the road. If this was true and they were near no

villa at the time, they must have fallen victims to the storm. But the populace was also fully aroused now, and already men were appearing in the streets astride of zebras, waiting only for others to congregate when they would hurry on to the rescue of the King and his party, if it was not already too late.

Sedai also brought out his zebra and joining the party, they started for the shore of the lake, knowing that somewhere near this would be found the King and his party. They started down the Avenue of On with the hope of reaching the King and his friends in time to help them, but the air was now becoming thick with sand and even sticks and stones, and the rescuing party were riding right in the face of this merciless hurricane. The zebras held their heads far down and moved on determinedly. Their riders lay close to their necks, endeavoring in this way to protect their faces. But it grew worse. The zebras, now thoroughly blinded, stumbled on, making heroic efforts to keep up the uneven struggle, but their pace was growing slower and slower and there seemed to be no chance for their getting much further. Suddenly Sedai's zebra turned to the right and left the avenue, the others followed. The party dared not open their eyes to see where the zebras were taking them, but after a little while noticing a cessation of the pitiless rain of sand and gravel, they opened their eyes as well as they could, and found that the animals had left the road and had sought shelter from the fearful storm near one of the farm villas. They had stopped under the east wall which protected them to some extent.

The men hurriedly dismounted and led the zebras to the large stable in the rear. All realized that it was useless to try to proceed further in the pitiless storm; it would only be death to do so, and they could not help their friends if they were in such a condition as the storm promised to put them in if they continued. Another hour of that fearful onslaught of gravel and sand, and small sticks and twigs, and every man would be dead. So they determined to wait until the storm would abate, when they would hurry on and give assistance to their friends, if it was not forever too late.

The inky blackness of the night, lit up only occasionally by the lightning, the fearful peals of thunder, the roaring of the storm as it rushed madly on, made the night one never to be forgotten. It must have been several hours past midnight before it abated in the least, and after it had once spent its wild fury it died quickly, and in a very short time it was perfectly calm.

Sounds of wounded and distressed animals could now be heard, pitiful in their mournful cries; trees could still be heard falling, and the night-birds which had escaped the fury of the storm, again took up their flight, giving out most dismal screeches. But the storm had passed, and Sedai and his party were again moving slowly along the avenue, for the night was still dark and many fallen trees now covered this beautiful highway.

So hurrying was out of the question, but the zebras, who had had their eyes washed out in the stable, and keen-sighted and sure-footed now, they went along at a good pace, considering the condition of the road. But it was so dark, and they had now proceeded far enough on their journey to expect to meet couriers from the King and party, if there were any left to tell the tale. Torches had been procured at the villa at which they had sought shelter, and lighting these, they carried them high above their heads with good effect. The lights threw weird shadows along the avenue as they picked their way through the debris. The storm seemed not to have touched the avenue or the grand trees bordering it, but had taken a course parallel to this, the outer edge of which had come very close to the southern border of the avenue. It was not, then, the avenue shade trees which occasionally lay across it, but the forest trees which covered the fields on each side. So close, however, had the tornado or cyclone come to the avenue, that some of the branches of its bordering trees had been cut off as with a knife.

Occasionally, in the glare of the torches, a wounded or dead animal would be seen. In one instance, a deer had been killed by a falling tree, and its mate, which had probably been with it at the time, now lay beside its dead licking the eyes and face. Again, a zebra had been torn and lacerated by the fierceness of the storm, and as it saw the lights and the familiar forms of the zebra in the cavalcade, it made a painful effort to rise and follow. Sedai seeing its suffering, dismounted and killed the poor beast, thus putting it out of its misery. The onyx pavement was covered with dead and wounded birds, the storm having played greater havoc among the winged inhabitants, than among any of the other.

At last faint streaks of dawn lighted up the eastern heaven, and gradually it grew lighter, until the great hot sun burst forth, its rays disclosing a scene of fearful devastation. But our friends had but little time to notice all of this. They were looking for the wounded or dead bodies of the King and his party. But look as they might, they could not see either a wounded or dead

zebra or elephant, in this part of the avenue. This was probably because these animals had stables, into which they could run if they chose, and as all the buildings were of onyx, and built to stand for centuries, the storm's violence had no effect on them.

The rescuing party's progress had necessarily been slow, for they were not only hindered by fallen trees and other debris which strewn the avenue, but a great deal of time had been taken up in looking over the ground carefully, they fearing that if they did not do this, they might pass some of their wounded friends. They had now reached the lake, and the numerous inlets, or bays, which stretched into the mainland for a short distance, showed, from the appearance of their banks, that they had also received harsh treatment by the storm. Near one of these, lay, with its body half twisted in two, one of the sea monsters which had been sucked from the stream and hurled against a neighboring tree. Many fishermen's boats were strewn along the banks smashed to splinters. The villa in which the King and party had spent the night of prayer, was visited by the rescuers, but the bewildered attendants here could only say that the King and his party had left the morning before, and had not again returned. Then Sedai, and those with him, after exchanging their poor, tired zebras for fresh ones, and after a hasty meal, pushed on. They might reasonably suppose that the party had reached a point at least twenty miles farther to the northwest before the storm broke in its fury; but it might have been that they saw the storm approaching even before those in the city did, and fearing serious consequences had turned back. In this case the rescuers might expect to meet them at any time now and especial care was taken to look behind each fallen tree or pile of debris.

An elephant had been taken along from the last villa in hopes that he might be able to sooner detect their near approach to any of his companions used by Onrai and his party. These animals are very sagacious and their senses are very acute, they being able to hear the slightest noise or see the most minute object, while their scent is only equaled by a bloodhound.

Carefully this great beast picked his way, stepping gingerly over the fallen trees and testing each bridge with his fore legs before venturing to cross it. The distance between the villa and where our friends might expect to be found, if safe, was now half covered and the rescuers had gained heart with each step forward, for if those whom they were seeking were not

found within the next few miles, they would know that they were safe. Suddenly the elephant stopped, and sniffing the air gave a sharp, quick cry. Looking to the left the party saw the huge body of an elephant, and beside it that of a woman.

CHAPTER XVI.

ENOLA FOUND.

Onrai had seen Enola slip and fall, and then carried away from him, with the greatest anguish. He stood for a moment gazing at the retreating figure, and saw the noble elephant grasp her. He now thought her safe and started toward her, but the storm caught him in its folds and he was also being hurried before it. But the attendants had been watching him and Enola from the entrance, and seeing him hurried on by the storm, they formed a line by clasping hands, and throwing this human barrier across the terrace they prevented the King from being blown further by the storm, and before he could realize it, he was hurried into the villa and was standing among his friends and attendants. The action had been so quick that he was at first bewildered, but the truth having suddenly dawned upon him, he made a rush for the door.

“Back, man,” said Mr. Bruce, throwing himself across his path. “What would you do? Do you not know that it is sure death to venture forth in this storm?”

Onrai stopped and looked at Mr. Bruce almost scornfully, then said:

“And would you let Enola perish?”

“No, not if the giving of my life would save hers,” said Mr. Bruce, “but to throw myself into that howling vortex, would mean instant death, and in no way could I help Enola. We must wait until the storm abates and then look for our friend. She has the protection of the only living thing which can help her now, her good friend, Gip. God grant that his powerful strength may prove mightier than the power of the storm,” and as he finished speaking, Mr. Bruce raised his hand to his eye and brushed away a tear.

Onrai turned away and paced the long hall like a caged lion, his hands crossed behind his back, and his body slightly bent forward, as if ready to spring through the open entrance and run, as soon as the elements would permit. Harry, who was also crazed with pain because of the fate of Enola, was also on the alert to give Onrai a race in his rush to rescue his friend.

The storm grew fiercer each moment and the noise more fearful. Mr. Graham stepped up to Mr. Bruce and with a white face, said, "No human being could possibly live in that storm; it is fearful."

"Yes, the most terrible I have ever seen," said Mr. Bruce. "But let us hope that in some way Enola has reached safety."

"If I could only hope; but I cannot, that storm would kill every hope," said Mr. Graham.

"Enola was not in the heart of the storm," said Mr. Bruce. "She was not carried into the centre of that seething, swirling tornado. She was only in the outer edge, and maybe the elephant was sagacious enough to work its way out of danger. Let us hope so at least."

But hope seemed futile when they looked into that fearful on-rushing storm.

"Look," said Mr. Bruce. They all turn toward the door. The elephants had gathered beneath the trees in one corner of the garden, and here, bunched together they had resisted the storm, but as Mr. Bruce spoke, the storm had reached the height of its fury, and the elephants no longer being able to withstand its power had been blown forward, some of them falling and the others tumbling over them. Those that were able to keep their feet had been rushed forward with such force, that in striking the trees they were crushed and badly wounded; those that were left prone on the ground were rolling over and over in their efforts to regain their feet, the wind blowing them over again before they could stand erect.

Most of the zebras had run to the stables when they actually realized their danger, but others, which had remained to graze the fresh grass until too late, had been drawn into the circling, whirling mass and hurried on.

Onrai was still pacing the floor, almost crazed with the thought that Enola was in fearful peril and he unable to help her. Frequently he would walk to the door and clasping his hands, cry in an agonized voice: "Will it never cease?" It was now three hours after midnight and the fierce winds

had slackened, and the storm seemed broken. All were watching it now with an eager look, praying for its speedy death. The attendants went into the stables, and in a little while brought zebras to the terrace, and Onrai with his guests and twenty attendants started in search of Enola. But the night was still very dark and the torches helped them but little. Every foot of ground was gone over carefully. They did not keep in the avenue, but to the right, or in a direct line with that taken by Gip as he left the garden.

Several elephants were lying about the garden or in the surrounding fields, dead or too badly disabled to work. In the clear light of day Gip could have been easily distinguished from any of these, but in the darkness all looked alike, and each prostrate form was examined carefully, and in some cases ropes were thrown about the legs and the elephant turned over, the party thinking that Enola might possibly be lying crushed beneath it. But none of these proved to be Gip, and the party moved slowly on.

“I feel hopeful that the elephant with Enola has escaped,” said Mr. Bruce to Onrai, as they rode along.

“Oh, I hope so,” answered Onrai, “but it was fearful,” and he shuddered.

“But tell me, Onrai, when you have such storms as these, are many of your people killed?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“We have never before had such a storm, never during my life. We have some storms in this season, but never like this, and death has never resulted. The death and ruin which I have seen to-night appalls me. Never before have I, or any of my race, I believe, experienced such sensations as these fearful sights bring forth. I cannot understand why this should be. That it is a visitation of our God, I know; but why? That the punishment is just I cannot doubt; but for what is this punishment? I or my people have sinned, but I know not what this sin is, unless——” and Onrai’s face turned ghastly pale in the glare of the torches.

“Unless what, Onrai?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“Unless it be in a way of which I cannot tell you,” said Onrai, “or, unless my people have failed, in my absence, to carry out certain rites preparatory to the Day of Resis, which must not be neglected.”

Mr. Bruce looked at him for a moment with the intention of asking him something further regarding this strange day, but something kept him from doing so.

The dawn was breaking and it seemed that these hours had been spent in a fruitless search. But so careful had been the search, that all felt assured that Enola had not been passed. They had covered but few miles, but in this space the whole width of the storm's track had been carefully looked over.

"I cannot see how the elephant could have held out sufficiently long to reach this distance," said Mr. Graham to Mr. Bruce, "and I think that it is convincing proof, that the beast beat his way out of the trail of the storm and took a circuitous route back to the villa."

"If that was so," answered Mr. Bruce, "he should have reached the villa before we departed, or else we would have met him on the way."

"No, I think that we will yet find both the elephant and Enola safe," said Harry, who then joined them, but probably too exhausted to return, and awaiting assistance. "See there," and as he spoke all looked in the direction of the avenue and saw a party of natives, headed by Sedai, approaching.

"They are coming towards us," said Onrai. "Let us meet them."

They started towards the approaching party, Onrai in the lead. He turned his zebra to one side to go around a pile of debris, when, upon reaching the far side of this, he pulled up his zebra so quickly, that it nearly dismounted him. His eyes were bulging from their sockets and a groan left his lips; he seemed paralyzed, so rigid had he grown. The rest of the party had now come up, and also Sedai and his followers, and all looked in the direction in which was Onrai, and there, half hidden by the debris and great body of the elephant, lay Enola, her robe almost torn from her body and her face and hands black and bleeding.

CHAPTER XVII.

“SHE IS MAD.”

As both parties met and looked down on the bruised and blackened face of Enola, a cry of horror went up from each one of them. Hope had still had life as long as there was any uncertainty, but now it had met its death.

“Look,” said Harry, “the elephant is not dead. See, he is trying to move his head.”

Hurriedly the party dismounted, and Onrai lifted Enola carefully in his arms. She had fallen across Gip’s outstretched trunk when the crash came, and here she now laid. When Onrai lifted her up, Gip tried to raise his head, but this he could not do. The whole side of it was crushed in, or the lower part of it was, and he looked up with pitiful eyes, begging help from the party bending over him.

Onrai still had Enola in his arms when Mr. Bruce came up and said:

“Lay her down on the grass, Onrai, until I can make an examination. Quick, she may yet be living; the elephant is.”

Carefully Onrai laid her on the grass, holding her head in his lap. Mr. Bruce bent down, and placing his ear to her heart, said:

“She yet lives. Quick, bring me a flask of brandy.” A flask was handed him, and placing this to the lips of Enola, poured a few drops down her throat. “Bring some water,” he again commanded, and this having been handed him, he bathed her bruised face and hands with it. She was badly lacerated, the cuts not being deep, but so many of them that an inch of whole skin could scarcely be found.

Harry looked as long as he could, but finally walked away; the sight of his loved one in this condition crazing him.

But for the faint beating of the heart, all would have pronounced her dead, for it could scarcely be hoped that one so terribly cut and bruised could survive. Even the body had not been spared, and great blotches of flesh had been torn from it by contact with the flying debris.

“Is there hope?” almost whispered Onrai.

“I cannot say,” said Mr. Bruce. “But if blood-poisoning does not set in, I should think, with her splendid constitution, she might get well. But she has laid here for hours exposed, and it is greatly against her chances for recovery. She must be taken where women attendants can help her, and that immediately.” And Mr. Bruce had to again place his ear over the region of the heart in order to tell whether she was yet alive.

“See, she opens her eyes,” said Harry, as he again comes up.

Yes, it was true, she had opened her eyes, but only for an instant, and then closed them again.

“Enola, look; do you not know us?” said Harry, as he bent over her.

Her eyes again opened, and she tried to part her parched and bleeding lips, but she had not yet the strength.

“There may be some hope now, I think,” said Mr. Bruce.

Hurriedly a litter was made from the blanket taken from the elephant, and with one of her friends at each corner of this, Enola was carried to the nearest villa. This was not far away, and, when reached, attendants were found in waiting, and Enola being carried to one of the large, cool and comfortable apartments, she was soon under the care of female attendants. Carefully they bathed the bruised and bleeding body, and under Mr. Bruce’s orders they anointed and bandaged the cuts. Finally, after long and hard work, and after hope of resuscitating her was nearly lost, she opened her eyes.

Mr. Bruce was standing at her side at the time, and seeing that she had regained consciousness, and that danger for the time was passed, he carried the glad news to the anxious ones waiting for his report. All immediate anxiety being allayed they breathed freer. Onrai, who now felt at liberty to return to the city, began to make preparations for so doing, he feeling that at such a time his presence was greatly needed among his people. Accordingly he took a few of his attendants, and after making arrangements for hourly messengers to be sent him, giving full account of Enola’s condition, he

started. Just before leaving, Enola opened her eyes, and after a moment, uttered the one word, "Gip."

It was perfectly natural that returning consciousness should bring to memory the fearful experiences of the night before and of the brave animal which had fought so nobly to protect, and save her life. In their anxiety for Enola all thought of poor Gip had been forgotten, but when she spoke his name and they knew that she was anxious about him, and when they remembered all that he had done for her, they censured themselves for having forgotten him for even a moment.

Onrai gave orders to some of his people to go to the assistance of Gip, and to do all in their power to relieve the noble beast, if yet alive. Mr. Bruce, not being needed for the time in the sick-room, went with the party as did also Sedai. The great animal heard them coming, and tried to raise his shattered head, but could not. A slight movement of the trunk was the only sign of life he could give. Mr. Bruce had not made a study of the anatomy of the elephant, and he understood very little about them, but he determined to do all he could for the animal.

Gip had unfortunately fallen on his right side and it was necessary for them to turn him over. This was no easy task; in fact it looked at first as if this could not be accomplished; but Mr. Bruce quickly thought out a plan which proved successful. Large ropes were tied to the legs of the side on which the animal was lying, and by a long and hard pull he was turned over onto the unbruised side. A groan, almost human in its intensity, escaped the crushed beast, as he was pulled over but he seemed to understand that his friends were there to help him. Mr. Bruce commenced at once to examine his wounds.

The lower side of the head had been crushed and the body for half its length was lacerated. He had fallen on these wounds and the sand and gravel which covered the ground had worked into the wounds and were now held there by clotted blood. Water was brought from the lake and poured into the wounds until cleansed of all dirt, and then soothing liniments were poured into them. Gip did not make a movement, the great intelligent beast realizing that all this washing and anointing was being done to help him. It was a question as to how they were going to bandage the huge body, and after careful consideration this was deemed impossible until he could stand, as they could not carry the bandage about the body

otherwise. The head, however, was lifted by the exertions of a dozen of the attendants and great, white silk bandages were carried around the monstrous hulk. Pails of water were now brought and he drew in great draughts with his trunk. Food was also brought where he could reach it. Everything that could possibly be done for his comfort was done, and two men were left to watch over the animal until evening, when he was to be again bandaged, and, if possible, gotten on his feet and taken to the villa.

Mr. Bruce now hurried back to the villa. He had been gone for some time and he feared that Enola might need his attention. He had considerable misgiving regarding her speedy recovery, or even her recovery at all, for she had been fearfully bruised and cut, and had been so long exposed afterward, that there was great fear of blood-poisoning setting in. He realized what this wonderful woman had undergone in these few short hours, and he doubted if another could have passed through such an ordeal and lived. But Enola had a perfectly healthy constitution and Mr. Bruce had a faint hope that this intrepid girl might pull through.

As he entered the villa, Nellie, who had been sent for, met him in the hall, and to his look of inquiry, said,

“She has awakened but her mind is gone; she is mad.”

CHAPTER XVIII.

ONRAI VISITS THE PRIEST.

Onrai hurried on to the city. At frequent intervals on his journey he met couriers from the city, all hurrying to give him the details of new discoveries of the storm's devastation. The track of the tempest, as he now followed it, so shortly after its fearful advent, showed ruin and death everywhere. But so far no loss of human life had been reported and the King felt more than thankful for this. As the inhabitants would meet the King, they would look at him in the same wondering way as they had at the storm the night before, they were evidently seeking an explanation from their King, of the phenomenon. When they did ask him why such ruin had overtaken them, he would invariably answer by saying that there was sin among them. Then they would look one at the other as if wondering, if it were he or she who was guilty.

Arriving at the city, he found the populace awaiting him. On all previous occasions when Onrai had been away from the city for a season, upon his return the people had been glad to see him and had met him at the city limits with harps and glad songs. But now they stood and looked with no joy in their faces; but this was easy to account for. The people had never before in their lives had one little thing to occur to disturb the even tenor of their existence. Their lives were simply one long, happy or perfectly contented existence, they knowing no pains or sorrows.

The seasons came and went, each occupying just so many months, never varying greatly one from the other, for it was perpetual spring in this delightful country. But at one season more rain fell than at another, and for several months of each year rain never fell. Severe storms were very infrequent and such storms as the one of the night previous had never been known before. And this had happened right in the middle of the dry season.

It was not so much this latter fact probably which made the people wonder, as it was the death and ruin which it left in its wake. This the people could not understand, for life to them was a sacred thing, even those animals of a meat-serving kind, never being allowed to be killed wantonly, or where there was no use in the slaughter. Why had the poor dumb beasts been killed in this way? There was a world of inquiry in their looks as they stood perfectly still, and saw the King pass.

But Onrai heeded them not. He hurried on past the great square and up the broad avenue to the Temple, where the head priest was awaiting him, and as the King drew up, the priest approached him, saying, "You have come, oh King. Throughout the night I have prayed for you and those with you. You are safe, God be praised," and taking Onrai by the hand he led him into the Temple.

"It was your prayers then which brought us to shelter before the storm overtook us," said the King. "But tell me, you who know all of the sacred writings, what has caused this death-dealing and destroying storm. I can only believe that our people are sinning. Tell me, do you not think this so?"

"I have made research, knowing that both you, King, and the people would want to know the cause of the storm, and I too have wished to learn the reason. I find among the sacred writings words admonishing us to do right at all times and if laws were broken and the inhabitants of this great Land of On treated lightly, the commands laid down for their good and prosperity, they would be made to suffer in such ways as God would devise. I also find that God will give warning to the good of coming events. I do not know what to think, but I hardly believe that our good people are sinning."

"Are there any motives which might make us break the laws?" asked the King.

"I think not," answered the priest, and as he said this, he looked at the King and was surprised to see his face so pale. "No, it must be a warning," he continued.

"But what unusual event can come to our country?" asked Onrai.

"Was not the storm of last night an unusual event?" asked the priest, "and should this not be a sufficient warning to us to guard against all such? I believe that naught else can come to the Land of On but the wars of the

elements, and if these visit us, it is God's will and they purpose some good."

"If it be God's will, he must have some object in it," said Onrai. "But tell me, priest, did the Kings of On ever marry?"

The question almost staggered the priest and he started back for the moment unable to answer. But controlling himself he came forward and looked Onrai straight in the eye, asking sternly, "Why do you ask? Do you not know that it means death to the King who even contemplates marriage? Were not the sacred teachings imparted to you when you were yet young, and have these not been told you many times since and expanded on, and explained? And does not the law say that the King shall not marry? I cannot understand you, King."

Onrai's face was puzzled as he looked at the priest as he spoke.

"I hardly understand myself," said the King. "I have indeed read the great laws and have heard them read since my earliest childhood, and I know that the King cannot marry and that there are great and good reasons given for his not marrying. But God forgive me if I have thought for one moment that this law was unjust. I am King, chosen by the people because of my physical attainments and stature. I am strong, powerful; through my veins courses the blood of endless generations of perfect manhood; every nerve, every tissue, every muscle tingles with life; I have been trained until my naturally healthy sinews are as hard as the black metal which we dig out of the foothill of the cliffs; my whole being vibrates with health and vitality and for these reasons I am chosen King and denied a wife; I of all men who should be granted a mate," and as he ceased speaking he strode up and down the Temple, his powerful form shaking like an aspen; his breath came quick and short; his hands opened and shut nervously.

The priest looked at him in wonderment and seemed at a loss to know how to answer him. But he must say something to this rash man, this ruler of the people, who was supposed to be pure, to be sinless. If others should hear him talk in this mad way the consequences might be fearful. He stepped in front of the King as he came near him and said, "Onrai, are you not mad? Do you not realize the consequences of such ravings? Do you not know that death awaits you if you give up to such sinful thoughts? Oh, Onrai, King, brother, great and good, strong and beautiful, drive these fearful thoughts from your mind; smother these emotions, which can only

lead you to destruction. Remember that endless line of ancestors of whom you speak, and let not an act of yours disgrace their memory or make sorrowful the people who chose you for their King. Tell me, oh my brother, what it is which has wrought this great change in you,” and then, seeming to remember the strangers, he clutched Onrai’s arm nervously and said, “Tell me, is it they?”

“Of whom do you speak,” asked the King.

“Of the strangers,” answered the priest.

“Why should you suspicion our guests,” asked Onrai. “Is it just to them, who for the time may expect only the kindest treatment from us? I do not like this,” but as he spoke, his heart smote him for being the first to suspicion the good motives of the strangers.

“Forgive me, King,” said the priest. “I had but your interest at heart and thought only of you when I spoke; but I could not suspicion you of fostering such thoughts unless encouraged by some one. And I could not suspicion any of our people, for they have too great a reverence for our holy laws to ever speak on such subjects. Then, who could I think of but they of the fair skin? But I was wrong, forgive me.”

“No, it has been nature itself, this strong vital power which permeates my being, which has prompted the thoughts. I cannot be held responsible for these thoughts, but only for nurturing them, and allowing them to influence me in doing wrong. It has not reached this point yet and it never shall. If I am weak in the body I am strong here,” and Onrai tapped his forehead.

“Now, you are the Onrai I have known since a boy,” said the priest. “But Onrai be careful; guard against temptation, as our sacred writing commands us to do. Come to me and tell me if you are again tempted; I have never had such thoughts as yours and I can better counsel and advise you. And if others should hear you vent such thoughts, the whole populace would soon know it and the end would be death. Let me again admonish you, my King, to fortify your mind against such temptations. If certain ones create such thoughts, go not near them,” and the priest, with this advice, left him.

Onrai walked down the main hall of the Temple, his mind trying to throw from it the gloomy thoughts which the priest’s negative assertion had raised. So the hope, which sprung into being when he saw Enola’s innocence, could not be cherished; the fulfilment of it could never be

realized. The thought was maddening and Onrai groaned aloud in his fearful agony.

“God help me in this struggle,” he cried, “is it sin, can it be sin, this longing to be like other men, be allowed to take unto myself a wife? I cannot believe that it is, but the law says “No,” and I, with every impulse fighting against it, must comply.”

He now left the Temple and walked down the broad avenue. Word had gone forth that the King would speak at the large open square, and crowds who had seen the King come to the city had now, with their friends gathered and were waiting with those same wonder-depicting countenances, for the King to come and tell them why the strange storm had come and ruined the Land of On. Walking straight to the fountain, Onrai mounted the dais and glancing about him for a moment at the hushed, bewildered Onians, said:

“It has pleased our great God to give us a warning; this warning admonishes us to be careful, watchful and diligent. If any among you have sinned or are sinning, this fearful storm tells you to turn from the evil of your ways; if you have intentions of sinning, it speaks to you a warning, but I cannot believe that my people are sinning. I look among you to-day and see not one guilty face. You are bewildered, in wonderment, but this is not guilt. It can be a warning to us of some disastrous event which may visit our fair land. It may be that it will all be revealed to us later, but let us not be worried, but obeying the laws, go on in our happy way. The fearful storm has caused no loss of life of our people, and we may believe from this that God was not angry with us. Let us be watchful of coming harm, but let us not live in dread, for such will destroy happiness. The storm has left a vast track of ruin behind it, but ruin easily righted. We must, for the time, give up all other occupations and repair the damage done by the storm. Only let the food be furnished and the city kept clean. All traces of the devastation will soon be gone and we will forget, or it will only be a memory to us after a short time. Our guests from the far-away planet escaped injury, all but one and that one was the fair and sweet Enola, who is so much loved by you all. But I left her better and she will recover, for God would not take one of our guests, and leave our people unharmed.”

As if in denial of Onrai’s words, a messenger stepped to the edge of the crowd and waved a piece of papyrus over his head. Onrai saw him at once and raising his hand, said:

“A courier has just arrived from the villa in which lies the fair Enola. I must hasten to this villa as these people are our guests, and I should be with them. Again I pray of you, be watchful, and keeping from sin, be happy and contented as in the past.”

Onrai ceased speaking and descending to the pavement took the message from the courier. It read as follows:

“Enola lives, but her reason is dead.” His face turned ashen and he jumped on to the zebra held for him by an attendant, and dashed off madly down the avenue. The populace watched his retreating figure in still greater wonderment, and the attendants who followed him were soon left far in the rear, as the zebra which he rode was fleeter than any other in the land. On the King rode, each moment urging the zebra to greater efforts, each moment shortening the distance between Enola and himself. The avenue had been almost cleared of fallen trees by the large body of men who had immediately gone to work after the storm, and Onrai hardly met with any obstructions in his mad rush. It was growing dark now and Onrai had ridden nearly fifty miles that day, but he showed no fatigue as he bent well over the zebra’s shoulders and urged it on. He had but one thought, an excruciating one: “Enola was mad.” The agony of that thought. She would no longer look at him with those beautiful eyes or speak to him in those charming accents, or smile on him with those lips which seemed only made to kiss. Mad, mad, mad; the word rang in his ears, the zebra’s hoofs seemed to pound it out of the flinty pavement, the birds in the air were screeching it; everything seemed to be telling him the fearful story. On, on he rushed with unabated speed, the zebra reeking with sweat and panting as if it would drop each moment, its eyes bulged and glaring, until, pulling up in front of the villa, and Onrai jumping from its back, the beast falls dead.

CHAPTER XIX.

ONRAI CONFESSES HIS LOVE.

Yes, it was only too true. The sufferings of that mad ride before the storm and the long exposure had unbalanced Enola's reason. As Mr. Bruce entered the apartment after visiting Gip he found two women attendants struggling with her trying to prevent her leaving the couch, while Mrs. Graham was standing near trying to reason with her. But there was no longer any reason in Enola. She had awakened to oblivion, her mind groveling in darkness.

Mr. Bruce walked up, and looking at Enola closely, saw that she was in a high fever; feeling her pulse he knew that she was in a very dangerous condition. His troubled look told the story to Mrs. Graham and Nellie as they stood watching him anxiously. He sent for the small medicine chest which they had brought with them from the States, and which they had thought to place with the equipments when starting on this excursion. From this he took medicines that would allay the fever, first giving Enola a quieting powder. This had to be forced down her throat as she closed her teeth tightly and refused to take anything. It soon had its effect and as her muscles relaxed and bruised limbs became quiet, Mr. Bruce could better diagnose the disease.

After a careful examination he came to the conclusion that she was suffering more from a nervous fever than anything else, caused by the fearful suspense, suffering and exposure of the night before.

"Is there any hope for her?" asked Harry, who had come into the apartment.

"I cannot say," said Mr. Bruce, "but we will hope until the disease has run its course and the change comes."

“But of her reason,” questioned Harry. “If she lives, will her mind always be clouded?” and Harry’s look of agony was fearful.

“That I cannot say, for unfortunately, I am not an expert in mind diseases,” answered Mr. Bruce. “It may be though only the ravings of a fever-racked brain, and when this has passed she may regain her reason.”

“God grant that this may be true,” said Harry.

Mr. Bruce was a great advocate of ice in cases of fever and he had at once ordered a liberal use of this. Fortunately Mrs. Graham and Nellie were with Enola, for they had both had experience as nurses and knew just what to do, and then their love for her would insure her the very best of treatment.

The day rolled by and Enola had not yet come out of the long sleep into which the morphine had thrown her. Harry had strolled up and down before the door of the sick chamber, stopping occasionally to listen, hoping to hear signs of returning consciousness from within. But all had remained quiet and Harry had kept up the vigil from without. He had suffered fearfully in those few short hours since Enola, snatched by the storm, had been carried away, giving her up only after it had destroyed the greatest gift of God—reason. It seemed an age to him, these few short hours and the suffering had grown more intense as the day advanced, and the possibilities of returning life and reason grew less. Harry was not one to say much or to carry his heart on his sleeve, but his love for Enola was deep and sincere, and his suffering now fearful as a consequence. He had seen Enola’s growing friendliness or infatuation for the King and this had wounded him terribly. Still he had so much faith in her that he could not doubt but that she would be perfectly true to herself in the matter, and if, in the meantime she should learn to love Onrai, she would tell him candidly.

But the thought was torturing, the very possibility of his losing her after these long years. The barbarous grandeur, so it might be called, of the King and his people, was enough to turn the head of any woman or man, for that matter, and he could not blame Enola if she should turn from him to the King. Yet there was something about these people which could not be understood, a certain mystery unsolved and unsolving; they had now been among them several weeks, and had been let into all their mode of life, their customs, habits, and nothing, seemingly, had been kept from them; but there had been mentioned a certain day, the Day of Resis, over which there hung

a cloud. This had only been mentioned unguardedly, and there seemed to be a secret connected with it, which was not to be divulged to the vulgar ears of the strangers. Harry had hopes that the uncertainty of this mystery would guard Enola from allowing herself to form an alliance with the King, an alliance which might make life a hell ever afterwards.

Harry was not superstitious, but there was a certain dread of the future with these people; a sort of premonition of coming evil; that before long this pleasant life would end, and a something would occur which would make the party forever regret the day they entered this strange country. These thoughts might have been occasioned by the fear that Enola was being infatuated by the subtle influence of the King; an influence, which he, Harry, thought lay in the mystery overhanging the entire race. But when Enola would once come to believe as he did, that there was a future life with these people, which was the very reverse to the one they were now enjoying, she would at once turn a deaf ear to the love-making of Onrai. But had he made love to her? Harry could not make himself believe that Enola would allow this from one whom she had known but such a short while; and then Onrai, when Harry came to think of him, was such a great, powerful man, so straightforward and free from all deceit, so brave and strong; he looked a lover, and yet he did not know. One thing Harry was assured of: Onrai did not make love to Enola with those simple nothings which make up the wooings of modern lovers in civilized countries. And it might be the total absence of these idiotic expressions which won her friendship and esteem, and finally, love. It might be the grand physique and strength of the man which attracted her. But at any rate, Harry would not relinquish all hope of yet winning Enola, and when he thought of that mysterious something which threw a sort of shroud over the future of these people, he felt almost confident that Enola would not allow herself to become entirely infatuated, or, as it has been said, allied with this King.

But now this slender hope had been shattered. Enola lay at death's door physically and mentally, with but slight hopes of regaining bodily health, and less of her ever regaining her reason. For the first time Harry regretted their ever having started on this hazardous journey, but when he thought of the determination of Enola, and realized that she would have come at any rate whether he had or not, he felt glad at least that he was now here to help her. He must be resigned and await the future. But this was easier said than done, especially when the one great loved one was lying at death's door.

Again he stopped and listened, and hearing no sound, walked to the entrance, and looking out saw Onrai dash madly up on his winded charger and dismount. Onrai almost stumbled over Harry as he hurried through the entrance. Looking up almost angrily, he was about to make some passionate remark, when, seeing that it was Harry, he grasped him by the shoulders, and said, hoarsely:

“Tell me quickly, how is she?”

“The same,” answered Harry. “Still mad, and no hope.”

“It is fearful!” cried Onrai, as he dropped his hands from Harry’s shoulders and commenced pacing the floor.

Harry watched the suffering of this strong man, and for a time, almost gloated over the thought of this rival’s agony. But why should he feel this way? Had not Onrai been open and above board with him, and did he, Onrai, ever suspect that he had a rival in himself? So if they were to be rivals, let it be an open and square fight, and not for a moment harbor such miserable jealous thoughts. Going up to Onrai, he said:

“Tell me, King, why do you take such an interest in us—in Enola? We are your guests, certainly, but your interest in us is even greater than we might expect from you, our host.”

“I cannot answer you,” said Onrai, “further than as you have suggested, it is because you are my guests. You come to us strangers; you knew not what to expect when you threw yourselves on our bounty, but you trusted us, and for that reason you are deserving of every attention which we can give you.”

“But pardon me, Onrai,” said Harry, “if I ask you a pointed question. I saw your fearful agitation as you witnessed Enola being borne away from you last night in the teeth of the storm; I saw that you suffered far more than if you had only a friendly interest in her; and I saw you to-night when you came tearing up the driveway and then up the steps of the terrace, the dead zebra testifying that you must have ridden like mad: I see you now, your face pale, your eyes bloodshot, your whole appearance displaying mental anguish. Have you not a personal interest in Enola, and is not this interest prompted by a feeling deeper than friendship?”

Onrai now stood with his arms crossed over his breast, his bearing erect and scornful, as if to give Harry the impression that he was accountable to

himself alone for his actions and did not recognize Harry's right to question him. He stood looking at Harry for some time after he had finished speaking, as if debating with himself as to whether he would answer him or not. But his just nature asserted itself, and he said:

"Your question is a strange one, but I feel that you have some right to ask it; for you have been Enola's companion for years and must have a brotherly regard or love for her. I cannot blame you, now that I remember the difference in our lives, for this solicitation for her future. But have not my attentions to Enola been honorable? Do you think that I, the King of the Land of On, chosen by the people because they knew that I was pure of mind, do you think that I could so far forget my natural traits or early teachings, as to have any but the purest thoughts of Enola, and do you not know that the Kings of On cannot marry?"

"So I have learned," answered Harry, "but are you not still a man, and as a man have you not human emotions and passions? Because you are a chosen King, is the ruling passion, love, driven from your heart?"

"No, I would to God that it was," answered Onrai, and his face betrayed his fearful agony of mind. "No, this passion is still ours, but sufficient strength is given us to keep it in check. We must smother it and cast it out. We must so interest ourselves in our people as to forget all else."

"But can you do this?" asked Harry. "Is not love all-powerful? Even among your people, who are supposed to keep it in check until after marriage? You have lived, Onrai, thirty-five years; have you not in that time felt the delightful sensations of love, and have you found it possible to smother it?"

"Yes, I have loved," answered Onrai. "But it came over me like a dream and was so subtle in its movements that I did not realize that it had taken possession of me until a long time afterwards. But an unlooked for event opened my eyes to my sin and the knowledge of it nearly crazed me."



“No, I would to God that it was.”—
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“Your sin?” asked Harry. “Do you consider it a sin when you did not realize that it was love that had taken possession of you? I would not call it by such a name.”

“Still it was a sin,” said Onrai, “for I had allowed myself to be drawn into its meshes without even making an effort to extricate myself. To escape this tempter it is necessary that we guard against the influences which lead to it, and I have not done this.”

“But, King, could you, after your discovery, tear this love from your breast and go on as if you had never experienced this grand emotion?” questioned Harry again.

“I must,” answered Onrai, “for it would be death for me to nurture it and allow it to influence my life, which it would do if I did not kill it. Still, the struggle will be terrible, and I know not how it will end. It is too early now in the fight, perhaps, to expect great results, but I almost doubt my strength to overcome its machinations. But I must see her,” and Onrai hurried toward the door of Enola’s apartment, Mr. Bruce having beckoned him to come.

CHAPTER XX.

THE AGONY OF ONRAI.

The day must have seemed interminable to the wounded elephant as he lay on the hard, sand-covered earth. All that could be done for his comfort, however, had been done; his wounds had been dressed again in the evening and repeated efforts had been made to get him on his feet, but without success. They had, though, gotten him on his haunches and he seemed easier in this position. They had gone to the villa and procured ropes and a sort of pulley, which they were now rigging to one of the trees above Gip. They thought that by getting him on his feet he might be able to walk to the villa stables, as the trouble all lay in the right foreleg, which had been sprained by the log striking it. The block and fall had been rigged and the rope worked under the immense body and fastened in a loop; then two other elephants were hitched to the other end of the rope and started. They moved slowly, and as the rope tightened about Gip's shoulders, he did all in his power to help regain his feet. But his help was not needed for the two elephants lifted him bodily until his forelegs were pulled from off the ground, his hind feet alone touching; then he was lowered until the forelegs again touched the ground, and after awhile, when he had become used to the weight, the rope was taken from about his body and the other two elephants taking up a position, one on either side of him, he was gently urged to take a step forward.

It was painful to see the effort he made to walk. His right foreleg was stiff and he had to limp in a distressing manner. It took a long time to reach the villa stables, where a soft bed had been made for him with a sling rigged above, so that he could be raised or lowered as the attendants saw fit.

"I declare," said Mr. Bruce, "it does me good to see the brave animal housed. If it were not for him we would not now have even a small hope of

Enola again being with us, alive and well.”

“It is a small hope, indeed,” said Mr. Graham. “But it is a hope, and even that is better than knowing that the bruised and mangled body lay buried under a pile of debris. Gip, you do not realize the full significance of your brave act. It may mean health and happiness or it may mean suffering and mental death. God forbid that it should be the latter.”

Mr. Graham and Mr. Bruce now turned and went into the house and direct to Enola’s apartment. She lay still in that death-like sleep into which she had fallen after taking the morphine. Mr. Bruce looked at her anxiously, and stepping up to her couch, felt her pulse.

“Her fever is abating,” he said, “and I can now say there may be some hope of her recovery. When I first felt her pulse this morning it was beating at the rate of 105; but the smallest rise in this and she could not have survived,” and saying this, Mr. Bruce proceeded to rebandage the swollen and inflamed face and limbs. Now that the fever was checked he feared blood-poison, and especial precaution against this had to be taken. As Mr. Bruce and the attendant unwound the old bandages, Enola opened her eyes and looked about her in a half-dreamy way, but there was no intelligence in that look; the eyes were dull and seemed to recognize none of the friends about her; her lips parted and she again breathed the word “Gip.” That was all. Everything else was forgotten, friends, past, all was wrapped in darkness now.

“The experiences of that night must have been terrible,” said Mr. Graham, as he looked upon Enola with tearful eyes.

“More terrible than we can even imagine,” said Mr. Bruce, “but the strong constitution may bring her back to health and happiness again; I feel more hopeful now.”

Nellie, who was standing by one of the large curtained arches at the far end of the room for a moment, breathing the fresh air from the garden, exclaimed hurriedly:

“Father, come quickly, it is Onrai dashing madly up the drive. Look, he is now at the terrace. Oh! his poor zebra has dropped dead, and he hurries up the steps. He looks wild, crazed by the experiences of the past few hours.”

“He will come directly to the apartment,” said Mr. Graham. “Mr. Bruce, warn him back.”

Mr. Bruce stepped into the wide corridor and motioned to Onrai to remain where he was. Coming back into the room, he said:

“Care must be taken when the King comes in, for he is not the Onrai we have known for the past few weeks. One short night and day has changed him wonderfully. He may, in his impetuosity, do something which will injure our fair patient.”

“How strange,” said Mrs. Graham, “that he should have changed so. Why, only yesterday, as we rode along, happy and without a care, I thought to myself that I had never seen a man so thoroughly free from all care and trouble as Onrai.”

“I think,” said Nellie, “that an explanation is easy enough to find.”

“Then tell us, Nellie,” said her mother.

“Why, he has fallen in love with Enola and the events of the past few hours have crazed him. We do not wonder at ourselves for being buried in grief at Enola’s sufferings, and it is but natural that Onrai should feel the same.”

“Don’t say that,” said Mrs. Graham. “It would grieve Harry deeply if he suspected such a thing to be true.”

“I doubt not that but Harry has seen the trend of things, for I have watched him closely lately and he seems to be worried,” said Mr. Graham, “but he would never admit it.”

Enola had fallen into the stupor during this short conversation and this was probably better so, for any violent movement would loosen the bandages and open the wounds afresh, and this must be avoided. As she lay partially on her side, a full view of her bandaged face could be had; nothing but the eyes could be seen however, the remainder of the face being entirely covered. She looked like one dead and with scarcely a breath stirring the gauze over her nostrils, and with the white silk robe falling about her, one could easily believe that she had succumbed to the excruciating sufferings. Just at this moment Mr. Bruce stepped to the arch and motioned Onrai to enter.

“Be very quiet,” said Mr. Bruce, as the King came forward hurriedly. Harry also came up quickly, and together they entered the apartment where the dearest one on earth to them, lay at death’s door.

Both stepped up to the couch, and as Onrai's eyes fell on the white bandages and saw only the discolored eyelids, he fell back exclaiming in an agonized voice, "Dead;" then, almost beside himself with grief, he rushed forward and falling beside the couch would have clasped her in his arms had not Harry, who was also suffering untold agony, caught him by the arm and held him back. Mr. Bruce also stepped up and said calmly;

"Onrai, what would you do. Do you not realize that such an act on your part would endanger her life? Calm yourself and do not ruin the small chance which this poor girl has for recovery."

Onrai arose and stepped back slowly, his whole frame convulsed with strong emotion. Drawing his hand over his eyes he said slowly.

"She is not dead then, thank God. Forgive me, I should not have acted thus for her sake and my own." Then looking about him and seeing several native women attendants in the apartment, his glance fell on the floor, for the first time in his life ashamed of his own actions.

Mr. Graham noticing the look of humiliation and guessing its cause, felt for this strong man to the bottom of his heart, and taking his arm, said;

"No, Onrai, she is not dead; but come with me, I would talk with you."

Onrai, with his glance still resting on the floor, went out with Mr. Graham. When they had reached the terrace, Mr. Graham said:

"Onrai, I saw your suffering to-night, and, believe me, it touched my heart. But do you realize what you are doing? Are you doing this with your eyes open? Have you forgotten the laws of your land? I know but little about these, but I do know that you cannot marry. Then, are you doing yourself or that dear one inside, justice, by harboring such feelings? It can only bring unhappiness to both of you; therefore, banish such thoughts from your mind."

"It is easy enough to say, do this, and I found it easy enough to resolve to do this, but I cannot do it. I cannot understand my weakness. My life has been spent, like my people's, adhering to the laws laid down for us to follow. I have never questioned these, and have, by living up to them, been perfectly contented, as are all of my people. But you come to us from afar, and my life is changed immediately; at first I was pleased with you all, and then I found myself happier when alone with Enola and discontented when away from her; and not until last night did I realize that it was love which

had wrought this change in me. Since then, what with the discovery of my sin and the fear for Enola's life, I have suffered the tortures of hell." As Onrai ceased speaking a noise like the marching of a heavy body of cavalry reached their ears. It was coming nearer and nearer. What did it mean?

CHAPTER XXI.

IN PERIL.

The rumbling noise came nearer and nearer, and Onrai and Mr. Graham stood without saying a word. In some respects the noise resembled that of the night before, but it came from the opposite direction. Involuntarily the two watchers looked at the heavens, but seeing the stars shining brightly, all fears of another storm were allayed.

“What can it be?” asked Mr. Graham.

“I cannot tell,” said Onrai. “It sounds like the tramp of many zebra, but I cannot understand why there should be any riders out to-night, unless it be a body of men who are on their way to to-morrow’s work. But even they would have started so as to have reached their destination long before this. It puzzles me greatly.”

“Could it be a body of men coming to you on a mission of some kind?” asked Mr. Graham.

“No, none would come to me at this time of night,” said Onrai. “And then there is no reason whatever for any of my people coming to me. The people know my wishes regarding the repairs to be made where the storm has brought ruin, and this is the only thing which they could wish to consult me upon. But they come nearer, and now we can distinguish the different sounds; yes, it is a body of riders, but where they are bound I cannot say,” and as Onrai finished speaking, a hundred flickering lights could be seen far down the avenue toward the town.

“Yes, it is a large body of men,” said Mr. Graham, as the riders came in sight, “and they are riding fast, as if their mission, whatever it may be, was important.”

“Yes, they seem in earnest,” said Onrai, “and they are turning toward the villa. They are coming here. I cannot understand,” and Onrai looked puzzled.

There seemed to be thousands of them as they rode toward the villa, winding in and out between the trees, for they disdained the single roadway. The leaders at last reached the terrace and seeing the King standing with Mr. Graham, they dismounted and stood beside their steeds. One of the leaders came forward and doffing his helmet and bowing low before the King, said,

“We have come from the city, oh King, to consult you on a matter which has come up to-day before the people.”

“I am always glad to heed the matters of my people. But why do you come to me at this hour of the night; would not the morrow do as well? It is late and within the villa lies one of our guests very near unto death, a victim of yesternight’s storm. Will the matter not rest then until daylight when a more suitable place can be chosen for its discussion, and where there will be no fear of disturbing the fair sufferer? I ask this not for myself but for one whose comfort you should all consider.”

“It is of her and her companions that we wish to speak,” answered the man.

“And what manner of business can the people possibly have with the strangers? Have they not been given into my charge and am I not responsible for their welfare and comfort? I cannot understand your reasons, man, for coming here on such an errand or the object the people had in sending you. Have you lost confidence in the ability of the King, to take care of and make enjoyable the life of our guests?”

“No, it is not that, oh King,” said the man. “We do not fear for the well-being of the strangers nor do we doubt your power to make all things pleasing for them. Our mission is of a different character; we wish to complain of them.”

“To complain of them,” said Onrai. “What do you mean, man? Have my people then so far forgotten their respect to the King’s wishes as to complain to him of his guests or the guests of the Land of On? For have not these strangers come to us from afar and have they not thrown themselves on to our hospitality, and is it not our sacred duty to care for them as long as

they are with us? It is your duty as well as mine, then why do you forget this so far as to make complaints of them?"

"We have not made these complaints as yet, oh King," said the man, "and we wished to place our suspicions before you and let you decide if they be well-grounded before we would call them complaints. But complaints to us seems to be the only fitting word to use in this connection."

"I cannot understand you, my people," said Onrai, "I was among you only to-day and you said naught to me about this matter. You allowed me to depart and come here without so much as a hint of your protest. Now, you follow me but a short time after, at the dead of night, and here where a fair life hangs by a thread; you come a thousand strong and voice your miserable suspicions. Our life has been so quietly peaceful that this trait has never before shown itself. A word which has almost passed from our vocabulary alone can fit the act, and that is cowardice," and as Onrai ceased speaking he drew himself up grandly and faced them with such a haughty bearing and scornful look that the leader drew back involuntarily.

"No, no, King, not that," said the man, "not that, for we had only your and our own best wishes at heart when we came here at this hour of night."

"And had you no thought for those who are now under our protection? Had you a right, even with complaints to make, to sneak here like a band of jackals, in the dead of night? Why do you not come in the bright open light of the day and then in numbers only equaling those against whom you are going to make complaints, and not with a horde as if to intimidate them."

"Listen, oh King," answered the man. "You must know that this is an event which has never before occurred in our land, and the people did not know how to act. They then got together and decided that we were to come to-night, and in a large body; this is to impress the strangers within our land that, although war and strife, such as our sacred writings speak of, are unknown to us, still we can come before them in a formidable body and fight for our fair Land of On."

"Are you mad, man?" asked Onrai. "What is this I hear? Are you talking of waging war against a handful of strangers, whom you ought to protect? Do you speak of war, that which has never been heard of in this land? Have the people of On gone mad with the advent of the storm?" and Onrai turned and strode up and down the terrace.

Mr. Bruce and Harry had come on to the terrace and now stood back with Mr. Graham but saying nothing, so alarmed were they over the new turn things had taken. The leader of the party said nothing for a few moments after the King had finished speaking the last time. He seemed convinced of the justice of the King's remarks, but still he had a mission to perform and he was expected to carry it out to the letter. Again stepping forward, he said:

"We do not come to fight the few of another sphere, who are now here but to fight those of this race who might come to help them. These people came in the dead of night to our land; we know not how they came or whence they came and how should we know but that they could call to their assistance thousands of others. It is this possibility that we have prepared ourselves for."

Onrai turned on the man almost savagely and said:

"Enough, now. I will listen to no more to-night. Begone, and find you quarters until morning, when I will meet you near here on the shore of the lake and hear these miserable complaints which you have to make. Discuss the matter well among yourselves to-night, but remember this, that I come to you to-morrow morning prepared to refute any statements which you may make against our guests. Your fears, whatever they are, are based on superstition and are simple. Now go and move away quietly, so as not to disturb the woman whom you come to war against."

The men remounted after this and rode away, but not far, for when the shores of the lake were reached they halted, and made preparations to spend the night. Even at the villa the low hum of their voices could be heard as they discussed the subject which had brought them here.

After their departure Mr. Bruce stepped up to Onrai, who was standing, lost in thought over the unexpected turn which events had taken, and said, "What is it, Onrai?"

"I cannot tell," said the King, "but the people seem to have taken a sudden fear of your party. Never before have I seen this quality in my people and it worries me, for now that it is aroused it is hard to tell where it will end."

"But why should this sudden dislike and fear of us have taken possession of them," asked Mr. Bruce. "Heretofore they have done all in their power to make our stay in their country pleasant. Something strange must have happened to make them change so suddenly."

“Have no fear, my friends,” said Onrai. “Whatever it is, I will learn tomorrow and then I will know how to meet their arguments. They will abide by my decision and will again extend to you their friendship.”

They were now called into the sick-room for Enola had again awakened. She was still raving about Gip, nothing else seeming to break through the dark pall which had fallen over her mind. Loudly she called “Gip, Gip, Gip,” half raising from her couch.

As if in answer to her call a noise is heard outside and through one of the open arches Gip pushes his great bandaged head. Enola seems to hear the sound and, turning, sees the mighty head and before they can restrain her, she springs forward and clasping the trunk in her arms cries, “My noble, true friend, Gip, you have saved me.”

CHAPTER XXII.

“THEY MUST DIE!”

Yes, Gip, the great, noble, loyal Gip, had saved Enola. When that great cry of hers had broken out, it had floated through the arches and out to the open stables where Gip had been placed. He had just been raised to his feet preparatory to having his wounds rebandaged, and as the agonized cry reached him, he raised his head and listened, and when the second cry came he pushed the attendants aside who tried to stop him and limping and almost falling he started for the open arches through which the sound came. Such loyalty, such love for a mistress had never before been displayed by the domestic animals of On and Onrai and the attendants looked with astonishment at Gip as he pushed his great head through the arch of Enola's apartment, and gave that peculiar cry.

Enola a moment before had seemed very close to death's door, her breath being scarcely perceptible and no movement of the body showing any signs of life. But she had awakened and in her delirium had called on that friend who had shared the danger with her and had suffered in trying to protect her. Her movement had been so quick when she had seen Gip, that those about her had not time to stop her before she had fallen on the floor clasping the great trunk of the animal. But it was well perhaps that they did not, for any hindrance or objection on their part in allowing her to go to that protector, the only one she had recognized, might have resulted seriously to her reason, that reason which was already darkened, but which now gave a glimpse of light.

All looked at her in astonishment as she caressed the elephant, throwing her arms about the great trunk, patting him and calling him by endearing names in the meantime. She now noticed the bandages about his head and said.

“Oh, my poor Gip, and you were wounded? Ah, yes, I remember now, that great, cruel log struck you,” and as she said this she almost fell backwards in her weakness, but Mr. Graham caught her and attempted to bear her to the couch, but she clutched Gip’s trunk and cried so pitifully not to be taken from him, that Mr. Bruce stepped forward and said:

“It will not hurt her and it may do her an inestimable amount of good. Listen, she already remembers a few of the instances of the storm and mad ride.”

“It was terrible, was it not, Gip?” Enola went on, “and you tried so hard to keep me from danger; but it blew so furiously and the air was so thick with stones and sand and sticks, and you were blinded, dear friend. But you are safe now, all but that poor head which the cruel log struck. But where are we now, Gip? The storm is over and we are together; but where?” and Enola looked about her with eyes which began to show some signs of returning reason.

“Ah, I see, they have found us and have taken us back to the Temple; and what are these?” and she looked at her bandaged hands and arms. “And my face, too! Oh, they hurt so,” and the poor girl seeming for the first time to realize her suffering, fell back on the floor.

“Come, Enola,” said Mr. Graham, “you are tired and weak, and must lie down. Gip shall stay near you,” he continued, as Enola again turned toward the elephant.

“Oh, uncle, I am so tired,” said Enola, as Mr. Graham laid her on the couch.

“Thank Heaven!” almost whispered Harry, “her reason is not destroyed.”

“No,” said Mr. Bruce, as he gave her a quieting powder, “Gip has indeed saved her life and her reason, too, for the sight of him has brought from out of the chaos the scenes of last night, and these have brought in their train other thoughts, until reason itself has been restored.”

This news was received with tears of joy. All fears were now allayed regarding Enola, but there were the greater ones awaiting them on the morrow. What was to be the result of the conference of the King with the people to-morrow? Onrai had assured them that it would be all right, that they would abide by his decision in the matter; but was there not a possibility of these people, who were experiencing for the first time the

fears which superstition brought out, being swayed by these rather than by the King? Such thoughts had occurred to Mr. Bruce, but he had said nothing of his fears to the others, not wishing to worry them unnecessarily. Indeed, the thought had come to Mr. Bruce to suggest their immediate departure from On, but Enola's condition forbade this, and again, they could not possibly reach the cave before morning, and if this intended escape was once discovered, they would be stopped and dealt with roughly to say the least.

The news of the coming conference had not been imparted to Mrs. Graham and Nellie and they, happy at Enola's assured recovery, were quietly dozing in their chairs, the events of the past twenty-four hours having tired them greatly. The watches were now set for the night and the men had retired with the exception of Onrai, who went into the garden and strolled up and down, his arms hanging listlessly by his side and his head bowed as if in deep thought. Was he, too, thinking of that coming conference and of the possibility of the men refusing to heed him, and following their own blind reasoning? Whatever his thoughts were he was completely wrapped up in them and hardly heeded the approaching morn. The eastern heavens grew lighter and lighter, but still Onrai paced the drive, his head bending low and his eyes cast on the ground. The whistle of a bird seemed to rouse him at last, and raising his head and noticing the rosy tints of morn lighting the east, he shook himself and said:

"The battle is fought and I now feel stronger; but it has been cruelly hard."

A song sung by a thousand male voices, now arose on the morning air, and Onrai, turning toward the lake, exclaimed:

"Oh, I had forgotten. I must meet the people this morning at the lake," and he started off in that direction.

Mr. Bruce came running from the villa, and hurrying up to the retreating figure of Onrai, said:

"Onrai, you are about to go to your people. They have a grievance with us. Is it not best that we also accompany you, and plead our own defense?"

"No," said Onrai, "I can better do this myself. I am dealing with a new phase in their character to-day, and I do not know just how I will handle them, but, at any rate, it is best that I should go alone."

“I would ask one favor of you before you leave,” said Mr. Bruce. “We came to your land uninvited, and it is not right that we should create any disturbance, or destroy the peace of mind which your people have always known. If they demand our departure, and you feel that their demand is just, and this decree is irrevocable, do not hesitate to tell us, and we will leave immediately, although it would grieve us greatly to be compelled to do so, just when we have fully experienced the full delights of your beautiful country, and tasted the pleasures of your hospitality. We cannot understand why they have learned to fear us, but we do not question their motive, in wishing us to leave, if this be so.”

“Fear not,” said Onrai, “Some question of difference has come up probably, which has led them to fear that if you should remain here long, established customs might be changed. By talking on this subject and expatiating on it, it has assumed great proportions, and has seemed of greater importance because of the mystery which surrounds you. They have never been able to understand how you came to our country. They found you on the side of the cliff one morning in the heart of our wild beast range; you had been there overnight, and had been unmolested by the ferocious beasts. This alone made them look on you with awe, and they have never forgotten it. As I have said, it is superstitious fear, which is now urging them on, and we will have to first destroy this.”

“I hope that you may be able to do this completely,” said Mr. Bruce, “for we wish to be friends with your people, and remain a long time with them.”

“I would have it so,” answered Onrai, as he turned and again started for the shore. “I can understand now, I think, why these people have turned on their guests. In some way they have learned of my love for Enola, and a fear has taken possession of them that I would give myself up to the fascinations of this fair woman. And they have attributed a supernatural power to her, for they could not believe that any other could make me so far forget my laws and people as to love; and I do not know just how I am going to deny their charges and still ask them to allow the strangers to remain with us. This they must do, however, for I would have them with us until they have fully learned our customs and ways. They will not fully know these until they have seen the ceremony of the Day of Resis. And, am I still weak? May be so; but I cannot now see Enola leave me. I will be strong, I will bury the love, which, if mentioned, will ruin my whole life and that life to come. But

I must see her; I must have her with me yet awhile. Ah, I am approaching the appointed place. Now for the struggle.”

The party had seen him coming and were now drawn up before a large rock, which was intended for a platform, from which Onrai was to speak; Onrai approached and took his stand on the rock; the men stood in a semicircle about him, their heads uncovered and as Onrai took his position on the rock they bent their bodies respectfully, and then stood waiting for him to speak.

“My people,” he commenced, “you came to me last night with a strange complaint. For a short time we have had in the Land of On a number of strange people, the first which has ever visited our world since we can remember. If at any previous time such visitors came to the Land of On, we know not, for the events of the past ages are not made known to us. But we are concerned only with these strangers from a distant planet. When we stop to consider, we cannot wonder that these enlightened people, of another world, seeing our world as we see theirs, should wish to visit it and learn, if here was a race of people like unto themselves. We cannot fully understand, perhaps, the curiosity which should prompt this desire, for we have been taught to be contented with the good land which God has given us and not to seek anything which we have not here given us. We have certain laws to follow, and these laws are life and death. But it is not so with the people who are now here as our guests; they have certain political and moral laws, as they call them, which they must adhere to, but they have no laws restricting their research into the unknown. They may invent new contrivances for making their labor easier, they may advance new theories on great subjects, even their religion, not being altogether as ours is, but a number of different beliefs, these beliefs being subdivided, each advancing different theories, which in the end are widely varying. And they are allowed to study the heavens and learn the different stars and to name them; and they learned that there was a world similar to theirs and they determined to visit it, and immediately devised new means to do so; and they came and found that another race was here, a race much like themselves in many respects but different in others, principally in physique; but they worshiped the same God, the great God, and this makes them brothers, and now you would destroy them, or send them back to that world from whence they came, even before they have fully learned the world or people which they traveled so far to find. You have an imaginary complaint

to make against them; it cannot be a genuine complaint for I have been with them almost constantly since they came to our land and I know that they are as pure in heart and deed as any among us. Accept your King's word for this, for he knows of what he speaks. I have done."

The party of men had stood perfectly still during this speech of the King, but it would be impossible to tell from their mobile features whether they were being convinced or not. They stood stolidly silent, not a muscle moving, leaning against their zebras. They made a grand sight, these thousand men in their beautiful tunics, holding their bright helmets. A body of men which would make the armies of the civilized world look like pigmies and which would make the eyes of a general open wide with admiration. But that stolidity; not one among them betrayed an emotion in the face. As Onrai finished they did not even change the position which they had held while he was speaking.

Onrai now stepped to one side of the rock and the leader, who had spoken the night before, came forward and mounting the rock, bowed to Onrai and then proceeded with his explanation.

"Oh, King, I was chosen by the people, who sent us here to make the charge against the strangers last night, but you ordered us away, and we have always learned to obey our King before all else, so we have waited until this morning. The decision reached by the people was caused by a report which was brought to the city by one, who has been a member of your expedition since you left the city and was for some time before attached to the woman Enola before she left the Temple. She was alarmed by certain things which transpired, and no longer being able to keep them to herself, rode to the city yesterday morning, arriving even before you did, oh, King. She tells of the King of On, being in the company of the woman Enola most of the time, and that certain expressions passed between the King and this woman, which could mean but one thing; the King had become infatuated with the woman. This news could hardly be credited and would not have been believed probably, if one of our men, who was also in the party, had not rushed madly into the city yesterday, giving out that the King was mad; that he had stood on the terrace of the villa, occupied by Onrai and his party on the night of the storm, and had heard the King accuse the woman Enola of having bewitched him; of her having known before the laws and customs of the people of On, even before she had come

here; but notwithstanding this she had thrown a spell over him, the King. The King told her that she had been balked in her machinations before it was forever too late, by the warning of God. This warning was the storm. The man had not stopped to listen longer; the storm causing him to seek shelter. The people had seen the King come to the city, where he should be in the time of great trouble, but that word had come from the woman Enola and he had forgotten his people and had rushed off quickly, even killing the zebra which he had ridden. This latter, we learned afterwards. The people love their King, oh, Onrai; they feel that he has not sinned but that he is in the meshes of one who would ruin him, and they have decided that the woman and her party should die, and we have come to fulfill this mission.” And the man, as if this declaration ended the matter, stepped down from the rock and commanded the men to don their helmets and again mount.

“Hold,” cried Onrai, “what would you do? Consider well the step which you would take. Have you forgotten that these people are our guests and as such demand our protection? The stories which you bring are true, but they are the results of my own blindness and are not due to any supernatural influence, which Enola has had over me. She is innocent and even now lies at the point of death, and, will you not at least wait and see if her injuries are fatal? Oh, heed your King and do not this thing which hurts him. Let them be escorted to the place where they were found, and let them from there return to their own world. Do not kill them,” and Onrai wrung his hands in despair.

The only answer the leader made him was, “We must save our King, for we love him and this is the only way,” and he ordered the men to march. Onrai jumped from the rock and ran like a deer ahead of the riders, and reaching the villa, met Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham and Harry on the terrace awaiting his return. The hurrying figure of Onrai coming toward them told them that something was wrong, and stepping up quickly toward him, Mr. Bruce asked, “What is it?”

“It is settled,” said Onrai; “they are coming to kill you; I tried to dissuade them, but it was useless. Rush to the rear and take zebras and make all possible speed to where you were found. I will try to keep them back for a while; it will mean my death, but that matters little.”

The three men turned white, but did not move.

“But what of Enola?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“She must be taken too,” said Onrai, “but it is too late.”

The riders had now reached the terrace and dismounting, a number of them stepped forward and laid hands on the strangers. Others prepared to enter the villa, for the women. Onrai stood with bowed head, overcome with emotion. This then was to be the miserable end of the expedition.

CHAPTER XXIII.

A MESSAGE FROM THE PRIEST.

The moment was a critical one and the three men realized it fully; what could they do? They were powerless against such a mob; their only hope seemed to lay in Onrai, but he had said that the men would no longer listen to him. Onrai stood with arms crossed and head bowed and it could be seen that he was fearfully agitated. But he made no move to stop the men, who were now entering the villa to take the women. But the thought of these men, laying their hands on Enola, on that poor bruised body, finally overcame Onrai, and rushing madly into the villa, he grabbed the two men who were about to enter the sick chamber and pushed them forcibly from the house.

“What would you do?” said he, beside himself with anguish. “Would you war against poor defenseless women, or worse, sick women? Men, have you forgotten your manhood; have you no longer any self-respect? Has your pride and honor all been killed by this horrible suspicion?”

The men stood quietly by as they had at the lake, listening, but not seeming to heed their King. Those who had laid hands on Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham and Harry still stood guarding them, waiting for those who had been sent for the women to come from the villa, when they would carry out the rest of the miserable programme.

“Why do you look at me in that strange way?” continued Onrai, “do you not know that it is the King who is talking to you, that it is he who implores you, that it is Onrai who commands you; have you forgotten that it is I, Onrai, whom you yourselves chose for King, and whom you have sworn to love and obey, that now entreats you? How are you keeping that oath? Oh, that I should ever be chosen ruler of such cowards.”

The men did not move, but when Onrai ceased speaking the leader walked up, and again bowing to the King, that King, whom he still respected, but did not obey, said:

“King, we know of the great goodness of your heart; we know that that great goodness of heart would still be influenced by the love; no, not love, but unholy infatuation, which this woman has thrown about you, and we know that because of this, you will forget yourself, your future, your people, the holy laws and all, and would plead for the lives of these people. We knew this and we hardened our hearts against such pleadings before we came to you. It was decided that we would not be influenced by these pleadings, for we knew that it would not be our King, our great, noble Onrai, who would ask pardon for these people, but the evil one, which the woman Enola had possessed him with. We believe this with all our hearts and consequently we cannot listen to you. We are chosen by all the citizens of On to carry out this mission and we must do it or go back to our people traitors.”

“Traitors, traitors, did you say? The word is well-chosen, but one which heretofore has never been used in the Land of On. Traitors to those who sent you! Would you then rather be traitors to the King than to the people? Which is the greater sin, if you would call obedience to your King a sin, which is the greater sin to be traitor to the people or to the King, which you have sworn to love, cherish and obey? Come, man, can you answer?”

“Quickly,” said the leader, “for as I have said, it is not now the King which commands us, but that evil one within. If it were the King, he would say, ‘Take these people who have made your King sin; take these people who have called the great God’s vengeance down on us, because we harbored them; take them and show them no mercy, for they stole upon us like thieves in the night; and when we clothed and fed them, when we made them honored guests, giving them every comfort and luxury which the Land of On knows, even taking them into the most sacred sanctuary, making them special guests of the King, thinking that he alone was fitted to entertain them, when we did all this for them, they repaid us by making our King sin, and bringing God’s wrath upon us. Take these and kill them, for they have betrayed our confidence.’ This is what the true, noble King, the great Onrai would say to his people if it were he talking to us. Oh King, we pity you, for we do believe that even now you suffer, when you see the

people, whom you have learned to love through their machinations, going to their death. But the people have settled the matter, having first given it just consideration and they know that it is best that the cause of your sin and the land's suffering should be put out of the way, for if they remain, even if you no longer fell under their spell, the land or people would no longer be safe. We know that you are suffering for these strangers; these traitors are making you suffer, because they would have you intercede for them, but when the spell is broken, when you are no longer in the power of this subtle Circe, you will thank your people for thus delivering you."

"I look at you now and wonder if this be the happy, care and superstition-free people, whom I have known for so long and I am almost persuaded to believe that you are not; that I have been transported in some unknown way in my sleeping to another world, where the people have never known what happiness, contentment and lack of all superstition is; where the people are governed by the most imaginative fantasies of the brain; where common sense and reason play no part in their decisions or judgment. No, you are not the strong, mighty people that I once knew, and yet you are the same. I know you all, every face is familiar to me, but that is all. The solid mind has wandered, leaving in its place nothing, or worse than nothing—superstition. That you believe in your own ignorance that you are now right and that you are following the dictates of sensible minds can easily be seen and your decision is as much as could be expected from such miserable beings, as would be swayed by superstition. Oh, where are the noble minds which once dominated over those bodies? Have they gone beyond recall? Have they been so outraged by these miserable superstitions that they have gone forever? Will not sense, and reason and justice break the flimsy wall of these superstitions and place the right mind again in possession? Oh, men of little brain, why will you insult me by still calling me King?" And as Onrai finished he turned his back on them as if their presence was hateful to him; as if their stolid gaze would contaminate him.

The leader stepped forward again and motioned the men back. Mr. Graham and his companions watched these proceedings with renewed hope, but Onrai did not even turn to see what they were doing. His strong nature and nobleness of mind would no longer allow of his suing for mercy, even for the sick girl, whose life meant so much to him.

He had first plead; then he called on them as men; then he had commanded them as King, and all had been useless; they had still stared at him with that set look which would indicate that their decision was so irrevocable that nothing, not even positive proof of this decision being wrong, would make them change it. Then he had used contempt, he had belittled their manhood, their intellect, and unwittingly he had made an impression; an impression surely, but whether a good or bad one could not yet be said, for the men had taken a position at the edge of the park and were now in conference.

Mr. Bruce had slipped into the sick chamber and had looked at Enola. She was now resting quietly; her breathing being regular, her temperature being almost normal. Mrs. Graham and Nellie were sitting near her, and the women attendants were gathered in a group in one end of the apartment, conversing in low whispers.

“Mr. Bruce,” asked Nellie, “what is that great body of men doing outside; are they here to congratulate the King and his party upon their escape from the storm?”

“Exactly,” said Mr. Bruce, and he tried to smile. “They came as a delegation from the people of the city to express their heartfelt thankfulness for our escape; and also sympathy for Enola’s suffering.”

“But they were here last night,” said Nellie, “and still remain. I cannot see why they should do so.”

“They are waiting for further news of Enola’s condition, and when this is learned they will depart for the upper part of the country, where they are bound to repair the devastations of the storm;” answered Mr. Bruce; but as he spoke, Mrs. Graham had walked to the curtained arch and parting the hangings, said:

“See, Mr. Bruce, they are returning; their movements are very strange; can anything be wrong?”

“Nothing, I assure you, Mrs. Graham,” said Mr. Bruce, “I will see what it is,” and saying this he again went on to the terrace.

The leader was just pulling up his zebra, and raising his voice, said:

“Oh King, we cannot heed your command or words. Our duty is plain and we must do it. Men do your duty.” Again the men placed their hands on the shoulders of the three men and two again entered the villa for the

women. Onrai stood motionless as if turned to stone. The men came from the house, one leading Mrs. Graham and Nellie, and the other with the still sleeping figure of Enola in his arms.

A zebra's gallop was heard on the hard pavement of the avenue. Whoever it was, was keeping up a most fearful pace, for the sound of falling hoofs came and quick. The men turned to see who this rapid rider could be and just then Sedai hove in sight, his zebra fairly flying over the ground. He turned into the park and the body of men parted to allow his panting zebra to pass between them.

“Hold!” he cried. “A message from the high priest!”

CHAPTER XXIV.

THE CRISIS PASSED.

The noise of the zebra galloping madly over the avenue, had so surprised the men that for the moment all else had been forgotten, and those holding the strangers had let go their hold, and stood with necks craned to catch the first glimpse of the mad rider. Mrs. Graham and Nelly had stood where their guard had stopped when the first sound of the zebra's hoofs had reached them. They had been so surprised by the entrance of the men into the sick chamber, and by their command to follow them, that they could not at first realize what the men meant. But when one of them attempted to raise Enola from the couch, Mrs. Graham rushed forward, and would have tried to stop him, but for the retaining hand of the other man.

"What does this mean?" indignantly asked Mrs. Graham.

But the man did not understand English, and simply stared at Mrs. Graham.

But now that Enola had been secured, Mrs. Graham and Nellie were made to understand that they were to go with the man. They then began to realize that something was wrong, and that this was being done with the knowledge of those outside. They walked to the terrace, and when they saw the men holding their male companions also, they knew that they were being made captives for some reason or other. They turned pale, and thoughts of dungeon cells and murder came into their minds, which were probably not far from the truth, if they but knew it. But the men stopped as Sedai rode furiously up, flourishing a piece of parchment in his hand. Onrai stepped forward hurriedly, and taking the parchment into his hand, read the hieroglyphics inscribed on it. His face at first wore a puzzled look, then became brighter, and finally broke into a smile, as he handed the parchment to the leader, saying:

“There, man, read that to your followers. It is from the high priest, one whose authority you cannot question. Read also how fickle are the people whom you represent, for they now order you to return without fulfilling your mission,” and saying this, he walked over to where the man stood who was holding Enola, and taking her in his arms, carried her into the apartment, and laying her on the couch, kissed the fair cheek, saying:

“Mine, all mine, and they were trying to take you from me. Oh, God, I thank thee.”

Outside the leader had taken the parchment, and, first reading it to himself, turned to the men who were watching him closely and expectantly, and said:

“This message, as you have heard the King say, is from the high priest, and it relieves us from the painful duty of disobeying our King’s orders, listen:

“I, the high priest of On, who has access to the most sacred laws, have, knowing that a matter of great moment depended on the proper reading of these laws, perused them carefully, studying each character as it is written, and have made this discovery: in those laws which govern the King and his conduct, I find the law which says he shall not marry; this has always been read that the King shall not marry. But it does not end here. In believing that our race is the only one on earth, and that we could never be visited by other people, we have read but the first part of this law which says, the King shall not love or marry. But the whole reading of the law is this: ‘The King shall not take unto himself a wife chosen from among his own people.’ The great law-giver of our land undoubtedly foresaw that at some future day, people of another race would visit us, and although he has virtually given no consent to the King’s marrying one of his people, he has, by writing the law in this way, namely: ‘The King shall not marry one of his own people,’ made it possible for him to marry one of his own race, if he so chooses, providing, of course, if such a woman comes to the land of On. Therefore I, the high priest of the Land of On, do hereby declare that Onrai, the King of On, has full and proper rights to marry the woman, Enola, who is of another race, and that the men who have been sent to kill the strangers, because of Onrai loving one of their women, are on an unlawful mission, and must be recalled.’”

As the man finished his reading, he turned to face those whom he and his men had been sent to take and kill, and said:

“I came to you with orders from the people to make you prisoners, and to take you to a certain place and kill you. We had learned to respect you, and it was hard for us to believe that you were guilty of that of which you were accused. But all signs seemed to be against you, and we were compelled at last to believe that you were guilty. But we have just learned from the words of the high priest, that the King’s love was sinless, and if there be no sin in his loving, Enola must be sinless. If we have shaken your confidence in us, we know not how to regain it. All we can do is to assure you that if we have doubted you and have proven ourselves traitors to the confidence you have placed in us, we will now strive all the harder to make your stay among us a happy sojourn. We crave you to pardon us, and believe it was the respect to our laws, as we knew them, which made us act as we did.”

The man waited for a moment after he had finished speaking, as if expecting a reply from one of the strangers, but none of them understood the language well enough to make themselves understood as they would wish. Onrai came forward, however, after telling him that they wished him to express to his people that they freely forgave their mistaken understanding of their mission to their country, and further intention of killing them. Onrai turned and interpreted this to the men, who then mounted their zebras and departed.

The party again entered the sick chamber and looked at Enola. She had awakened from the stupor or sleep into which she had fallen after taking the powder, and as they entered she was looking wistfully at the great open arch, which had framed the bandaged head of Gip the night before. She looked up as the party came in and tried to smile, but the effort was lost, the bandages covering her face so completely, that they hid all expression.

“Was I so badly wounded then?” she asked, as she half raised her head and looked at them.

“Yes, dear,” said Mrs. Graham, who had hardly yet got over the scare which the recent event had given her. “But you are going to get well now and we will be so happy.”

“Yes, Enola,” said Onrai, as he stepped up and took the poor bruised hand, “happiness has been unknown to us since you were wounded, but we

know now that you will get well, and our happiness has returned,” and he raised her hand to his lips.

CHAPTER XXV.

“HE WILL MARRY YOU.”

One week had now passed and Enola had almost entirely recovered. Her fever had lasted only a day or two and with Mr. Bruce's prescriptions and treatment, and Mrs. Graham's and Nellie's gentle care she mended rapidly. Her wounds, too, had healed so quickly, the bandages had been discontinued and altogether Enola was nearly in as good a condition as before her fateful ride.

“Why, Enola,” said Mr. Graham, “you look as bright and happy as ever, this beautiful morning, and I prescribe a good long walk for you in the garden.”

“And I feel quite as well as usual, Uncle,” answered Enola. “My arms and limbs are a little stiff yet, but outside of that I am all right and will gladly accept your invitation. Ah, the morning is beautiful, glorious,” she continued, as they stepped to the terrace. “Uncle, have you noticed that the sun seems to be brighter, the air purer, that all verdure is greener, that the waters of the lake and river bluer, that the birds' notes clearer and their plumage gayer, that all nature seems brighter and happier here than in the civilized world?”

“Ah, that is quite a speech, Enola,” answered Mr. Graham, smiling; “but seriously, I have noticed all this many times, and I have long ago ceased wondering at the happiness and contentment of the people, for they could hardly be aught else with such environments.”

“Yes, they are truly a happy lot,” said Enola, “yet how human. For centuries, more than likely, their ancestors had never known such words as fear and superstition and they themselves could hardly have defined the meaning of these words, yet one little word set them wondering and just a

word more and a little act on the part of their King made them slaves to superstitious fears.”

“Yes, that is so,” said Mr. Graham, “I am very much afraid we are all alike after all.”

“No, not all alike,” said Enola, “for we, with our advanced notions on such matters could never believe as did these people for a short time.”

“May be not,” said Mr. Graham, “but we must take into consideration that these people have always been led to believe that they were the only people on earth, and have never been told of other people on other planets, so our advent among them was a great surprise in the first place and they looked on us with awe, mingled with fear; and Onrai’s strange actions and the storm simply ‘capped the climax.’”

“We had rather a narrow escape, don’t you think?” asked Enola.

“Yes,” answered Mr. Graham, “too narrow for comfort; but I think we stand on a better footing with these people since, and that for this reason the occurrence should be looked upon as being a decidedly lucky one for us.”

“That is very true,” said Enola, “but look, Gip has seen us and is coming to meet us.”

Across the lawn strode the great monstrous beast, his limp nearly gone, but his head still bandaged. This great elephant stood fully twenty feet high and as he stalked under the trees his back touched the lower boughs. He had been given the freedom of the garden from the first night of his removal from the scene of the accident to the villa, and he had taken up his position beneath the arch which opened into Enola’s apartment, and here he had remained, only going to his stall for a few moments’ rest; he knowing that if he lay down beneath the window, he could not again rise. Such love for a mistress had never been displayed before, according to Onrai, and his people could not understand it; but it was clear enough to them that the elephant was attached to Enola, and this was quite enough to let him have his own way.

Quickly he passed over the smooth lawn until he had reached them, when he affectionately stuck his great trunk into Enola’s face. Perhaps this was not a very pleasant way of having him show his love, but it was the only way he knew of, and Enola seemed to enjoy it.

“Good Gip,” she said, “and could you not see me in my room? I saw you poke your big head in the arch and pull it out again and look about. You are a dear, good fellow, Gip, and you can come right along and walk with us.”

And he did. Back and forth on the lawn the three walked, the great elephant keeping close to Enola’s side, occasionally thrusting his trunk over her shoulder, giving out that little squeak, as if to let her know that he was still with her. And his great moving hulk shook the ground at every step, making Mr. Graham look around now and then with apprehension. But Gip paid no attention to him, simply looking at Enola and trying to make her look at him.

The day before Onrai had gone to the city to attend to any matters which might need his attention. He was to return to-day, and on the morrow they were again going to take up the journey to the field of diamonds, which had been so unexpectedly interrupted by the storm. Mr. Graham and Enola had now walked to the edge of the garden, and were standing looking down the beautiful roadway, when far away, where the perspective came to a point, could be seen a small black spot. At first it looked like a pedestrian, then like a zebra, and finally the form of zebra and rider were made out. It was Onrai returning, and as impatient as on the night when the message had reached him of Enola’s serious illness. Gip pricked up his ears, and looking down the road, saw the rider approaching; then kneeling, he placed his trunk for Enola to step on, as of old. She divined his intention and placing her foot on his trunk, he raised her to his back and started off down the avenue, she sitting Turkish fashion on the silk covering which was always worn by the white elephant.

Onrai was now near enough to distinguish her form, and seeing her approach he urged his zebra into a still faster gallop and in a moment he and Enola had met, and Gip, turning, strode along beside the zebra. Far above Onrai Enola sat, her face almost hidden by the huge figure of the elephant, but Onrai was happy in the thought that he was near her. That was enough for him at least.

“You came to meet me, then?” asked he.

“No, I think it was Gip, who came to meet you,” answered Enola, smiling, “I simply accompanied him.”

Onrai laughed as he said, “Well, you are here and that is enough. You are looking entirely well this morning; are you feeling so?”

“Perfectly so,” answered Enola, “and ready and waiting to again take up the journey.”

“We will start to-morrow, at break of day,” said Onrai, “and let us hope that our journey will not again be broken by such an event as the storm.”

“Yes, it was fearful,” answered Enola, “but let us not talk of gloomy things on this beautiful morning. The miserable past is gone and let us forget it. I hope your people will not again mistrust us, for this hope only will again insure us comfort and happiness.”

They had now reached the villa and Gip, placing his trunk for Enola to step on and kneeling for her, she was soon standing beside the King.

“I thank you for having met me,” he said.

“Don’t thank me,” said Enola. “Thank Gip.” Then she tripped lightly up the terrace stairs.

“She seems to have lost all seriousness since her recovery,” said Onrai to himself, as he followed Enola into the villa, “but this may be joyousness over that recovery. But she will have to be serious when the time comes, for my people will demand it.”

Enola had gone into her own apartment, where she found Nellie awaiting her.

“Has Onrai said anything to you yet?” asked Nellie.

“About what?” asked Enola.

“About his intended marriage,” said Nellie, and she tried to smile, but could not, the whole matter seemed such a farce.

“About his marriage? why he has not mentioned it to me,” said Enola.

“It is strange he should not have spoken to you about it,” said Nellie, “for it concerns you quite as much as himself.”

“In what way?” asked Enola. “I cannot possibly see how I am concerned in his marriage.” But as she spoke she remembered the conversation of the night of the storm and of his accusation. For he had told her then that a King was not allowed to marry, how was this then, that he was going to break the law.

“Tell me, Nellie,” said she.

“I can hardly bring myself to do so,” said Nellie. “We told you that we had trouble with the people when you were sick, which nearly ended in our

massacre, but we did not tell you all concerning that trouble. You are strong enough now and can hear it. They accused you of bewitching the King, when you knew he was forbidden by the laws to either love or marry. They said that the storm had come to them as a warning, and was God's wrath on them for harboring us, and they were going to kill us. But the high priest learned that the King could marry you if he so desired, and so we were pardoned, and now it is the King's intention and the people's desire that you should marry him. But I cannot understand why he has not spoken to you about it. Oh, Enola, can you marry this barbarous king?"

"Don't ask me, now, Nellie, I cannot answer—I cannot understand." And Enola drew her hand across her eyes as if to break the spell.

CHAPTER XXVI.

A STRANGE DISCOVERY.

The following morning opened bright and beautiful; all rose early, and after a light breakfast again took up the journey. Gip had sufficiently recovered to be allowed to go, and as it was intended that for the first few days' the marches were to be short in order not to fatigue Enola, it was thought best for her to ride in the large howdah on Gip's back, for the motion would be less and the position more comfortable than it would be on the back of a zebra. So Gip was happy in carrying the precious burden, and strode out at the head of the large cavalcade as proud as any of them, with scarcely any sign of lameness left. Onrai had also mounted an elephant so as to be on a level with Enola, for the idea of trying to keep up a conversation when he was riding some feet below her, was entirely out of the question.

Harry preferred his zebra, notwithstanding this left the field entirely open to Onrai. Still, he thought it might as well be thus, for Enola might look on his riding near her as an intrusion, and this would hurt his cause far more than it would help it.

Mrs. Graham and Nellie were both on elephants this morning, Mrs. Graham being stretched out in a half reclining position, enjoying to the fullest the comforts of the huge howdah and easy motion of the elephant. Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham and Harry rode well on ahead of the rest of the party, and Sedai was directly in their rear. The story of his hard ride from the city, when bringing the message from the high priest, he had kept silent on for a long time, but Mr. Bruce finally prevailed upon him to tell how he had been chosen as a courier. His story was substantially this:

"I was standing just before the terrace when I saw the body of men come up. I heard them make the demand and knew that they would make trouble.

I heard one of the number say that it was because of Enola having made the King sin by wishing to marry her, she knowing that the King could not marry. I then remembered having heard one of the men, whom I had talked with in the city, say that the law did not forbid the King marrying a woman of another country. I heard Onrai tell them to wait until morning. I then determined to ride to the city and look up the man who had made this remark. After the men had withdrawn, I stole to the stable, and jumping on my zebra started for the city. I rode hard and it was still night when I reached there. I found the man after considerable trouble and he told me that that was his opinion only, but that the people had decided that the King could not marry, and he must believe this as did they. He told me to go to the high priest. While on my way to the Temple some of the populace saw me, and fearing that I had broken away from those who had been sent to kill our party, they pursued and overtook me at the base of the terrace steps which led to the Temple. I fought hard but they overpowered me and bore me into the Temple. The high priest came forward and asked me how it was that I was not with my friends. I told him as well as I could, for I knew little of the language, that there was a doubt regarding the law governing the King's marriage; that I had been sent to him with the request that he examine carefully this law and give me his decision and let me bear it to the King. The high priest left us for a few moments and then came back and handing me a piece of parchment, commanded the people to leave me go, and bade me ride with all speed to the King and my friends.

"The priest was very much agitated as he said this to me, and kept urging me to use all speed. I rushed down the steps and jumped on one of the zebras of the natives, mine being winded, and never stopped until I had reached the villa."

This was the story Sedai told in his quiet and unassuming way and he never seemed to realize that he had, by his quick forethought, put into immediate action, saved the lives of his friends. And Sedai had ever since this held a new place in the hearts of the party and Onrai himself seemed to look on the Abyssinian as one who had done him a personal act of kindness which could never be repaid. He was a hero, was Sedai, and it was decided by the party that although he might never again have an opportunity to help them in a like way, still it was good always to have him with them, and upon their telling him this he said that he would never again leave them; not

even for a day. And so he was one of the party to-day, his sturdy figure riding the zebra like a native.

The journey would occupy some ten days yet and it was decided to travel early in the morning and in the cool of the evening; spending the warm part of the day in one of the villas en route, as they had on previous marches. The storm's track could be seen very plainly from the avenue and a large body of men were still employed cleaning away the debris. A remarkable thing about the terrible storm was that it had not killed a single human being. Some had been very badly injured, but these had all recovered or were recovering, so that not one death could be laid to the storm; many animals had been killed and it was expected that many of the wild animals in the hunting reservation had also been killed, but this had not yet been ascertained, as none had gotten as far as the northwestern part of the country, where the storm was supposed to have started.

It would remain with Onrai and his party to ascertain this.

All was life and happiness this beautiful morning and all thoughts of the storm had been relegated to the past. On their right stretched the lake, its clear waters stretching far to the north; on the left were the farms and pastures, through which the storm had ploughed its way; on ahead of them, as far as the eye could reach, stretched out the shaded avenue; way off to the northwest could just be seen in the blue distance, hardly perceptible, the faces of the cliffs, and at the base of these cliffs was their destination, and there too were the points of interest, which the party were to see before their return.

"The journey for the next few days will be uneventful enough, will it not?" said Mr. Graham, as he pulled up for a moment alongside of Onrai's elephant.

"Yes, we will have little to break the monotony between here and the field of brilliants, but the country is beautiful and I think you will find it all interesting," said Onrai.

"It is all interesting to me," said Mr. Graham, "but I wished to know if there was anything of special interest, such as mines and quarries."

"No, nothing of that kind," said Onrai, "but wait a minute; there is a deserted mine or something, which has never been explored by any of my people, since I can remember, and I cannot tell whether it be a mine or well or natural hole in the ground. It is about the width of the avenue and goes

down, down, down, far below where the eyes can reach. I have only looked down this dark hole when I have been passing and know positively nothing about it, but if you would like to do so, we will halt there to-morrow and go down with ropes and explore it as far as we can. A villa stands near in which the ladies can wait for us.”

“I should like to see what this curious place is,” said Mr. Graham.

“Well, then, it is settled, we will explore it to-morrow,” said Onrai.

Mr. Graham again rode up alongside of Mr. Bruce, and telling him of the hole in the ground, had his interest aroused at once. All along the track of the storm many men were at work, but for some time past none had been seen.

“It is strange, is it not?” asked Harry of Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, decidedly so,” said Mr. Bruce.

“But, look, what is that in the distance?”

“It looks like a body of men,” answered Harry.

“Perhaps they have congregated there for some special work.”

No further comment was made about these men. They could now be plainly seen standing in a circle. They were not working as far as could be seen, but were standing with heads bowed as if contemplating something on the ground before them. They now saw the King and his party approaching, and one of their party hurried to the avenue and came towards the travelers.

“He seems to be excited over something,” said Mr. Graham.

“Yes, he acts differently than most other men I have seen in this country,” said Mr. Bruce.

“May be they have made a discovery.”

“Something agitates him,” said Harry, “that is sure.”

The man now came near, and seeing that it was the King and his party he stopped, and making a respectful bow, said:

“I have come, oh, King, not knowing that you was of the party, to call attention to a strange being which we have found in the field. We know not whether it be human or not, and we would ask you to look at it and tell us how to act with it.”

“Go, we will follow,” said the King, and the party followed the man from the avenue into the field to the left.

The body of natives moved, upon seeing the King and party approaching, to one side, disclosing the object which had so interested them. The party looked and saw the body of an African negress with a child strapped to her back.

But how had it gotten here?

CHAPTER XXVII.

IN THE HOLE.

Yes, it was a negro mother and her babe. The body was that of a slight woman, weighing not more than one hundred pounds, and perfectly black. The babe was probably three months old, and was strapped to the back of her mother. The features of the mother were flat and broad, and showed but little intelligence. Both bodies were considerably mutilated; this being caused, very likely, by the storm; not a rag of clothing covered the bodies. Silently the native men and women stood gazing on the strange figures; they could offer no explanation on this as to how these bodies had come here or from whence they had come; they looked at the bodies and then at the white strangers as if to trace some likeness, but there was none, and this puzzled them all the more. Involuntarily they glanced into the heavens, as if expecting to see a new planet looming up in the midday sun from which these black bodies had fallen. That they had come from the same world which they themselves inhabited—that world which was theirs alone, they could not believe, of course.

Onrai looked at one of the guests and then at another, as if expecting some explanation from them, but they offered none; they being nearly as much in the dark as was he. But finally Onrai, stepping up to Mr. Bruce, said:

“You know so much of the heavens and of the stars, can you not tell me whence came this woman!”

“I can only offer one explanation,” answered Mr. Bruce, “and that is that the woman and child were caught up by the great storm and blown from their own country into this.”

“Ah,” said Onrai, “that explanation maybe truthful, and looking over his people he called them all closely about him and told them what Mr. Bruce had said. It seemed to satisfy them, but it raised their curiosity to a greater extent, and they crowded more closely about the bodies. The hot sun had poured down on these bodies until they were in a bad state of decomposition and our friends soon moved away, leaving the find wholly in possession of the natives.

“What shall we do with these bodies?” asked Onrai of Mr. Graham.

“I would order them burned,” said Mr. Graham.

So Onrai told some of the men to throw together a pile of wood and lay the bodies on it; this was soon done and the torch was then applied. As the flames shot into the air, licking the reeking flesh off the bodies, our friends again mounted and moved on.

“What do you think of this, Mr. Bruce?” asked Mr. Graham.

“I can only say what I have already said to Onrai,” answered Mr. Bruce. “The force of the storm must have blown this woman and her child over the cliff and thus far into the heart of the land.”

“Do you not think that another explanation might be made of their appearance?” asked Mr. Graham.

“There may be many explanations made,” answered Mr. Bruce, “but if this country is impregnable, how else could this woman and her child reach here?”

“I think myself that the storm has played a great part in this woman’s appearance in this part of the country, but I cannot help but think that she was this side of the cliffs before the storm,” answered Mr. Graham.

“If that be so, then these people have lived in ignorance of this tribe’s having taken up a residence in this country,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes,” said Mr. Graham, “but these Onians very seldom visit the northwestern part of this country, as Onrai has said, and this tribe might have found an entrance and settled in a fertile part near the cliffs, and may now be living there in total ignorance of their having entered a country which has for ages been shut in from the rest of the world?”

“This may all be so,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I would rather cling to my theory.”

“I would gladly accept your explanation,” said Mr. Graham, “if it were not for that part of it, which says that the woman was blown over the cliffs. Now, if this storm had started on the western side of these cliffs, the cliffs themselves would have broken the force, or destroyed it entirely before it reached this side. Therefore, I claim that the storm must have started from this side of the cliff.”

“When put in that way,” said Mr. Bruce, “you almost convince me that I have made a mistake. But whatever the way in which this woman reached this country, I believe that we will hear more of it. It would be strange indeed if we should find a race of negroes quietly villaged in this country.”

“Well, there is a possibility that we may,” said Mr. Graham.

Off to the right, in a clump of trees, is now seen a villa and the party made for it, it now being nearly midday. Once in the cool villa, and all thought of the morning adventure was forgotten. Lunch was served and then came the afternoon siesta.

Late in the afternoon they again started, intending to ride until late in the evening. The journeys in the cool of the evening were delightful. There was always a breeze coming off the lake at this time and it was very refreshing after the close, warm air of the day. Along toward evening the villa, which they had occupied on the evening of the storm, was passed. The storm had made great ravages here, tearing up immense trees by the roots and piling them one above the other. The earth was gouged out in places to a depth of twenty feet, and all along the track of the storm were immense piles of debris.

Thoughts of the storm had long since passed from the minds of our friends; they were interested only in the far northwest toward which they were headed, and which promised them so many surprises and adventures. This northwest was almost unknown even to the natives; they knew certain parts of it very well, such as the field of diamonds and one or two other points, which had come under their notice for some special reason. But taken as a whole very little was known of the country, and for this reason Mr. Bruce and the others expected to make some very interesting discoveries. The country had wonderful resources; every known part of it producing certain products, which made it a veritable Eldorado, and it might be expected that the northwest held resources which would astonish all, even Onrai and his people. The field of diamonds alone was enough to

make this part of the country interesting to the strangers, and for this alone they had started on this journey.

The following morning the party was up and off exceptionally early, long before the sun had risen. They were only to make half a march that day, for the shaft, which Onrai had spoken of on the previous day, was to be explored. That is, men were to be lowered into it and if the bottom could be reached and openings found leading from it, then all of the men of the party were to go down and explore these. Such was the programme laid out for the day and with this prospect of new diversions the men started off with happy hearts.

Each day now was bringing them nearer to the great northwest and the cliffs were growing plainer as they advanced. The country began to assume a wilder appearance; still there were well-kept fields and numerous farm villas and many men at work in the fields. At another point to-day they had passed a great herd of elephants, which had been brought from the city to recuperate, the former hospital having been almost entirely destroyed by the storm. These elephants, like many others which they had passed, had followed them until driven back by the attendant.

The morning was getting pretty well-advanced and the hopes of reaching the shaft shortly were making the men keep up a constant watch on both sides of them for fear of passing it. It was partially hid in a piece of woods which bordered the lake at this point for some distance. None of the party knew the exact locality of the opening and so care had to be taken in order not to pass it.

“What do you think of this hole in the ground?” asked Mr. Graham of Mr. Bruce.

“I do not know what to think of it,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I do know that it is a very strange thing that these people should be in ignorance of its origin. It seems to me that such things would start the curiosity in these people, but I have seen very little of this article in their make-up. They did look a little bewildered yesterday when they saw the negress and child, but I will wager you a shilling they have forgotten all about it by this time. This very lack of curiosity in these people almost puts me out of patience with them.”

“It may be, though,” said Mr. Graham, smiling at Mr. Bruce’s impatience, “that it is better that they have left to us the exploring of this extinct mine or well, or whatever it is; anyway I would feel better satisfied finding

something, which is not already known by this people. There goes one of the attendants now towards the trees; perhaps we have reached the hole.”

And they had, for the fellow, pulling aside some underbrush, disclosed a large, dark opening running straight into the ground. The wind seemed to be rushing into this hole with great force. He turned and motioned to the party and they rode toward them. All dismounting, ropes were procured and tied to the trunks of the trees, surrounding the hole. A glance down the dark aperture would have been enough for most men, but for those here assembled, the blackness but whetted their curiosity and desire to investigate. A lighted torch was thrown down, but the fearful wind which rushed down the hole extinguished this before it had fallen far.

“Let us all go down in a bunch and with our combined efforts we may be able to keep our feet,” Harry said.

And so it was decided; Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham and Harry and Onrai were to go down, well tied together, only allowing enough freedom for the limbs to move easily. A small supply of food and a few skins of water were put up and strapped to the back of each and several torches were also taken. It was strange, but Onrai seemed to take quite as much interest in the contemplated subterranean journey as did the other members of the expedition, and he showed more enthusiasm than he had at any time since the arrival of the strangers. This was the first opportunity though that he had had to display any enthusiasm, for everything in this country had been familiar to him since childhood and he could hardly be expected to show any great interest in things. But now, though by the eagerness displayed by his guests, he had also had his curiosity aroused and he was really impatient to get started.

“Are you ready, Onrai?” asked Harry.

“I am,” answered Onrai, “and eager to start. If there is anything new in my country, I want to know it.”

“Well, I think you will be surprised by the things that you will see and learn to-day,” said Mr. Bruce. “That is, if the passage-way and its gale of wind are any criterion.”

“’Tis well, let us start,” Onrai answered.

All bade the ladies good-bye, Enola almost crying because Mr. Bruce forbade her accompanying them. Sedai was left to look out for the interest of the women folks.

The four men were now tied together, and many sturdy hands grabbing the strong rope, they were lowered over the side of the hole. Slowly they descended, each moment nearing the passage. Suddenly, without any warning, they were swung in, and the line giving way, they landed on the floor of the cavern. They scrambled to their feet in the dark, for they had not lit the torches in descending, and by keeping breast to back and throwing themselves well against the wind by leaning as far back as possible, they were enabled to keep their feet and advance. The angle was reached and they turned; now the wind caught them full force again, and it was hard to keep an upright position. They were in hopes of reaching another passage though, through which the wind did not rush with such force, and where they could keep their torches lit. If they could not find such a one, they might as well return, for they could explore or learn nothing in this Egyptian darkness.



“Grinning at them with open mouths and sightless eyes.”—Page [209](#).

Slowly they proceeded, feeling their way every step, and keeping tight against the right wall. Mr. Bruce, who was in the lead, suddenly felt an

opening on the right, and telling his companions to follow him, turned into this new avenue. They were now comparatively out of the wind and, stopping, they lit a torch. Looking about them they saw, grinning at them with open mouths and sightless eyes, thousands of human faces.

CHAPTER XXVIII.

PRISONERS IN THE CAVERN OF THE DEAD.

Mr. Bruce, who held the torch, dropped it to the floor at the ghastly sight which met his gaze. From all sides these horrible visages were looking at them. There seemed to be thousands of them; in fact, the number seemed unlimited and as the torch flickered away on the floor, casting long shadows over these sombre surroundings, the scene was enough to curdle the blood of the strongest. Mr. Bruce stooped and picked up the torch again, he having recovered from the shock which the scene first gave him.

The hall was about fifty feet wide and ten feet high; the depth could not be ascertained because it went beyond the vision. They had entered the hall by a door about seven feet high from the corridor of winds. This hall or chamber was like the corridor hewn out of the solid rock, the ceiling, sides and floor being perfectly smooth. The party now began to examine the bodies which were arranged in groups about the walls and piled in heaps all over the chamber. These figures were small, being on an average about five feet in length; but the bodies had been well-proportioned in life more than likely, but now the skin was drawn tightly over the bones; the lips having dried and drawn away from the teeth, leaving the grinning, ghastly expression, which first struck such horror to the hearts of the explorers. The bodies were nude, having no covering whatever, but around each, just below the arms, was a band of copper. There were no signs of embalming cloths at all about the chamber and their bodies had seemingly been preserved by a process of injection of some powerful fluid, whilst there was a natural means of some kind in these underground passages which preserved them. The skin was almost black and rather thin, having that dull color which death or age gives to the skin; it shone like ebony.

Mr. Bruce took hold of several of the bodies and removing them, found their limbs and arms as pliable as in life. This, too, was against all natural and scientific principles and could not be explained.

“What do you think of all this?” asked Mr. Bruce of Mr. Graham.

“I should say that these bodies had been here for some time, but how long it would be impossible to say,” answered Mr. Graham.

“Onrai,” said Mr. Bruce, “have you ever seen any such people in your country?”

“Never,” answered Onrai, and his face looked puzzled. “I cannot understand this at all. Can it be that these people have always inhabited these underground passages, here under our country? Can this be the great death hole, to which the wicked are condemned?” and Onrai turned to look about him.

“No, no, Onrai, let not such thoughts come into your mind,” said Mr. Bruce. “These are dead and they know no suffering. If they were, as you suppose, they would be alive and undergoing great torture. You have been kept in ignorance of the existence of these people for good reasons, or it may be that the founder of your country knew nothing of this.”

“But are there any of these now living, I wonder? This we must learn before returning, so let us go on, taking good care not to lose our way,” said Mr. Graham.

They accordingly moved along through the death chamber, keeping straight ahead. The chamber seemed unending and went on and on, with the dead still piled in heaps and leaning against the walls. It must have taken ages to accumulate these thousands of dead.

“There seems no end to all this,” said Mr. Graham. “I would prefer that we get out of this place and into another not so thickly populated with the dead.”

“It must end some place,” said Mr. Bruce, and he had hardly finished speaking, when a wall loomed up ahead of him and the chamber was ended.

“Well, we are a nice lot,” said Harry; “there is no opening here and we will have to return.”

But after looking around for some time, and by moving several of the bodies, an opening was discovered in one corner. This was small, but after crawling through it the party found themselves in another corridor,

resembling the one of the winds. The hideous sight of the dead was now lost and they passed on down a smooth hallway quickly, nothing obstructing their headway. On, on they went, the corridor leading in a straight line, as near as they could calculate, in a southeasterly direction.

“I should much rather have followed the windy passage, if it had been possible,” said Mr. Bruce.

“And I,” said Mr. Graham. “But to fight against being blown away by that strong current would soon have exhausted us. But we may strike it again further on.”

“Yes,” said Harry, “and this passage may be leading us to great discoveries. I believe that if any of the strange race of people are yet alive, they must use this passage, for it would be quite impossible for them to get through the windy one.”

“How long it must have taken to cut this hall from a solid rock,” said Mr. Bruce, “and how many thousands of men it must have taken to accomplish this immense work.”

“It was not done in a day or a year, or in many years,” said Mr. Graham. “Still the work looks as if it might have been done years or hundreds of years ago.”

“We have made a greater discovery than the one of On,” said Mr. Bruce.

“That’s so,” answered Mr. Graham, “for this has the additional interest of being underground.”

“Is it possible?” said Onrai, “that my people have lived so long over these strange inhabitants of the under world and have learned nothing of them?”

“Your people are not at all curious, Onrai, or they would have long ago investigated these things,” said Mr. Bruce. “The desire for discoveries is altogether lacking in your make-up, and your laws have had a great deal to do with it. You believe that yours is the only race on this earth and that all things are known to you, so you have never thought it necessary to look beyond the things that be.”

“There is much for us to learn here,” said Onrai, a puzzled look coming into his face.

“No,” answered Mr. Bruce, “you know enough to make your lives contented and happy and anything beyond that would be folly. But that

certain things exist that you do not know of, there is no doubt; these, however, are not necessary to your happiness or well-being, and for this reason have been kept from you. I would not let the things which you are now learning of for the first time, worry me in the least if I were you. Whatever these underground passages may bring to light, they cannot in the least effect you or yours; so it would be best not to give these any serious thought yourself or ever mention them to your subjects."

"I believe you are right," said Onrai, "for we are happy now and any greater knowledge might make us discontented, giving us a desire to reach out and learn more, thus making us restless. I can now realize how this can be."

They were still following the smooth-floored corridor and throughout its entire length it had kept up that uniform width and height. The angle formed by the meeting of the floor and walls was sharp and perfectly cut as could be, and the beautiful arched roof showed wonderful skill in chiseling. They all walked along, after this conversation, each one engrossed in his own thoughts, when Onrai, who was in the lead, stopped, and stooping, picked up a peculiar-shaped spear; the handle was short and made of the backbone of some kind of fish; the head was long and narrow and made of a very flinty stone; this head was set into the handle, a slot being cut into the latter for this purpose; a cement was used to fasten this head firmly into the handle, it also being bound to it by thongs in much the same manner as are all spearheads of the African tribe. Examining it more closely, stains were seen on the head and handle, and the handle was notched in several places. The spear might have been left there a day before or a century before; it was in a perfect state of preservation, but the substance of which it was made was very nigh indestructible, so it might have laid there for ages.

"This passage has never been used since that spear was left here," said Mr. Bruce.

"Why do you think so?" asked Mr. Graham.

"Because," answered Mr. Bruce, "if it had been the spear would undoubtedly have been picked up, as it is more than likely that these are not so easily made as to be thrown away or left without being picked up."

"If that be so," said Mr. Graham, "it tells nothing that we may want to know. We are only interested in the live portion of this race, if there be any of them yet extant, and we want some clew that will lead us to them."

“Well, I can say this much,” said Mr. Bruce, “that we will find them ahead of us if we find any at all.”

“Another indefinite declaration,” said Mr. Graham, “tell us how you know this, Mr. Bruce?”

“Why this spearhead was lying, turned in that direction in which we are going and when it was dropped, it was but natural that its loser was moving in the same direction, for in falling it would naturally fall that way.”

“There is considerable in that argument,” said Harry, “and I agree with you, Mr. Bruce, that whoever dropped it was the last person through here and was going in the direction in which we are now moving.”

“Well, we shall see,” said Mr. Graham, “have you made out the stains on the handle, Mr. Bruce?”

“No, but they look very much like congealed blood and I suppose they are nothing else. These people probably use the spear for killing fish.”

“Why fish,” asked Onrai.

“Well, that was only another supposition of mine,” said Mr. Bruce. “You see it is hardly likely that these people have any land animals down here. Such things have never been found yet or at least not in any numbers. But fish in subterranean rivers and lakes are very prevalent; in fact an underground river or lake is seldom found without these fish, some of them, as is the case in the great Mammoth Cave of Kentucky, being without eyes. Then, we know that these people find fish in some part of their underground home, for we have the proof of it here,” and Mr. Bruce held up the spear handle.

“But do you know that that is fish bone?” asked Harry.

“Well, from what I have learned on the subject, I should say that it was,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, it looks like a bone in the fish we catch in the lake,” said Onrai.

“Well, it is decided that it is a fish bone and the stains are made by the fish blood,” said Mr. Bruce. “Now, we know that somewhere in this cave there is a river or lake and I would say that the passage, which we are now traversing, is but the avenue leading to the death chamber. These people probably realize that it is best to have the dead well-removed from the living quarters, for the same reason, may be, that we do this above. Therefore we are on the right road to the living habitations of this people, if

there be any of them now living. Listen,” and as Mr. Bruce, ceased speaking, he stopped and the others following his example, a low buzzing sound was heard like the hum of many voices.

“What is it,” whispered Mr. Graham.

“Hard to tell,” said Mr. Bruce, “but we will soon learn for it is growing louder,” and raising his torch he blew it out, leaving them in perfect darkness.

“What shall we do?” asked Onrai.

“It is hardly safe to look forward, and it looks decidedly cowardly to retreat, and we will be an open mark if we stand still,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Let us move a little further forward,” said Mr. Graham, “and we may find a hiding place. If we find that these people are coming this way and are in great numbers, we can keep ahead of them until we reach the death chamber, when we can barricade the small entrance with the bodies and in this way hold off an army.”

They all agreed to this and moved a little further forward. The passage at this point made a slight turn to the south and as our friends rounded the corner they came in sight of a number of lights far down the passage. These were being carried by a number of beings, who looked, at this distance, to resemble the bodies in the death chamber. Our friends stopped, not knowing whether to turn and go back or keep on for a short distance.

“Look well down on the left,” said Harry, “don’t you see that hole in the wall?” They looked and all saw it, but it was fully half-way between the torchbearers and themselves. It would be almost suicidal to try and reach it, but Mr. Bruce, who was looked on as the ringleader of the party, said: “Come, keep close to the left wall and walk sideways and step as quickly as possible. I think we can reach the hole before they see us. They seem to be engrossed in something else at present and not expecting to find any strangers in this hole, which has never seen one before probably. We may escape them.”

And so saying, Mr. Bruce took the lead. They hurried forward, walking with their backs to the wall. The natives were coming towards them slowly and each moment brought them into better view. Their figures were perfectly nude and of a bluish-white color; looking as if they might have been black originally, but long absence from the light of day had faded

them to the present color. They were not over five feet in height and their bodies were slender. They were chanting a strange dirge in a peculiar tone and this did not make the strangers' position any brighter.

Slowly our friends moved toward them and the hole. They were still hid in the shadows, but they could not expect to be out of the light of the torches much longer, for the natives were now getting very near them. The hole was nearly reached when a shout went up from the natives, but instead of hurrying forward they crowded back, apparently afraid to encounter the strangers which they saw coming toward them.

"Keep on to the hole," said Mr. Bruce.

They did so, and a moment later reached it and passed through. When they were all inside the new chamber or hall, they stopped; it being perfectly dark. The torchbearers, after running back for a short distance, stopped, and again resuming their chant, started forward. Our friends stood perfectly still, and threw themselves on the defensive. They could see the light through the doorway growing brighter and brighter, and could hear the voices growing louder. Had they seen them, or was the shout caused by something else? It might have been a part of the strange proceedings which they were now going through.

"Do nothing until they attempt to enter the opening," said Mr. Bruce, "then use your weapons."

The procession outside came nearer and the chant grew louder, as if the strange people would in this way strengthen their courage. What would it be, fight, or run, or neither? Whatever it was to be they would soon know, for now they were at the doorway and passing. They are safe.

"No, look," said Mr. Graham, "the door——"

It was true. A huge stone was slowly moving into the open place, making them prisoners.

CHAPTER XXIX.

THE DEATH-TRAP.

“Light a torch,” said Mr. Bruce, as he saw the stone door slowly slide into place.

One hideous head of a native stooped and looked under the lowering door, and shaking a torch in his hand, dodged back as if afraid of being charged upon by the prisoners. The door fell to its place and a torch was lighted at Mr. Bruce’s command, and an inspection of their quarters was made. This did not take long, for the chamber was only about twenty feet square; the ceiling was about the height of that in the hall or passage. Try as they would they could discover no other opening, nor any opening now, for the stone fitted the doorway so perfectly, that not even a crack was left to show where this had been.

“We are in for it,” said Harry.

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “and it looks very much as if we were here for good, for there is no opening that I can see at all, and all our energy and strength would be wasted in trying to dig our way out.”

“We must make an effort of some kind,” said Mr. Graham, “so let us consider the matter for a moment.”

They all stopped, and putting their wits to work, tried to devise some means for escape. When they realized that they were not only entombed in a room cut out of the solid rock, but this rock, hundreds of feet beneath the surface, the thought was not very cheering; but they were not the ones to give up without a struggle. They had stood for some moments thinking over their unpleasant position, and trying to formulate some plan of procedure, when Onrai, who was probably the most helpless of the number, began sniffing the air as if he had detected some foreign substance in it.

“Can you not smell something strange?” said Onrai.

They all drew in a deep breath. Yes, there was something; a nasty odor, which they had not noticed before, and it was getting plainer each moment. They looked about them, but could see nothing.

“It may be the torch,” said Mr. Graham.

“No, it is a different smell from that, but we must extinguish the torch or the smoke will soon suffocate us, if this other smell does not,” and saying this, Mr. Bruce blew out the torch. But that fearful smell, what could it be? In a short time their eyes began to smart.

“It is smoke of some kind,” said Harry, “and I am going to find out from where it is coming.”

He relighted the torch, and for a moment the men could hardly see, so thick had the smoke become in those few minutes.

“It is stifling,” said Mr. Bruce. “Can you see where it comes from?”

Harry, who had the torch and who was looking for the source of this new danger, examined every nook and corner, but could find no hole or opening. The smoke was getting thicker each moment, and the men were gasping for breath; it would only take a very few minutes of this to kill them all; still there seemed to be no avenue of escape. These natives had shown great cunning in thus allowing them to get into the chamber, imprisoning them and choke them to death with smoke.

Mr. Bruce took the torch from Harry and started inspecting himself. He was staggering about the room half-blinded and choked by the smoke, when the torch fell from his hands, and falling to the floor went out. He stooped to pick it up again, when he felt a draft near the floor; he hurriedly relit the torch and placed it near the floor; he had to get down onto his knees and bend close to the floor before he could see, and there, coming in a great broad stream, he saw the smoke coming through a crack about an inch in width, and five feet in length. The crack ran with the floor, and Mr. Bruce at once came to the conclusion that another stone door must be at this point, and it had been lifted to leave a space for the smoke’s entrance.

“Come quickly,” he called to the others, not knowing but that they had already succumbed to the fearful smoke, as he could not see them. They had been leaning against the opposite wall, fighting off that fearful suffocation, when they heard Mr. Bruce’s voice.

“Hurry, pull yourselves together and help me, and we may escape. Who has the spear? Bring it here.”

Harry, who had been holding on to the spear, using it for support, staggered towards Mr. Bruce, and handed it to him mechanically.

“Brace up there, men,” he again called out, and they shuffled towards him almost falling. “Now, get your fingers into that crack, and lift, lift for your lives, for it is our only chance. I will work the spear under and hold all you can get. Now.”

The men seemed to realize that there was a chance to escape, no matter how faint a one, so making a despairing effort to overcome the suffocation, which was parching their throats and bursting their heads, placed their fingers in the cracks, and lifted. They strained every nerve, stretched every muscle, and look, it was raising. Yes, the huge stone was moving; now it was an inch higher, and now two inches higher, and then there was a space of a foot under the door, but the wider became the space the more smoke poured in, and the men were almost ready to drop the fearful weight and fall over unconscious. Mr. Bruce realizing this, broke the handle of the spear, and placed this under the stone just as the men fell exhausted.

This act of his, if delayed one second longer, would have cost them their lives, for he had barely gotten it under the huge stone when the men dropped. The solid straight piece of bone held the stone, however, but would he have strength to pull the three men through the opening; and would there not be a body of their would-be murderers on the opposite side to fight him back? He had no time to spend in conjectures, however, so catching Harry by the feet he pulled him to the hole; he rolled him through and then Mr. Graham, but when it came to Onrai, he had to roll the man over and over, his body being too heavy to move in any other way. And he was fast giving out himself, but he must not do so before he got him and his friends on the other side of the hole. Getting Onrai to the opening and pushing him through, and then crawling through himself, he looked about him for the generator of this fearful smoke. Groping his way about, he stumbled over a large stone brazier in which was a powdered substance, and it was this which was smoldering and making a dense smoke. Taking his water-skin from his back, he quickly poured its contents over the smoldering coals and extinguished them. He was nearly fainting and he felt that he must soon give up; his eyes were nearly blinded, he was choking

and his head was bursting; he was fast losing his senses, but he staggered about the room, and finally found an open archway. Through this he plunged, falling to the floor, but the air was pure here and a cooling breeze was blowing through the apartment, and it was this draught probably, which had forced the smoke through the crack. Mr. Bruce lay still for a moment in the refreshing air, but realizing that his three friends were still in the stifling smoke and unable to help themselves, he again picked himself up, and by rolling them over and over succeeded in getting them all in the outer chamber or corridor.

But where were the natives? Mr. Bruce had not seen or heard them since leaving the death-trap, and he could not account for their absence. But he felt very thankful for their not having interfered with him, for if they had it would have been all over with him and his friends. He had his companions in the pure air now, and unstrapping the water-bag from Harry's back, he bathed their faces and poured some down each parched throat. He worked hard with them, and at last brought them all around; but they were not able to do much walking for a while, so while they were recruiting, Mr. Bruce took the torch and reconnoitered. They seemed to be in another corridor, somewhat wider than the other, but about the same height.

Mr. Bruce, after following this for some distance, returned to his companions and made his report.

"What had we better do?" asked Mr. Graham. "Turn back or go on?"

"I say, go on," said Mr. Bruce, "but if you think the risk is too great and wish to return, we will do so; what do you say, Onrai?"

"I know not what to say," said Onrai, "but if you would like to proceed, I am willing. I am afraid, though, I should be nothing but a hindrance to you."

"No, no, Onrai, you must not say that," said Harry. "Such an ordeal as we have just passed through is enough to make any man go under; any man but Mr. Bruce, and he is a wonder. How did you do it, Mr. Bruce?"

"By pure force of will," said Mr. Bruce. "I felt like giving up several times, I can tell you; but a man can do a good deal, I believe, when his life and the lives of his friends depend on it. But don't let us talk of that now. The question is, shall we retreat or advance?"

"Advance, I should say," said Harry, "what do you say, father?"

“I am willing; but before we run into a trap again, rather let us retreat.”

“Agreed,” said Mr. Bruce.

They now rose, and stretching their legs and taking another drink of water, they advanced cautiously down the corridor; not knowing what moment their escape might be detected and the natives of this hellhole be after them again. They had not long to remain in suspense, when suddenly into the corridor rushed a mob of howling naked natives, making straight for them.

CHAPTER XXX.

THE CAVE DWELLER'S FUNERAL.

The howling mob came hurrying toward them; their faces distorted with horrible grimaces, their arms flying in the air, brandishing spears like the one found in the corridor. They came on howling, yelling and shouting in a blood-curdling way.

“Fall back, slowly,” said Mr. Bruce, “but keep in this corridor.”

They retreated slowly, keeping their faces on the approaching mob.

“If they come too near discharge your pistols in their midst,” continued Mr. Bruce.

The natives were gaining on them fast, but they were not moving as quickly as they might, showing that they were undecided as to whether it would be best to attack the strangers or not. There seemed to be about two hundred of them, each bearing a torch in one hand and a spear in the other.

As time went on and they saw the hostile movements on the part of the strangers, they became bold and moved more rapidly. They were closing up quickly when our friends heard a shout in the rear, and looking over their shoulders saw another mob of the natives closing in on them from that direction.

“Which shall it be?” said Mr. Bruce, “advance or retreat.”

“Advance,” said Harry, “and give those howling demons a taste of lead.”

On all the excursions our friends had carried their small arms but had never used them; but they had these with them now and it was well that they had taken this precaution, for nothing else would have had as much effect on this barbarous race of underground dwellers, as the noise and explosion of the pistols would. Our friends were still standing waiting for

the men to advance. The natives, seeing that they now had their game safe, became wilder in their demonstrations and bolder in their movements. The body in the rear also hurried forward and in a very short time the strangers in this horrible place found themselves very sorely pressed.

“Now,” said Mr. Bruce, “make a rush and fire as you go. Harry, you and I will take the lead, for it is best to go in twos. When the chambers of our revolvers are empty, we will drop behind and let Mr. Graham and Onrai take the lead. If these beasts do not turn and run, charge right into them, for it is our only chance. Now, forward, double quick.”

The men started on a run, discharging their revolvers as they went. At each discharge, one of the natives would fall, for they were so tightly wedged in the narrow passage, there was no chance of missing them. As our friends started and the fearful noise of the pistols, as they were discharged, rung through the cavern, the natives stopped and watched the advance with open-mouthed wonder. Then they saw their companions dropping one at a time as the weapons were discharged, they began to grow uneasy, and then to move slowly backward and then, at last, as the full force of the panic struck them, they turned and fled down the corridor, each trying to outrun the other and trampling those under foot who were unlucky enough to fall. On, on they flew over the hard surface of the cave, occasionally throwing frightened glances over their shoulders as they ran; then, seeing those strangers still after them, they strove still harder to place a greater distance between themselves and their pursuers.

Those in the rear of our friends had turned and ran in the opposite direction from which they came, when they saw their companions retreat. They saw too the work of those awful barking, smoke-belching weapons and thinking that they might be turned on them in the same manner, probably thought it best to get out of the way as quickly as possible. This took a considerable load from off the minds of our friends, for they had feared that these howling barbarians would attack them from the rear as they ran. After the first three or four discharges of the pistols had started their enemies, they had discontinued firing in order to save their ammunition, but they kept up the pace and were close on the heels of the devils. Suddenly the mob turned to the right and disappeared. As our friends had thrown away the lighted torch, when first surprised by the natives they were now left in total darkness again and when the danger disappeared, they

stopped to hold a consultation. Looking back they saw that their former pursuers had also left the corridor and this decided them to wait a few minutes for further developments.

“We must be careful now,” said Mr. Bruce, “for these natives may lay in ambush and attack us, as we advance or retreat. They are cunning, as they have shown by their smoking process, and we must be on our guard.”

“I think they are so badly scared they will not again bother us;” said Harry.

“Perhaps so,” said Mr. Bruce, “but if they have a means of attacking us without running any risk of personal injury to themselves, you may remain assured they will do so.”

“They are a strange race of men,” said Onrai, “I thought, when I first looked upon your people, that you were small in stature, but these are very much smaller and are hideous. Do you think them human?”

“Human, yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “but of a very low order of humanity. The race has so long inhabited these underground dwellings that they have become wild and barbarous.”

“They must be,” said Onrai, “for they are so unlike your race. But do you suppose that they have always lived here or have they come from another world like yourselves? I cannot believe that they have been here, right under our fair Land of On, for long, for if they had we would have known it.”

“But how would you have known it, Onrai?” asked Mr. Graham. “You nor yours have ever investigated nor have you ever cared to, and you might have gone down to your graves and countless generations of those who follow you have done the same, without ever knowing that these strange people lived beneath your land, in the very bowels of the earth. And, we have said so frequently, Onrai, your people have no curiosity and take no heed of things which do not directly concern them.”

“It is better so, I think,” answered Onrai; “for surely you can find no happiness in an undertaking like this, can you?”

“Well, yes, we can,” answered Mr. Bruce, “for in the first place it is a pleasure to us to see and learn of new and strange things. That is where one’s curiosity comes in, you see; and then we enjoy, in a way, the excitement which such adventures always bring. But at the same time I

would not recommend any such questionable pleasures to those who have never had any desire for them. But we are in a strange place and predicament now to be discussing this question. We must decide on which way we are going and how we are going to proceed.”

“What do you say, Mr. Graham?” asked Onrai.

“Well,” said Mr. Graham, “we have kept in one direction so far and I see no reason for returning now. Our friends will not worry about us if we do not return for two or three days and there are many things here which I would like to find out before going back. We have proceeded so far and it will be no more difficult for us to get back from a short distance beyond here than it would be from this point. So let us go ahead.”

“Agreed,” said Harry, “and let us keep close together, for we may need each other’s immediate help.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “we must move cautiously and silently if possible and may be we will pass the point where the natives turned off.”

With this they moved on, feeling their way by the walls of the corridor and keeping close together. A braver lot of men it would have been hard to find; in fact, not one of these men felt the least fear even after their recent experience, unless it might have been Onrai, and it was not a fear with him, but more that unexplained uncertainty. He had been led to think, throughout his life, that his race was the only one inhabiting this world and he had first been visited by a number of strange people, even coming into his company in a strange way. He had accounted for these by believing that they had come from another planet. This had not worried him but only a few days before, while moving through his country his men had found a woman and child, which had evidently belonged to another race of people. This had set him to thinking and now, down here in the bowels of the earth, living in caves hewn out of rock, he had found still another race, a miserable half-dwarfed race, and Mr. Bruce had assured him that these people had lived here for ages, probably longer than had his people in the open country above. All these things had upset the teachings and the beliefs of a lifetime and Onrai now was in a doubt as to what to believe. But he felt no fear really, but only a disgust, brought on by all this doubt.

The party calculated that they had now reached the point where the natives had disappeared and the precautions were doubled. The floor of the cavern at this point was strewn with spears, which had been dropped by the

frightened natives and it was hard work to walk over these in the dark without making some noise, but no signs of natives were seen, as it was supposed that they had hid themselves in some remote part of the cave. After passing this point, the explorers moved faster but did not attempt to light a torch.

“Do you think that we can be able to find the other corridor again, the one by which we entered this place?” asked Onrai.

“That’s so,” said Mr. Bruce. “I had forgotten that we were now in another corridor.”

“No,” said Harry, “and even if we look for it we would not know where to find it. We may wander about here for weeks or months and never find our way out.”

“Now, these are disagreeable things which we must not think of if we would enjoy this adventure to the fullest,” said Mr. Graham. “I can understand that to be lost in this hole would be fearful, but we are not lost yet, for if we are, we are not aware of the fact; so let us not think of that. We must try, however, to keep in this corridor or one which leads off from it and to know at all times just how many turns we make.”

“It would be well for us to notch these walls occasionally, or in some other way leave marks by which we can find our way back,” said Mr. Bruce.

“That is a grand idea,” said Harry, “and I will commence right here by scratching the wall.”

The torch was lit and Harry, taking one of the spears, attempted to chip the wall with this, but one stone was as hard as the other, seemingly, and the spearhead would make no impression.

“We will have to find some other means than this,” said Harry. And stooping, he looked over the floor of the cave, in hopes of finding something which would cut the hard stone. But he was not successful, so the notching was given up.

The corridor still stretched out straight ahead of them, and they hurried along as fast as their tired limbs would allow their doing.

“What time is it, Mr. Bruce?” asked Harry.

“Why, it is nine o’clock,” answered Mr. Bruce; “and to tell the truth I feel as though it were twelve. A little rest would not go amiss.”

“But I do not think it advisable to sleep here,” said Mr. Graham, “we are not far enough away from that bloodthirsty mob.”

“No,” said Mr. Bruce, “we will hurry on for a while yet, and if no side aisle leads off into which we can hide for a few hours, we will lie down in this, leaving watchers.”

For another hour they trudged along, until thoroughly exhausted and ready to drop, they decided upon taking a short rest. The first watch fell to Harry, and he took his stand against the wall, being afraid that if he sat down he would go to sleep. The others stretched themselves out upon the hard floor of the corridor, and in a moment were fast asleep. Harry put out the torch for fear of its attracting attention to them, should any of the natives happen in the corridor.

The moments passed on leaden wings; his eyes grew heavy and he began pacing the corridor to keep awake; his legs were too weary to longer support his body and he squatted down upon the floor with his back resting against the side wall. The scenes of the day passed through his mind in a dreamy sort of way. In a short time he caught himself dozing; then tired nature asserted itself and his eyes closed and refused to open again; his head dropped to one side and he slept. How long he had slept he did not know, but he was awakened by a humming noise, which seemed far away and yet very close. Starting up and opening his eyes he looked far up the corridor in the direction in which they were traveling and there he saw a procession of torches coming toward him. He hastily awakened his companions and telling them what was up they held a consultation.

It seemed folly to longer go ahead, for these bodies of natives might be met continually and to have to chase them every few hours would be nonsense. Harry had walked up the corridor a ways, while the others were talking, feeling his way by the wall when his hand, which went out to touch this wall failed to come in contact with it; he tried again with the same result and then moved his body in that direction thinking that he might have wandered away from the wall. But there was no wall at this point and after moving in this direction for a short distance, he struck a match; he could not see very closely, but he understood that he was in a side corridor or room of some kind. He at once called to his companions and they having joined him, they lit a torch; the natives still being a great distance up the corridor. This room was considerably larger than the one in which they had been

imprisoned and was evidently a living chamber; for in one corner was a raised slab, on which were dead coals and some fish offal. The room had evidently been used very recently from the looks of the fish remains.

On the opposite side of the room was another door, leading into another corridor, and upon examining this corridor it was found to extend only a short distance and end against a solid rock. But if there was a secret door in this rock, the explorers could not see and they had no time to give it a thorough examination, because of having to extinguish the torch, the natives now getting very close.

“What shall we do now?” asked Harry.

“I think,” said Mr. Bruce, “it will be well to hide behind the slab on which are the coals and watch the procession as it passes. They cannot certainly be after us, for they have not had time to get so far ahead of us. It is probably another band on their way to this part of the cave for some purpose or other.”

They took up their positions behind the slab, lying on their sides with their heads just above the stone, looking for the natives. They could be heard coming, chanting a dismal dirge; the glare of the torches already lighting up the hall outside. “I would not care to be made a prisoner again,” said Harry.

“They can’t catch us in the same way here,” said Mr. Bruce, “for these arches have no sliding doors.”

“This may be some holiday celebration,” said Mr. Graham.

“It may be their Day of Resis,” said Onrai, “that is if they have a Day of Resis.”

“I doubt their having such a day, Onrai, although we do not know what the ceremonies of your Day of Resis are, but look they are opposite.”

The first one of the procession now came up and our friends lowered their heads as they passed, but the natives were seemingly oblivious of their presence, the explorers grew bolder and raising their heads well above the slab watched the procession. First the men came, bearing torches stuck on the ends of spears, then came a number of men bearing spears alone; following these were a number of women each carrying a peculiar-shaped fish—a sort of combination fish and lizard, as it had four short legs and feet; there were a great number of these and it took a long time for them to

pass; after them came a great number of children, ranging, as nearly as the explorers could guess, between the ages of five and ten; each of these children bore a small piece of coal, which brought to the minds of our friends thoughts of the great cave which they had crossed in coming to the Land of On. Following the children was another body of men and it was these men who were chanting. The wailing tones of these men, as they came nearer, were fearful to hear and our friends felt the cold chills running down their backs. These men also carried torches, black torches, which looked as though they were made of sharpened pieces of coal; they made a very bright light and but little smoke. As the men came forward it could be seen that they were bearing a very thin slab of stone on their shoulders and on the slab lay the body of a native. It was a funeral procession.

CHAPTER XXXI.

LOST IN THE CAVERN.

They watched the funeral rites, and soon afterward discovered that they were lost in the ground, and did not know their bearings. They thought they must be several miles within, as the direction taken from the point where they entered the cave was several days' journey from the City of On, and as they had traveled nearly due south, or as nearly as they could calculate, they must now be a good many miles from the secret door. They might take the same corridor which they had traversed in coming to the lake, as this would take them directly to the hole near which the rest of the excursionists were awaiting them; but this was dangerous and it was quite possible that before they had gone far into this, they would again fall into the hands of the natives.

They were in a quandary as to what to do. If they traveled to the east in quest of the hidden door, they might not find it, and before they could again reach the long corridor they would be overcome by hunger, thirst and fatigue.

"What shall we do," asked Harry.

"I think," said Mr. Bruce, "it would be well to strike straight for the north wall and when this is reached we may find another opening which will take us in a roundabout way to the hole leading to the surface. You know we left the windy corridor and took one to the right. This windy corridor may lead to this cavern also. If this were so it would come out further to the east, or may be at a point directly south of where we are now."

"Even if that should be so," said Mr. Graham, "could we beat against that wind for so many miles?"

"I am afraid not," said Mr. Bruce, "but other corridors may lead from it, which would carry us into one or the other halls which we have already traversed, but at a point beyond all danger."

"It is a chance, at least," said Harry, "that is, if this corridor leads into the cave."

"Are we beneath the Land of On, now?" asked Onrai, who had spoken but seldom since coming into this strange place.

"No, Onrai," said Mr. Graham, "we are under the mountains or cliffs which surround your country. These though may be said to belong to the Land of On, or half of them at least, for they stand on the dividing line."

"It is strange," said Onrai, "that I should never have known of all this or that my people had never learned of it before me."

For a second time Onrai had spoken thus and the events of the past few hours seemed to have made a great impression on his mind; he could not realize that all these things had existed for years and hundreds of years. It all seemed so improbable to one who had been taught to believe that his race was the only people and that his or their land above the surface, was the only country. He had seen strange things in the past few hours the only strange things he had ever seen in his life, with the exception of our friends, if they may be classed under this category.

"I will have strange tales to tell my people," said Onrai.

"You must not tell them of these things," said Mr. Graham, "for it would but make them discontented and long to see them also. It would be much better never to mention these; you can easily evade the subject when broached and our people will never say anything."

"Do you think they would care to investigate?" asked Onrai. "I would never care to come here again and I cannot believe that they would ever care to visit this place if I should explain to them the danger and trouble attending the trip."

"Yes, it would be better, would it not?" said Mr. Bruce, "to obey the laws which have governed you for centuries, and which forbids your prying into anything which has not already been explained by these laws."

"I begin to think as you do," said Onrai, "but I doubt my ability to keep from my people, should they ask me, the things which I have learned here."

We have never had secrets, as you have taught me to call these things, and I have not learned the art of withholding things which I do not wish to say.”

“Nothing may be said to you about your journey, and then it would be easy enough, would it not, to keep these things to yourself?”

“It may be so,” said Onrai.

They were traveling in a good easy walk, and were covering considerable ground, but they were growing weary and it was decided to rest for a few hours. This they proceeded to do, but before they stretched out on the hard floor, they blew out the torches so that any of the natives, who might be prowling about, would not see them and again be on them. The journey had been long and they had had but little rest, so when they finally lay down and stretched out their weary limbs, their eyes soon closed and all was forgotten in a very few moments. The hard floor of the cave, the memories of the recent events, the fear of not again finding their way out of the dark hole, these things could not keep them awake for they were worn out, mind and body, and once they had fallen into a reclining position, they were soon oblivious to everything.

They had been sleeping for hours, it seemed to Harry, when he was awakened by a distant cry. It sounded to him like the yell of the natives, when they had first discovered the strangers. He looked about him half dreamily but could see nothing and turned over, thinking he would sleep awhile longer as the others had not yet awakened. He was just falling off again, when that cry broke out just a little shriller than before. This time Harry jumped to his feet, certain now of its being a human cry. He looked about him, he even took a few steps away from his sleeping companions, and stopping again, listened. No, he could hear nothing; still, he was sure that he had not been mistaken. All sleep had now been knocked out of him, and feeling refreshed he knew that he had been sleeping for some time. He walked over to his companions and awakened them, but before he had time to interfere or explain to them what it was that had awakened him, Mr. Bruce had lit a match, and with this, the torch. Harry made a movement as if he would extinguish this, and not having heard the sound after this second awakening, he thought there might be just a possibility of his having been mistaken. But he told his companions of the occurrence so that they might not blame him if anything should come of it later.

“I could not say that you were mistaken, Harry,” said Mr. Bruce, “but it seems very probable that we would see some light if these natives were again on our track.”

“Yes,” said Harry, “I don’t suppose they have dark lanterns which would give them light, but would still keep the light hid from us.”

“They might have such lights,” said Mr. Graham, “but we would see the reflection on the ground, at least.”

They had now started again when Harry stopped, saying:

“How do we know that we are moving in the right direction? We may have turned completely in our moving about, and may now be making a bee line for the lake.”

The party stopped, looking at each other in a puzzled way. Mr. Bruce’s face lighted up though as he asked:

“Did you touch my torch, Harry?”

“No,” answered Harry.

“Well, and then we can depend on it, that we are moving in the same direction that we were before, for I laid down the torch with the burnt end looking in the direction we were going when I laid down, and when I picked it up and lighted it again, after you had awakened us, I remember I was standing facing the same way, and I did not turn again before we started.”

“But that tells nothing,” said Mr. Graham, “for we may be walking round and round in a circle not a mile in circumference. We have nothing to guide us, and it very often occurs, in cases of this kind, that the travelers who think themselves miles away from their starting point will, the next moment, bring up at the same spot.”

The friends stood and looked at each other as Mr. Bruce said this; the terrible truth flashing upon them. It was only too true; they were helpless in this great dark cavern. They might wander until starved and famished, and still be miles from the encircling wall, or may be but a few feet from it. It would only be chance if they should come up to the wall; not chance either, for even chance was barred in this Egyptian darkness. It would be the hand of Providence which saved them if they should ever now escape from this cave. If they had followed the lake until the bridge had been reached, they could then have followed the old path to the hidden door, and in that way

have gotten out. But no, the only thought they had in getting away from the scene of such carnage, was to leave it far behind and to reach their friends as soon as possible.

They realized their mistake, but now it was too late. The thought completely prostrated them as its full significance dawned upon them.

“But we must not give up while there is strength left,” said Mr. Bruce; “so let us go on in some way, even if we are bearing right away from our goal. We may be right, you know. Anyway we will never find our way out of this by standing still.”

They again took up their way, but with a halfheartedness, which made every step a task and every movement painful. It was strange how these strong men, who had just gotten up from a refreshing sleep, well and hearty, should so soon be changed to despondent beings; their faces looking years older and their gait indicating feebleness. Such is the change which the awful sense of complete helplessness had wrought in these men. They had hit upon a possibility, even a probability, and all else had been forgotten from that moment they had given themselves up for lost, lost in this vast cavern, which had probably been the tomb of many others.

When these thoughts took possession of them, they could not be persuaded that there was any possibility of escape, and it was no wonder they lost hope so quickly, for here was a cave miles in extent, without a guiding light or post to beckon them on. All was dark and still as the death which would so soon claim them. For some strange reason, Onrai seemed to be more affected than any of the others. He said but little, but his face was painful to look at, so frightfully changed had it become. He shuffled along, his shoulders bent and feet dragging over the ground like a man of eighty.

Occasionally he would mutter to himself:

“I have missed my Day of Resis!”

This seemed to be the thing which was worrying him.

“Wait,” said Harry, and they all stopped suddenly, for this was the first word which had been spoken by any of the party excepting Onrai. “When wandering in the cave, as we came,” went on Harry, “I remember seeing pieces of coal lying along the path. The thought has just occurred to me that these marked the path, or else how could the natives find their way. Now, if we could find these.”

“But these would be as hard to find as the border wall,” said Mr. Graham.

“True,” said Harry, his face again falling, “but it is another chance and this makes two.”

This cheered them but little, however, and despair took possession of them completely a few moments later. They ought to have reached the wall hours before, yet there were no signs of it. Suddenly they were brought to a stand by the same cry, which had awakened Harry. There was no mistaking it now; it was human and right in front of them.

Our friends stopped. There was no mistaking the cry now; it was human and only a few feet ahead of them. They peered through the gloom but could see nothing; the man, whoever he was, could not be far away, so they moved forward and a moment later a dark mass was seen lying on the floor of the cave just ahead of them. As they hurried up to this, another cry went up from the heap. Our friends now came up to the object and found it to be a native. As they approached and stood over him, he raised his head and looked at them in a half-scared way and then tried to crawl away from them. Seeing them following him he raised to his feet and staggered along for a short distance but again fell. The party now saw that his left side from knee to shoulder was badly lacerated, but how had he come into this condition? Had he been wounded in a fight or in a blast and brought to this fearful place to die?

Although this man was probably one of their captors and would have helped to kill them if they had not turned the tables on them, still the man's plight was so pitiful and his condition so helpless that their sympathy went out to him at once and coming up close to where he had fallen, Mr. Graham stooped and taking the bag of water from his back, poured its contents over the raw wounds of the native. He writhed under the momentary pain, but realizing that they wished to help him, he tried to facilitate their good acts by turning his side to them, exposing the wound. He kept looking at Onrai, as if the King had a fascination for him, which he could not resist and at last he raised his hand and motioned to Onrai to approach. Onrai came up to him and the native looked at him for fully a moment, then addressed him in the language of On.

Onrai started back completely surprised by hearing his own language spoken by this man. The native's face fell, showing that he had built much on this disclosure to the King and the result had bitterly disappointed him.

“Speak to him, Onrai,” said Mr. Bruce.

Onrai again stepped up to the native and asked him how he had become acquainted with his language.

“The story is long and I am hurt,” answered the man, “but if you will carry me to the lake, where my companions were killed, and let me there wash my wounds, I will tell you all.”

“The lake,” said Mr. Graham, “why, my good man, that is many miles away.”

“No,” answered the man, “it is only a short distance from here.”

Our friends looked at each other with astonishment; they had seen the lake upon their entrance; their fears then had been realized; they had been describing a circle and were now but a few feet from the starting point. But there was now hope and the men carefully lifted the native and carried him in the direction indicated by him and in less than five minutes they were again standing by an underground lake. The man was laid on the floor of the cave and his wounds washed again with water. Harry tore from his tunic a piece of the silk and this was bound about the wound.

“Do you know a way by which we can reach the death chamber without traversing that part of the cave where your people live?” Onrai asked.

“I do,” said the man, “but I could not explain so that you could understand.”

“But if we took you with us, could you guide us?” asked Onrai.

“But am I strong enough to walk?” asked the man, and he tried to rise to his feet.

“You may be able to walk a part of the way and we will carry you the remainder,” said Onrai.

“I can guide you,” said the stranger, and his face lighted up with hope as he thought that he might yet see that great outside world of which he had heard. The more the native thought of this, the more probable it seemed to him and with this great hope springing into life came renewed energy, and after awhile, when Mr. Bruce had bandaged the wounds well and he had been given something to eat he stood erect and declared that he could walk as well as ever. But this he could not do, although with help he got along very well for a time, and then Onrai picked him up in his powerful arms and carried him as if he were a babe.

Before leaving the lake they had caught some fish after the method of the natives and had cooked them over a slow fire. This they hoped would last them until they reached the upper world. They found the line of coals and found it easy work to follow it. The way was long but not tedious, still there was that desire to leave this place which made the time long and the journey anything but pleasant. The native was doing very well with the help of Onrai and would very frequently relate such things concerning his people and country which would help to while away the time.

“We do not know,” said he, “when first our people came into this underground world, nor do we know from whence they came; but we do know from traditions handed down, that we have had this world many, many ages. Then our old tunnels have been abandoned many ages, how many we know not, nor do we know why these have been laid aside for new ones, unless it be because new ones had to be built in order to keep down our population.”

“What do you mean by that?” inquired Mr. Bruce.

“Why,” said the native, “our people increase very rapidly and we can only keep them within bounds by constantly blasting these tunnels. Each blast costs the life of one of our men.”

“But what of the women,” asked Mr. Bruce.

“The women and criminals are all fed to the water-monster,” said the man.

“But are none of these placed in the death chamber?” again asked Mr. Bruce.

“None,” answered the native. “The death chamber is only for the men. At the end of these long tunnels, is the Tunnel of Wind, which keeps a circulation of air in all of them. The wind flies through this tunnel, making no sound and giving no warning, and when once in its awful clutch you are lost.”

“But how do you embalm the bodies of your men,” questioned Mr. Bruce.

“With a preparation of coal and yellow stone, which we find in one part of our country. These are pounded into a powder and are then mixed with fish oil and rolled into small cakes and left to dry. These we burn beneath the bodies and the smoke puts them in a state of preservation.”

Our friends had now reached the wall and were about to enter the tunnel indicated by the native when a body of natives jumped forth only a few feet distant and rushed onto them. The explorers started back and seeing that there was a great number of them, decided on retreating. They accordingly followed the wall to the east, running as fast as they could with the wounded native. The natives were following them closely, and our friends, seeing another tunnel, opening out from the cave, turned into it and hurried forward. The natives were hurrying after them. On they rushed covering mile after mile, until breath and strength were nearly exhausted. The natives had called out to them in their language to drop the one of their number which Onrai was carrying. The man interpreted this to Onrai but it only had the effect of making him hold him all the tighter. But after a while the natives began to drop off one by one and our friends were thinking of turning on them, when they saw their tunnel ending in one running at right angles with it. Hurriedly they pushed forward and were just on the edge of the cross-tunnel, when the native called out:

“Not in there, it is the Tunnel of Wind;” but it was too late. They were launched into it and were even now in the power of the mighty wind.

CHAPTER XXXII.

THE TORTUOUS TRAMP.

Our friends might have turned and faced the natives but they were still a great number of them following, and the capture of the strangers would have been certain if they had tried to fight it out. Their treatment at the hands of these natives had been such that they might expect nothing else but death if they were again captured, so the thought of taking any risk by fighting had not occurred to them until the last moment. There was but one way to escape these beings and that was by flight and they had been so intent on making their escape in this way, that they had forgotten for the moment the windy corridor, their former experience in this and the experience of the native of On, which their new companion had so recently related. They had rushed madly forward, caring little where the cross corridor led, so long as it enabled them to keep ahead of their pursuers. And they had dashed into the windy corridor, not giving it a thought and were now being blown through this at break neck speed.

It would be impossible for human being to stand alone in this gale, and in an instant the men were thrown violently forward and were now rolling over and over unable to stop themselves. Onrai, although he carried the wounded native, was the first in the tunnel and was now some feet ahead of his companions, but was being borne on just as fast as the others. The native had fallen behind him and his wounded body was suffering fearful tortures in this violent exercise; each time the wounded side would strike the rock a cry of pain would escape him. Mr. Bruce was right back of the native, and after a while managed to call to Onrai to work himself toward the wall, if possible, and get head on to the wind and thus offer less resistance to the awful gale. Onrai immediately began edging his way toward the wall and would have succeeded in doing this if the native had not struck him full

force on the side, thus starting him rolling again. But Onrai had caught the native and had clung fast to him and they were not moved nearly so rapidly, being together. As a consequence Mr. Bruce, Mr. Graham and Harry came bowling along and bumped into them, and as they did this the men grabbed each other, and held on, and in this way they were all joined and the wind could no longer move them.

“Now,” said Mr. Bruce, “let us get into position and try to regain our feet, and in single file, as we did upon our first entering this corridor, try to resist its awful power.”

They worked around until one was immediately behind the other, and at a given signal, first rose to one knee and then to both knees, and in this way continued until they were standing on their feet. The poor native asked them to leave him in the corridor to die, but they would not hear of this, and Onrai again threw him over his shoulder, when they were ready to move. They started, leaning well back so to offer greater resistance to the wind, but it was hard work tramping along in this darkness, frequently hitting up against the walls, and bruising their already sore bodies. And then the uncertainty of where the tunnel would finally land them, was making things all the more unpleasant. They could not possibly guess where this would lead them; they had had some experience in the tunnel before, and had heard more about it from the native, but all this had told them nothing. They knew that this gale of wind must have an outlet some place, but what sort of place was this? Would it be a shaft leading to the surface as did the shaft which seemed to be its source? Would it take them back to the great cavern, or to the center of the earth, or where? The thought was maddening, but they could do nothing but go with it, wherever it might lead them.

They had gone on in this way for miles, they thought, and their bodies were bruised and exhausted; still there was no way to stop and rest even for a moment; they would have to keep up the awful rush until too exhausted to longer keep their feet, they would drop and be blown—where? To death, surely. Onrai, who was still carrying the native, tried hard to keep up, but he was fast giving out, and our friends knew that when he should do so, their mainstay was gone, and hope might be abandoned. Onrai suddenly stumbled, and would have fallen had not Mr. Bruce, who was next to him, held fast, thus saving him and may be the others.

“What is wrong, Onrai,” asked Mr. Bruce.

“It was something on the floor,” said Onrai. He had hardly said this when he stumbled again, and this time Mr. Bruce lost his hold, and Onrai went down bearing the native with him. The others threw themselves back, and managed to save themselves from falling.

“Can you get up, Onrai?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“I will try in a moment,” said Onrai. “But can you take the native?”

The others now held on to Mr. Bruce, and he stooped and raised the native.

“Can you stand?” asked Mr. Bruce of the native.

“Yes,” the man answered; but when Mr. Bruce lowered him to the ground, the poor fellow’s legs gave way under him, and he would have fallen had not Mr. Bruce held him. He then raised him again with the others’ help, and threw the man over his shoulder.

Onrai had risen and had again taken his place at the head of the column. But they had noticed something; the wind was not blowing so violently in this part of the tunnel. They could not account for this, neither did they try to, but it made their progress much easier. And another thing which was being forced on their notice, was the great number of loose stones which covered the floor of the tunnel at this point; it must be that the tunnel here had never been finished completely, or it might be that the rock, being softer at this point, had crumbled and fallen from the ceiling. They were suddenly brought up by Onrai striking violently against a rock, which seemed to end the tunnel. For a moment they stood still, Onrai having been shocked in being brought up so suddenly.

“What is it, now?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“It is the end of the tunnel,” said Onrai, “or else we have suddenly turned in our course and have struck the side wall.”

“Move to your right, and see if there be an opening,” said Mr. Bruce.

Onrai did so and then moved forward again.

“It seemed to be a projection,” said Onrai.

He kept his hand on the rock and followed its curves closely until they were on the other side of it and at last they were out of the fearful wind.

“Have you a match?” asked Mr. Graham of Mr. Bruce. “If you have, light a torch and let us see each other. Onrai move about and see what kind of a

place we are in.”

Mr. Bruce fumbled about his tunic for a moment and then produced a match; this flickered for a moment as he applied it to the torch and then a bright light lit up the scene about them. They were surprised at the strange scene, for they were no longer in the smooth walled and floored tunnel, but in a natural cave, which looked very much like the great cavern; but whether it was the same or not, they could not say. The ceiling was high above their heads and could just be seen in the dim rays of light. The wall to which belonged the projecting rock, behind which they were now standing, was ribbed and seamed and was the only one to be seen. The cavern had widened until they could not see across it.

“If this be the large cave then we are safe, for all we have to do is to look for the hidden door,” said Harry.

“But I do not think it is the same,” said Mr. Bruce, “for the reason, that never, in the large cavern, did we feel this draught or wind.”

“That is so;” said Harry, “we must have struck another cave altogether, and it is probably all the worse for us that we have.”

“Why do you think so?” asked Onrai.

“Why, because we knew how to get out of the other, but how to find an opening to the outside world here, we have no idea.”

“I believe, though,” said Mr. Bruce, “that if we can hold out longer, we will come to a shaft leading up to the surface.”

“There must be some great hole leading to the surface, which causes this draught.”

“It would be well for us to take some rest before trying it again,” said Mr. Graham.

“But what of the poor native?” asked Onrai.

They had forgotten him in their surprise at finding themselves where they did, and the poor fellow had laid on the floor of the cave almost dead with pain and fatigue. They went to work on him, though, and used very nearly all of the little water left, bathing his wounds. Then they rearranged the bandages and fixed them as comfortable as possible, so that he might rest; then they also laid down and were soon asleep.

The native laid for a long time with his eyes closed, completely exhausted; but he could not sleep, and after a while his eyes again opened, and he looked about him. The torch had been left in a crevice in the projecting rock, and it threw its fitful glare about them. The ceiling arched far above them, the torchlight throwing long shadows along its rugged crevices; the wall at his side he could follow with his eyes for some distance, but it was then lost in the gloom. He tried to penetrate this gloom and look far beyond and find there a ray of that same light which he had heard his friends tell about. If he could only see such a light, then he would know that these kind companions, who had done so much for him, when they could have left him behind to die, he would know then that they were safe, and that they would again reach their friends. He cared little for himself, for his life had never known any of that strange feeling which he had heard his present companions speak of. He was nothing but a burden and retarded their progress. Oh, if he could but die before they again awakened, it would be so much better for both him and those who had so long kept him with them, even when they would have been fully justified in leaving him behind. Suddenly he starts and half rises. What was that he saw away off there in the darkness? Was it a light? Yes, several of them. They were very dim; in fact he could hardly say they were lights, but they surely resembled the lights of torches in the distance, and they were growing thicker. He could see great numbers of them moving about like will-o'-the-wisps, or was it his fevered brain which was calling up these phantom lights? He raised a little higher to look at the things about him so as to assure himself that he was still in his right mind and would then let his gaze penetrate the gloom, seeking the strange lights.

Yes, he could not be mistaken, they were torchlights; but did they belong to his people or some other strange people, who inhabited this part of the cave. He could not tell this, and as he was not certain that there were others near them, he determined to awaken his companions. Leaning over and touching Onrai, who was lying next to him, he wakened him and then pointing into the darkness said, "Look, do you not see the lights?"

Onrai looked long and carefully before he spoke, then said, "Yes, they must be," and waking his other companions he bade them look also.

It was soon decided by all that there were others in the cavern beside themselves, but who these others were was the question, and could only be

answered by getting closer to them. Eating a small lunch of fish and merely wetting the lips with the little water which they had, they again started, Onrai carrying the native. They blew out the torch before starting, thinking it best not to attract attention with it.

The strong wind, too, which still blew from out the tunnel, would make it almost impossible to keep the torch lit. So they stumbled along in the darkness, feeling their way as best they could, but receiving frequent bumps, which bruised their bodies and exhausted their patience; but they kept the flickering lights in view.

The air was, for some reason or other, getting much cooler, and the explorers began to shudder, and hurry as they would, the exercise would not keep them warm. Every moment now the wind blew colder, and seemed to come from a direction to the right. The scant clothing, which had covered their bodies at the start, had mostly been torn away in the rough experiences which they had had, and their bodies were almost laid bare to this merciless cold. And the poor native had nothing on whatever, excepting a bandage, which bound his side.

They were nearing the lights very rapidly, and now dark forms could be seen moving about. But the cold had grown so intense, they doubted if they would be able to hold out until they reached the strangers. When these were reached what might they expect? Would they be antagonistic or friendly; they could not be a body of the tribe which they had already found, for the native now with them had never heard of such a cold region as this, and had never seen one of his tribe wearing clothing, and it would be an utter physical impossibility to remain here and not wear clothing.

But who were they then? It mattered little, for they must seek aid of them. So stumbling and falling, their benumbed flesh freezing to the bone, they hurried on as fast as they could. They had again clasped hands for fear of getting lost one from the other, and in this way one helped the other.

A horrible rumbling sound now broke on their ears, and grew louder as they advanced. They were getting closer and closer to the men, and far beyond them they could now see one bright ray of daylight. This spurred them on until completely exhausted, their bodies frozen and bleeding, they fell at the feet of the surprised torchbearers.

They had come to the cave of ice.

CHAPTER XXXIII.

AGAIN IN THE WORLD OF LIGHT.

The ice-cutters, for it were they, had never before in their lives been surprised. They saw coming out of that inky blackness, from far up that windy quarter, where none of their people had ever dared to go, a party of half-clad human beings, who staggered on as if intoxicated and, at last, falling at their feet. They hurriedly gathered about the fallen fugitives and throwing restoratives in their faces, tried to make out who they were and if they were any of their people, but these had been rolled about the floor of the windy cavern so long, that what with bruises and dirt, they were unrecognizable. Onrai, who still had enough life left to whisper a few words, motioned for one of the men to stoop; the man did so and started back with still greater surprise, as Onrai said:

“Hurry, get us out of here into the sun. Don’t you know me? I am Onrai.”

The man could not speak for a moment, but then, regaining his senses, said:

“It is Onrai, the King, and his guests; hurry or they will perish.”

In an instant those about them began to take from their bodies the warm garments and place them about the half-frozen bodies of our friends. Then, taking them in their strong arms, they hurried towards the entrance of the cave. This was soon reached, and in the villa just outside, the attendants were soon working hard with their benumbed and bruised bodies. They were first plunged in a bath of warm water and then rubbed down thoroughly; then their wounds were dressed, after which they were placed on comfortable couches and made to rest. The poor underground native was treated likewise, and a suit of the cool silk was thrown about his body after his wound was dressed. He could not understand why all this was being

done to him, but he could appreciate the delicate touches and the comfort which he was deriving from the treatment. Everything was strange to him; the peculiar white light of the sun, the green fields, the great shady trees, the high elephants, which he could see from his apartment stalking about the garden, and this grand house, to which he had been brought. And the food which they had given him was so different from the fish, which had always been his only diet; and the cooling honey wine, which they poured down his throat.

There was comfort in all this though and very shortly, his wound dressed and pain gone, his weary body soothed by the bath and treatment which the natives had given him, he fell asleep at last; his troubles ended, with no care on his wearied mind.

It had been early morning when our friends had emerged from the cave and after being thoroughly revived, they fell asleep and it was late in the evening before they awakened.

“Onrai,” said Harry, “will you ask one of the attendants what day this is?”

Onrai did so, and turned to him and said:

“We have been gone just six days, according to your method of measuring time.”

“Six days,” exclaimed they all in chorus, “impossible.”

“But then,” continued Mr. Bruce, “when we consider how far we have traveled, we can hardly expect that we have been gone less time than that.”

“Yes, it has been just six days,” said Onrai, “but remember where we were when we started and see where we are now. Why, our friends are three days march from us, that is, easy marches, but I think we can overtake them in two days by not taking too long rests.”

“But when shall we start?” asked Mr. Bruce, “our friends must be worried about us.”

“Just whenever you wish to,” answered Onrai, “to-night if you choose.”

“Why not to-night?” asked Harry, “we still have some hours left and going through the cool avenue at night would be grand.”

“Well, so it shall be,” said Onrai, “we will travel with elephants so that, if we get sleepy, we can rest in the howdahs.”

“And can I go with you?” asked the stranger.

“You can, my good man,” said Onrai. “Our friends would want to see and thank the one who has saved us; for if you had not helped us out that night, or day in the tunnel, we might have been wandering until now and on until death relieved us, in that awful hole.”

Elephants were brought and the party again took up their way. The elephants had been kept in an easy gait and had covered many miles and our friends hoped soon to reach the rest of the party.

“When shall we take up the journey again to the fields of diamonds, Onrai?” asked Mr. Bruce, as they rode along.

“Just as soon as you are all ready to start,” answered Onrai.

“And how far are we from the field,” asked Harry.

“Fully two hundred miles, as you would compute it,” answered Onrai.

“Then it will take us about ten days, will it not?” asked Harry.

“Yes, unless we make longer marches,” said Onrai, “and that is hardly necessary.”

“Not at all necessary,” answered Mr. Bruce, “and we can, by taking easy stages, better see the strange country through which we are passing.”

“Yes,” said Onrai, “and the scenery will be wilder and different in some respects.”

“Ten days to go and fourteen days to return,” said Harry. “That will take pretty near a month.”

“Yes, it will be fully that long before we return,” said Onrai, “and besides we will return by a different route, which will take us considerably longer. The new route will be over the regular macadamized roads, which, for many miles, are used very infrequently; but they are always kept in first-class repair, so that we will experience no discomforts for having left our onyx-floored avenue.”

“It is surely delightful riding over this perfect avenue,” said Mr. Graham, “everything though is delightful in this fair land. How different from that fearful country far down below us.”

“Probably only to us who know the difference,” said Onrai. “They may have their pleasures and comforts and hopes and Day of Resis. We know only what this man has taught us, and he has told us little.”

Again Onrai had mentioned The Day of Resis. What did it mean?

CHAPTER XXXIV.

AGAIN WITH FRIENDS.

The day came to a close; the stars came out and the cavalcade came nearer its destination. They had traveled now nearly twenty-four hours constantly, and if it were not for meeting their friends, they might wish that the journey would last as long again. It had been more than pleasant and was so restful, after the long tramp underground, that they appreciated it more for this reason. A little longer and they were in sight of the hole through which they had gone into the underground world. It was dark now and they could not see very far through the fields, but near where they thought the hole ought to be, there were lights flickering about. It seemed strange that there should be lights here at this time in the evening, for there was nothing to call them there.

“What do you suppose brings these lights here?” asked Mr. Bruce of Onrai.

“I can’t tell,” said Onrai, “but we will ascertain.”

He gave the leader of the caravan orders to turn into the field on the left and make for the lights. As they came nearer they could see that a number of men were standing about the hole, while others were lying about in the grass as if resting. Near by stood a group of women attendants and standing with them were Enola, Nellie, Mrs. Graham and Sedai. The parade of elephants seemed to attract their attention and they were now watching them closely and had even started to move toward them. The cavalcade stopped, the elephants fell on their haunches and our friends scrambled from their howdahs and ran towards the ladies.

“Oh,” they cried, as they, too, hurried towards the travelers.

Mrs. Graham threw herself into her husband's arms, Nellie fell on Harry's shoulder, and Enola? Well, she seemed for a moment to be puzzled, but then walked up very gracefully and placed both hands in Onrai's. Onrai, however, was not satisfied with this and pulling Enola toward him, he threw his great arms about her and pressed her to his heart.

"Are you glad to see me back again, Enola?" said he.

"Why, certainly, Onrai," said Enola, as soon as she could extricate herself from his arms, "more than glad, for we thought you were lost."

"We were," answered Onrai, "and the thought of perishing without again seeing you, nearly drove me mad."

"But did it not grieve you, too, to think that you would not again see your own people?" asked Enola, trying to call the conversation from herself.

"Yes," said Onrai, "but it was a different grief. My religion has taught me to expect that I will meet my people again in the next world, and this softened the pain caused by parting from them. But you," and here Onrai again clasped her in his arms, "I have just found you and learned to love you, with all that love, which has been kept locked in my heart for years waiting for you to come and break the locks which held it captive. It seemed my life had only commenced when I met you, Enola, and the thought that, at the very beginning of our happiness, I was to be taken from you forever, was maddening; and you, Enola, did you not grieve when you thought I was lost?" and Onrai asked this with all the simplicity of a child.

"Yes, Onrai," answered Enola, "I grieved for all of you."

"We found a strange people, Enola," said Mr. Bruce, "but their attractiveness lay only in their strangeness."

"What did you say, Mr. Bruce?" asked Enola, "a strange people in the bowels of the earth? It is hard for me to believe this. Are you not jesting?" and Enola seemed incredulous.

"No," said Onrai, "we fell in with a strange race of people down there, and it was they who detained us."

"Tell me all about them," said Enola, and she was all attention at once.

"Not now, Enola," said Mr. Bruce, "wait until we have reached the villa, and all are together, and we will give you a full account of our six days' jaunt in the Land, not of, but under On."

“I think,” said Mr. Graham, “this is the happiest moment of my life.”

“Why, my dear,” said Mrs. Graham, “I have often heard you make the same remark concerning the eventful time when you first met me.”

“Why, certainly, wife,” answered her husband, “that was the happiest moment which I had known even up to the present time, but now you see I am happier for having been brought out of a position where I never expected to see you again.”

“And was it as bad as that, father?” asked Nellie.

“Quite,” answered her father; “in fact, it was dollars to cents that we would never again see daylight, but it all goes to show how little we know of what will transpire in our little lives.”

“Yes, things looked pretty dark in every way,” said Harry. “In fact, we couldn’t see our hands before our eyes. And all chances for escape were equally dark and obscure. Where do you suppose we were, mother?”

“Why, somewhere down there in the bowels of the earth,” answered Mrs. Graham.

“Well, we were in the great cave, which so nearly cost us our lives.”

“Where did you come out of this wonderful place?” asked Enola, “I have not heard that yet; and here you have been back nearly twenty minutes.”

“Why, we came out in the ice cave,” said Harry.

“The ice cave,” exclaimed Enola, “and is this then a part of the great cavern?”

“All the same,” said Harry; “or no, not the same, but connected by a tunnel. But if we don’t reach the villa shortly, Mr. Bruce will have little to tell.”

They had now reached the grounds surrounding the villa, and after a short walk through these, they mounted the terrace, and taking seats, Mr. Bruce told the strange story.

CHAPTER XXXV.

A BLACK SURPRISE.

The party rose early the morning following the story of Mr. Bruce. All were happy now that they were together again and all were eager to take up the journey.

“What do you think about starting to-day?” said Mr. Bruce.

“I am perfectly willing, if the others are,” answered Onrai.

“We have been here now about eight days,” said Enola, “and the time has seemed long without you all, and the place has become lonesome. Why not start this morning?”

“Well, we will, if that is the way you look at it,” said Onrai.

“I would like to extend this journey much farther, if such a thing could be possible,” said Mr. Bruce, as they rode along.

“But why?” asked Onrai.

“Well, because it has been so full of pleasant surprises and adventures. It is these things which have made our stay in On a pleasant one, and we have found many of them on this journey and elsewhere.”

“It has been fruitful of these things,” said Onrai, “but even these might grow monotonous in time.”

“Yes, I suppose so, but I could not imagine so at this time,” said Mr. Bruce.

“To us, of course,” said Onrai, “none of the things in On are new; but the adventures under this land were of a very startling nature, and I would not care to have many like it.”

“It is not at all likely that you will ever experience another such a one,” said Mr. Graham.

"I cannot tell," said Onrai. "There is still a mystery to solve which worries me considerably."

"And what is that?" asked Mr. Graham.

"Have you forgotten the black woman and child which you found lying in the track of the storm?" asked Onrai.

"Oh," exclaimed Mr. Graham, "I had forgotten it for the time."

"It has puzzled me not a little, and I do not know now whether it be woman or beast, but if it be woman, where did she come from?"

"The storm comes from the heavens," said Mr. Bruce, "and could not the woman have been brought with it from one of the distant worlds?"

"Yes," said Onrai, "but why should she come to us dead?"

"The storm, in its great fury, killed her," said Mr. Bruce.

"I cannot understand why it should," said Onrai, "for it killed none in our world."

"No," said Mr. Bruce, "but you forget that it nearly killed Enola."

"No, I can never forget that," said Onrai, and he looked up quickly at Enola, as if afraid now, that she might not be with him.

"Hush, do not speak of unpleasant things to-day," said Enola. "We can put in our time to so much better advantage. See, is not the country beautiful hereabouts?"

"It grows wilder as we go farther and the scenes change very frequently. We can just see the great cliffs on the western side of On and they do not look so far away, do they? And we can hardly believe in looking at them that it would take ten days to reach them. And look, there is a column of smoke arising from them. What causes that?"

The men looked at the strange sight, but could give no answer. There was certainly a column of smoke ascending from what looked like the cliffs, but this might have been at a point far this side of them. Still the sight was very unusual, in fact, it was entirely unaccountable and it puzzled all the natives as well as the strangers.

"It could not be some of your people burning the debris left by the storm," said Mr. Bruce to Onrai.

"No, that smoke comes from far away," said Onrai, "but it would take a tremendous fire to cause smoke which could be seen from here."

“I should say,” said Mr. Graham, “that the smoke rose from the cliff and not from any point this side.”

“Yes, but what would make such a smoke at the cliffs?” asked Onrai.

“I cannot answer that,” said Mr. Graham, “But I think that you will find that I am right. Have you ever had any active volcanoes in your country?”

“I do not understand you,” said Onrai.

“You do not know the meaning of the word?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“No,” answered Onrai.

“Well, volcanoes, in our world,” said Mr. Bruce, “are mountains, through the sides of which great volumes of molten rocks and sand and earth come rushing and pouring.”

Onrai looked in astonishment at this, never having heard of such a thing before.

For the rest of the day nothing else was looked after or talked about but the column of smoke in the far northwest. In the evening, after the arrival at the villa in which the night was to be spent and after the party had been somewhat separated into little groups, Mr. Bruce found himself for the first time during the day, alone with Mr. Graham and immediately the conversation reverted to the column of smoke.

“What do you think of it, anyway?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“I think there can be but one answer to that question,” said Mr. Graham, “and that is that the column of smoke belongs to a volcano, that the volcano was the outcome of the earthquake and the first cause of the terrible storm.”

At this moment a song rose on the night air, which, for its brilliancy, eclipsed anything yet heard by the strangers, and immediately after Onrai came on to the terrace and stood with bowed head. Mr. Bruce and Mr. Graham watched him for a moment and then going up to him Mr. Bruce asked, “What is it, Onrai?”

“It is the song of joy,” answered Onrai, “of those who will participate in the chiefest ceremonies of the coming Day of Resis.”

The party had now been out nine days on this last stage of the journey, and to-morrow would bring them to the villa near the field of diamonds. The column of smoke had grown in size, and was much blacker at this point than when first seen. There was no longer any doubt about its coming from

the top of the cliffs, or else from a point directly back of them, and there was scarcely any further doubt about its coming from a volcano, for even at this distance, some thirty-five miles, as near as Mr. Bruce could calculate, a regular storm of flying cinders began to fall, covering them completely.

They watched the great volume of smoke anxiously, and as they came nearer to it, and as it grew larger and blacker, and as they could see no real cause for it, they began to regard it with superstitious awe. Nothing else could be talked about. The great belching cliff stood directly in their pathway, and the black smoke rose some thousands of feet above it. A great shower of ashes came rolling down on them, giving them all a grayish coat.

“If it is like this all the way it will be far from pleasant,” said Enola.

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “but think of the field of diamonds at the end of our journey; we could undergo much worse trials at home than this, to get to a field of diamonds, and think nothing of it.”

They were stumbling along now, almost blinded by the dust, and the zebras were getting fractious. At times they would stop, refusing to go further, and it would take all the persuasion the men could muster, to get them started again. But they were nearing the villa where they were to stop and still had hopes of reaching it. It lay very near to the field of diamonds, and would also be near the volcano, which the men had resolved to visit before returning.

It was awful work, though, this blindly stumbling along, only the solid pavement of the avenue letting them know that they had not lost their way. But a light loomed up in the darkness at last, and they decided this must be the villa, where some of the men working in this part of the country had taken refuge. They made for it as fast as possible, but as they came nearer to it the light grew brighter, until a flame shot up and they knew that it did not come from the villa. Slowly they approached it, having left the avenue and taken their way through the fields. They came closer, but suddenly all pulled up their steeds as of one accord. Ahead of them was a camp-fire, and about it, dancing and throwing their arms in the air, were a hundred naked black Africans.

The scene was a weird one, and the whole thing was such a complete surprise to our friends, that they could do nothing but stare in open-mouthed wonderment. The negroes were naked, with the exception of a cloth about the loins. There were but few women among them and these were seated

about the fire, while the men clasped hands and danced in a circle about them. The dance was wild and the yells, which broke from the large mouths of the men, were terrible. Their black bodies had been covered with oil of some kind and shone in the firelight like polished ebony. They were of average height, probably five feet five or six inches, and their bodies showed good feeding; they looked half intelligent.

Each one carried, slung over the back, a shield, made of some kind of hardened hide, and a spear with a long arrow-point made of bone; another strange instrument of war, or for the hunt, was a sort of stone hatchet with spear-point. This hatchet had a stone head or blade, with one side sharpened, and the butt end or side, running to a sharp point; the handle, which was about eighteen inches long, passed through the head and extended beyond this about six inches, ending in a point of bone as sharp as the point of a stiletto; to the other end of this handle was fastened a long piece of leather string, which was now wrapped around the handle.

All these things were taken in by our friends before the negroes seemed to see them, for they had stopped well back among the trees, and the negroes were making such a fearful noise with their hideous yells, they could not hear the rather quiet approach of the cavalcade. But when they caught sight of them at last, they stood as if paralyzed, and then moved up a little nearer, as if to get a better look and satisfy themselves that they were not mistaken. When they at last caught a good glimpse of the huge elephants and great zebras, all beautifully trapped, and the large men and women, they seemed suddenly overcome with fear, and turning, ran off into the darkness. Our friends would have pursued them but for Onrai, who said that such a move would be simply suicidal in such dust-laden darkness. They accordingly started for the avenue again and following this for a short distance further, saw another light, and coming up to this, found that their dusty ride was at an end.

The inside of the villa was a pleasant change to them after the dust-filled air of the outside, and the bath was first sought by all, and then the meal-table. There was no great mirth at this meal to-night, though, for the different scenes of the day and night, had had their effect, and all were thinking. The last adventure of all had clapped the climax. What could it mean? Where had the negroes come from, and how had they entered the Land of On?

That night the party was attacked by the negroes, but they were on the lookout and repelled them. About fifty of the negroes had been killed, or mortally wounded by the forty Onians, as nearly as Mr. Bruce could estimate, and there, were now about fifty of the black bodies fleeing over the rock-covered plain. They had dropped their assagais and hatchets in their fear, and their yells now was something pitiful. They evidently supposed that they were being followed by a whole army of the powerful men, which they had seen that evening. Fear lent them wings and they actually flew over the hard flooring of the plain, and were increasing the distance very perceptibly between themselves and their pursuers. Still the Onians kept up the race determinedly, their feet now being torn and bleeding with the tramp over the sharp pebbles of the plain. The stone wall bordering the hunting ground was reached, and a long hole was found in it, broken probably by the storm. The river was crossed by a stone bridge at this point and still they hurried on.

The light was getting brighter as they neared the volcano and the negroes could easily be seen away ahead of them. They were nearing the great cliffs and they could now be seen looming up far into the heavens. A little while longer and the negroes had disappeared. Our friends hurrying forward nearly fell into a great gulf which opened at their feet.

CHAPTER XXXVI.

CLEFT BY THE EARTHQUAKE.

Our friends pulled up just in time, or they would have gone tumbling into the black chasm. They moved back hurriedly, almost expecting to see the hole open still further and engulf them as it had the negroes, for they could make no other explanation of the negroes' disappearance. The light from the volcano made most objects discernable about this point, and our friends could look into the great gulf for some distance, but then the further view was lost in the darkness.

"What shall we do now," asked Onrai of Mr. Bruce. "We can no longer follow the negroes."

"No, this hole has swallowed them up," said Mr. Bruce, "but we cannot tell whether they have dropped to eternity, or have followed a path into its depth, of which they alone know. Has the chasm always been here?"

"I can remember no such crevice," said Onrai, "nor have I ever heard any of my people speak of it. I think it is another of the mysteries which seem to abound now," said Onrai, and his face seemed in the half-light to wear a very troubled look.

"These mysteries as you call them, Onrai, are only such to the uninitiated," said Mr. Bruce. "They are all understood by those who are acquainted with the great principles of nature. This crevice is undoubtedly caused by the earthquake, as this very often occurs during a disturbance of this kind."

"But these strange people," said Onrai. "Can you explain their presence?"

"If you cannot understand it, Onrai," said Mr. Bruce, "don't worry yourself in trying to, but look on those negroes as I have before told you to,

as wild beasts, and treat them as such if they should break down a portion of the retaining wall and intrude upon your inhabited country. These beings are human, of course, but they have never felt the quieting hand of civilization, and they are but little removed from the wild beasts which inhabit the forests.”

“Then we shall kill them all as we did those last night,” asked Onrai.

“Yes, as opportunity offers,” replied Mr. Bruce. “Listen; these people must never be allowed to gain a footing in your land, or the result might be your extermination. You must fight them from the first and never allow them to rest for a moment in your domain. You may lose many men in thus defending your country, but it is your only chance to retain it. So, imbue in your men the necessity of fighting with all their hearts, and souls, and might, and strength, for God and their country, and impress them with the fact that only in so doing can they ever expect to again enjoy those privileges and that great freedom which has always been theirs.”

“I will do this,” said Onrai, “but what shall we do now?”

“We must wait here,” said Mr. Bruce, “until daylight and see what we can make of the hole, and whether the negroes have been killed or have used it as a means of escape. We will also investigate the volcano while here. But you must send men back to the villa immediately, to bury those dead negroes before the women see them; and tell this body of men to inform the women that we will return in a day or two; that we started early to look into the volcano or would have bade them good-bye. Don’t, by any means, let them know of the fight of last night. Impress upon your men the necessity of secrecy; it would only worry the women unnecessarily if they knew that the negroes were making trouble.”

The other men now laid down on the hard ground, making themselves as comfortable as possible, to rest until morning, when they could explore the hole and the volcano. They had tramped nearly twelve miles during the night and were now well up against the cliffs. The black cloud of smoke was still being blown to the north, however, and they were saved the extra misery of the falling ashes.

At last the east began to show signs of returning day, and long before the sun had crept into the heavens, our friends were up and looking down the great crevice. They were surprised to see the strange formation of this hole in the ground. It had undoubtedly been made by the earthquake, and was

probably about ten feet broad at the top and narrowed in width as it went down, until it had reached a depth of two hundred feet, where it was only a narrow crack hardly six inches in width. But along one side had been left a natural foot path, about eighteen inches in width. This run up and down in a very irregular fashion and was narrower in some places than in others, but there was enough space at any point of it on which to walk, and it was this which had probably been followed by the negroes. They had known of this then, or they could never have found it in the darkness of night. Mr. Bruce and Mr. Graham followed the crevice for some distance, and then had returned and taking the footpath, had determined to follow it until they had learned what had become of the negroes.

They were accompanied by Harry and several of the Onians, Onrai remaining behind with the others. The footpath would bring them very near the surface at times, and again it would carry them so deep into the crevice, they could almost touch the opposite side by stretching out their hands. Taken on the whole, the chasm ascended with the foothills of the cliffs, or in other words, it kept a mean depth throughout its length until reaching the face of the cliff, where it ascended very rapidly, and upon looking up, our friends were not surprised to see the great cliff a thousand feet high, cleft as clean as if cut by a monstrous knife. And this cut was at straight as a die, our friends being able to see through it in a direct line a great distance. Still the footpath continued as it had commenced, along one side of the crevice. When once inside of the cliff the explorers could look up through the cavern, far above their heads and see the stars, for the crevice here was narrow and of such a depth, the light of the sun could not penetrate it.

“I think it would be better to return,” said Mr. Bruce, “we can only follow this path through the mountain and that is too great a journey for to-day, especially when we have had no breakfast.”

“I think as you do,” said Mr. Graham. “These negroes must certainly have escaped by this route, and it will be an easy matter to keep them from again entering the Land of On, for ten men could guard this pass against an army.”

They turned and retraced their steps and were soon with their companions again. They now turned their attention to the volcano. As the morning advanced and the wind changed, the smoke was again driven over them, and the ashes fell in great sheets about them. They had to cross the

crevice and tramp some distance to the north to reach the base of the cliff, over which towered the cloud of smoke. The question as to how they should cross the crevice was easily answered by their going to the end of it; which was a mile distant from where they now were. The whole party joined in this exploration tour, the attendants keeping their eyes open for any small game which might be induced, by some cause or other, to enter these bad lands. They were now in the Hunting Reserve, but the land here was so barren, and of such great extent, these animals would not come into it for any reason, unless it might be to cross it. Just at this time, too, it was made worse by a thick covering of ashes which had deluged everything. And the same shroud of ashes was now coming down in a blinding sheet, and was worse than it had been the night before, because of the heat which now went with them.

They were very near the belching crater now, and when the wind would change for a moment, blowing the cloud in a different direction, they could see the great black mass of smoke coming from the cliff, and bringing in its folds, very often, live coals of considerable size. The wind did not change very often, however, and most of the time our friends were engulfed in the awful dust and ashes, which at times were so thick, they were even hid from each other. But by perseverance, they reached the foot of the cliff right above which rose the volume of smoke. They stood here for a moment gazing up at the towering wall of rock, it being, at this point, fully two thousand feet high, and perpendicular, and wondered how they were going to scale its great height. They could not possibly do it; there was not even a foothold on the face of that rock wall, and our friends turned away disheartened.

They had hoped to find fissures or rents in the rock, caused by the earthquake, which might allow them to reach the summit; but their hopes in this direction were all shattered by that one glance up the palisade. It was now beyond noon and they had had nothing to eat that morning, and they were all beginning to feel desperately hungry. This, too, puzzled them, for they could not expect to find anything to eat here or anything to kill nearer than two miles, where the good lands began again. But something must be had, so three of the attendants were sent to the woods, two miles away, to procure, if possible, a deer or something light, which they might carry back with them, and which would be so palatable in their present condition of hunger.

They took up a position just at the base of the cliff, at a point where they were sheltered from the shower, and prepared to await the hunters.

“What do you think of our chances for reaching the summit of the cliff?” asked Mr. Graham of Mr. Bruce.

“Well, I should say they were bad,” answered Mr. Bruce.

“Bad,” said Harry, “well I should say so. There is no chance at all. That cliff rising above us is duplicated throughout the entire circumference of On.”

“So Onrai says, and it is true,” said Mr. Bruce.

“There is but little difference in the face of the cliffs,” said Onrai. “Those about here are seamed to a greater degree than those at other points, but one can just as easily scale those as any of the others.”

“That is not very encouraging,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I do not think you have taken into consideration the earthquake and the changes which it might have made. We have already found one place where the earthquake has split these mighty walls and I think we may find others. At any rate I will not give up trying to find a place where I can reach the summit.”

“I will follow the base of these cliffs for miles but what I find a place,” said Mr. Graham.

“You forget that the base of the cliffs lie, throughout their entire length, in the Hunting Reserve,” said Onrai, “and I do not think that they could be followed closely for ten miles, let alone their entire length.”

“True, I had forgotten that,” said Mr. Graham, and his face fell.

“It is only here,” continued Onrai, “that we can follow them at all, for the animals do not bother us here, and there is no underbrush to hamper us.”

The men talked on in this way until the hunters returned, two of them with a small deer, and the third with a bear cub. Their burdens were heavy and the trip had been quite long, but the prospect of the feast which would be theirs when they again reached their friends, buoyed them up and the party greeted them with cheers, and all fell to and cut the choicest parts of the deer and bear to roast; but one important thing had been forgotten. They were in a barren waste and not a sprig of wood could be found with which to make a fire. They were looking at each other in blank amazement, when a huge boulder flew through the air and fell in their midst.

CHAPTER XXXVII.

IN THE CRATER.

They jumped back in affright, as the great rock rushed through the air and half buried itself in the soft earth before them. They looked from one to the other, as if seeking an explanation of this new surprise, but none could answer. They could not suppose for a moment that the rock had been broken from the great cliff, for the surface of these was so smooth, nothing could come from this source. They looked above them, but the air was so full of the ashes and dust, they could not penetrate it over a hundred feet. They hurriedly moved away from such a dangerous position, taking the bear and deer with them.

“Where could this rock have come from?” asked Harry.

It puzzled them to answer this question, and they kept their gaze fastened on the cliff above, hoping to see the wind change for a moment, and the cloud of smoke blown from them long enough to see the top. After waiting for some time, the cloudy atmosphere did break for a moment, and far up, so high that they looked like pigmies on top of the cliff, they saw a number of negroes, their bodies half hanging over the edge.

“Ah! the mystery is solved,” exclaimed Mr. Bruce. “They are probably the same band which we drove from here last night.”

“Yes, and now we can feel assured that there is a way to reach the summit. Look out!” said Harry, as he saw the negroes start another large stone from the summit.

Down it came dangerously near to the party, and they decided to go back to the old position of the morning, for there they would be out of the way of these falling stones, and they could also drive back any of the negroes if they again tried to return. Back they trudged, taking a part of the deer and

bear meat with them, and upon reaching the old stand, and while looking around, they saw, not far away from them, a monstrous tree, which had probably been blown from the summit of the cliffs by the storm. A fire was soon built and the meat roasted and eaten, after which they laid down for a night's sleep, their day having profited them little but experiences which might do them some good in the near future. They had learned that there was a way to the summit of the cliff, and the finding of this way was to be the work of the morrow. The night was passed as comfortably as could be, on the fearfully hard bed of stone and earth, and early in the morning they were astir again, and after a meal of the roasted venison, they all started for the small pathway in the crevice.

They soon reached this, and falling into single file, with Mr. Bruce in the lead, they kept up the march for a couple of hours, when they were well into the heart of the cliff. No other footpath had yet been reached by which they could gain the summit.

"I think," said Mr. Bruce to Mr. Graham, who was following him, "that we will have to walk right through this mountain, and on to the end of the crevice, when we can turn and climb the cliff from the back, which I expect to find of easy ascent."

"I quite agree with you," said Mr. Graham. "It is quite certain that there could be no way of reaching the summit from this crevice; at least, not at this point."

"It has taken a powerful stirring up of the internal fires to cause this fearful crack," said Mr. Bruce.

"Yes," said Mr. Graham, "and that volcano looks as if it might throw out something more than dust and ashes very soon."

"That it will, and sooner than we will want it to," replied Mr. Bruce. "We are treading dangerous ground, and we cannot tell what moment we may be overtaken by a flow of molten lava, or a greater shower of ashes, such as buried Pompeii."

"But," said Mr. Graham, "if we stop to think of such things, we will not do a great deal of exploring."

"No," said Mr. Bruce, "but it is always best to bear these things in mind, and be ready at any moment to meet them as well as we can under the

circumstances. But I can scarcely see my way here. Were any torches brought along?"

"Yes, the attendants have torches," said Mr. Graham.

It was true; at this point the crevice was so deep one might think it was night, so dark had it grown. The torch was lighted, and Mr. Bruce, taking it, they all again took up the march. But from this point the path began to widen and ascend, until they were not only again in the sunlight but two could walk abreast, and a little further, and the path had widened until four and five men could walk abreast. The path ascended gradually, so gradually that it was not difficult to climb, and in a short while it ran out even with the surface.

This was a great and pleasant surprise to the explorers, for they had expected to have to tramp much farther before getting out of the hole. They looked about them and saw that they were on the side of a lofty mountain, the cliff opposite being but a precipitous side of the same mountain. This side was very fertile and wooded with great trees almost to its summit.

Below them lay a verdant valley stretching on and on as far as the eye could reach. Onrai looked on in wonderment at this unexpected sight. He had, and so had his people, been led to believe that the world ended at the cliffs, that beyond these was naught but space. He could not have told, had he been asked, how this land ended or how it must look to see no land or water beyond, nothing but that infinite space. It had never occurred to him to think of this himself, but if it had, he would have immediately banished the thought as being perfectly absurd. He had been told that the end was there, and that was enough; it couldn't be different, and as to how the end might look, that didn't matter at all. So this was a wonderful sight to him, all this land as far as he could see, covered with verdure and with occasional streams of water running through it. So much like his own fertile country, that he might have supposed that he had turned in some magical way on his tramp through the mountains, and was now looking upon that Land of On. If this picture, which stretched out before him, was real and not a dream, as he was almost led to believe, then what of those teachings which declared that their land was the only land, and that their people were the only people. The very foundation of this teaching was shaken when this idea was exploded. He turned and looked at his companions, and then at the

great landscape which opened out before him. The attendants were no less surprised at the strange scene, but none of them made any comments.

Turning and looking far up the mountain or volcano, they could now see a round cap at the summit, and out of this poured the fearful smoke. The wind was favorable for the ascent, for it was blowing the smoke over the Land of On, and they could climb without being hampered by the falling ashes.

“We are extremely lucky so far,” said Mr. Graham.

“Yes, and the ascent looks easy enough,” rejoined Mr. Bruce.

“It may prove otherwise before we reach the summit, though,” said Mr. Graham.

“Well,” said Mr. Bruce, “we must get at it, for we should get back to On to-day, if possible.”

“How different are the mountains on this side,” said Mr. Graham.

“They are different, yes,” said Mr. Bruce. “One would hardly suppose that beyond they are so precipitous. The whole Land of On must have been the immense crater of some mighty volcano, at some prehistoric period.”

“It is hard to tell,” said Mr. Graham. “In my estimation it has been at some remote age a vast inland sea.”

“Either explanation might fit,” said Mr. Bruce. “But let us start. We are losing valuable time.”

Turning toward Onrai they saw him still standing wrapped in deep thought, with the attendants standing near, also looking at that great expanse of field, forest, river and lake before them, with wondering faces.

“Come,” said Mr. Bruce, “we must start. From the summit you can get a better view both of this and your own country. And now we must hasten to reach that summit.”

“You do not seem surprised at the great expanse of land beyond the cliffs,” said Onrai to Mr. Bruce.

“No, I am not surprised,” replied Mr. Bruce, “because I knew that it existed before we ever came to you.”

“And you did not tell me?” inquired Onrai.

“And why should I tell you, Onrai,” asked Mr. Bruce. “Have you not a beautiful country with everything that heart could wish for? Were you not

happy there in your belief, and could the knowledge of the fallacy of the teachings which has helped to make you happy make you any happier? You would not have thanked me for such information and I would advise you now, as I have before, to try and forget that you have seen these things.”

“That I can never do,” said Onrai. “But they may never have any great impression on me, further than in making me disbelieve that part of the teachings which relates to the end of our world. I cannot believe that any longer, of course.”

“No,” said Mr. Bruce, “but you can refrain from speaking of it, and you can make it a punishable offense for any of these attendants, who have also witnessed these scenes, to ever speak of it; and in this way it will soon be forgotten, and the next generation will go on in blissful ignorance of the existence of the land beyond the cliff. It will be better, will it not?”

“I think so,” answered Onrai.

They were now ascending the mountain, the ascent for a way being very gradual, but as they proceeded further the ascent became steeper and more rugged. No trace of negroes were seen, but our friends knew that the negroes seen the day before on the summit, must be somewhere near. They had probably ascended the mountain in order to get a sight, if possible, of that land from which they had been driven, and in thus doing they had spied those who had driven them from it, and had immediately conceived the idea of hurling the great stones in their midst, and may be, by so doing, kill all, thus giving them an open sesame into the coveted country. They had villages near this point, according to Sedai, and if our friends should fall in with any of these tribes, there would very evidently be more bloodshed, for they were the intruders now and the African negro considers this a sacrilege. Nothing is so sacred to him as his country, and they will fight for this quicker than they will for their wives.

But nothing was seen of these, and no trace was found of a beaten path which might indicate that they lived as high as this on the mountain, or that they visited this altitude very frequently. The verdure grew thinner as they ascended, and great hunks of lava were now cropping through the surface soil. The cloud of smoke grew more ominous as they neared it, and looked like a huge umbrella spread, and with the handle resting on the summit of the mountain. The party were getting very close to the summit now, and low

rumblings could be heard far beneath the surface; hissing noises were also heard, like that made by water striking hot coals.

At last, after considerable tortuous climbing, they stood at the base of a rugged cliff, which was not more than a hundred feet in height; this was seamed and rough as if it had been thrown up hundreds and may be thousands of years before by an overflow of lava, which, upon cooling, had left this wall about the crater. Following about the base of this for some distance, a place was at last discerned where an ascent might be made, and after hard work and much slipping backward, and three or four narrow escapes from instant death by falling into one of the crevices, the summit was reached. The sight which here met their gaze was forboding, to say the least. They were standing on the top of a wall not more than ten feet thick at this point, and as near as they could guess about one and a half miles long, running about a deep hole or crater, one hundred feet deep. Looking down into this they could see the black smoke issuing from great crevices in the flooring. As it came from these crevices, it was lurid with the glow of the hot fires which was its cause. These crevices were numerous and in places our friends could almost look into them, and into the bright fires burning far beneath. After much discussion on the matter, it was determined to try and get down to the floor of this fiery hole which might so soon be filled with molten lava. A place was found where the descent could be made easily and the party started. As they descended, the foul smoke would be blown about them occasionally, almost choking them with its density, but the bottom was reached and they started to cross it in order to get to the opposite side, from which they could look into the Land of On. The flooring was found to be warm and really hot in places, and so crumbling beneath their feet that it was almost impossible to walk. Several of the great crevices were approached, but the smoke would drive them back before they could reach the edge and look into the depths. Most of these crevices were narrow and ran from east to west, but when the centre of the crater was reached a great hole was found, probably the true mouth of the crater. The rumbling here was very distinct and the hissing very plain. The party tried to reach the edge of this wall but was again fought off by the dense smoke. They had passed this and were nearer to the opposite side of the crater, when an unusual loud rumbling was heard and a great crack suddenly opened before them, the shock throwing them off their feet, prostrating them on the ground. Mr. Bruce fell so near this new crevice that his head leaned far over

the side, and for a moment it looked as if he would roll into the fearful hole. But he soon recovered himself, and rolling over and over he put a safe distance between himself and the crevice before he ventured to rise to his feet.

When they had all recovered from this surprise and fear and had again regained their feet, they approached the crevice and peered into its black depths. Down, down, down it seemed to open, into the very bowels of the earth, and at the bottom they could see a molten mass, boiling, and seething, and hissing, but just for a moment and then the scene was hidden by the black smoke which came pouring up from it.

“Come,” said Mr. Bruce, “we must get out of this.”

The party then hurried as fast as they could to the opposite side of the crater to where the wall was several hundred feet thick, ending on the opposite side in the cliff. A long look was taken at the beautiful Land of On and then the retreat was ordered. They now followed the top of the wall of the crater until they had come to the place where they had ascended this, and then, with but very little difficulty, reached the sloping side and hurriedly descended. It was growing late and already the sun was throwing long shadows over the mountain side.

They had several miles of the strange footpath to cover yet through the dark crevice. They began to feel anxious and hurried still faster as they neared the bottom. The sun sank into the distant valley as they reached the crevice. They were hurriedly following the side of this, looking for a beginning of the footpath, when they heard a loud yell as if from a hundred throats, and looking down they saw a great crowd of black demons holding the end of the footpath.

CHAPTER XXXVIII.

KILLED IN THE CREVICE.

The fearful yell startled them, and they fell back out of sight of the wild band.

"They have watched us ascend the mountain," said Mr. Bruce, "and have held this vantage point awaiting our return, knowing well that they had us here."

"Yes, but we can't stay here," said Mr. Graham.

"I am afraid that we will have to," said Mr. Bruce, "until these fellows will kindly consent to go away."

"But can't we beat them off?" said Harry.

"No. I think not," said Mr. Bruce. "We are about twenty-five, and they must number fully one hundred."

"We ought to be good for that number, I should think," said Mr. Graham.

"I don't know," said Mr. Bruce, "they may fight better in daylight. They were taken by surprise the other night, and had but little else to do but run. I am in for giving them a chance to show their fighting qualities at any rate. As you say, we can't stay here; if we do, we may be attacked by such a horde of these blacks that we could do nothing but surrender."

"Then we had better get to fighting at once," said Mr. Graham. "It will be better, perhaps, for us three to head the column, for with our fire-arms we may scare them away, leaving the road open to us."

"I think as you do in the matter," said Mr. Bruce.

Onrai was told then, to form his men into columns of threes and not to make a rush, or use the daggers until they were attacked by the negroes. The men formed, and Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce and Harry heading the column,

they started for the crevice. Here they saw the negroes, still waiting for them, their black faces grinning hideously in the semi-light. Slowly our friends advanced with their revolvers in position, ready to start at a given signal from Mr. Bruce. The negroes seemed to consider this a matter of amusement, for they only grinned the broader, and yelled the louder when they saw the queer column approaching them.

The party advanced until only a few feet from the negroes, who were so confident of capturing their enemies alive, they had not even brought with them the ugly-looking hatchet. They took no concern at the approaching column then, but looked on, as though the whole matter was a huge joke. So when Mr. Bruce said deliberately: "Now make ready, fire," and the three leaden missiles went on their mission of death, the negroes jumped backward, and several, losing their balance, fell into the ravine. Again the pistols were raised, and three more shots were fired.

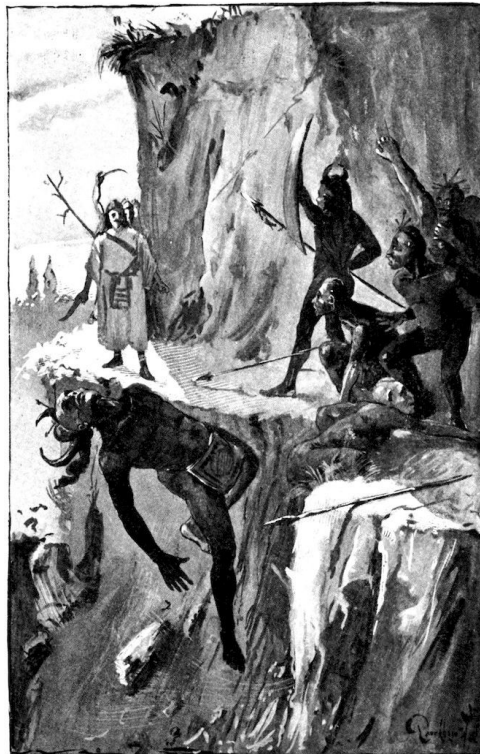
"We are disturbing them," said Mr. Bruce. "Once more, and we will have them on the run."

And again the pistols were fired, this time at very close range.

The expression on the negroes' faces had changed now, and they looked at the slowly approaching party with eyes almost standing on their cheeks, and mouths wide open, showing their white ivories. They stood still after the first shots, paralyzed with fear, but when the last shots were fired, and they saw three more of their companions topple over, their fright induced them to seek safety in flight, and they turned and ran down the footpath, crowding, shoving and jostling each other in their frantic efforts to get farther away from these death-dealing missiles, many of them being pushed off into the crevice in the wild rush. Our friends fell into line with Mr. Bruce again in the lead, and followed slowly after the negroes.

It was now quite dark and as they descended further into the ravine, it became so dark that they could no longer see the path, and a torch was lit. The negroes had long since passed out of sight and hearing, and our friends were giving them little heed, having enough to think about in looking after themselves, for they were in a very dangerous position, the pathway being so narrow at places, that a misstep would undoubtedly hurl them into eternity. They kept close to the side of the crevice and moved slowly, and the mountain was passed through without a mishap.

The light from the volcano now lit up the scene somewhat, and our friends began to congratulate each other on getting out of the several difficulties so easily, when a shout was heard, and looking through the semi-gloom they saw the negroes coming hastily toward them, and a band of Onians following them along the top of the crevice hurling stones at them. The party halted, and raising their arms fired, when the negroes came within range. The negroes stopped and in a moment realized that they were between two fires; but the pistols were too much for them, so they again turned and ran toward the Land of On. The Onians, seeing them do this, started for the end of the path to head them off. This they did, and one of their number, a mighty fellow, jumped into the path and with his dagger began plunging it into the backs of the unfortunate negroes who had again turned toward their own land. As one would receive his death-wound and would fall over the side of the crevice, this great Onian would stab another, and he kept this up until his arm was red to the shoulder with the blood of his victims.



“As one would receive his death-wound and would fall over the side of the crevice, this great Onian would stab another.”—Page [293](#).

The head of the column now came up within range of the pistols again, and they were shot down like sheep, the few who were not killed with the knife of the Onian. The slaughter did not last long, for in a short time the negroes were all killed and the bodies lay at the bottom of the crevice. It had been a onesided fight, for the negroes had not raised a hand to defend themselves.

The party were finally out of the crevice and found quite a number of Onians camped near the base of the cliff, and with them Enola. Their surprise was great when they saw her with the party, and upon asking her why she was here, she told them that she had gotten tired of remaining at the villa and as she had come to this land to see all that there was in it, she did not intend being cheated out of any part of it.

“Your departure was so unexpected,” she continued, “and the attendants had been so mysterious in their movements ever since, I began to fear that all was not right and came to see for myself. Are you not all glad to see me? But where have you been? Your faces and garments are as black as the skin of the negroes which have just been killed.”

It was true, they had been so long exposed to the smoke of the crater that they had become perfectly black, and it might have been this which made the negroes laugh so when they saw them approaching. They had seen the white skins before and they must have thought that it was a ruse to fool them, in thus blacking their faces.

“But Enola, this has been a long, hard tramp for you,” said Mr. Graham.

“Tramp, Uncle,” said Enola, “have you so soon forgotten the zebras and elephants? I came on a zebra.”

“Oh, that is so,” said Mr. Graham, “I had forgotten for the moment. You look tired though, nevertheless, Enola.”

“And I am tired,” said Enola. “It is quite a journey even on the back of a zebra. But I see little chance for a comfortable night’s rest here.”

“The only bed is this stony surface,” said Mr. Bruce, “but you surely cannot expect to stay here over night.”

“And why not, pray,” said Enola. “And am I better than are you? Did I not withstand the hardships of the jungle? I want to remain here to-night and to-morrow and see this crevice and more of these stony surroundings.”

“Very well,” said Mr. Graham, “I know there is no use in talking to you when you once get a notion in your head; but you will find this the hardest bed you ever slept upon.”

“Don’t worry about me, Uncle, I will get along all right, but I brought you all something to eat and you had better get at it.”

“I will forgive you now for having come,” said Mr. Graham, “for I, as well as the rest of us, am just about starved.”

“I am glad that you look on my sin as pardonable,” laughed Enola, “but, believe me, bringing food was a secondary thought. I came only to see the strange things in this part of the world, and when about to start, thought that, as I was coming here, I might as well bring this food with me.”

“I know you too well to believe any such story,” said Mr. Graham.

The attendants had now gotten their meal ready and a hungry party it was who sat down to it. They had eaten nothing since morning and their fatigue of the day but added to their hunger.

“What are we to do to-morrow,” asked Mr. Graham, as they all sat down on rocks which had been placed for them, holding their platters of food in their laps.

“I know of no reason why we should remain here any longer,” said Mr. Bruce. “I think the negroes are done for, for awhile at least. This band, which has been entering the land of On, are wiped out; they cannot return and there is hardly a chance now of other bands or tribes knowing of the new passage-way through the cliff.”

“But it is only a matter of time until they will know it,” said Mr. Graham.

“True,” said Mr. Bruce, “but before that time the crevice might be filled and the Land of On made impregnable again.”

They all looked up in astonishment at this.

“Do you think this possible?” asked Onrai.

“Possible, yes,” said Mr. Bruce. “It would be a stupendous work and would take a long time to carry it out, but it can be done, and this fair land will be forever free from intruders, unless of course some such like occurrence as the one, which has made this fissure in the rock, should cause a like one.”

“Then you would commence on this work immediately?” asked Onrai.

“Just as soon as possible,” said Mr. Bruce, “but the sooner you do it the less chance there will be for invasion.”

“It shall be done,” answered Onrai.

The party, after the meal, stood up in groups and it was but natural that Enola and Onrai should be together. They walked to a point well up toward the cliff, and seating themselves on a large rock, Onrai again told Enola of his great love and of his intention of making her his wife on the Day of Resis. But when she asked him why he had chosen the Day of Resis for their wedding day, he made her no answer.

Onrai sent messengers throughout the country and to the city, for men to build this wall across the crevice. He sent for all of the available men in On, ordering all other branches of work to stop for the time being.

“It will take a considerable body of men to do the work,” said Mr. Bruce. “But more than a wall must be constructed. The crevice at the face of the cliff must be at least three thousand feet deep, and this has to be filled for considerable distance to get a safe foundation for the wall. It will take many men and most of them will have to work from the crater of the volcano, casting large rocks into the crevice from the first, until it is filled up as high as the shelf or footpath, from which point I think it would be well to commence the solid masonry.”

“But if this work goes on and is finished before we leave, chances are against us ever again reaching civilization,” said Mr. Graham.

“That is true,” replied Mr. Bruce, “for we have seen enough of the rock-bound country to know that the cliffs cannot be scaled. It would be an utter impossibility to get out by that way, and we would have to resort to a balloon.”

“You have suggested a way which is always available,” said Mr. Graham. “The silk of this country is especially adapted to this purpose, I should say, and the other materials can be had easy enough. And these people could raise no objections to our building such a conveyance, even if they objected to our leaving them, and we would be up and away before they could possibly know what we were about. So we need not worry about the means of escape.”

“The volcano is throwing off more rock and ashes than ever, to-day,” said Mr. Bruce, as he glanced up at the ominous cloud of smoke.

“Yes, and there seems to be a new element this morning,” said Mr. Graham. “Look at that white vapor. Would you not say that that was steam?”

“It looks like it,” said Mr. Bruce.

“If it is,” said Mr. Graham, “it will but hasten the coming eruption.”

“The eruption is not far off, anyway,” said Mr. Bruce, “for the lava is already near the surface, as was shown by its running through the crack of the tunnel to-day.”

“This alone will be well worth the trip,” said Mr. Graham; “but we must be well out of the way before it takes place.”

“I think we will be safe at the villa,” said Mr. Bruce.

As he ceased speaking, the earth trembled beneath their feet, and, looking at the volcano, they saw a huge mass of red-hot cinders and smoke shoot high in the air.

CHAPTER XXXIX.

THE FIELD OF DIAMONDS.

The rumbling was heard fully five minutes before the shock came, and our friends had stopped when it had first reached their ears, wondering what could make such a noise. It was all explained, however, when the earth trembled beneath them, nearly throwing them from their feet. Thoughts of the volcano immediately rushed into their minds, and they turned just in time to see a great mass of stone, rock and molten lava mixed with steam and smoke, shoot into the air. It rose to a height of nearly a thousand feet above the mountain, and then fell back into the yawning abyss from which it sprang. Then came another shock and another discharge of rock and ashes, and another and another in such rapid succession that our friends were afraid to move for fear of being thrown flat on the ground.

The air was black with ashes, and smoke, and dust, and a vapor seemed to be rising from the ground, which, with the rest, nearly suffocated them. From where our friends now were, they could not see the crevice in the cliff, but they could see the summit of the mountains, and saw huge rocks tumbling from the top and rolling over the edge, being lost to view in the thick atmosphere as they descended.

“We must get out of this,” said Mr. Bruce, “for that volcano may belch forth a stream of lava which will take but a few moments to reach us.”

“Do you think it would flow this way?” asked Mr. Graham. “The opposite side of the mountain would give it a freer channel, I think.”

“It is impossible to tell,” said Mr. Bruce. “The whole side of the cliff might open up and let the lava flow into this slope, entirely unobstructed. These volcanoes change their craters and channels so frequently, there is no telling from what direction the lava will come, or which way it will go.”

“It is quieter now,” said Mr. Graham, “and as we cannot be far from the villa, we had better try and reach it.”

Everybody at this started again and were groping along in the dust-filled atmosphere, when they saw, right ahead of them, the bridge. It took them only a minute to cross this and to get through the break in the wall, and to reach the villa and get into its cool and ash-free atmosphere. It was certainly a great relief for these weary, hungry and dust-besmeared travelers to enjoy once more the delights of a bath, and the splendid cuisine of the villa. They were tired out, and had inhaled the thick atmosphere so long, that their lungs had become almost raw, while their eyes were nearly closed, being swollen and sore. But a bath and several applications of sweet honey and wine had made them feel like new persons, and after the evening meal was over, they all declared that such delights as On could offer, were all the more welcome and could be better appreciated after a few days separation from them.

The evening was spent on the terrace, the wind having again shifted, leaving the atmosphere free from the dust and ashes. The column of smoke was very bright to-night, the fire seeming to be nearer the surface, lighting up the great black mass as it poured forth from the crater. In fact at this distance it cast its light, making objects at some distance, quite perceptible. But our friends were surprised to see to what depth the ground about the villa and all the barren waste had been covered by the ashes and dust. Fully one foot of this lay over the surface of the country for miles around. The beautiful lawn here was no more, and the large fields adjoining the villa, which had been used as a pasture for the zebras and cattle were now made useless by the volcano. But this extended only a mile beyond the villa, so said the attendants who had arrived that evening, bringing fresh provisions and ice. This being so, the zebras, cattle and elephants, would be able to find pasturage close at hand, and they were taken there immediately as they were already suffering for food.

But the depth of ashes destroyed the beauty of everything about here; the green lawn, the beautiful trees, all bore the same dull, gray appearance. There was but little enthusiasm then shown by the party on this night, as they walked on to the terrace. The volcano attracted all the attention with its lurid glare, mass of smoke and bright red rocks, which were thrown into the air at times.

“I am afraid we have forgotten our object in coming here,” said Enola to Onrai, as they came on to the terrace.

“No,” said Onrai, “I have not forgotten, but I am afraid the brilliants have met the same fate as all else about here. They are buried beneath the ashes of the volcano.”

“What a pity!” said Enola. “We have thus lost one of the most beautiful sights of On.”

“I am afraid so,” continued Onrai. “But wait, let me think. The field of brilliants extends far to the north, if I remember rightly, and we may reach a point beyond this circle of ashes; but you are too tired to go over there tonight, are you not, Enola?”

“How far is it?” asked Enola. “I am tired, but if there be a chance of seeing this beautiful sight, then we had better accept it, for a delay may mean to lose this pleasure, for the possibilities of that volcano are beyond reckoning.”

“It is about three miles due north of here, as you would say,” said Onrai, “and if you wish to go we will find elephants plenty to carry all of us.”

“But we will have no moonlight to enhance the beauty of the brilliants,” said Enola.

“No,” said Onrai, “but we have the light from the volcano, and this may have a grander effect.”

“That is true,” said Enola, “let us go immediately.”

Onrai gave the order, and several elephants were soon standing in front of the terrace, awaiting the pleasure of the party. The other ladies also decided to go, not having been out of the villa since their arrival, and the men jumped at the chance, surprised to think that there might be a field of these diamonds still uncovered by the ashes.

The elephants followed a road, or path rather, which led almost due north for a distance of three or four miles. The easy motion of the elephants had most of the tired party asleep before the point was reached, and they were awakened from their sleep when the elephants stopped. They were entirely unprepared for the beautiful sight which met their gaze. As far as they could see to the north, the ground was strewn with brilliant sparks of light, looking up from its black surface, like bright eyes from a dusky face. The

red glare of the volcano made the scene all the more beautiful, in bringing out so many varied lights from the diamonds.

“How far are we from the volcano?” asked Mr. Graham.

“Only about a mile farther from it than we are when at the villa, I should judge,” said Mr. Bruce.

“And is the land here as barren as it is at the villa,” asked Mrs. Graham, of Onrai, as he came up.

“Quite,” answered Onrai, “and the field which you see here is but a continuation of the field directly back of the villa. We were just too late, or we might have had this scene closer at hand.”

“It is indeed too bad,” said Mr. Graham, “but it has lost none of its beauty by having the volcano’s light thrown on it.”

Mr. Bruce here stooped and picked up one of the twinkling stars; it was about the size of a hen’s egg and almost the same shape; rough on all sides but one, this being polished to a brightness which was hard to account for.

“Can you account for this smooth side,” asked Mr. Graham, as he walked up to Mr. Bruce with another diamond very much like the one he had picked up.

“I have been trying to solve the riddle,” replied Mr. Bruce, “and can only offer one solution of the mystery. These stones probably have been thrown from the bowels of the earth by the last eruption of the volcano. How many years, or thousands of years ago this has been, we cannot say, but since that time a part of these diamonds have been exposed to the storms and all kinds of weather. These have gradually polished the stones until they have reached this state of smoothness. You will notice that the polished side is somewhat flatter than the others, and as this side is always turned upward, I think these things but emphasize my theory.”

“I can only interpose one objection to your theory,” said Mr. Graham, “and that is, that diamonds are so hard that it is a question as to whether the wear of the elements would affect them at all.”

“The dropping of water for long has washed away great cliffs, has bored holes in monstrous rocks, and why should diamonds alone be proof against this influence?” argued Mr. Bruce.

“I do not say that they are,” replied Mr. Graham, “and I am willing to accept your explanation for the want of a better one.”

“They are diamonds, I think, without a doubt,” said Mr. Bruce.

“If they are not,” said Mr. Graham, “then we have discovered a jewel, the brilliancy of which is superior to that of diamonds, and there lies about us fortunes,—thousands of fortunes.”

“But fortunes which will never benefit the civilized peoples,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Probably not,” said Mr. Graham, “unless it be ourselves, for I shall surely not leave here without a generous supply of these beautiful gems,” and he and Mr. Bruce proceeded to each gather a bag full of the precious stones, the ladies doing likewise.

At this point Onrai came up and Mr. Bruce asked: “Onrai, do you not use these stones for aught else than for the sling-shots, and ornaments, and decorations?”

“Yes,” answered Onrai. “We find here a peculiar brilliant, which the direct participants in the ceremonies of the Day of Resis wear as an emblem,” and the King here remounted, and the remainder of the party doing so, they started toward the villa in silence, our friends thinking what fortunes they carried in the little bags at their waists, and what immense sensations they would create when these stones were brought before the world.

Two weeks had now elapsed since the night of the visit to the field of diamonds, and our friends were still at the villa near the volcano. This had remained about as active as it had on the night in mention, and our friends had stayed on to see the development of the eruption.

At times the earth would tremble slightly, and at such times the volcano would always become more active. The fall of ashes had become much less in this part of the surrounding country, but this was due to the wind which had blown steadily from the northeast, carrying the cloud of smoke over the country beyond the cliff.

Onrai was daily expecting the arrival of his army of subjects to perform his bidding.

At the end of two weeks, after an exciting day hunting the jungles of this strange new land, the party one day approached the villa, and saw encamped about it thousands of men, elephants and zebras.

CHAPTER XL.

THE CAMP OF THE ONIANS.

Yes, there were thousands of these. The great field on the opposite side of the avenue was completely filled with them and their animals. Tents of beautiful colors spread over the plain, their peculiar shape suggesting scenes of the Orient. These tents were large and roomy, one side being half turned back so as to admit plenty of air; the floor was covered with soft, skin rugs, and in the centre was a small, round table of wood, on which was resting a lamp.

As our friends approached, the scene was so strange and novel, they thought they had never before seen anything quite so interesting. The glare of the volcano half lighted the level plain giving a reddish glow to everything within its rays, and the lights inside the tents throwing out the varied colors of the beautiful cloth, made these tents look like huge, Japanese lanterns. The ashes had been removed from the floor of each tent and piled up at one side, thus giving a clean floor for the rugs and small mattresses which were used for sleeping on.

As our party came up the whole body of men, who had been informed of the King's approach, drew up in front of the camp in a line along the avenue, and waited for him to say something to them.

"My men," said the King, "you are called here on a mission which had never before fallen to the lot of Onians. A great storm has visited On and has left as a legacy of its mighty strength, a great crack in the wall which surrounds our world. This must not remain so, for it is meant that we should be guarded by the wall, and consequently we must close up the trench. It will be a mighty undertaking, the great wall about the hunting reserve being nothing in comparison to it. It will require a great length of time to do this work and you who have come to do this, will have to remain here at the

same work until it is finished, as it will be impossible to go from here each day and take up other duties. We are a great distance from the city, and it will not be possible for you to return frequently, but this you shall do as often as you decide upon among yourselves. To-morrow we will move to the pit where the great work is to be done, and after finishing all preliminary arrangements we will commence at once.

“This is to protect our good country and I know the work will be done well and quickly. Until to-morrow, then, I will bid you farewell.”

The men bowed in their stately way and the King and his party moved on to the villa.

The volcano seemed to be especially active to-night, the smoke not being as black, but more steam seemed to be mixed with it. The fires, too, seemed to be very active, for the glare would be very bright at times and illuminate the entire heavens, and then dying until scarcely a ray of light could be seen. And several times during the evening a low rumbling was heard, and the earth trembled slightly; then the volcano would throw forth an immense shower of hot ashes, rocks and stones and make the hissing noise, reaching over this great distance to the party at the villa, who were on the terrace watching the scene which was ever changing and ever interesting.

“It is more fitful to-night than ever,” said Mr. Bruce, to Mr. Graham.

“Yes,” said Mr. Graham, “and I think we are foolish in staying so close to this seething mass of lava, rock and ashes which may overflow its bounds and engulf us at any moment.”

“But we are far enough away to escape if we should be threatened,” said Mr. Bruce.

“So the Pompeiians and even those of Herculaneum thought, as they laughed and jested on, while old Vesuvius was preparing to bury them,” said Mr. Graham.

“Then you think we had better leave this place?” asked Mr. Bruce, convinced himself that they were playing with fire by remaining here.

“I do most assuredly,” replied Mr. Graham, “but I hate to do so, for this sight is grand and one which we may never see again.”

“Would it not be well to conduct the ladies to some villa at a safe distance and then return and see the thing out. I confess it has a strange

fascination for me, and I would like to see the grand climax,” said Mr. Bruce.

“That may be a long time coming,” said Mr. Graham, “for these things are very uncertain.”

“That is true,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I have a strange premonition or something, whatever you might call it, that this grand finale will come very soon.”

“If it does,” said Mr. Graham, “and catches us here we are doomed.”

Onrai and Enola then came up and turning to the King, Mr. Bruce said: “Aren’t you a little hasty in sending your men to work on that dreadful volcano?”

“I may be,” said Onrai, “but I have taken your advice in the matter.”

“I did give you such advice,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I did not think at the time that the volcano would assume such a lively attitude. You may be interested in knowing, Onrai, that that great seething mass of ashes and melted rock, may overflow its confines at any time and destroy every man in this party, if he were near enough to it.”

As Mr. Bruce finished speaking, an unusually severe shock was felt, and great showers of red-hot coals were driven high into the air, and then, falling back into the crater, all was dark for a moment, after which the volcano assumed the same appearance as it had ever in its quieter moments, for the last twenty-four hours.

“I do not think it is advisable to send the men to the mountain just yet,” said Mr. Bruce. “We will want them.”

The party remained on the terrace until far into the night, witnessing the weird sight. The volcano might be said to be in a state of eruption now, but not a violent state of eruption.

“It is certainly throwing off enough matter to be considered in a state of eruption,” said Mr. Graham, as he and Mr. Bruce were about to retire for the night. “But if it grows no worse than this, we are safe.”

“But it will get worse,” said Mr. Bruce.

But, notwithstanding this prediction, on the following morning when the party arose and looked at the volcano, the first thing that had been their wont to do ever since being here, they were surprised to see only a thin

column of smoke rising from the volcano. The black cloud had entirely disappeared and a vaporous volume now rising might be taken for that coming from a camp fire, so small and insignificant was it. Mr. Graham and Mr. Bruce looked in astonishment at this new freak in the rather prolific volcano, and were unable to offer any explanations.

“It is beyond explaining, I think,” said Mr. Graham, after the two had stood for a long time contemplating the now almost lifeless volcano.

“It is more than I expected, at any rate,” said Mr. Bruce, a little slowly, as he remembered his last words of the night before.

“You were not alone in your belief of yesterday,” said Mr. Graham, “for we all expected to see a mighty eruption.”

“It is better as it is, probably,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I am disappointed. If it remains as tranquil as this another twenty-four hours, I shall make another visit to its crater and see if it is really as quiet as it looks.”

“And I will go with you,” said Mr. Graham.

So the day wore on and night came and went and another day broke fresh, beautiful and sunshiny, and the volcano was as quiet as on the morning previous.

“What do you think of the volcano, to-day?” asked Onrai of Mr. Bruce. “Will it be advisable for me to start the men to work?”

“I think you can send them to the volcano to-day with perfect safety,” said Mr. Bruce. “The danger is past, I think, for the present, but may not be for good, for the volcano, now that it has again broken out, may become active frequently.”

“Enough,” said Onrai, “I will get the men in readiness, for they can work but a week at this time, as they will have to return to the city to celebrate the Day of Resis. All are required to be there on that day. During this week they can get well started, and upon their return they can begin where they left off. Would you like to accompany me?”

“With pleasure,” added they all in chorus, and together they started for the camp on the other side of the avenue.

The men had been up for sometime, the morning meal had been eaten and the remains cleared away, and they were now awaiting orders from the King. The party crossed the avenue and immediately upon the word being sent around the camp that the King was with them, all were attention and

awaiting orders. One of the men, who seemed to have command, came forward and received orders from the King to get in readiness at once, and proceed to the cliff to begin operations. It took but a moment for the word to be sent flying around the camp, and in an instant, almost, the tents were lowered, rolled up and placed upon the backs of the zebras and elephants, and the men in line to start.

“If these men are as practical in their fighting as they are in this kind of work, what an army they would make,” said Harry, who had spent five years in one of the crack regiments of the O. N. G., and thought he understood the art of breaking camp.

“These men could be made regular fighting machines,” said Mr. Bruce. “Did you see how they fought on the nights when the negroes tried to make the attack on the villa? They stood like statues until the hot breath of the negroes were in their faces, and then their arms rose and fell like automatons, and each stroke killed its man. I never saw a cooler piece of business in my life.”

“Their great ability in this direction is to be wasted though, if such an ability can be wasted,” said Harry; “for with the crevice closed again, they will never have a chance to try their powers in this direction against invaders.”

“No,” said Mr. Bruce, “but it is far better as it is.”

The men had now fallen into line, none of them riding, for only the pack animals were to be taken. In a column of tens they started on their march over the bad lands toward the crevice. There were fully five thousand of these, and they made a most imposing sight as they marched in perfect order, each man having slung over his shoulder, his cross-bow, and in his belt, his dagger and ax. These equipments had been brought along for two reasons; they might have to fight off the negroes, and then they had to make hunting tours to get meat for the camp. In perfect step, this army of giants moved toward the cliffs. They had gone several miles, when, looming up before them, they saw an immense body of negroes, speared and hatcheted, and ready for the fray.

CHAPTER XLI.

THE SLAUGHTER.

The leader of the large body stopped short and those in the rear craned their necks to see what had caused the sudden halt; but they could see nothing, for it was only the leaders, who had just reached the top of a slight eminence, who could see the large body of negroes, standing with shields in place and spears in hand as if expecting the Onians. The men looked again and could hardly believe their eyes. No, they could not be mistaken; there they were; an array of black, grinning devils, brandishing their spears, or pounding their shields with them.

Onrai and his friends, who had been riding in the rear, hurried forward when the column stopped, to see what was the matter. It took them sometime to do this, but when they arrived at the head of the column and saw from their high position on the elephants' backs, the great body of negroes facing them and only half a mile distant, their surprise knew no bounds. The Onians looked at the King and his white companions, as if wondering if they had been led to this point by a lie, to fight these black animals, for none of them realized that these black, shiny-skinned and nude beings were human. But why should the King lie to them? They were perfectly willing to come here on any mission for the King, and it was not necessary to get them here by a ruse.

Again that superstitious fear of the whites took possession of them, and their faces began to assume that startled look as if afraid that some unknown calamity was about to overtake them. They kept their eyes on the whites as they advanced and consulted with the King. Why were they talking in such low tones? Why did they not address the men and explain this new mystery? Not a word had passed between the Onians, but the same

fear seemed to take possession of them at the same time, and they looked from one to the other and knew that the same thoughts had come to all.

Mr. Bruce looked over the men and noticed that hunted look in their faces, and he knew that immediate action must be taken or they would be lost; that these men, crazed for the moment by a superstitious fear, might turn on them first and, getting them out of the way, turn and flee from the strange enemy.

“Onrai,” said Mr. Bruce, as he rode up hastily beside the King, “Quick, don’t lose a moment, but order the pack animals to the rear. The men are becoming demoralized and need immediate action or all is lost. The old suspicion in regard to us has again taken possession of them and they may turn on us at any moment. It matters little about us, but the negroes must be driven back. Give your orders.”

Onrai turned to the men and he too, saw that dread look on their faces.

“Men,” said he, almost beside himself with fear of the consequences if he should lose control of them; “men, yonder horde of black demons are here to take your country, to take your lives, but worse, to take your wives, mothers, brothers and sisters. They are here to destroy our land, to devastate our fields of grain and fruit, to steal and kill our animals, to destroy our beautiful city and the many villas throughout our land. They know no law, they have no religion, they care nothing for the lives of others. They will kill us or drive us from our own land, into a distant world where we will starve and die. Will you not fight for country, home, loved ones and for the right? These demons have come through the crevice which we were this day to commence closing, and they must be driven back. If we do not drive them back, killing as many as is in our power in doing so, then will they force us to travel that path which leads from our old Land of On, and which, when once followed, can never be retraced. Come, Onians, quickly; shall it be those black beasts who shall leave On, or ourselves?”

The men looked at each other in astonishment. They could not realize at first that such a state of affairs could possibly exist, as there being the remotest possibility of their being driven from this land, which was theirs by right of inheritance and possession. The truth began to dawn on them, though, as Onrai continued speaking, and when he had finished, a low rumbling sound was heard, like the first faint sound of the approaching earthquake, but like this it grew in volume, until it broke in a mighty shout,

and the men were Onrai's, to do with as he wished. Only let them drive from the beautiful land of On the hated beasts which faced them, waiting the end of the parley.

Onrai understood that shout, although he had never heard it before as a shout of consent, he had heard it frequently as one of approbation, when he or others of the land would perform some particularly hard feat in athletics, or show great heroism in the hunt. It simply meant that they were pleased with what he said, and they were anxious to get at the fray.

"I will give you orders at first," said Onrai, "but you must obey those of my companions when they give them. They have had invaders in their land and have learned to repulse them, and drive them back. Do as they command you and we will be victorious. Are you ready?"

Again that shout.

"Then get the pack animals to the rear quickly."

Without a word the elephants were driven to the rear, and the men awaited further orders.

"Mr. Bruce," said Mr. Graham, "we think you are better capable of handling these men and we will act as your subordinates."

"I accept the commission," replied Mr. Bruce, "not because I feel myself superior to yourself or Harry, but because some one must act at once. We will divide our men into three battalions and march in line of battle. Harry, you will take the right. Mr. Graham, you will take the left and I will take the centre. If the negroes, as I expect them to do, charge straight for the centre, you will each close in on their flanks; but if you see the centre giving way, rush for that point at once for we must hold the position. Now we will divide our men."

They divided the men into three battalions and formed them into the line of battle, explaining to them, in the meantime, that they must hold fast together, and not allow the negroes to break their line. The men went about the different manœuvres like old soldiers, when they once saw through them.

The line now drew up and Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce and Harry, each in front of his battalion, mounted on elephants, with Onrai riding next to Mr. Bruce in the centre, they marched slowly toward the negroes. Every man had his cross-bow in position and arrows ready for use. The formidable

hatchet and daggers were in the belts handy, and where they could be gotten at the most easily. The negroes' faces had lost the grin, and the yells had ceased for the moment as they saw the array of giants advancing. They had never before, in all their many wars, stood before such a formidable body of men, and their courage was failing them. But they had a chief, a wild, barbarous fellow, who knew not what fear was, and seeing that cowardly look stealing over the faces of his men, he jumped before them and racing up and down in front of the line, halloed and yelled, pounding his spear on the shield, and in this way worked the men into such a state of bravery, which was only equaled by his own.

Then again facing the army, which was moving silently toward them, he gave a few words of command, and with a yell and a rush, they came tearing toward the Onians.

"Halt!" thundered Mr. Bruce. "Stand fast and do not let them force your line."

And the black demons came, never stopping until within range, when Mr. Bruce, giving command, a volley of arrows poured into the negroes and nearly the entire front line of these fell. This checked the negroes but rallying in a moment they again charged, and before the Onians could raise their bows, the negroes had raised their spears and hurled them at their enemy. The volley made most frightful havoc with the front rank, and the Onians fell back for a moment, for the first time in their lives seeing a body of their men killed in this way. They looked at the dead and wounded, not knowing what to think of this fearful slaughter, and again the strange fear began to creep over them.

"On, men, do not stop!" commanded Onrai, seeing them falter, "or they will kill you all. Don't you see they have killed your comrades? Avenge them!"

And the men, looking up, and seeing the black demons on them, and fearing the same fate which had met their companions, made a rush, and with the daggers uplifted, on they went at the blacks, meeting them with a crash as they came forward, and hurling them back by their superior weight. Then began a most fearful slaughter. The Onians, remembering the death of their companions, became as Bruce had said they would, regular fighting machines. Even he and his subordinates were swept on by the irresistible ranks from the rear as they pushed their companions forward. Perfect order

was kept, however, and those in the front ranks wielded the dagger with fearful force and alacrity. The negroes, overpowered, and almost crazed with fear at the slaughter going on among their people, forgot all about fighting or even defending themselves.

The one great desire to escape these fearful daggers took complete possession of them; they turned on their countrymen who were crowding them forward, and using their hatchets, fists or feet, they walked, ran, rolled or crowded over these, trying to get out of reach of those muscular arms which were now as bloody as the knives they wielded, but stained with the blood of the negroes. At last they broke into a run and started for the crevice, which was a good four or five miles distant. The Onians needed no orders now, but rushed wildly after the fleeing negroes. The negroes being light of limb, however, and probably used to such rough fields as this, gained on the Onians and were some distance ahead, when, looking ahead of them they saw another band marching toward them. This proved to be a reinforcement, and the chief of the routed band, after haranguing his tribe for a moment, prevailed on them to turn, and with the reinforcement again give the giants battle.

The flying Onians were again brought to a halt by Mr. Bruce, and formed in regular line of battle. The remaining negroes also formed in line of battle and advanced, as nearly as could be judged, almost in equal numbers to the Onians. Their chief was again running up and down in front of the line crying, and soon had the men worked up into another fiendish frenzy. Mr. Bruce halted his men, determined to wait for the negroes. The negroes came tearing forward until within a few feet of the Onians, when the latter again raised their cross-bows and sent a volley of arrows into the front ranks of the negroes. But the negroes were expecting them now, and turned the arrows aside with their shields, scarcely a dozen having fallen. They did not stop, but kept up the mad rush until within twenty-five feet of the Onians, when they stopped suddenly and their right arms shooting out quickly the fearful, sharp, spear-pointed hatchets, flew toward the Onians, and striking the unprotected bodies of the giants, passed clear through them. Then, with a sudden jerk of the wrist, the hatchet was wrenched from the gaping wound, and pulled back to the negro by the leather string which was attached to the handle of the hatchet. Then again would the deadly weapon be hurled, and again buried in the breast of a fresh victim; and again and again, the whole fearful thing being done so quickly that the weapon could

scarcely be seen flying through the air. The slaughter was worse than had been that of the negroes by the knives of the Onians. The horribly lacerated bodies were being piled up high on the ground, but the brave Onians still stood perfectly helpless in front of those merciless hatchets.

Mr. Bruce was nonplussed for a moment. This style of warfare was so new to him and so horrible, he could but look and wonder at the horrible ingenuity of the weapons.

“Send a volley of arrows into them,” cried the King, who seemed to come to his senses first.

The men mechanically raised their bows, but before they could spring them, the deadly hatchets struck them full in the chests or bodies, and torn and bleeding, with a hole clean through them, in which an arm could have been shoved, they fell headlong over the bodies of their companions, who had met the same miserable fate. The situation was becoming desperate. Men who had shown such bravery, and who could on equal terms annihilate the army before them, were beginning to quail before that fearful onslaught, and were unconsciously probably, falling back. Still that fearful, never-ceasing charge of flying hatchets. Slowly the men fell back, but the movement was becoming quicker each moment. In a few minutes more they would be in a run, and all would be lost.

Mr. Bruce was growing desperate, as he saw this grand army being demoralized by one which was so inferior in every respect. Riding down the line with the huge elephant, which was pierced by the hatchets as he passed before them, he called to the men to take courage and rally once more. Onrai, too, rode before them, and by every word he knew, tried to imbue them with new courage. But he understood how these poor men, who had been kept in ignorance their whole lives, of the existence of other races, and the art of fighting, could not understand why this awful slaughter should be, or who these demons could be who were mowing them down by hundreds. The horrible dread was taking possession of them again, and Onrai and his companions saw this.

“Men of On,” said Onrai, in despair, “these devils will not only kill you and your companions, but they will kill your wives, sisters and brothers; they will throw down your houses, they will destroy the land. Brave men of On, who turn not from the lion, tiger or elephant, do not let these black beasts show themselves the greater. Turn on them, cut them, chop them,

beat them, hammer their foul bodies into the earth, slash them until not a piece large enough is left to feed a jackal. On to them.”

Mr. Bruce had given Harry and Mr. Graham orders to close in with their battalions, as soon as Onrai could again encourage the men to advance, and show no mercy; to ride into the black ranks with the elephants, and crush them beneath their feet. Accordingly, when Onrai had ceased speaking, and had turned and had himself led the way into the black ranks, the men went with a rush, notwithstanding that hundreds of them dropped in the advance. Harry and Mr. Graham closed in on their flanks, and were slowly surrounding the now emboldened blacks.

Still they plied the frightful weapons, and scores of the Onians were dropping. It was a fearful advance, but the men were sticking to it bravely; but there were great chances against their ever overcoming this hellish tribe, with their fiendish weapons. The Onians were again losing ground, they could not withstand that awful massacre.

But what is this coming up in the rear? The earth trembles as with another earthquake, but there is no rumbling with it now. The men looked back. Ah, yes, it is Sedai mounted on Gip, and with a hundred immense elephants back of him, all being hurried on by their riders. Quickly the elephants come forward, their swinging gait turning their bodies from side to side, the earth trembling with each fall of their huge feet. Straight for the blacks they made the ranks of the Onians breaking away to allow them to pass. The blacks look and see the awful enemy coming straight for them, on which their murderous hatchets could have no effect. They hurled once more the hatchets at the Onians, and pulling these back, dropped them at their sides, and tried by flight to escape the crushing feet of the elephants. But the elephants rushed into their midst, not only killing with their fearful feet but using their trunks and tusks as well, slaying and crushing as they went. Now the Onians made a charge, and clutching their daggers in one hand and the hatchets in the other, done as Onrai had told them to do, and hacked and chopped, and cut and beat and pounded the enemy, their faces and arms being covered with the blood, but still showing no mercy; they were for the time merciless brutes. They had fallen on to the flanks of the negroes, and such was their fearful onslaught, and so fast were these hacked and mutilated bodies piled up, that it looked as if the awful carnage would

not cease, until every black carcass was heaped up in one fearful mass of reeking and quivering flesh.

But a low, rumbling sound is heard, which grows louder and louder, and comes nearer and nearer. It is another earthquake. The Onians stop for a moment in their awful massacre, and in this one moment the remainder of the black horde turn and make for the crevice. The earth was shaking fearfully though and the men could hardly keep their feet. On they staggered, until the Onians, finally realizing that the blacks were escaping them, made a rush after them. But the earth still trembled and it was suddenly growing dark. What was wrong with the volcano? A huge mass of stones and smoke came forth in a rush in a greater volume than it had at any time before, and great showers of rock and ashes were pouring from its hellish mouth. On the negroes ran, and on the Onians sped after them. The negroes had now reached the crevice, and were fighting for a foothold on the ledge. Some of them were successful, but most of them were forced over the side, falling into the yawning abyss below. The Onians were about to dash after them, when a fearful, deafening report was heard, and looking up to the volcano, they saw a mighty mass of molten lava thrown far into the heavens, and then dropping back into the crater, overflow the wall of this, and fall in a great stream into the crevice. Our friends, spellbound, watched the sight, while the immense flow of lava rolled over the sides of the mountain, and into the crevice, filling up that great hole. It was running in a monstrous flow, easily five hundred feet wide, and twenty feet deep, as near as our friends could calculate. It came pouring through the crevice, well up toward the party, and they started back, in alarm; but it gained on them, and to make it worse, a terrible shower of hot ashes and water was pouring down on them. They were blinded and gasping for breath, turned toward the villa. They were being burned and scalded, their feet becoming blistered; they could not see, they could not breathe.

CHAPTER XLII.

BURIED ALIVE.

And so they stumbled blindly on, blindly, for they could not open their eyes because of the fearful dust and ashes. The thick cloud of dust and ashes came forth in a mighty avalanche, burying the land and filling the air with its death-dealing particles; making such a darkness as could be felt; a close, suffocating darkness more like the blackness of an unventilated dungeon than the open darkness of night; a darkness which was penetrated only by the mighty light of the belching volcano, the light varying with every phase of the eruption; now a lurid glare which gave the dust-covered earth the appearance of a blood-stained floor; again it would change to a blue which would almost equal the soft rays of the moon; then it would die away to a faint green, casting a death-like glow over all.

And the fearful rumbling continued and far down in the bowels of the earth, could be heard that great lake or river of molten rock and ore, rushing to the outlet which would free it; and the earth would tremble with the fearful fight of the mass as it surged and burned and crushed its way through its underground channels. Then again could be heard the hissing and blowing off of the steam as it escaped from the crevice in the crater.

About the fleeing army fell the hot ashes and steam. They had made a wild rush toward the villa when the first shower had struck them, and they were still hurrying as fast as their bleeding feet could carry them. They had covered miles, and this was wonderful when it was considered, that the ashes had fallen almost to the depth of a foot; and each step that they took they would sink into the hot, ragged substance which would burn and blister their feet, protected only by sandals. And their progress would be suddenly checked now and then, by great fragments of rock, having been hurled by the awful power of the volcano, falling directly in their path, perhaps

crushing one of the poor Onians beneath its weight. Then in their blindness they would rush into each other, knocking each other down, and burnt and bleeding, and almost smothered by the fearful dust, they could hardly regain their feet. But hurry as they would their progress was growing slower each moment and they were not getting out of the fearful shower of dust and ashes. This seemed to grow worse as they advanced, and the survivors, who were still left to suffer on, were fast giving out.

It looked as if they could not possibly survive the terrible struggle, this unequal fight with the forces of the earth's interior. The atmosphere would clear for a moment, and the lurid glare of the volcano would again light up the scene, giving a momentary hope which would be killed again by a heavier downpour of ashes and dust. Then the struggle would recommence; a silent struggle, for no sound was made by these helpless creatures, as they fought on, gasping for breath, reeling in their weakness, falling now; but putting forth another great effort and standing erect once more they would stumble ahead again and so on, until, strength exhausted, they would fall for the last time, the shower of ashes and dust soon choking their last breath, and burying the burned and bleeding bodies beneath their awful folds. But these Onians were more than ordinary men, they had more vital life in their bodies, they were strong to the last muscle; their every sinew was developed and health and exercise made them powerful, and so they kept up the struggle longer than would our friends had they been on foot. But they had been mounted on great elephants during the battle. They at first mounted them upon leaving the camp in the morning, expecting only to accompany the men to their scene of labor when they would return. So when the negroes were met, and they saw that a battle was inevitable, they remained mounted so as to better conduct the fight.

At first it had been suggested that they should ride zebras, but it was decided to take the elephants, as they would stand the hard journey over the bad lands better. And it had been a lucky decision on their part, for now they were saved the fearful fight with that hot shower of ashes, which not only filled the air, making it almost impossible to breathe, but which also made a bed which was nearly impossible to walk over or through, as the bed had grown to such a depth, that it was nothing more than wading, Sedai had been foremost, in the charge of the elephants into the negro band, and had gotten far ahead of his friends, reaching the volcano even before some of the negroes had. When he saw that awful sea of lava pouring over the

side of the crevice, he had turned and motioned his comrades to follow, and had made Gip understand that he must travel as he had never traveled before. The intelligent animal seemed to understand, and hurried on, too, by the heat and burning ashes as they fell on his back, he started on a run which would have soon brought them safely to the villa, if the air and road had not been obstructed by the miserable ashes.

But the elephants, all of which had followed Gip, were, too, experiencing the torture of the awful cloud and shower, and they had stumbled many times, over the rocks and in the soft bed which was getting deeper each moment. The elephants had kept close together though, and had in this way, kept trodden a very good path. Our friends could see, during the few intervals when the cloudy atmosphere would break and the light of the volcano penetrate this, the poor Onians stumbling along in the darkness and scorching cinders. They had called to them to keep up courage, but it was needless advice to these men, for they would not give up until the last moment.

They had tried to get the elephants to kneel, and take on their backs, as many as they could carry; but the animals, crazed by pain and fear, dashed on, often crushing beneath their feet, those whom their riders would save. And so the elephants rushed on and as the light would break through the awful blackness, the riders could see that the number of poor pedestrians was growing less and less, until at last, none were seen. They had all succumbed to the overpowering cloud of ashes, and their bodies now strewn the ground, which but a few hours before they had passed over, strong in healthful life; and of the five thousand who had started on the march that morning not one was left; all, all had met their fate. Some by the deadly hatchets of the negroes, others by the fearful downpour of hot cinders.

The Land of On had met its first great catastrophe; it had for the first time in his history, experienced some of those adversities, which had so frequently befallen the other countries of the world. But our friends were still alive. Onrai, Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce, Harry and Sedai, were being borne through the blackness by the elephants. Their throats were parched, even their lungs seemed burning up with the great heated shower of ashes, which they had been compelled to breathe so long. Their eyes were almost swollen shut, their faces and bodies were covered with blisters where the

cruel, hot cinders had struck them. Even they, who had not been exposed wholly to the storm, and who had been spared the awful struggle of limping through the hot bed of cinders, even they began to despair of ever getting out of this radius of dust and ashes.

And the elephants were now beginning to stumble and sway from side to side, growing weaker and weaker with the terrible exertion, their strength being sapped by the plungings into the ash-bed, which was now beyond their knees. They would rock from side to side striking each other, but, again bracing up, try it once more. The position of our friends was becoming unsafe, as the elephants were liable to fall at any moment and crush them beneath their huge bodies; but it meant sure death to leave their backs, so expecting death to overtake them each moment, either from the burning air which was scorching their very lungs, or beneath the prostrate animals which were now struggling so bravely to save them. They were hurrying on, but where? Only to death. Again there was a fearful rumbling, the very bowels of the earth seeming to be disjointed and ground to fragments. It grew louder and louder; it almost deafened the sounds of hissing steam and ashes which fell around the little group, and the sucking sound caused by the sinking in and pulling out of the feet of the fast-failing animals.

Finally the earth began to shake and the exhausted elephants, unable to withstand this new enemy, fell to their knees and then flat on their sides. The men had strength enough left to jump and save themselves from being crushed, but they were forced nearly to the hips into the ashes, and they could not extricate themselves. Then this was the last, this was the end of the happy sojourn in the Land of On. No, it could not be, they must not die here in this miserable way and be buried by the never-ceasing shower; they must struggle on.

“Up,” said Mr. Bruce to his elephant, as the rumbling ceased and the earth again became steady. “Once more, now,” he halloed out as he reached forward and struck the poor beast across the ear with his hook. But the elephant, after making several ineffectual struggles, gave a plaintive cry and let its head drop into the relentless ashes. As in a quicksand, the five men stood perfectly helpless, and their lives fast going out. The elephants had, one by one, given up the struggle, and were now panting and gasping and waiting for the end. They seemed to realize that they were doomed and the

plaintive cry would break from their gasping throats, as if asking aid of those whom they had tried to save, but all were powerless. Hope was fast failing them. They could not possibly last much longer, but what mattered it whether they went now, or lived to suffer for a few moments longer. There was no power on earth that could save them now, and they must look death square in the face. It seemed hard surely, to die so near to friends, and life and sunshine, for they knew that this death-dealing shower could not extend many miles unless it be worse than was that other.

They knew that the dear ones were safe in the villa, for, though they were in the radius of the shower, they were sheltered from this, and the flow of lava had not run toward the villa, or they would have seen it. It was some consolation then to know, that if they must die, these dear ones at least were safe. But what will become of them alone in this strange land? They would have to entrust themselves wholly to the people, who had once looked upon them with superstitious fear, and who might again, after this dreadful catastrophe, turn on them, and having no longer any one to protect them, or having no defense to offer as they had before, destroy them. It was not pleasant to think thus as the awful ashes continued to pile up around them, burying them alive.

The pain which this thought gave them of possible danger to their loved ones, was worse than the physical tortures which they were now suffering, and they turned and wrenched their bodies in their living graves, in very agony of mind. And Onrai, too, seemed to be suffering more than bodily pain. If his thoughts could have been read, they probably would have told the story of baffled hopes, and of the death of aspirations which the love for Enola had kindled in him. It was harder for him to die thus than for any of the others, for he had been so strong and mighty, and his life was full of such bright hopes, and he had so much to live for, but it was ended. All, all was lost.

But may be not, thought Mr. Bruce, for Gip, who had laid for a moment perfectly quiet, had now begun to again exert his awful strength and was twisting and plunging about, as if to make a place on which he could stand. He accomplished this finally and rose to his feet. He had had a short rest from the fearful struggles of the flight, and he could again commence the fight. Sedai, who was near him, caught the howdah as he rose and was lifted out of the ashes. He then made Gip understand that he was to help the

others, and one by one the great elephant, lifted by his trunk, raised them to his back. Then starting in the direction, which they had kept since starting on the awful ride, the great beast fought on; they had been moving thus for several moments, when he suddenly stopped and refused to move further. Just then the sky became light for the moment, and a zebra was seen lying in their path, and lying beneath it, the body of Enola.

CHAPTER XLIII.

LOST.

But what of those who had been left behind? What had been their fate, and how had they spent those dreadful hours, when they could but reasonably expect that their companions, who had left them only that morning alive with hope and health, had met the most miserable death? The morning had been beautiful, and all had gone to see the striking of the tents and breaking of camp, and they had followed the marching army for some distance over the bad lands; but at the earnest request of the men they had at last turned and gone back to the villa. They had noticed the continued inactivity of the volcano and had hoped, woman fashion, that the worst might be over, and their spirits had been, accordingly, bright.

But the long morning hours grew tiresome, and the women became restless, and could find no way to pass the weary time. They spent a while on the terrace, but the garden had lost all its beauty by the shower of ashes. They ate their luncheon mechanically at midday and then tried to sleep awhile, but made a sad failure of this, and at last, not knowing what else to do, they had ordered their zebras and started for a ride down the avenue. It was not long before they were well beyond the radius of falling ashes, and it was a great relief to them to see green fields and shady trees again, and the beautiful smooth pavement of the avenue. They rode for a long distance, forgetting, in their pleasure, that they were getting a long way from the villa. But the sun was so bright here, and everything so fresh and green, and the air so pure, they dreaded returning to the rather doubtful atmosphere of the villa.

But they must turn now, for the sun was getting well down toward the west, and what is that? The question was easily answered, for they had become quite accustomed to the rumbling sound of the earthquakes. Still it

startled them, and they urged their beasts forward. The sound grew nearer, and then the earth began to shake so violently the zebras tottered and almost fell. And then another awful shock came, and the zebras became frightened, and, taking the soft bit between their teeth, they tore down the avenue. Then the awful explosion came like the report of a thousand cannons, and the riders saw the awful spout of dust, ashes, steam, smoke, pouring from the volcano, and almost immediately afterward they were engulfed in that fearful black atmosphere which choked and blinded them.

The zebras stopped so suddenly that their riders almost lost their seats, but by kind words, and by gently patting them, they were persuaded to proceed carefully. Here the avenue was plain to see, and there was little fear of losing the way, but the ashes were falling with such force and such volume, the roadway was fast becoming blocked. Still the zebras were light-footed, and their riders had hopes of their being able to reach the villa. But the borders of the avenue continued in that unbroken line of trees, and the surrounding country was so much alike, it was hard to tell just where to turn off to the villa. The thought had occurred to Enola that they might be carried by this, and on and on until the beasts, overcome, would sink to the ground, leaving the riders to their fate. It was impossible to see anything, excepting now and then, when the light of the volcano would break through the awful gloom for a moment. Even then the air was so thick with the cinders and dust, they could not penetrate it more than a few feet.

And so they plodded along, each moment the gloom becoming more dense and the avenue pavement harder for the zebras to traverse. They must certainly have reached the villa by this time, but for all they could see, they might still be ten miles from it. They could not place any dependence on the zebras, for they were too badly scared to act rationally; besides their senses of smell and sight were entirely lost in this stifling atmosphere.

The situation was becoming desperate, but there was positively nothing to do but ride on with the forlorn hope of riding beyond the circle of the shower. But if they could not reach the villa, why not turn and ride back to the green fields and open country again? Aye, why not. The thought had occurred to Enola, and the more she thought of it, the more feasible the idea seemed to be, and at last it occurred to her that this might be their only chance of escape. Waiting until the volcano's light broke through the gloom for a moment, she motioned to her friends to follow her, and after a moment

she managed to turn her zebra's head, and when this was done, and they had gotten started in the opposite direction, they seemed to have the wind at their backs and they could ride with a little more comfort. But the darkness was intense now, for night had closed in, and if possible, had added to the Egyptian blackness. The riders could only see each other at very infrequent intervals when the volcano's light would, for a moment, melt the gloom and give the almost exhausted women a moment's respite.

They were moving very slowly, the ashes getting so thick over the avenue pavements, that the zebras found it almost impossible to further beat their way through it. But one of the infrequent light spells now allowed them to look about again, and Enola saw that they had left the avenue. On an ordinary dark night this could have been easily detected by the sound of the zebras' hoofs, but now the grass sod and the hard onyx pavement were the same; they were both lost beneath the carpet of ashes. This new aspect of things did not please our friends. They were being overcome very rapidly by the thick atmosphere; it was killing them by inches. They could scarcely breathe any longer; every breath was like the stab of a stiletto, the sharp particles of the ashes had penetrated and cut the soft membranes of the throat and lungs, and then that steamy air, upon touching the raw flesh would cause the most acute pain. Their hands and faces were blistered, and their eyes seemed to be burning out of their heads.

Enola and Nellie stood it better than Mrs. Graham. She had almost fallen from her zebra several times, and Nellie and Enola were now trying to ride on either side of her, to save her from falling, if possible. But it was growing worse each moment, and hope was nearly dead. They were staggering along in the darkness, the zebras every now and then stumbling up against a tree, and nearly rubbing their riders from their backs. They felt satisfied that they had lost their way, and if this was so, and they could not again reach the avenue, then, indeed, might all hope be abandoned. Black as Erebus, the air was not only laden with the death-dealing ashes, but was so hot and humid, that no living thing could withstand it for any length of time.

It seemed an age since that first awful rumbling of the earth, and this fearful darkness overtook them; it seemed that night ought to have given way to day and the day to night again. So acute was their pain, so fearful the darkness, so quiet all else but the rumbling of the earth and the hissing

of the steam in the volcano, that time itself seemed to stand still waiting for the hellish scene to pass. In such a moment one could imagine that a lifetime had been passed, and if youthful features should be changed to those of old age in such a night of suffering, it would not seem strange, for in those few short hours more suffering is crowded than in many years of ordinary life, and when it is all over with, one cannot realize that this could be in such a short space of time. Then these women were fast losing consciousness; their brains were in a whirl; they could no longer think; they had almost grown insensible to their pain; their eyes no longer tried to penetrate the darkness about them; they no longer tried to guide the zebras as they had done heretofore, notwithstanding that the zebras were more likely to know the right path than themselves. They still clung to the mane and rein and tried hard to retain their seats on the backs of the zebras, but they did this mechanically and not because they were guided by any spirit of self-protection.

They had now become separated too, and each of the zebra was trying to pick out a path for itself. But it was dreadful, for the zebras were now also wandering on from a mere sense of habit, and not because they had any longer any hope of escaping. Their heads dropped until their noses almost touched the ash-covered ground. Their eyelids seemed frozen in a cramped position over the eyes and the balls of their eyes looked out like pieces of glass which had been rubbed with sand paper. There was no longer any sight in those eyes; there could not be after being exposed to the beating ashes and dust as long as they had. The legs of the poor beasts were raw to the knees, but still they plodded through the ashes which must have set them crazy with pain, if they too had not lost all sense of pain.

Such dreadful sufferings could not help but make one helplessly mad. It was a hell, an awful, reason-destroying hell, but a merciful hell in a way, for although it lacerated the poor, tortured bodies of its victims, it at the same time destroyed all consciousness of their suffering. So like poor, undying spirits in a helpless state of painless suffering, if such a thing could be, the zebras wandered on, bearing the almost lifeless bodies of the women.

Suddenly Enola half roused herself and opened her swollen eyes. Only for a moment, however, for they soon closed again and she lapsed into that comatose state, and then had dropped to the zebra's neck as before. But

again the eyes half opened and this time she showed signs of returning consciousness.

But the eyes closed again for a moment and then she starts as if having been struck; no, she had not been mistaken, there it was, a light burning through the darkness. Could she call for help? Her throat was dry and parched; she had not tried to make a sound in hours, days it seemed to her, but she must try now; so opening the baked lips she made an effort, but it was useless. She could not articulate. But the zebras were moving slowly toward the light and they might see her yet. It must be the villa and they were safe at last. She turned to point the light out to her companions, but they are gone. She looked again, for just at that moment, the flash of light broke through the gloom. But no, her companions were no longer with her. Had they found their way to a place of safety and had she been lost in the darkness, or had they been lost? She tried to remember when she last saw them, but she could not. She had a faint recollection of their having all been together sometime during this awful night, or, was it night? She could not say. It might have been years ago, so indefinite had grown the flight of time. She again turned toward the light; yes, it was still there, and then she tried to turn the head of her zebra towards the spot. Her arm was stiff and she could hardly move, but she managed to slap the zebra on the side of the neck, but he did not turn. He still wandered on in that aimless way, seeming to heed nothing.

Oh, this was fearful. She tried again and again but the only response the poor beast made, was to drop dead in his tracks. She felt him giving way under her and made a last effort to save herself, but too late; the beast caught her limbs as he fell and half burying her in the soft ashes, held her fast. She tried hard and wrenched the tender limbs until torn and bleeding, but to no purpose; she was held as secure as if tied to the side of the beast. She was too exhausted to make much of an effort, and the little she had made, had caused her to lose consciousness for the moment.

The moments flew by but all unknown to the poor, insensible girl and death seemed inevitable. There was no hope now, there could be none, unless it came from where that mocking light still gleamed through the darkness. But it would have been as helpful to the dying woman had it been ten miles away. It was better then, that the poor wanderer should never

again wake to consciousness, for she would be saved the helpless suffering caused by knowing that she was near help and yet was beyond it.

The ashes still fell in torrents, the humid air was growing more intolerable each moment with the hot steam and dust, and the blackness had grown more intense. Yes, it could be felt, and here in the midst of all its hellish night, lay Enola dying.

But no, what is that huge mass which has almost tramped on her, but which stops just in time? It is Gip.



She tried hard and wrenched her limbs until torn and bleeding, but to no purpose.

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CHAPTER XLIV.

OUT OF THE ASHES.

Yes it was Gip. Great, strong and faithful Gip. The only surviving animal of all that vast number which had started on that fateful morning for the cliffs. His great strength had enabled him to overcome all dangers and obstacles thus far, and on his back he bore the few whom he had saved. And his almost human intelligence, coupled with his animal sagacity, had enabled him to direct his course straight for the villa, through the almost impenetrable atmosphere and fearful darkness.

Each moment the riders had expected to see him overcome by these obstacles, but he stumbled on, going down on his knees at times, when he would become too exhausted to move another step; but after resting for a moment, he would struggle to his feet again and make another effort. He was almost blind; he must be for he had been exposed for so many hours to this cyclone of ashes. But he could still see a little, or else he would not have stopped when he was about to crush out the little remaining life left in Enola. Or, was it that animal instinct that made him realize that he was about to tread on a human being? But the light from the volcano which now half lit up the weird scene, must have enabled him to see the prostrate zebra and Enola, for he had only stood for a moment, when he lowered his monstrous trunk and catching the zebra firmly about the neck, lifted him completely from off Enola and laid it at one side. Then he caught up Enola as tenderly as a mother would lift her babe, and raised her to his back, where Onrai, who seemed to be the only one who had retained consciousness, took her in his arms, and after patting the noble beast gently on the end of his trunk to make him understand that he appreciated this last noble deed of his, he settled back in the crowded howdah and also lost consciousness.

Gip stood for a moment longer and looked about him. Yes, he must have seen, for his head turned until it was in range with the light seen by Enola, and then he starts towards it. The light grew larger as he drew nearer to it, and he was finally stopped by the terrace of the villa. He had only hesitated for a moment, however, and then had mounted the few steps and crossed the terrace to the high arched doorway of the villa. Over this had been drawn a silk covering, to keep out, as much as possible, the ashes and dust. Gip did not stop for this, however, but pushed right through it. Two or three frightened attendants saw the great beast enter with its burden of unconscious human beings, and hurrying up to it they stood for a moment, while Gip kneeled for those whom he had so bravely rescued, to step from his back. He was weak and almost exhausted; his great body heaved with a short quick respiration, which the heated air and over-exertion had caused. His back was covered with a thick coating of the ashes, and those who were lying or sitting in the howdah were almost buried in this awful death-dealing substance.

But Gip could no longer keep the tiring position, and giving a last short pant, he fell over on his side.

Those in the howdah were thrown upon the hard stone flooring and laid there in a heap. The attendants now recognizing the King and his white companions, hastened to their assistance, and in a very short time they were laid upon couches and after the scorched garments had been removed from the bodies, they were deluged with cool water and oil. No part of their bodies had escaped the tortures of the hot ashes and steam, and they were almost raw. The limbs of the men who had been buried for some time in the bed of cinders, were horribly burned and blistered, and even Enola, who, having laid under the dead zebra for quite a while, had escaped with hardly less injury. Gently the attendants worked on the bleeding bodies, not knowing whether life had left them or not. It matters little, they thought, for it was but a question of a little while longer until all would be buried beneath the shower of death, which was slowly but surely burying them.

But their love for the King and their regard for his guests still dominated over all other feelings, and they worked hard and faithfully on the survivors. Enola was the first to recover consciousness, and when she had fully recovered, and she remembered the awful ride and that Mrs. Graham and Nellie had been her companions, she tried hard to make the attendants

understand that she wanted to know something of her friends. But the poor, bewildered women could not comprehend her meaning and sadly shook their heads. But Enola did not despair, and kept at them, until, in their desire to help her, they sent for one of the men who managed to grasp her meaning, and going out made inquiries about her companions.

They had not returned with the others who had been saved, and he now gave this information to Enola. She almost became frantic and made such pitiful signs for the attendant to go and search for her friends, that, notwithstanding his awful fear of the dust-laden atmosphere outside, which had killed so many of his companions, he went for Enola, promising to make a search for Mrs. Graham and Nellie. And he did. He persuaded two of his companions to accompany him, and with them he managed to reach the stables, where the only three remaining elephants had been left before the eruption. It took considerable time to persuade the beasts to leave their comfortable quarters and go into the darkness outside. But the darkness cleared in a short time, and the lurid light from the volcano made things as light as day. The shower of ashes ceased, and the atmosphere became comparatively clear, and the elephants strode forth into the deep covering of ashes.

The attendant had been able to get but little information from Enola, as to what direction they had come from when they turned their zebras back. She could give them positively no information and could not even make them understand that her zebra had wandered from the avenue, some distance, she thought from the villa; for she could not articulate a word, and the men were not accustomed to reading signs.

But the men started, each taking a different course from the front of the villa, hoping in this way to find the lost women. One of the attendants stumbled over the body of Enola's zebra the first thing, but after examining this and learning that neither of the women were with it, he again took up the tramp and had gone but a little distance further, when his elephant stopped. The man looked about him but could see nothing. He tried to urge the elephant forward, but he would not move. He then slid from its back and was half buried in the soft ashes. But his foot had struck something which was soft and giving, and stooping down, just above the surface he saw a woman's head. It was Mrs. Graham. He gently pushed the ashes away from her body, and speaking to the elephant, it kneeled, and the man, after

much trouble, managed to crawl into the howdah with his lifeless burden. He continued a short distance further, when, not finding the body of Nellie, he returned to the villa.

Mrs. Graham was carried carefully into one of the apartments and given the same treatment as had been the others. It was only a few moments later when one of the other men brought in Nellie. He had found her in much the same position as had been found her mother, but nearly a mile distant from her. It was thought for a long time by those who were working on them, that they were surely dead, but after very hard rubbing and frequent applications of native restoratives, they began to show signs of life, and after a little they opened their eyes and looked about them. That these women had withstood the dreadful experiences of the past few hours, could scarcely be believed, but so they had, and had regained consciousness long before the men.

They too, though, had been brought back to life and their first inquiries had been of the women. The attendants had told them that the ladies were safe but had been somewhat overcome by the close atmosphere, and were slightly indisposed as a consequence. But Onrai knew that he had seen Enola and had assisted her in some way, but how he could not tell, for the whole fearful experience seemed, in some way, like a horrible nightmare. He could not yet fully realize that the events of the day had really occurred. They seemed too horrible to be real. He shuddered as he thought of the massacre of his men and later, the horrible slaughter of the negroes, and then the last occurrence, when the remainder of his men had perished. Then the fearful ride for life, the last hope, when the elephants gave out, and then the terrible fear that Gip would give out after he had once more renewed hope in them.

Then he saw Enola lying there nearly buried beneath the dead zebra; he had seen Gip raise her with his trunk, then he had clasped her in his arms; but all was a blank from here on, until he had wakened and found the attendants standing about him, and had felt himself bandaged from head to foot. Yes, it must be, the whole fearful story must be real; else why this terrible weakness and soreness and all these bandages. He was convinced at last, that it was no dream, but a terrible reality. But he marveled that he and his companions yet lived. The whole thing now passed before the mind's eye and as he remembered the flying assagais and the formidable spear-pointed hatchets, and later, the death-dealing shower of ashes; when he

thought of how men and beasts had dropped about him like sheep, he could but wonder that they, of all the others, should survive.

But that brought him to Gip, and he wondered what had become of the noble beast. He signed to his attendant that he wished to know of the elephant which had brought them back. The man left the apartment for a moment, and then returning, said that the elephant had borne them directly into the large hall of the villa, and had dropped dead a moment later. But this did not please Onrai, and he gave orders to see that the elephant had restoratives given him, and to be sure that he was dead before they gave him up. The man had taken several of his companions, and they had gone to work on the great beast. He was turned on his back with great difficulty, and buckets full of stimulants were poured down his throat. His head was deluged with water, and everything was done to restore the brave animal to which the survivors owed their lives. And their work was rewarded at last by the animal showing signs of life, and a little later, by his again turning on his side and attempting to rise. This he finally did, and staggering about for a while, he then laid down in one corner of the hall and was now resting quietly.

So all the survivors were doing as well as could be expected after the dreadful experiences through which they had passed. But what of the eruption?

Shortly after Gip had burst into the villa with his precious load, the shower had ceased, as if the volcano had known that now there were no more victims for it to destroy, and it was useless for it to further keep up the terrible strain which had shook the earth and covered a great part of the surrounding country with a layer of ashes. But the internal fires were still raging, for the great, lurid light flashed into the dark heavens above, and made all bright within the radius of several miles. There were no more shocks, and the violent eruption seemed to have spent its greatest force. From the cliff to a point some three miles beyond the villa, in which lay our friends, the ground was covered with a layer of ashes well mixed with a sort of loam, which would probably make a fertile soil in time. Some large rocks of a lava formation lay here and there, having been hurled by the mighty internal fires to this distance.

The lava flow had ceased, too, as far as could be seen, for none of the red stream was now visible coming over the side of the cliff.

It had been very fortunate for the survivors that the flow of lava had confined itself to certain channels, for if it had taken the old course, which was shown plainly by the bad lands, there would be no hope of their escaping. It had run over the sides of the great crevice when our friends stood looking at it, and it, together with the falling ashes, had been fast filling the awful crevice. But would the great eruption end here? Truly it had done damage enough, but would the internal fires be satisfied with this temporary vent? It seemed hardly possible that they would, and if they did burst forth again, what would be the further outcome? But now it was quiet. The hot bed of steam and ashes were fast cooling into an almost solid mass, and there would be no more plunging and falling when walking over its surface, hereafter. It would be as the surface had been before, only a few feet higher.

A few days longer, and if the party had convalesced sufficiently to allow them to travel, they would start on their return to the city, for Onrai had said that all must be in the city on the Day of Resis. Then, after the ceremonies of the day, after its mysteries had been learned, on the evening of that day, Enola was to become the bride of the King.

CHAPTER XLV.

SEARCHING FOR BODIES.

One week had passed away since the fearful eruption, and our friends had convalesced rapidly under the care of the attendants, until now all were entirely recovered. The sun had shown brightly for a week, its light unobstructed by any further shower of ashes. The fire and smoke from the volcano had subsided, until now but a faint blue line was seen slowly ascending into the heavens from the summit of the mountain. All about the villa, as far as could be seen, was a bed of ashes, or not so much a bed of ashes now as it was a cinder soil. But the trees had been stripped of their verdure and no green thing was seen. If it were not so excessively hot, our friends could have easily believed that they were in some temperate zone and winter was on them.

But the cooling of the thick mass had made the air hot and humid, almost suffocating; still, notwithstanding this, the air had not seemed unhealthful, for our friends declared that they had never felt better in their lives, with the exception of the stiffness and the soreness, which was the direct outcome of the bruises and the burns. But if the eruption had lasted but a few hours, its consequences had been fearful.

The slaughter of human beings and beasts had been terrible. On that fateful morning, five thousand men, one hundred elephants and nearly as many zebras, had left the villa, strong in perfect health and vigor; but a few hours later, and but one elephant and five men were left to tell the fearful tale. Those who had not been killed in battle, had been slaughtered or had been buried beneath the hot shower of cinders and steam. And fully as many of the negroes had perished also, in all making a fearful total.

It had had an awful effect on the King for a few days. He had wandered about the villa like one demented, and had spoken to no one, keeping well

to himself, his head bowed and face pale, and eyes sunken. One could hardly imagine that this was the great and powerful King of On. But Enola had been persevering in her efforts to draw his mind away from the saddening events, and he could not long remain insensible to her pleadings, to try and forget. She would tell him pleasing stories of the life in her own world; would relate strange tales of adventure and daring, which, for the time, would blot out the thought of his fearful loss. And when he would turn to Enola with words of love, she would no longer turn from him, but would encourage him in this. She had wanted to make him forget, knowing that if his mind brooded on these events, he would surely go mad, and then what would become of her and her friends?

Such fears had already taken possession of them, for they knew that such an occurrence as this would impress the Onians fearfully, and this impression might be as it had once been before, namely: that they were in some way the cause of the fearful event. If such a belief should become fully established in their minds, nothing could save them they knew, unless it would be the interference of the King, whose desires they held in high regard.

So Enola, although now determined never to marry the great King, would, to save her friends and herself, humor him in the belief that she loved him. It was a deception which was loathsome to her, but so much depended on it that she could not help herself.

It was one week ago to-day that the volcano had belched forth, and the few survivors were sitting at their morning meal.

“Well, shall we venture to the volcano, to-day?” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, we must go to-day, or give it up altogether,” replied the King, “for our provisions are fast giving out and we must get back to the country that has not been devastated by the eruption.”

“Yes, let us leave this horrible place as soon as possible,” added Mrs. Graham.

“I confess that I, myself, am desirous of leaving the place which has so nearly been the scene of our deaths,” rejoined Mr. Graham. “But Mr. Bruce thinks that we ought to look over the ground where so many of the Onians have fallen.”

“I will find no pleasure in thus going,” said Mr. Bruce, “but we should know the exact state of things here before returning to the city. The relatives and friends of all these buried thousands, will want to know if it will be possible to recover their bodies. And then it would be well to see the crevice. I think Onrai still holds the idea that this should be closed.”

“Yes, it will be one of my first duties, now,” said Onrai. “But what a task it will be for the men who do the work. The first unpleasant task they have ever had to perform.”

“The hole may have been closed somewhat by the stream of lava which poured into it,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, I feel quite sure that it has,” said Mr. Graham, “for it poured into it in such a volume it could hardly be otherwise.”

“Yet there will be much to do,” said Mr. Bruce, “and it will mean a great deal of hard work before the break is made impassable.”

“Let us start,” said Onrai, “so as to be able to investigate as much as possible and return before nightfall. To-morrow we must start for the city in order to be there for the Day of Resis. It will be a sad return;” and again the King fell into that melancholy condition out of which Enola had tried so hard to draw him.

“True, Onrai,” said Enola, “but the only sadness which has ever darkened your life. It will cast a gloom over your life for awhile, but as time goes by and you see those about you again happy, and your life falls into the old routine, then will you also grow contented and happy once more. In our world we have so much sadness that we at last become accustomed to it, and expect it. But here you hardly know the meaning of the word. This experience has been fearful, I know, but it is better that you lose a few of your mighty men, than that all should lose country and, may be, life too, and even be sold into slavery. That must certainly have been the fate of your people, if they had fallen into the hands of the negroes. But that time has forever passed and out of this sad experience, which will cause so much grief, comes this grand assurance. The men who have been thus slain might have been spared until they had the wall on the way, and while in the country beyond the cliff, for they would have had to be there some of the time, they might have been overpowered by the natives, and the land been overspread with these hated negroes, before the majority of your people could have learned of their presence. In such a case your country would

have been destroyed with all its villas and its beautiful city. But such a thing can never occur now. God has simply taken the work out of your hands, and in his own way has avenged your people and has also, by turning the lava into the crevice, helped to close to the outside world, the only means of ingress into your country. The present generation will die, and as it is forbidden your people to ever mention or talk of such things to those who will live beyond your reign, the thing will die from memory, the same as has all of the previous events of your history. This fearful occurrence has been ordained to come during your reign, but it casts no reflection upon you or your people, for it has been wholly the work of God.

“If He has chosen to take the men before their time, He has had a good purpose in it and I think that purpose has been shown. So don’t give up to despair in this moment, but be the brave, noble King which we have all learned to love. Be superior to the events which would crush most other men. Be strong, and set such an example before your people. They will look to you for strength and comfort, and you must be able to give them both.”

The King had listened quietly to the words of Enola, and seemed much impressed by her strong, clear-cut remarks and the sound advice which she had given. For the first time he realized that it would not do for him to give way to his feelings, in this hour of trial, for, as Enola had said, his people would look to him for comfort and strength, and he must be able to give them both. Somehow or other he felt better after Enola had talked to him in this way, and he felt that he could meet the inquisitive looks of his people and answer their mute questions without flinching.

“But come, we must be off,” said Onrai.

So the men-folk went to the terrace, where the only four elephants, which had been left, were awaiting them. Gip had entirely recovered, and was now with the three which had been left in the stable on that fateful morning. The five men mounted, and were soon making good time over the smooth surface of the bad lands. This new covering was of better soil than the old, and would some day become very productive. The elephants, heavy as they were, hardly made an impression in this, so solid had it become. They jogged along for nearly an hour, when they came on the body of an elephant lying on its side, nearly covered with the new soil. Digging away some of the dirt from his back the body of an Onian was disclosed to view. He had been one of three who had leaped to the elephant’s back when the eruption

first broke forth. Further on they came across all of the one hundred elephants and a few of the zebras. Only one or two Onians were found with any part of their bodies above the soil. They were buried almost completely. It was thought at first that they would take these bodies back to the villa, and cremate them as was the custom this land, but Mr. Bruce had dissuaded Onrai from this, saying that as all of their companions were lying here in one common grave, there also might better be they. The King declared his intention of exhuming all of the many bodies which filled the immense graveyard, but his companions also made him change his mind in regard to this, saying that such an undertaking would take a great amount of time, and would be next to an impossibility.

At last the crevice was reached, but little of it remained. The hole in the ground was not even ten feet deep. It had been filled by the flowing lava up to that height. The party followed the crevice to the cliff, where a most unexpected scene met their astonished eyes. The crevice in the cliff was entirely filled, for the lava had run into the crevice until on a level with the surrounding country, after which it had still dropped its flinty substance into the hole and gradually cooled until the chasm had been entirely filled, when it had turned its stream into the country beyond, leaving the face of the cliff as straight and impregnable as it had been before the earthquake.

“It is more than I expected,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, it is the handiwork of God,” answered Onrai.

“You need have no further fears about your country being again invaded, Onrai,” said Mr. Graham.

“It is as Enola has said,” replied the King. “A blessed assurance that we are safe from those who would molest us.”

“Come, let us move on up to the cliff,” said Mr. Bruce. “I would like to see where the stream of lava has ended in the cavern.”

“I wonder how it has affected that part of the Hunting Reserve which the storm has covered,” said Mr. Graham.

“It must have driven the animals farther back into the jungle,” said Onrai. “But there is plenty of room for them all. A few miles, as you would call it, cut off of this great tract, amounts to but little.”

“But the whole tract will again be fertilized now, I think,” said Mr. Graham. “Those ashes have a great deal of good loam mixed with them,

and it will be very productive, I think.”

“Yes, the animals will find as good grazing here as in any other part of the Reserve, at some future day,” said Mr. Bruce.

“Look,” said Mr. Graham, “what is that black object away there in the distance? It is moving, is it not?”

They all looked and came to the conclusion that it must be some sort of animal, but what, they could not say. As they proceeded the black spot grew larger and larger, but they could now see that the animals, or whatever they might be, were not moving but standing still. They had now come to the hole in the side of the mountain and concluded to enter this first, and investigate the black spot later. Accordingly they entered the hole and lighting a torch turned to the right and moved toward the upper end of the cave. From where they were, they could see no change in the crevice, but there might be nearer the crater, for it was from this that the stream of lava was running. They hurried on for they had much to look after before returning, and already half of the day had passed. The end wall was at last reached and they turned to follow this until they had reached the small tunnel, through which had run the lava. Arriving at this they were not surprised to find it considerable wider than it had been before the lava had found its way through it. The lava had raised the floor of it to quite a height, but this new flooring was cool now and they decided to follow up the tunnel for some distance, and see what had taken place in the farther end.

As they advanced up the tunnel the air got somewhat warmer, but still not excessively so: The lava bed also grew thicker as they advanced until the floor had become so raised, they could extend their hands and touch the ceiling. They at last reached the end of the tunnel and were surprised to see that the crack had widened until it was nearly five feet broad.

“Shall we enter?” asked Mr. Bruce, as they all stood looking at the crack rather hesitatingly.

“Most assuredly, if there is no danger,” replied Mr. Graham.

“I cannot answer for the safety of it,” said Mr. Bruce, “but I can say that it would be interesting to look into it a ways.”

“Let us proceed then,” said the King, who was fast becoming as curious as his white companions.

The party then, headed by Mr. Bruce, stepped rather gingerly into the passage-way, and moved along slowly. The side-walls were still very hot and very soon the soles of their feet became almost burned with the hot flooring, for the hot lava had passed through there so recently, that it could hardly be expected to be very cool yet. They had gone some distance into the crack when Mr. Bruce suddenly stopped and said:

“Look ahead, can’t you see a ray of daylight?”

All heads were immediately screwed to one side and a glance thrown ahead.

“Yes, that is surely daylight,” said Mr. Graham, “but how in the world, or in this hole, does it get there?”

“Shall we go on and see?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“Yes, by all means,” answered the King.

So the party again pushed on, now at a little livelier gait, for they could no longer be mistaken that that was the light of day penetrating this dark crevice. Hurriedly now they advanced, so anxious had they grown to see what sort of hole it was that admitted the sunlight; and after a short walk further they burst out into the bright open light of day. They looked above them and there, sure enough, was the bright, blue sky.

“What do you make of it, Mr. Graham?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“Well,” replied Mr. Graham, “I should say that we are looking up out of one of the crevices which opened into the crater of the volcano.”

“That’s so,” replied Mr. Bruce, “I did not think of that. But I supposed these cracks must have opened far into the bowels of the earth, and were vents for the steam, ashes and lava.”

“Some of them undoubtedly are,” said Mr. Graham, “but this is surely not. This may have been caused by one of the earthquakes, and was later widened by the excessive heat. Whatever the cause, it is here at any rate.”

The tunnel at this point was very wide and fully two thousand feet deep.

“Can you notice any peculiarities in this crevice?” asked Mr. Bruce of Mr. Graham.

“None,” replied Mr. Graham, “unless it be its crookedness, but they are all crooked. But why do you ask?”

“I was just thinking,” said Mr. Bruce, “that we might have occasion to use this crevice some day.”

“I hope not,” replied Mr. Graham, “for if we had to trust to scaling these perpendicular walls, I am afraid we would perish here at the bottom.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “but it is well to have several strings to your bow.”

“It might be possible,” said Mr. Graham, “to lower one’s self into this cavern, but I don’t believe it would be possible to hoist one’s self out of it.”

“We may have occasion some day to lower ourselves into it,” said Mr. Bruce. “At any rate, we have found another way to enter the Land of On.”

“But one never to be used as long as the other is open,” said Mr. Graham.

“As you like,” said Mr. Bruce. “Shall we return, Onrai?”

“If you are ready,” answered the King.

They accordingly turned and retraced their steps until again in the cavern. Instead of turning to the left and following the wall as they had done previously, they followed the lava bed which had gradually spread over a very wide area in the cavern, in one place being fully a mile wide. They followed this until opposite the hole, when they moved over to this and left the cavern.

The large black group again attracted their attention, and they determined to see what it was before returning to the villa. The sun was getting well down toward the western horizon, and they had a good fifteen miles to make, but they must see what it was that could make such a mark in the heart of this ash-covered plain. From as near as they could make out the animals were nearly two miles away. They hurried on, wishing to reach home before it grew very dark. When within a mile of the dark object, they saw that it was a herd of elephants, lying down. They drew up to these cautiously, so as not to be molested, if possible, but they saw that the elephants were undoubtedly very much exhausted, or else dead, for they paid but little or no attention to the approaching riders.

But just before they came up to them, one of the animals half raised his head, but that was all, they made no further sign. The riders now came up to them and saw their predicament. These animals had undoubtedly been overcome by the shower of ashes, and sinking down had been too weak to again rise, and now, after a week of suffering and fasting, they were nearly

dead. There were fully a hundred of them and they had been perfectly wild, but were now as docile as so many lambs.

“If we can save them,” said Onrai, “they will take the place of the hundred we lost.”

CHAPTER XLVI.

“WE DIE TOGETHER.”

The elephants were sadly emaciated, for they had now been seven days without food or water. Their great bodies looked gaunt, and their little eyes were sunken well into the head. Their bodies were nearly half covered with the ashes, and together with this and the fact that they were so weak they could only move their heads, turning them from side to side, showing that there was still life in their huge bodies.

“Yes, if we could get these elephants to the villa,” said Onrai, “they could well take the place of those which were killed.”

“But even if you were to get them there, they would, with returning strength, grow as wild as ever, would they not?” said Mr. Bruce.

“No,” said Onrai, “hunger always tames an elephant, and if he is taken while hungry, and given food and placed with tame elephants, he is generally as docile and manageable as any of those which have been in captivity all their lives.”

“This is strange,” said Mr. Graham.

“Yes,” replied the King, “it is, but nevertheless true. Elephants do not seem to have the fear of human beings that many other animals have, but seem rather to like the association of man. I have seen wild elephants follow us from out of the jungle, right down to the gate of the Hunting Reserve, as gentle and seemingly as tame as the ones we were riding, and I have no doubt that if we had let them through the gate, they would have followed us to the city, and would have been just as happy and contented with their tame companions as they had been running wild in the jungle.”

“It seems a pity, then, that we have to leave them here,” said Mr. Bruce, “when with help they might be gotten to where they could be nursed back

to life.”

“It would take considerable time and trouble, though, to do so,” said Onrai. “Still, if we had men with us they could bring them food and water and in this way put life enough into them to get them to the villa. But come, the sun is nearly hidden behind the cliffs, and we have a long ride before us.”

As if the dying elephants knew that their would-be rescuers were leaving them, they turned their heads and watched them as they rode away, the most pitiful expression coming into their little black eyes. There were easily a hundred of them, and they made a great black spot on the plain with their bodies, which were only half covered.

Our friends now hurried toward the villa, and after a ride of two hours, again pulled up in front of the terrace. They had entered the villa, and were just about to seat themselves to the evening meal, when the tramping of many zebras’ hoofs were heard, and our friends, going to the front entrance, looked toward the now covered avenue, and there saw in the half light, a band of not less than two hundred mounted men. When they saw the lights of the villa they turned and came toward it. Silently they picked their way between the trees and up to the terrace, where, recognizing the King, they gave a loud shout and then began a chant, which Onrai explained to his companions, was a chant of praise. After the chant was finished, the King stood on the terrace steps and said:

“Onians, my countrymen, the sight of your faces, coming so unexpectedly, pleases me greatly and draws from my heart some of the sadness which the events of the past short while have caused. Your presence makes me feel that if some of our dearly beloved men have gone, there yet remains their sons and brothers and fathers, who will make this fair Land of On yet the same as we knew it before the fearful eruption. We have met with a terrible loss, but our men died in a good cause, and died bravely.”

“We do not understand you, oh King,” said one of the foremost.

“Ah, I forgot,” said Onrai, “but enough to-night. Find quarters for yourselves and beasts, and on the morrow I will explain further. Prepare yourselves, however, for sad news, for such you will hear.”

The men turned from the terrace and the King and his guests again went into the villa. Onrai seemed much depressed, for how was he going to tell these men that their fathers, sons and brothers had perished by the hands of

a band of negroes, and the terrible shower of ashes. They would not understand either unless they could realize that this new covering of ashes had overtaken their friends unexpectedly, and had buried them. But then it would be hard to make them understand the eruption and what caused it. They were too far away at the time to see or know anything of the awful overflow, unless it be a black cloud which they could possibly see. They may have felt the shocks of earthquake, but even this they might not have experienced. Then they could know nothing of how their friends had met death, nor could they understand the means by which they had fallen.

So the King had a hard task before him in the morning and it worried him fearfully. Enola had seen his downcast countenance, and guessing the cause, had followed him out on the terrace. Taking hold of his arm, as he paced up and down, she said:

“Onrai, do not give up at the outstart. This is a sad task which you have to perform. But it is only the first one of a number like ones which will come later, when the mothers and sisters and wives of the unfortunates will come to gain information from you, when you will be in the city. So if you give up now what will you do after awhile? Be strong and make these men understand as well as possible, the real condition of things. Try and impress them with the greatness of the deed which made such heroes of their dead comrades, and of the fearful consequences if they had failed to act so nobly and bravely. Say not too much about the eruption, but leave the impression that it buried and burned the hated negroes who had invaded this country, and had slaughtered so many of their countrymen. Impress them with the fact that all of these brave Onians were killed in defence of their country and their loved ones, and then, if you can make them understand why these negroes were here, and how they entered the country, they will better appreciate the great sacrifice of life which has been made for them. Let them still retain their old belief that theirs is the only world on this sphere, letting them think that the negroes came from another world far away. They can better understand the latter for they have seen us and believe that we came from another planet, and this too, would leave the old belief unshaken, and would insure less unhappiness, than if their life-long teachings were destroyed.”

“You are right,” said Onrai, “as you always are, and I will act upon your advice. But Enola, have you thought of the time when we will be married?

We are about to return to the city and the word has gone forth that on the Day of Resis you will marry me.”

“The day has then been fixed?” questioned Enola. “I had not learned this.”

“Yes, it has been decided upon,” said the King. “On that great day when so many of my countrymen will meet, with joy and loud songs of praise, on the evening of that day, after the ceremonies have been performed, you will become my wife.”

Enola had expected that Onrai would make some such announcement soon, but she had no idea that he would name such an early day, for, as she understood it, the Day of Resis, was but a short time away.

“When is the Day of Resis?” asked Enola.

“Four weeks from to-day, according to your calendar,” said Onrai.

“Is not that very soon, Onrai?” asked Enola.

“Too soon?” exclaimed Onrai; “how can you ask such a question, Enola? If you love me as I do you, you would wish, as do I, that the day was tomorrow. The time to me seems a long way off. Our days will not be too many after our marriage, and it is well we should add to these as many as possible. And again, my people have so decreed that we should be married on that day.”

“What are the ceremonies of the great Day of Resis?” again questioned Enola.

“Hush, Enola, you must not ask me. The secret of the day is never divulged, or even spoken of among those who know its secrets. But once seen, the secret is then yours, and you will then know the meaning of the Day of Resis. It is a glorious day, a day of great rejoicing and happiness. Not one on that great day but feels a wonderful happiness, even those who are not direct participants in its great ceremonies. It falls to the lot of all, though, to be principal participants in the proceedings of the day, one day of his life, and this is the greatest day of all his or her days. Their joy is supreme, and their happiness knows no bounds.”

“It must, indeed, be a great day,” said Enola, “and the people have chosen this day to be my wedding day. How they must love their King!”

“Yes, the King and the fair stranger whom he is to marry,” said Onrai.

“I doubt the latter,” said Enola, “for they were too ready to kill both her and her friends when they thought that she had been the cause of the storm.”

“Don’t, don’t, Enola, mention that fearful time. I would blot it from my mind. It was the one time in my life that I lost confidence in my people, and the one time when I would have turned against them. I feel, though, that they have now bitterly regretted their action, for they have seen the folly of it.”

“Will we be married in the Temple?” asked Enola, wishing to take Onrai’s mind from such a painful subject as the one she had mentioned.

“Yes,” said Onrai; “in the Temple, surrounded by my people, and the ceremony will be grand in the extreme. I am, I suppose, the first King who has ever been married, but this, of course, I cannot say positively, for we know nothing of the reign or history of past Kings. Still, the high priest has said as much. Our marriage ceremonies are mostly of a religious nature, and are accompanied by much song and music. Our marriage garments are made of pure cloth of gold, and those who will be with us, will be robed much in the same way.”

“Shall we live in the Temple?” again asked Enola.

“Yes,” said Onrai; “but in apartments which you have never seen; apartments grand beyond description. These apartments were made by the builder of the Temple, for the King in whose reign an unusual event would occur. So says the high priest; and he further says that my marriage is an event never before heard of, and that it must have been this which the founder of the country foresaw when he had these chambers planned and held for this purpose. None but the high priest has ever entered them, but they must be sublime from what he has told me of them.”

“And what will be my life as the King’s wife?” questioned Enola.

“Your life will be much the same as it is now, but you will be called upon to take a part in all duties which belong to the King. In the ceremonies of the Day of Resis, for instance, you will stand near me and perform the same duties which alone belong to myself, and in this way, sharing the duties of my office, we go down to our death, happy, knowing no sorrows or troubles and assured of that great happiness in the eternity beyond.”

“And do we then go together?” asked Enola, as she remembered the mode of death of some of the women of India.

“Yes; it is so decreed,” said Onrai.

The horror of this made Enola faint for a moment, and she made a resolve to leave this land as soon as possible. Until beyond the rocky cliffs again, all happiness for her had flown.

CHAPTER XLVII.

IN THE CITY AGAIN.

On the following morning the men were up early and at the terrace, awaiting their King and the strange, sad tale which they must hear. Onrai came on to the terrace with his friends and told the sad story of the battle and the eruption. The Onians stood drinking in every word, their eyes changing from curiosity to pain, and then to horror, their faces depicting the same emotions. Onrai related all of the fearful tale, of how the men had stood up before the negroes even when they were being mowed down like wheat before the scythe, and then of how the elephants had rushed on to them, thus turning the tide of battle, and then of the mad rush for the crevice, and the awful eruption which had killed and burned the survivors.

For some time after the King had finished speaking the men stood with that look of horror overcasting their faces, their very bodies having assumed an attitude which showed the greatest dejection. Onrai then continued: "We will start for the city again to-day and will make as long marches as possible, as we wish to reach there in time to rest, before the ceremonies of the Day of Resis takes place. On the plain, some few miles from here, will be found a herd of nearly a hundred elephants. They were driven, on this desperate night, into the worst part of the downfall of ashes, and half buried and nearly starving, are dying there now, on the plain. I wish one hundred of you to go, and if possible, revive these elephants and bring them to a place where they can receive proper care. The remainder of you will accompany us to the city. We start immediately," and saying this, he again turned to his friends and told them to make immediate preparations.

This they did and it was only a short while until they were mounted, and on their way from the spot which had become most hateful and loathsome to them. To the avenue, which could only be told now by the bordering

trees, they went, and following its course they headed for the city. Hope was rejuvenated as they left the scene of so much pain and death, and life seemed again to be putting on a garment of happiness which had long since been cast aside. The cavalcade of the witnesses of the recent fearful scene, left the place without a regret and without one glance backward to either volcano, bad lands or villa.

Their thoughts turned to things more pleasant, of the green fields and shady trees; even the lake with its memories of night horrors seemed less repulsive than the place they were leaving. But the thought of the city and its quiet pleasures were more pleasing than all others. In a half hour they could see ahead of them the green fields and trees, which they had so longed for. The layer of ashes gradually thinned until there was no longer any trace of it, and the hard, onyx-paved avenue again stretched before them in all its beauty. An hour later and they could see no traces of the eruption at all, and the long track of the cyclone had been cleared, until it presented very much the same appearance as did the rest of the surrounding country.

The country became more cultivated as they proceeded, and men were now seen frequently working in the fields. None of them approached the cavalcade, and none were made acquainted with the sad story of the battle and eruption. And so day after day passed in much the same way as they had on the journey out, the marches being somewhat longer only, and the midday rests somewhat shorter. But the evenings were spent in the cool villas, the nights of prayer being observed now as usual, for with the last body of men who had come to meet them, before leaving the villa near the volcano, had been another priest and attendants, and these were now with the party.

The lake had been reached and its banks followed. All former plans of taking another route back to the city had been abandoned on account of the eruption, and the party was not sorry for this, for the avenue, with its magnificent shade trees and its beautiful surroundings made it an enviable route. The days had passed and with them many miles of the long journey, until on the evening of the ninth day after leaving the villa in the bad lands they were at the point where they had embarked for the island, on the memorable night of the sea-fight. Here they put up for the night at the same villa which had held them once before.

“To-morrow,” said Mr. Bruce, after the evening meal had been disposed of and all had gathered on the terrace for their regular chat before retiring, “to-morrow, if nothing happens, will be our last day’s journey. We will reach the city before noon if we start very early in the morning.”

“I am not sorry that this excursion is so near an end,” said Mr. Graham; “but it has been loaded with adventures and that is what we were looking for when coming here.”

“Yes, but the adventures of the past month or so have none of them been agreeable ones,” said Mr. Bruce.

“I do not agree with you, Mr. Bruce,” said Harry. “I think the last horrible experience has cast a gloom over all of the others, and if it were not for the fearful slaughter of the Onians and our own narrow escape, we would have considered the other adventures as being at least, excitable, if not altogether enjoyable.”

“This land has not seemed the same to me since that fearful day,” said Mr. Bruce.

“I have noticed the change in you,” said Nellie.

“It has made this fair land almost hateful to me and I long to get away from it,” and Mr. Bruce spoke in such a bitter tone, that all looked at him in surprise.

“We have now seen most of the people and their country,” said Mr. Graham, “and it would be well for us to leave as soon as possible, especially as the King has decided that Enola shall marry him on the Day of Resis. By the way, Enola, have you learned anything of Onrai, in regard to this red-letter day?”

“Nothing,” answered Enola, “excepting that it is a day of great joy to all of the participants in its ceremonies.”

“But do not all participate?” questioned Mr. Graham.

“It seems not,” answered Enola. “That is, they do not all participate on the same day; but a day comes to each one when he or she participates. It has a strange meaning, this Day of Resis.”

“Yes, and one which will never be learned until the day comes,” said Harry, “for Onrai told me himself that none of his people were allowed to mention the secrets of the day, but all understood them.”

“And when is this day, which is to make you the wife of the King?” asked Mr. Graham.

“It is barely a week distant,” answered Enola.

“And do you think that you could be happy as the wife of Onrai?” asked Mr. Graham.

“I have never given the subject much thought,” answered Enola, “until the evening preceding our departure from the villa in the bad lands, then he spoke of our marriage and told of our apartments in the Temple, and of our marriage gowns, and another thing, which makes the very thought of marrying Onrai repulsive. He then told me that if he should die first that I would be sacrificed on his bier, and the King and wife would be buried together.”

“That is certainly fearful to contemplate,” said Mr. Graham, “and it but adds to the necessity of our getting out of this country before this eventful day.”

“What do you suppose, though, will be the outcome if we should leave the country before you become the wife of the King?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“It is hard to tell,” answered Enola, “but these people might object seriously to our doing so. It is certain that the King has fully decided on marrying me, and that his people have not only sanctioned the marriage, but it was they who fixed the Day of Resis as the one on which we should be married. They are a strange people. They have gone through life following certain laws and rules and have never been crossed in anything, and it might be a very serious matter to try and balk them in this, probably the most important event which has ever taken place in their history.”

“Yes, but if you do not wish to marry Onrai,” said Mr. Graham, “and you have just said that you would not, we must get away from here before this Day of Resis, in some way or other, whether they object or not.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “and as the time is so short it would be well for us to feel around and see just how the land lays.”

Onrai, who had been overseeing some work in another part of the villa, came strolling carelessly on to the terrace, his very carriage lending a gracefulness to his majestic figure, which was charming, to say the least, and Enola thought how easy it could be to love this giant under any other circumstances.

“Onrai,” said Mr. Bruce, “we have been your guests for many weeks now and we feel that to remain with you much longer would be a breach of etiquette, to say the least, and as the affairs in our own country need our almost immediate attention, we feel that we should leave your hospitable country, and return to our own.”

Onrai looked surprised at the very mention of such a thing and made no answer for some time; at last, however, he said:

“Your words grieve me; I had never thought of such a thing as your ever returning to your own country. I have always supposed that you would remain with us for the remainder of your lives. Why should you want to leave us? Have we not been kind to you, and is ours not a good land to live in? You have told me that you have much care, worry, trouble and unhappiness in your world; you have found none of those disturbing influences here; that is, until the awful fight and eruption came, but even that is over now, and your lives will soon drop into the old groove which you have said was the most delightful existence which one could desire. My people love you for yourselves alone, and if they forgot themselves for once, they must not be blamed, for you can readily see how superstition could spring to life in such uneventful lives as theirs. But they have forgotten those fears, and are now as much your friends as is their King. Then why should you wish to leave us? We love you; and as Enola is to marry me, and is to remain with us, it will be pleasant for both her and you to be together. Don’t ever again mention leaving us, let alone ever putting such a suggestion into action. Why, we look upon you no longer as strangers, but as part of us.”

“We thank you for those kind words,” said Mr. Bruce, “but you must understand us, Onrai, we have many personal interests in our world which would take us there, and we have brothers and sisters and friends who would grieve greatly if we should never return. If such were not the case, it would be an easy matter for us to take up our life residence with you.”

“I have, as I had said before,” said Onrai, “never thought of your leaving us, and I cannot now say how such a thing would affect my people or myself. I can only say that we have always thought that you would remain with us, and we cannot think of anything else just now.” And saying this, the King took hold of Enola’s arm gently, and drawing it through his, as she

had taught him to, they started to promenade the terrace. After they had gotten out of hearing, Mr. Bruce turned to Mr. Graham, and said:

“Rather non-committal, is he not?”

“I should say so,” said Mr. Graham. “And if I am not mistaken, we will have trouble in getting away from here.”

“One thing sure,” said Mr. Bruce, “he has no intention of letting Enola leave the country.”

“He is a strange man, this Onrai,” said Mr. Graham, “and, in fact, the people are a queer anomaly and hard to make out. They have no secrets, seemingly, their lives are like open books, and they have no reason for being otherwise; but they can be as mum as oysters, as they say in America, when they wish to keep anything from you, and as evasive as a man paying taxes, when they take such a notion. For a race who has never had occasion to use any deception, they are certainly without a peer.”

The talk now turned onto other subjects, and after a short time, all retired to their apartments to take their last sleep in the country, or away from the beautiful Temple. All were up very early the following morning, for they desired to reach the city before noon, so as not to have to stop before getting there for the midday rest. There was more life and gayety in the party on this morning than had been seen among them for weeks. All seemed happy and glad that the long journey was so near an end, and there was much joyous conversation and singing as they rode out before the sun had yet risen.

Straight to the beautiful avenue, which had been their guide for so many, many miles, and the trees of which had given them such shady comfort, they rode. Even the animals seemed to realize that their long journey was at an end, for they started off at a good lively gait and maintained it throughout the morning. Onrai this morning seemed depressed; his head was bent and he seemed dejected. He had forbidden those who had joined the party, just before starting on this journey, never to speak of or mention in any way the things which he had told them on the morning of their departure. He had said that it was his duty as King and head of the people to impart to them the sad news; that the details of this great calamity were better known to him than to any other of his people, and he could the better tell the story for this reason. Therefore, his men had said nothing during the long journey, and those of the Onians whom they had met had learned

nothing of the horrible event. Onrai now realized that the time had almost come for him to stand up before the mighty throng which would gather at his command, and tell them of the fearful death of five thousand of the fathers, sons, husbands and brothers of On.

He had seen in his mind's eye, the look of utter despair and great pain, and had heard the cries of the sufferers, and all this saddened him. He felt that it would be next to an impossibility for him to explain so they could understand, and the doubt which would accompany his explanation would but add to the pain of those who had lost loved ones.

But the elephants and zebras were bearing them fast toward the city, as if mocking the King and being desirous of hurrying him to that time and place so dreaded.

The sun had nearly reached its zenith, when the first one of the beautiful city villas was seen through the green trees in the distance, and not long after they were once more, after many weeks' riding, between rows of the pink villas. All was quiet, for this was resting hour; but as they got nearer the heart of the city, numerous ones of the Onians would show themselves, and upon seeing that it was the King and his party, they would make a respectful obeisance and watch them until lost in the distance.

At last the Temple was reached, and our friends were once more in their delightful apartments. Every comfort had been found in the villas en route, but none that they were ever in had such large and magnificent apartments as this grand Temple. The attendants took them in hand at once, and after a bath and light lunch, all of the tired wanderers slept.

In the evening all gathered in the dining hall as usual, and it was hard to suppose that they had been away for so long. Mr. Graham and Mr. Bruce started to take their evening promenade on the terrace, and were surprised to see a number of soldiers, so they looked, walking in a measured beat about the grounds.

"As I thought," said Mr. Bruce, "we are prisoners."

CHAPTER XLVIII.

NO HOPE OF ESCAPE.

At the usual morning gathering of the adventurers, on the following morning, Mr. Bruce said:

“It seems that we are prisoners, but why I cannot understand. It may be, though, that the Temple alone is to be guarded, and that when we desire to leave it for a walk or a ride, the guards may not follow us. Let us make the experiment, Mr. Graham, if we are accompanied by the guards we shall know that extra effort is needed.”

“I wonder,” said Mr. Graham, “if this custom of guarding a prospective bride, which this seems to be, applies to their courtiers as well. Anyway we can ascertain this, by ordering our zebras and taking a ride,” and stepping to the curtain which separated the apartment from the one which he occupied, Mr. Graham called one of his attendants, and told him they wanted their zebras at once. In a short time the zebras were awaiting them, and Mr. Bruce and he went to the entrance, and were not surprised to see ten mounted men standing near, seemingly waiting for them to start. Apparently unconcerned, our friends mounted and rode leisurely down the main avenue. And the ten men followed.

“As I supposed,” said Mr. Graham, “our escape is going to be a serious matter after all.”

“Yes,” answered Mr. Bruce, “we will undoubtedly be guarded by these men wherever we go, and it is hardly reasonable to believe that they will allow us to go to the cave, and make our escape without trying to stop us.”

“There is Sedai,” said Mr. Graham, “he may be able to offer some suggestion.”

They stopped their zebras and motioning to Sedai, he came up and asked what he could do for them.

“We are virtually prisoners, Sedai,” said Mr. Graham, “and we need your help. The King has announced his intention of marrying Enola on the Day of Resis, and to avoid this, we shall have to leave the city; but a guard has been placed about the Temple and a guard is now following us, and it may be hard for us to get away.”

“I have heard of this intended marriage,” said Sedai, “but I thought that Miss Enola must have given her consent.”

“Far from it,” said Mr. Graham, “she is most desirous of getting away immediately. Exert your thinking powers, Sedai, and try to devise some means by which we can leave the country. If you think of anything, come up to the Temple and give us the result.”

“I will do so,” said Sedai, as he walked away.

“Mr. Bruce,” said Mr. Graham, “our friends in the rear do not seem to be appointed as guards to ward off danger, but more as a guard of honor. This is probably what they are for, simply to announce to the people that we have marriageable children,” and Mr. Graham smiled.

“I think myself that they have no idea of danger befalling us, but it looks to me as if they had some suspicion of our intended escape. You know we mentioned the matter to the King a few evenings since,” said Mr. Bruce.

“That’s so; I wonder if that can have anything to do with it. It may be that he intends to keep us prisoners, at least, until he has Enola secure,” said Mr. Graham.

“It is hard to tell,” said Mr. Bruce.

They turned their zebras and headed for the Temple, and upon arriving there told their companions of how they had been followed.

Sedai came up in the afternoon, and, after talking with the guard for awhile, reported what he had learned. The guard was changed every four hours, and the old guard marched to the house used by them as headquarters. Here they reported, and a relief was sent to the Temple. From the time the old guard left until the relief arrived, fifteen minutes elapsed, and during this fifteen minutes escape must be made. This was their only chance. It was not allowing much time for accidents, but they might be some distance before their escape was discovered, and a guard sent after

them. This might not take the right direction at first, and in this way some time might be gained.

It was decided to have Sedai carry the provisions to the cave, since he would not be watched; consequently, he left them to make preparations. No time was to be lost, and Sedai went directly to the provision storehouse and asked for four days' provisions for himself, as he intended going to the large lake on a fishing excursion. The provisions were given him, but, to his surprise, when he came out of the storehouse and mounted his zebra, five mounted men, who were near and who were seen awaiting him, started just after he did and followed him. Straight on he went in the direction of the secret door, and upon arriving at the gate of the wall, his followers rode up and stopped him, saying, that as none of them had weapons they could not think of entering that wild part or of letting him do so. He made no objection, and leaving his bundle of provisions in a shady place near the gate, rode back to the city and went directly to the Temple to notify his friends.

"It begins to look very serious," said Mr. Graham, "but we must go, provisions or no provisions. It may be that some of the dried food which we left along the way as we crossed the cave, may be in good condition still, and if so, this would sustain us for quite awhile."

"I have an idea," said Enola, "which is not pleasant to contemplate, but which may mean the saving of life. The opening into the mountain is large enough to admit the zebras, and if we can get them through it, our journey will be much easier and quicker; and if the worst comes, we can sacrifice them."

"A splendid idea," said Harry, "but we must be ready to start by to-morrow night. But five days remain for us before the Day of Resis, and we must not put off our first attempt until the last moment. It may be that we will make some miscalculation the first time and have to try again, so let us be ready by to-morrow night."

During that day and the next they made as many preparations as they could without being observed. Each secreted some dried meats and a bottle of the exquisite wine and honey. Sedai had visited the guard frequently, and had learned when the changes were made. The stables, where the zebras were kept, was about three hundred yards to the rear of the Temple. They were guarded by one man, the attendants of our friends grooming and

taking care of them during the day. This man would have to be overcome, or called from the stable on some pretense.

The day intended for their escape drew slowly to an end. The evening meal had been eaten, as usual, with the King, but Enola had declined to accompany him to the terrace. They had gathered in Mrs. Graham's room, and were waiting anxiously for Sedai to announce that the time had come and all was in readiness. Sedai at last came, but the moment he entered they saw that some slip had been made in the arrangements, or that something had gone wrong.

"What is it, Sedai?" asked Mr. Bruce.

"This," said Sedai. "The guard, as usual, had left for their headquarters, and I had sent the stableman on an errand which would take some time to carry out. I started to the Temple to notify you, when, to my surprise, twenty men came up to the stable, and when I asked their leader why they were there, he told me that the Day of Resis was but three days off, and that all zebras and elephants were sent into the country to carry into the city those working in the fields, quarries and mines, one day's journey hence; and saying this, they took the zebras and elephants and went away with them."

The friends looked from one to the other speechless. The zebras being away they could no longer calculate on their help, but something must be done. They could not think of walking to the cave, for their escape would soon be discovered, and the inhabitants, having found out their intentions, would guard against any further attempt.

"When will the zebras be returned," asked Mr. Bruce.

"He said that the men who were to use them were one day's journey from here," answered Sedai. "If they come to this city immediately, they will be here the evening of the day after to-morrow."

"Let us see," said Mr. Bruce, "that will be two days before the Day Of Resis. Cheer up friends, we shall yet escape," and telling Sedai to keep his eyes open and to report to them the moment the zebras were returned, they dismissed him.

The next two days were spent by Mr. Bruce in the Secret Chamber, for he determined to learn from the tablets more of the history of this strange people and country. Harry and Enola scarcely left each other, for Enola now

realized that she loved Harry, and now that there was a possibility of their being separated from each other forever, they determined to see as much of each other as possible in the few remaining hours before the Day Of Resis.

Mr. and Mrs. Graham and Nellie walked about the beautiful Temple and tried to calm their anxiety.

On the second afternoon Sedai came to them and said that the zebras had been returned, but that the young men who had come with them had been given quarters in a villa adjoining the stable, and some of them were constantly lounging about and would undoubtedly see them, and give the alarm if they tried to escape. It seemed as if they must remain until the dreaded day. Sedai was told to try and find some means to get rid of the men about the stable, and to endeavor to have everything ready for that night. Night came but Sedai reported that the men had ridden a long distance that day, and were lying on the lawn of the park and could not be persuaded to move, so comfortable were they in the cool evening breeze.

“When is the next relief?” questioned Mr. Bruce.

“At twelve o’clock,” said Sedai, “and they may go to their apartments before then, thus enabling us to get away.”

“We will wait,” said Mr. Bruce, who had constituted himself the leader of the party.

Slowly the evening wore into the night and twelve o’clock came. The attendants had all been dismissed. Sedai came in at last but his face showed disappointment.

“The men are still lying in the garden,” said he, “some asleep, while others are awake and talking.”

“How many of them are there?” asked Harry.

“Thirty,” said Sedai, “and that many more in the large villa near the stable, so that it would be foolish for us to try to overcome them.”

“No, we must not resort to violence,” said Mr. Bruce, “for that would only hurt our cause. To-morrow these men will be thoroughly rested, and we can reasonably expect that they will go about the city visiting their friends. We must not lose courage but hope for better results to-morrow.”

On the afternoon of the next day our friends, mounted the zebras and with a guard of fifty following them, rode through the principal streets of the city. The city was crowded owing to all work in the fields, mines and

quarries being suspended for five days. The people never seemed happier, for singing and laughing was heard on every side. Just as our friends reached the large square, the King mounted the pedestal from which he had greeted them upon their arrival in the city. From a tablet of wood in his hand he read the law proclaiming the Day of Resis to be the only holiday, and, being now at hand, the direct participants in its ceremonies must prepare for them. He did not mention the secrets of the day, or did he give them idea as to what the ceremonies would be.

On the bare wrists of the right arm of the older men and women could be seen a peculiarly-shaped diamond of a reddish cast. This was about half an inch in width and held to the wrist by a chain of gold. Mr. Bruce turned to one of the guards, and asked:

“Why do certain ones wear this peculiar stone and chain of gold about their wrists?”

“It is the mark of Resis,” answered the man. And upon Mr. Bruce asking what this meant, the man made no further answer.

The faces of those wearing these bracelets were radiant. They seemed the happiest of the whole vast multitude, and the younger people appeared to look on them with envy. Truly, the happiness of the day must be supreme to those who participated in its ceremonies.

The King, after reading the law twice, descended from the pedestal, mounted his zebra and joined Enola and her friends. Carefully the zebras picked their way through the throng of people crowding the streets. Girls were dancing, men were giving exhibitions of skill in athletics; others were singing quaint, harmonious songs, and all were happy and joyous.

They soon reached the Temple and retired to the dining hall. After the meal the King excused himself, saying that he would have to go among his people, as on the Eve of Resis all were in the city and were anxious to have him appear at their games and pastimes.

Mr. Graham, Mr. Bruce and Harry walked toward the stables, and to their dismay saw their zebras again being taken away.

“Where are they taking the zebras?” asked Harry of Sedai, who stood near.

“To the great square,” answered Sedai. “These zebras are trained to do certain tricks, and are to give an exhibition to-night before the people.”

Harry almost broke down in despair. All hope of their escape on that night had fled, and all were thoroughly disturbed. Enola's despair could be seen in her white face, but she said nothing. A resolve had taken shape in her mind, that if all else failed, before she would become the wife of the King of On she would end her life, for the thought now of marrying this man had become abhorrent to her, and the longer she brooded over it, the more hateful did it become to her, and hence this determination.

Slowly the night grew on, and all listened with bated breath for Sedai, for they still had a faint hope that the zebras might be returned in time for them to get away at the midnight relief; but midnight came and passed, and our friends knew that their last hope was gone. They separated for the night without a word, even Mr. Bruce, who was usually so hopeful, now not having a word to say.

The morrow was the Day of Resis, and after its mysterious ceremonies had been performed, the King of this strange people was to demand Enola for his wife.

CHAPTER XLIX.

THE DAY OF RESIS.

“The Day of Resis” had come, and long before the sun had shed its golden beams on the Temple of On, the people were astir. The tramp of many zebras and the rumbling of chariots could be faintly heard by the adventurers as they lay tossing on their couches, the night having brought them but little rest. They listened with bated breath to the sounds as they floated through the wide arches of the Temple, and wondered what the day would bring forth. That it would be fateful, was certain, for if they did not effect their escape, Enola would become the unwilling bride of the King of On; and what would be the subsequent events? Would they longer be held prisoners, or, would they be allowed to go and come as they saw fit?

But if they failed to get away before the eventful ceremony should take place, would there be any further inducement to leave this beautiful country? Would not Enola be the wife of Onrai, and would not the bonds be binding, having been welded by the laws of this country? Would she not still be the wife of Onrai, even if she should go back to civilization, and would it not be better for her to remain here with the man whom she had been forced to marry? It was a difficult question to answer, and puzzled and troubled, the small party of adventurers rose, and after the morning bath, the last, they hoped, in the Temple, they repaired to the dining hall.

“The night has been a disappointing one in every respect,” said Mr. Graham, as he took a seat by the side of Enola, “for I had hoped that after the suspense and failure of the early evening, we would at least forget for awhile in our sleep. But I see in the haggard faces about me traces of unrest, and I know that we have all spent the night in worrying and in wondering as to what the day would bring forth.”

“The night has been a fearful one to me,” said Enola; “but it has seemed all too short, for I could remember only that with its darkness went all hope of mine.”

“Come, Enola,” said Mr. Bruce, “do not give up entirely. Remember that it is on the eve of this day that you are to marry the King, and there are many hours left us yet in which to escape.”

“No,” said Enola, “I feel that all hope is gone. We will be the central figures of attraction to-day and all eyes will be upon us, thus making it an impossibility to escape.”

“I differ with you,” said Mr. Bruce, “for we have learned that this is the greatest of all days with these people, and the ceremonies of the day may call attention from us, thus giving us a chance to get away. Listen, even now, the avenues seem crowded with the chariots and zebras, and the sandaled feet of the multitude can be heard shuffling over the hard pavement. The day for me has the greatest interest, for I long to fathom its mysteries, but not at the expense of your happiness, Enola, and I will watch every chance, as will all of us, to get you away from the hateful ceremony.”

“I had forgotten, in our trouble,” said Mr. Graham, “that there were secrets to be learned to-day. What can they be?”

“They must be of an exceedingly happy nature,” said Harry, “for I have seen the faces of those who have spoken of the day, light up as if with pleasurable anticipation.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “Onrai has said that the day was the happiest one in the lives of the people, and that must mean a great deal, for these people are always happy, or, have been so until the news reached them of the great battle and eruption. Hark,” and as Mr. Bruce ceased speaking, a song rose on the morning air so exquisitely beautiful and grand, that our friends almost held their breath, for fear of losing one note of its delightful harmony. It rose and fell one moment loud and powerful, ringing through the entrance and wide hall of the Temple, and the next dying away almost to a whisper.

“Ah,” said Enola, as the voices ceased, “it is beautiful. Oh, why could not Onrai have left me in peace, so that we might enjoy even yet awhile the delights of this grand country and people.”

“It is indeed too bad,” said Mr. Bruce. “But has Sedai been here this morning?”

“No,” said Mr. Graham, “but it is time that he was. Perhaps he is afraid of losing a chance for escape by coming to us,” but the curtain moves at this moment and Sedai enters.

“We were just speaking of you, Sedai,” said Mr. Bruce. “What are the chances this morning?”

“Better, I think,” replied Sedai. “I was sitting near the stables last night waiting for the watch to sleep, when Ephmer came to me and said:

“‘Listen, Sedai, your friends of the far-away country would escape, for the fair one whom Onrai the King, would marry, can see no happiness in becoming his wife. To-morrow is the Day of Resis, and on that day is the first King of On to marry. But you would escape. I have seen the look of fear and suspense on the faces of your friends since they have again arrived in the city, and I have seen you here day and night watching closely the movements of the men who have been placed to watch your friends. Now listen. I have longed to leave my native land and go to that far-away country, of which I have heard you speak, and I will help you escape. I only ask that you take me with you, and also my friend Shal, of the underground world. I cannot promise to effect your escape, but I will do all in my power to help you. Will you accept my help?’

“I looked at the Onian for a moment, but did not answer, for fear that if I should admit that we were trying to escape, he would report the matter to the King.

“Don’t mistrust me,” he continued, “and I decided to accept his offer. Have I done right?”

“You have,” said Mr. Bruce, “and if this man can help us, he shall see that great world beyond the cliffs to which he has so longed to go.”

“’Tis well,” said Sedai, “Ephmer will be near you to-day during the ceremonies and will explain all to you. I will immediately notify you if an opportunity affords for our escape,” and with this Sedai withdrew.

Onrai was heard outside a moment later, and very shortly he came into the apartment. His face wore a happy smile, as he walked to where Enola was sitting, and taking her hand, said:

“Greeting, Enola. This is the greatest day of my life and the happiest.”

“The day seems strange to me,” said Enola.

“Why strange, Enola,” asked Onrai, his face troubled for the moment.

“Because I cannot realize that in this strange land, so far from our own, and where the customs are so very different, I have found the one whom I am to marry, and that on this day I am to become his wife. I cannot accustom myself to the idea, that is all,” and Enola tried to smile, knowing that she must still keep up the miserable farce in order to avert suspicion.

“The strangeness will wear off with the day’s ceremonies,” said Onrai, “and now the ceremonies are about to commence, and places on the terrace are awaiting you.”

“Then we are about to learn the day’s mysteries,” said Mr. Bruce.

“They are mysteries to you only; to my people, the day’s ceremonies are well-known,” said the King.

“Then why are they never mentioned?” questioned Mr. Bruce.

“Because they are too sacred,” answered Onrai, solemnly, as he left the apartment.

“Ah, they are mysteries still,” said Mr. Bruce, after the King had left. “Not even at this late hour will he explain them to us, but leaves us to learn them ourselves, and that we are willing to do. Let us go to the terrace and there learn what it is which makes the day one of mystery.”

They all now left the dining hall and stepped into the large court. Here attendants were awaiting to conduct them to their seats. Ephmer, who was one of these, stepped up as they approached, and asked:

“Has Sedai spoken?”

“Yes,” said Mr. Bruce, “and we have consented. You will not fail us?”

“I shall do all in my power,” and saying this, Ephmer led the way to the terrace where they found seats awaiting them.

The scene which now met the gaze of the adventurers was strange, yet grand. The populace thronged the court of the Temple, the garden, the avenues leading to it, and even the tops of the villas were crowded with the happy-looking people. Before many of the villas could be seen a square pile of wood about ten feet high. These had been placed during the night, and our friends could but wonder what part these played in the ceremonies of the day. Turning to Ephmer, Mr. Bruce asked:

“Why are these piles of wood placed before some villas and not before others?”

“In these villas with the biers before them, live the principal participants in to-day’s ceremonies,” answered Ephmer.

“What did you call these? Biers?” asked Mr. Bruce, with a puzzled look on his face.

“Yes,” answered Ephmer, “for on these are burned the bodies of those who have this day met their Day of Resis.”

“Burned? Day of Resis? Why, what do you mean, man?” asked Mr. Bruce, and they all looked at the man with troubled faces.

“Only this,” said Ephmer, “that all Onians who have reached the age of sixty-five, since this day last year, will to-day be put to death by the hand of the King.”

Our friends looked at the Onian, as he said this, with fearful wonderment depicted in their faces. Could it be that the man told the truth? Could this race of enlightened people do this thing?

“But why are these put to death?” asked Mr. Bruce, as soon as he could find his voice.

“Because they have reached that time when old age creeps on; and having reached this age, too, they have earned the reward which is rightfully theirs, by having lived a sinless life,” answered Ephmer.

“But why should you kill a man because he has seen his best days?” asked Mr. Bruce, now interested in spite of himself.

“Because we would leave none but the strong and vigorous to bring children into our world, and, also, because our world would become overpopulated if the old were not killed. The same law governs our domestic animals.”

And this, then, was the secret, or one of the secrets of the great height, strength and healthfulness of this people, and it also explained the absence of all aged people in this strange land. Yes, such a law could have but this effect, but at what a cost was the beautiful stature and healthfulness acquired?

“But do not those who are to be killed, object?” asked Mr. Bruce.

“Never,” answered Ephmer, “it is the happiest day of their lives. Look at them. The ceremonies are about to commence.”

“I cannot stand this,” said Mrs. Graham, and she and Nellie rising, entered the Temple. Enola also arose intending to go to her apartment, but at that moment the King came on to the terrace wearing a long, crimson robe, and seeing Enola about to retire, said to her: “It is important that you witness the scenes of the day, because hereafter, you will have to perform the same duties which I am this day performing.”

“I cannot look on this wholesale murder,” answered Enola, with a shudder.

“It is the law,” replied Onrai, as he moved away. And Enola again sank into her seat. It was fearful, but what could she or the others do? Nothing.

Suddenly the blare of a trumpet sounded over the city, and the vast throng burst forth in a weird chant which rose and fell in great waves of sound, and almost stopped the beating of the heart with its impressive solemnity. Up the long avenue came a procession of men and women, and across the wrist of each was the gold chain and peculiar diamond, which symbolized the bloody ending of the day. A white bag of goat skin was suspended by a silken cord which encircled the wrist just below the gold band. All were in spotless white with golden girdles and fillets of gold about their brows.

The King, in a crimson robe, accompanied by seven priests, took his place in the court and faced the line of the doomed. At the sound of another trumpet the singing ceased. An onyx pedestal was brought from the Temple and placed before the King. On the pedestal was a shallow basin of gold.



“Again the flashing dagger was raised in the air.”—Page [393](#).

At a given signal the lines of the doomed moved forward, keeping the right foot foremost, and again the chant of the multitude rose higher and higher, growing wilder and wilder, until the front rank of the victims was ranged before the King. He drew from his girdle a glittering dagger, that flashed in the sunlight when he held it aloft, as the doomed men and women thrust out their naked wrists over the golden basin. One swift stroke severed the main artery and the goat-skin bag was instantly drawn up and tied above the wound, scarcely a drop of blood falling into the shallow golden vessel on the pedestal.

Again the flashing dagger was raised in the air as two members of each victim's family stepped from the throng and assisted the doomed into the chariot which stood waiting. On the faces of the vast throng no horror was depicted, but rather the intent look of serious and solemn interest. Even upon the faces of the victims a beatified look of hopeful expectancy, was the only evidence that they were not to mingle again with their fellow-men, in the duties and pleasures of the Land of On.

For a time Enola was enabled to keep her face turned away from the actual sight of the massacre, but under the influence of that wonderful music, she at last stole one brief glance at the King as the gleaming knife crossed the wrist of a victim, and from that time until the long procession had passed the pedestal of death, she was held as if by the glittering eyes of a serpent.

As the last man received his death-thrust, the King dropped the knife into the basin, and holding aloft both hands, intoned the words of the ceremony which were supposed to justify the deeds of the day, and speed the departing souls into the sublimity of the hereafter. At last Mr. Bruce exclaimed hoarsely:

“It is over!” and he looked up just in time to see Enola fall fainting into Harry’s arms. She was immediately borne to her apartments and was soon revived. As the men left the terrace, there was not a sign to show that the day had been one of dreadful tragedies. No drop of blood, no confusion. Simply the orderly dispersing of the multitude engaged in low-toned conversation.

All now met in Mr. Bruce’s rooms and breathlessly awaited Sedai’s arrival. The news which he would bring from the stables would decide how much or how little of hope they might have, for effecting an escape before Onrai should come.

Suddenly the curtain stirred and Sedai’s face appeared. He beckoned to them to follow, and noiselessly they crossed the starlit terrace and entered the garden. Here they found Ephmer and Shal awaiting them with zebras. Enola was about to mount her zebra when she heard a peculiar cry, and turning she saw the great white body of Gip looming up in the half light and coming toward her.

“Oh, Gip,” she cried, “this is my only regret in leaving On. I cannot take you with me,” and patting the great noble beast, which had saved her life on two different occasions and the lives of her friends, she turned and mounted her zebra and rode away with tears streaming from her eyes, afraid to look back, fearful of the pitiful look on Gip’s face.

Cautiously they picked their way through the park toward the road to the mountains. Along this road, which was used only for bringing the fodder for the stables, Sedai led them, explaining that it joined the main road leading to the cave a short distance from the city. As soon as they reached the main

road they urged on their zebras with all speed, for, turning to look back at the city, they could see torches glittering about rapidly and could hear a confused murmur of sounds which indicated that their escape had been detected. Here and there a steady flame shooting straight into the air, denoted the burning funeral pyres of the day's victims. Sedai motioned them to stop for a moment, and listening intently, he said:

“We are pursued.”

On they flew again over the hard road, through bits of forest, past the shores of small lakes and over green fields. Far ahead they could see the dark forest on the side of the mountain. Through the gate of the mighty wall they sped, and Sedai dismounted to hastily close and barricade it from the inside. Their pursuers would have to climb the wall, or seek one of the other gates and every moment was precious now. They crossed the bridge and plunged into the woods that intervened between them and the cave. The roar of a lion was heard to the right, but they did not hesitate.

The eastern horizon was growing brighter and brighter, and by the time they had passed the forest, the moon had risen high above the mountains. The rapid gallop of zebras could be heard and looking back, they saw a large body of mounted men struggling at the barricaded gate. Finding the gate impassable, they formed a pyramid and in this way the men reached the top of the wall, and then used ropes to let themselves down into the Hunting Reserve.

Harry first reached the secret door, but strove in vain to find the hidden spring. The pursuers were gaining upon them, and Enola, urging her zebra forward, sprang to the ground and, grasping the lever, pressed hard on it, but the stone door of the cave failed to open. Her heart sank within her. She remembered the last revolution it had made, and the difficulty with which she had rescued Sedai from its stony embrace. Could it be that the mechanism was then injured? The mighty spring broken, perhaps? She reeled for a second, as the dreadful possibility suggested itself to her. Then seizing Harry's rifle she dashed its butt against the lever and the heavy stone door began to revolve.

Sedai, seizing a heavy branch, struck the zebra upon which Mrs. Graham was riding, and the frightened animal sprang through the opening, followed by the one ridden by Nellie. One after another they were driven through, and as the leaders of the pursuing party dashed into the open glade, Sedai

drove the last unmounted zebra through the opening. Springing to the ground, the foremost of the pursuers sought to grasp Sedai, but with a swing of his club about his head, the assailant was laid low, and Sedai disappeared. Through the crack of the door, as it swung shut, came a heart-rending cry of "Enola, Enola," from the King.

Once more, with pale faces and beating hearts, the explorers stood within the great subterranean cavern, which had so nearly been their tomb, but which now was a place of refuge. The hidden City of On had been discovered, its history and its people were known to them, the object of their journey had been accomplished.

After the party had rested, they took their way across the cave, and with the zebras this was found easy to do. These trained animals easily leaped across the break in the bridge, but when it came to the small entrance at the opposite side of the cave, it was feared that they would have to be left here to die, as the hole was too small for them to pass through. Our friends were greatly grieved to think that they would have to leave these noble beasts to die in such a cruel way, in the cave, but there seemed no other alternative, and they dismounted and passed through the hole, but they had not calculated on the training of these animals, and they had hardly stepped into the open air, when one of the zebras came crawling through on his haunches, and shortly after the others followed him. These had been trained to do this, and our friends now remembered having seen them perform this trick on the night preceding the Day of Resis.

It took them but a short time to reach the village of Umsaga, where they found the carriers still waiting for them, and in a few weeks they were again in Zanzibar, and had no difficulty in getting passage to England, from where they sailed for home.

A few weeks after their arrival in New York, a double wedding was announced, and on the evening of the happy day, carriage after carriage rolled to the door of the Graham mansion, depositing richly clad women and courtly men. Under an arch of flowers, a little later, stood four people, arrayed in strange robes of silk, with bands of gold binding their brows and with girdles of gold about their waists.

In the costume of the Land of On, the double wedding was in progress, and in the faces of the women could be read a story of trust and confidence and love supreme, and in those of the men, the satisfaction of proud manhood fitly crowned.

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